

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

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Aquifer Open Study Notes (Themes)

"Belief" in the Gospel of John

The theme of "belief" is central in John's Gospel. John does not use the noun *faith* found often in the New Testament (for example, see [Matthew 8:8-10](#); [Mark 11:22](#); [Acts 20:21](#); [Romans 1:17](#); [3:27-31](#); [4:3-5](#); [Hebrews 11:1-39](#); [James 2:14-24](#); [1 Peter 1:5-7](#)). John prefers the verb form *believe* ("trust" or "be faithful") to show that faith is not just a fixed belief, but is "alive" and requires action. In John's Gospel, "believing" in Jesus is the mark of all true disciples.

In the Gospel of John, the verb translated as "believe" is often followed by the Greek preposition *eis*, which means "into." This combination is unique in ancient Greek usage. For John, belief or faith is not just a status, it is an investment in Jesus. Faith means accepting who Jesus is and who he claims to be.

Faith also involves a commitment to let his invitation to trust in him change how a person lives. Faith is the work God wants from us ([John 6:29](#)). We demonstrate faith by following Jesus' teachings, loving him, and obeying his commands ([John 8:31](#); [15:1-17](#); see [1 John 5:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:6](#); [Isaiah 28:16](#); [Mark 1:15](#); [Mark 9:23-24](#); [John 1:12-13](#); [John 3:10-18](#); [John 5:24](#); [John 6:35-36](#); [John 7:38](#); [John 9:35-38](#); [John 11:25-27](#); [John 12:37](#); [John 20:25-31](#); [Acts 10:43](#); [Acts 13:39](#); [Romans 1:16](#); [Romans 10:9-10](#); [Hebrews 4:3](#)

"He Will Come"

Jesus promised his followers that he would return to bring them to be with him forever ([John 14:1-3](#)). Right after Jesus ascended to heaven, the apostles received a message that he would come back one day ([Acts 1:9-11](#)). In the visions described in the book of Revelation, John hears Jesus promise to return again ([Revelation 22:6-20](#)).

The final completion of everything, "the Day of the Lord" ([2 Thessalonians 2:2](#)), will come as a surprise, "like a thief in the night" ([1 Thessalonians 5:2](#)). Jesus said "only the Father" knows when that day will be ([Matthew 24:36](#); [Acts 1:6-7](#)). Now is a

time for hope and confidence, not guessing. Christians should not set dates and times for the end.

When the Bible teaches about future events (what will happen at the end of time), it gives us two important things: hope during difficult times and wisdom for how to live now. The Bible's teaching about the end times, also called eschatology (the study of what will happen in the future), helps us focus on living faithfully today. Instead of worrying about exactly when these events will occur, we should concentrate on how we live now.

The apostle Paul describes events like "the rebellion" and the appearance of "the man of lawlessness" that will happen before "the Day of the Lord" ([2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)). Yet, he does not focus on the details. Instead, he reminds his audience of these events to refute false teachings and encourage Christians who suffer for the faith ([2 Thessalonians 1:3-10](#); [2:5](#)).

When Christ returns, he will:

- defeat the enemies of the good news about Jesus (the gospel)
- save suffering Christians ([2 Thessalonians 1:7-10](#))
- gather his followers to be with him forever ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-17](#))

This future event requires a response now. Those who accept the good news and live for God can be confident of rescue. Those who reject God will experience eternal destruction. God's choice and calling of Christians is their hope and comfort ([2 Thessalonians 2:13-14](#)). They can remain steady now as they look to the future ([2:14-15](#)). They have a guarantee of the outcome when he returns.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 25:1-46](#); [Acts 1:6-7](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:7-10](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)

"I Am" Sayings of Jesus

In the Gospel of John, Jesus often uses the phrase "I am" (in Greek, the phrase is *egō eimi*). Sometimes, Jesus uses this phrase to describe himself. For

example, Jesus said, "I am the bread of life." The Gospel of John contains seven statements where Jesus says "I am" followed by a description of himself ([John 6:35](#); [8:12](#); [10:9](#), [11](#); [11:25](#); [14:6](#); [15:1](#)).

It is important to note that Greek does not need the pronoun "I" (*egō*) in these sentences. Therefore, using the pronoun emphasizes the speaker's identity. Another example is in the sermon on the mount in the Gospel of Matthew. Jesus says, "You have heard that it was said ... but I [*egō*] tell you" (see [Matthew 5:22](#), [28](#), [32](#), [34](#), [39](#), [44](#), and other passages). Including the personal pronoun emphasizes the difference between Jesus' teachings and those of Moses. This phrase emphasizes the unique authority of Jesus.

Sometimes, Jesus used the phrase "I am" in a grammatically unusual way, without anything following it. For example, Jesus said, "Before Abraham was even born, I am" ([John 8:58](#)). *Before Abraham, Jesus was what?* (compare [8:28](#), [59](#); [13:19](#)).

The best explanation for this odd expression comes from the Old Testament. When Moses met the Lord on Mount Sinai, he wanted to know God's name ([Exodus 3:6](#), [13-14](#)). God told him that his name is "YHWH," four Hebrew letters that can express existence.

When the Jews translated the Old Testament into Greek, in [Exodus 3:14](#) God's name "I AM WHO I AM" became *egō eimi ho ōn* ("I am the one who is"). In other places, especially in Isaiah ([Isaiah 43:25](#); [51:12](#); [52:6](#)), the Greek Old Testament uses *egō eimi* ("I am") as a special way God speaks about himself. In many other verses, the Greek translation uses *kurios* ("Lord") for God's name. Some Jews understood Jesus's words "I am" as a claim to God's name, as in [John 8:58](#), where they tried to stone him. But in other places, like [John 8:24](#), they did not react that way and only asked him, "Who are you?"

Jesus not only represents God. The "I Am" statements show Jesus' divine nature, indicating he can work, speak, and act in place of the Father. He is not just a human. He is the Word of God who became human ([John 1:1](#)). His voice is the Father's voice, and his life reveals God's life in a human body. The phrase "I Am" powerfully expresses who Jesus is.

Passages for Further Study

[John 6:35](#), [48](#); [8:12](#), [58](#); [9:5](#); [10:7-14](#); [11:25](#); [14:6](#); [15:1](#), [5](#)

All Is "Vapor"

A key word in the book of Ecclesiastes is the Hebrew term *hebel*. This word means "vapor." Often it is translated as "meaningless." This word captures the main view about life in this world of the Teacher. The Teacher, also called Qoheleth, is the main speaker in the book of Ecclesiastes.

The Hebrew word *hebel* means physical "breath" or "vapor." *Hebel* appears seventy-eight times in the Old Testament, but only three times does it obviously refer to the physical sense ([Psalm 62:9](#); [Proverbs 21:6](#); [Isaiah 57:13](#)). In the other seventy-five instances, it metaphorically describes what is hard to understand, futile, meaningless, false, temporary, or without substance.

The term often describes the lack of substance, lack of reality, and lack of worth of false gods ([Deuteronomy 32:21](#); [2 Kings 17:15](#)). In this sense, *hebel* is the opposite of "glory." God's glory is his presence that has substance, is weighty, and lasting. Sometimes, *hebel* represents how life is short and momentary, like vapor ([Job 7:16](#); [Psalm 144:4](#)). In other cases, it refers to the how meaningless and frustrating life can be ([Psalms 78:33](#); [94:11](#); [Isaiah 49:4](#)).

There is a long tradition of interpreting *hebel* in Ecclesiastes as meaning "vanity." This does not mean thinking too highly of oneself. But it refers to experiencing life as empty and without purpose. The ancient Greek translation of the Old Testament used the word *mataiotēs*, meaning "emptiness" or "futility."

The Latin Vulgate then translated *hebel* with the Latin word *vanitas*, which means "without purpose," "hollow," or "without worth." From the Vulgate comes the tradition of translating the word as "vanity" in English. Most translators today understand *hebel* to mean that life on earth seems to have no clear purpose or meaning, and all that we do feels futile.

Some translators interpret *hebel* in Ecclesiastes as referring mainly to life's temporary nature. A vapor has no permanence or weight. This translation suggests a different view of Ecclesiastes. Life is not meaningless and futile, but rather not permanent and quickly ending. Many phrases in Ecclesiastes

hint at the quick or short nature of human life and its efforts.

In the New Testament, a similar idea appears in [James 4:13-15](#). Understanding *hebel* as "not permanent" in Ecclesiastes helps explain the book plainly. But it is a less common view among scholars.

When reading Ecclesiastes, remember the root of the word is "breath" or "vapor," which supports the metaphors. The shortness and challenges of life can feel depressing. This should encourage us to work hard and wisely, and enjoy life while possible. We have all experienced life's unfair events, like a foolish person succeeding or unpunished injustice. These things make more sense when we remember God is in control. God will judge everything we do, including all secrets, whether good or bad ([Ecclesiastes 12:14](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 32:21](#); [2 Kings 17:15](#); [Job 7:16](#); [Psalms 62:9](#); [78:33](#); [94:11](#); [144:4](#); [Proverbs 21:6](#); [Ecclesiastes 1:2](#); [Isaiah 30:7](#); [49:4](#); [57:13](#)

Altars

Noah built the first altar mentioned in the Bible ([Genesis 8:20-21](#)). Cain and Abel also gave offerings to God ([Genesis 4:3-5](#)). The patriarchs built many altars (see [Genesis 12:7-8](#); [13:4](#), [18](#); [22:9](#); [26:25](#); [33:20](#); [35:1](#), [14-15](#)). These altars marked holy places where God revealed himself and personal land claims in the promised land. These were both in the north (Shechem) and south (Beersheba).

They made altar of stone, earth, brick, or metal and wood. They were flat on top like a table, which helped the smoke rise. Altars were for memorials or used as places of sacrifice. They were the most common symbols of worship in the Old Testament and the ancient world.

Usually, an altar was on a raised platform with a ramp or stairs. This lifted the sacrifices for worship toward heaven. The four horns on the corners of many altars marked the holy area where the divine and human realms met (see [Exodus 27:2](#)). Through sacrifice and burning, the offering moved from the visible to the invisible world.

Jesus combines in himself the different symbolic roles of the high priest, sacrificial lamb, and altar (see [Hebrews 4:14-15](#); [7:24](#), [27](#); [9:14](#), [26](#); [10:10](#);

[13:10](#), [12](#)). He prophesied his own sacrifice by mentioning the blood of martyrs (see [Matthew 23:35](#); [Luke 11:50-51](#)). His crucifixion represents the final sacrifice on "the altar" of the cross. Therefore, the "Lamb" who is seated as king in Revelation makes the temple and altar unnecessary ([Revelation 21:22](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 8:20-21](#); [12:7-8](#); [22:9-14](#); [33:20](#); [Exodus 20:24-26](#); [Joshua 22:10-34](#); [1 Kings 18:20-40](#); [Hosea 8:11-13](#); [Matthew 5:23-24](#); [Hebrews 13:10-14](#); [Revelation 6:9](#); [8:3-5](#)

Ancestors of Jesus

Both the Gospel of Matthew and the Gospel of Luke include a list of Jesus' ancestors ([Matthew 1:1-17](#); [Luke 3:23-38](#)). These lists are called "genealogies." The two genealogies are different after they mention King David. Matthew's list shows Jesus' family history through David's son King Solomon, while Luke's list shows Jesus' family history through David's son Nathan. Why are there two different lists? One possible explanation is that Matthew records Joseph's family history, while Luke records Mary's. In this case, Joseph would be Heli's son-in-law.

In ancient Jewish culture, people kept very careful records of their family histories. Josephus (a Jewish historian who lived in the first century AD) confirms this in his writings. Genealogies were important in the Old Testament and Judaism because land rights were for families in Israel. Certain roles, like priest and king, passed from father to son.

Genealogies often showed connections from the past to the present. They emphasized religious themes, family descent, political ties, and simple timelines ([1 Chronicles 1-9](#)). Most genealogies listed important persons in the history of Israel. They were not a complete record of every family member.

Matthew and Luke each had different reasons for listing Jesus's ancestors. Matthew wanted to show that Jesus descended from Abraham through David. Matthew's genealogy confirms Jesus as a rightful heir to David's throne. Therefore, Matthew shows Jesus' ancestors back to Abraham, the father of the Jewish people. In contrast, Luke's genealogy lists Jesus' ancestors back to the first human, Adam.

This aligns with Luke's focus on Jesus as the Savior for all people everywhere.

In Matthew's genealogy, it is notable that he mentions women. These women include Tamar, Rahab, Ruth, and Bathsheba. Some had bad reputations and some were non-Jews (gentiles). This emphasizes God's grace to redeem those whom others consider unworthy.

The genealogies of Jesus do not prove he is the Messiah (God's chosen one), but they do make him a possible candidate. His identity as the Messiah becomes clear in other ways ([Matthew 11:2-6](#)). God guided history to its climax. Jesus is the expected Messiah of the Old Testament. He is the savior of his people, and the king descended from David who takes his throne (see [2 Samuel 7:16](#)). Jesus is the heir to Abraham and ultimately fulfills God's promises to Abraham ([Genesis 12:1-3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1-3](#); [2 Samuel 7:16](#); [Matthew 1:1-17](#); [Luke 3:23-38](#)

Ancient Law Codes

Until the late 1800s, people thought the law of Moses was a unique legal code. They believed it existed nearly a thousand years before anything similar in Greek and Roman laws. Yet, archaeological excavations in Persia in the early 1900s uncovered the laws from the Babylonian king Hammurabi (called the Code of Hammurabi). He lived in the 1700s BC. This was several centuries before the time traditionally associated with Moses.

Surprisingly, many of these laws are almost the same as those in the Bible. This suggested that biblical laws might have come from Hammurabi. But later discoveries found law codes that existed at least 500 years before Hammurabi. Several laws are common to all these codes, so Hammurabi was not the first to start them either.

What does this mean for the Bible?

1. It is not surprising to find similar laws in cultures near Israel. Similar societies need similar rules to ensure justice.

2. Biblical laws are unique because they are part of a covenant (special agreement) with God. In the ancient Near East, religious laws and civil laws were separate. Religious laws spoke of sacrifice, prayers, offerings, and others. Civil laws spoke of theft, lying, sexual conduct, murder, and others.

They considered ethics (rules about right and wrong) and religion to be different topics. Religion involved prayer, devotion, offerings, and ceremonies, managed by priests. Ethics dealt with social and civil behavior, managed by the king. The biblical view is different. God rules over both religion and society. So, a person in a relationship with the true God must worship properly and treat others well.

Israel's covenant with God used existing law forms but gave them new meaning. For example, the way God arranged Israel's tabernacle and temple was similar to others in the ancient world ([Exodus 26-27](#); see [1 Kings 6:1-7:51](#)). The Hebrew sacrifices were also similar to pagan sacrifices (see [Leviticus 1-7](#)). Yet, the temple and sacrifices had different meanings and purposes than those in paganism (see study notes on [Exodus 20:3-17](#); [25:1-40:38](#); [Leviticus 1:1-7:38](#)).

Many of the laws of Moses were not new to the ancient world. What was unique was that they came from the one Creator God, who called his people to live in a way that showed his character.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 20:1-23:33](#); [34:1-35:3](#); [Leviticus 1:1-27:34](#); [Deuteronomy 4:1-33:29](#); [Ezra 1:1-4](#); [Esther 1:13-19](#); [8:9-14](#); [Daniel 6:6-9](#); [Luke 2:1-3](#)

Angels

In the Bible, angels are God's messengers who carry out his plans and tell his will to humans ([Genesis 16:7-12](#); [Numbers 22:22-34](#); [Judges 13:3-21](#); [2 Kings 1:3, 15](#); [Zechariah 1:4-12](#)). The Hebrew Old Testament and Christian New Testament name only two angels, Michael and Gabriel, who have special tasks ([Daniel 8:16, 18; 9:21; 10:12, 21; 12:1-2](#); [Luke 1:19-20](#); [Jude 1:9](#)). Angels helped establish God's law through Moses ([Acts 7:30, 35, 38, 53](#); [Galatians 3:19](#)). They distribute God's grace and sometimes carry out his

judgment ([2 Kings 19:35](#); [Acts 12:23](#); [Revelation 9:15](#); [16:1-12](#)).

Angels witnessed Christ's life and now witness the lives of God's people ([1 Timothy 3:16](#); [1 Corinthians 11:10](#); [1 Timothy 5:21](#)). Guardian angels protect God's people ([Matthews 18:10](#); see also [Psalms 34:7](#); [91:11](#); [Acts 12:11](#)). They are "spirits sent to serve those who will inherit salvation" ([Hebrews 1:14](#)). Angels will join Christ when he returns ([Matthew 25:31](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:7-8](#)). They will participate in the final judgment ([Matthew 13:39](#), [41](#), [49-50](#); [16:27](#); [24:31](#); [Mark 13:27](#); [Luke 9:26](#); [12:8](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:7](#)).

Angels appear at important moments in the gospels. They announced the births of John the Baptist and Jesus and served Jesus after his temptation ([Luke 1:1-2:52](#); [Matthew 4:11](#)). Angels also appeared at the empty tomb after Jesus' resurrection ([Matthew 28:1-8](#); [Mark 16:5-7](#); [Luke 24:23](#); [John 20:12](#)).

The role of angels is important in the book of Acts. Angels helped with miraculous prison escapes ([Acts 5:19](#); [12:6-11](#)). An angel encouraged Paul during a violent storm ([27:23-24](#)). An angel also told the Roman centurion (military officer) Cornelius to learn the gospel from Peter ([10:3](#), [7](#), [22](#); [11:13](#)). An angel struck down King Herod Agrippa because he accepted worship instead of giving glory to God ([12:23](#)). Throughout Acts, God guided his people and used angels to achieve his goals.

Some angels have sinned and will suffer eternal judgment ([Matthew 25:41](#); [2 Peter 2:4](#), [11](#); [Jude 1:6](#)). Angels are spiritual and heavenly beings, but they are inferior to Christ and must not be worshipped ([Galatians 1:8](#); [Colossians 2:18](#); [Hebrews 1:5-14](#); [Revelation 19:10](#); [22:8-9](#)). Only God must be worshipped ([Matthew 4:10](#); [Revelation 19:10](#); [22:8-9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 91:11](#); [Daniel 8:15-18](#); [9:21-23](#); [10:4-11:1](#); [12:1-2](#); [Zechariah 1:8-13](#), [18-19](#); [2:3-5](#); [Matthew 1:20-24](#); [4:5-7](#), [11](#); [13:39-42](#), [49-50](#); [18:10](#); [24:31](#); [28:2-7](#); [Mark 16:5-7](#); [Luke 1:11-22](#), [26-38](#); [2:8-15](#); [9:26](#); [12:8](#); [John 20:12-13](#); [Acts 5:19-20](#); [7:30-35](#), [53](#); [10:3-8](#); [12:6-11](#), [23](#); [27:23-24](#); [1 Corinthians 11:10](#); [Galatians 1:8](#); [3:19](#); [Colossians 2:18](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:16](#); [1 Timothy 3:16](#); [5:21](#); [Hebrews 1:5-14](#); [12:22](#); [13:2](#); [2 Peter 2:4](#), [11](#); [Jude 1:6](#), [9](#); [Revelation 1:1-2](#); [5:2](#), [11-12](#); [7:1-2](#); [8:3-8](#); [9:15](#); [10:7-9](#); [14:6-10](#); [16:1-12](#); [19:10](#), [17](#); [20:1](#); [22:6-9](#)

Anger

Wise people do not get angry quickly. "A patient man has great understanding, but a quick-tempered man promotes folly" ([Proverbs 14:29](#)). Anger can cause bad judgment, so wise people think before they act ([14:16](#)).

The book of Proverbs views anger negatively, but not all anger in Scripture is bad. Many psalms speak of God's anger (for example, [Psalm 77](#)). Jesus was angry when he expelled the money changers from the temple ([Mark 11:15-17](#); [John 2:13-16](#)).

People must learn to tell the difference between righteous and unrighteous anger, though it is often difficult. Unrighteous anger focuses on protecting or promoting oneself (for example, [Genesis 4:3-8](#); [1 Samuel 18:8-9](#); [1 Kings 21:3-4](#); [2 Kings 5:11](#); [2 Chronicles 25:10](#); [Jonah 4](#)). Righteous anger shows God's hatred of evil and love of justice (for example, [Exodus 32](#); [Numbers 11:1](#), [10](#); see also [Nahum 1:3](#); [Romans 9:22](#)). A wise person understands the situation. Then that person decides if showing anger is appropriate (see also [Proverbs 22:24](#); [Ecclesiastes 7:9](#); [Matthew 5:22](#); [Romans 12:19](#); [Ephesians 4:26-27](#), [31](#); [James 1:19-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 18:8-11](#); [1 Kings 21:3-16](#); [Psalms 30:5](#); [37:8](#); [Proverbs 12:16](#); [14:29](#); [15:1](#), [18](#); [16:14](#); [19:11-12](#), [19](#); [22:24-25](#); [27:4](#); [Ecclesiastes 7:9](#); [Nahum 1:2-3](#); [Matthew 5:22](#); [Ephesians 4:26-27](#), [31-32](#); [1 Timothy 2:8](#); [Titus 1:7](#); [James 1:19-21](#)

Apocalyptic Literature

Several Old Testament passages have themes similar to later Jewish apocalyptic literature ([Isaiah 24-27](#); [Ezekiel 38:1-39:29](#); [Daniel 7-12](#); [Zechariah 9-14](#)). Apocalyptic literature is a kind of writing that uses visions and symbols to show God's final victory over evil and to give hope to his people. The entire book of Revelation in the New Testament also belongs to this genre.

Apocalyptic literature uses divine visions to communicate unclear or hidden things. The term *apocalyptic* comes from the Greek word *apokalupsis*, meaning "revelation." But, other prophetic literature focuses on the words of the message. In legal terms, a prophet delivering a divine message (oracle) is like a prosecuting

lawyer. A writer of apocalyptic literature is like a witness, describing the heavenly realities he has seen.

Prophecy usually predicts salvation or judgment within our current world. In contrast, apocalyptic literature expects a fulfillment beyond space and time. It does not hope for society to gradually improve. Instead, it prophesies a world-changing event that will end the way things are now and create something new. Apocalyptic literature views the present as a time of conflict between light and darkness. There can be no compromise or peace between the supernatural forces of good and evil.

Apocalyptic literature reveals the hidden elements of this battle. The presence of spiritual darkness becomes clear. This is also true of the unseen forces of good around us, which will ultimately win. This future victory is certain, regardless of any human or spiritual attempts to stop it.

Apocalyptic visions intend to encourage and motivate Christians, especially during difficult times. There is good news in these writings. Despite current hardships, God has already decided the final battle's outcome. The forces of good will win. Apocalyptic literature opposes pagan claims that things will stay the same. God rules and his kingdom will win in the end.

This message gives hope to believers during suffering. It urges them to stay faithful, despite challenges. It encourages those who struggle, affirming that God is in control and will ultimately win. Despite suffering, obedience is the only way to live. We trust in the final victory when God will bring a new era of salvation.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 38:1-39:24](#); [Daniel 7:1-12:13](#); [Zechariah 9:1-14:21](#)

Apostasy

Sadly, opposition to God is not limited to those outside the community of faith. The Bible tells of many who seemed to know God but turned away (see [Numbers 16](#); [Deuteronomy 13](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [Ezekiel 8](#)). God brings fair consequences to those who turn away from him ([Job 11:20](#); [Proverbs 1:24-31](#); [Jeremiah 11:11](#)). Jesus spoke about those who "fall away" and the judgment they will receive ([Matthew 16:27](#); [23:13](#); [24:10-13](#); [25:41-46](#)). The New Testament writers follow his

example ([Galatians 1:6-9](#); [2 Timothy 3:1-9](#); [2 Peter 2:1-22](#); [1 John 2:18-19](#)).

The Bible plainly states that disobeying God leads to severe consequences (see, for example, [Genesis 9:5-6](#); [Numbers 35:16-21](#); [Leviticus 20:10](#); [Zechariah 5:4](#)). God will eventually separate those who oppose his will and rule from his life-giving presence ([Isaiah 66:14-24](#)). In a similar way, several passages in the letter to the Hebrews warn those who do not take God's word seriously. It says that they will experience spiritual trouble and encounter God's judgment (see [Hebrews 2:1-4](#); [4:12-13](#); [6:4-8](#); [10:26-31](#); [12:25-29](#)).

Scholars interpret the "warning passages" in Hebrews about *apostasy* (falling away) and judgment in different ways:

3. Some think the warnings are suggestive. They are meant to arouse listeners from spiritual laziness, without referring to actual judgment.
4. Another view is that the author spoke of his concern about Jewish people who had not yet converted to Christianity. They were under God's judgment for not yet being part of the new covenant (God's new agreement or promise with humanity established through Jesus Christ).
5. A third perspective is that the "apostates" were Christians. Because of their spiritual state, they would encounter some of God's judgment. But, they were not at risk of losing their salvation.
6. A fourth view suggests the apostates were once full members of the Christian community. They had fully experienced the faith. But then turned away from Jesus and the church.
7. A fifth opinion is that the apostates were never true believers. This shows they never really knew Jesus from the start.

Warnings of judgment show God's grace. They intend to guide rebellious people back to God's ways. Understanding the consequences of turning away from the Christian faith can strengthen our commitment to follow Jesus faithfully.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 16:1-50](#); [Deuteronomy 13:1-18](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [Ezekiel 8:1-18](#); [Matthew 24:10-13](#); [Galatians 1:6-9](#); [2 Timothy 3:1-9](#); [Hebrews 2:1-4](#); [6:4-8](#); [10:26-31](#); [2 Peter 2:1-22](#); [1 John 2:18-19](#)

Apostasy and Renewal

During the time of Israel's divided kingdom, people often considered the northern kingdom of Israel as unfaithful and the southern kingdom of Judah as faithful. When Jeroboam started the northern kingdom, many righteous people moved to Judah to avoid his wickedness ([2 Chronicles 11:13-17](#)). Yet, the southern kingdom eventually also turned away from faith in God.

King Ahaz became like Jeroboam:

8. He made metal idols ([28:2](#)).
9. He worshiped the gods of Damascus ([28:23](#)).
10. He neglected the temple ([28:24](#); [29:7, 19](#)).
11. He promoted false worship ([28:24-25](#)).
12. His unfaithfulness was so bad that the north had more righteousness than Judah at that time (see [28:9-15](#)).

The person who wrote the books of Chronicles wrote to inspire hope that God would restore Judah. He showed that God always forgives those who repent. Repentance can lead to restoration and reconciliation (making peace) with God. This was seen in the northern leaders' response to the prophet who confronted their victorious army ([28:8-15](#)).

Judah's renewal under King Hezekiah also was a model for restoration and unity, similar to King Solomon's rule. In the first year of his rule, Hezekiah began to restore the temple ([29:3](#)). When Hezekiah celebrated Passover, he invited people from the northern kingdom. This showed that both kingdoms could worship together at the place God had chosen ([30:18-20](#)). He temporarily restored the glory of Solomon's time ([30:26](#); compare [7:8-10](#)).

Israel's exile from the promised land did not end God's covenant community. Spiritual healing was always possible if the people chose to seek the

LORD. This was true whether they returned with war spoils or reunited at the Passover feast. Many Old Testament prophets who warned rebellious Judah or Israel also spoke of future renewal and restoration.

The hope of renewal is also true for the church, even when encountering death by persecution (attacks because of their faith) or corruption (see [Revelation 2-3](#)). God's kingdom stands on the solid "rock" of his promises (see [Matthew 16:18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 21:1-29](#); [2 Chronicles 11:13-17](#); [28:1-31:21](#); [33:1-20](#); [Jeremiah 18:7-17](#); [Ezekiel 16:1-63](#); [33:10-16](#); [Joel 2:12-32](#); [Luke 19:2-10](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#); [1 Timothy 1:15-17](#)

Atonement

[Leviticus 16](#) explains the Day of Atonement. On this day, the high priest presented the community's sins to the LORD. Worshiping a holy God requires removing any ceremonial uncleanness or sin. God's grace accepted an animal's death instead of the sinner's life. In these offerings, the sacrifice represented the worshiper's life. They sacrificed the animal so the worshiper could live. Blood represents life. God chose the blood of the sacrifice "that makes atonement" ([Leviticus 17:11](#)).

Atonement involves both *expiation* and *propitiation*. *Expiation* means paying what is owed. For example, the guilt offering involves damages or property loss, which must be repaid with a 20 percent extra charge ([5:14-6:7](#)). *Propitiation* means appeasing or reconciling with an offended person or group. For example, the whole burnt offering and the sin offering do not require a plain debt payment ([1:1-17](#); [4:1-5:13](#)).

In the atoning sacrifices that make peace with God, laying hands on the animal shows the worshiper's connection to the animal ([4:4-35](#); [16:21](#)). The blood represents the animal's life ([17:14](#)). It replaces the worshiper's life ([17:11](#)). They kill the animal, and offer to God its blood and certain parts in a ceremony. This cleanses and reconciles the worshiper with God.

The blood of Jesus provides atonement ([Ephesians 1:7](#); [Colossians 1:20](#)). It secures "eternal redemption" for Christians ([Hebrews 9:12](#)). Jesus, God's "Lamb," reconciles us with God ([John 1:29](#); [Hebrews 9:14](#)). He paid our sin debt (expiation)

and satisfied God's judgment against sin (propitiation).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:17-22](#); [30:10-16](#); [Leviticus 1:1-17](#); [4:1-6:7](#); [16:1-34](#); [17:10-14](#); [23:26-32](#); [Numbers 15:22-29](#); [29:7-11](#); [Psalm 51:7](#); [Proverbs 16:6](#); [Ezekiel 43:18-27](#); [Daniel 9:24](#); [John 1:29](#); [Ephesians 1:7](#); [Colossians 1:20](#); [Hebrews 2:16-17](#); [9:12-14](#)

Babel: The Dispersion of Nations

The story of the tower of Babel explains how language barriers separated nations and ethnic groups, scattering them geographically. After the great flood, when God judged a very evil human race, humans rebelled again by building a tower "that reaches to the heavens" ([Genesis 11:4](#)). Instead of worshiping God, they wanted to glorify themselves and unite without God. God saw their dangerous independence and pride that could lead them back to evil and destruction. So, God acted to "confuse their language," and he "scattered them over the face of all the earth" ([11:7, 9](#)).

Babel marks the start of differences and misunderstandings between peoples and nations who cannot understand each other's languages and cultures. This separation only begins to reverse with the coming of the Holy Spirit (see [Acts 2](#)).

After the nations scattered at Babel, God renewed His relationship with humanity through Abraham and his descendants ([Genesis 12:1-9](#)). Unlike the people at Babel, Abraham was righteous because he "believed the LORD." He lived by faith in God, not pride in his achievements ([15:6](#); [17:1](#); [18:19](#); [26:5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 11:1-9](#)

Baptism

Baptism has been a key part of Christianity since it began ([Acts 2:38](#)). In Judaism, "baptism" and "baptize" referred to a religious cleansing ceremony. The law of Moses required water to cleanse people from ceremonial impurity ([Numbers 19:14-19](#)).

Later, gentile (non-Jewish) converts to Judaism had to do certain things. These included studying the *Torah*, circumcision, and a ceremonial bath to

remove spiritual impurities from their gentile past. This cleansing often took place in special baths called *mikvahs*. Many synagogues had *mikvahs*, and the temple in Jerusalem had many as well. This suggests that worshippers would ceremonially bathe before worship.

John the Baptizer preached "a baptism of repentance for the forgiveness of sins" ([Luke 3:3](#)). John's baptism helped spiritually prepare people to receive God's chosen one, the Messiah ([Luke 3:4-6](#)). Those who received his baptism and repented were ready for Jesus' message ([Luke 7:29-30](#)).

After his resurrection, Jesus told his disciples to baptize new Christian disciples ([Matthew 28:19](#)). Christian baptism symbolizes dying and rising with Jesus. It represents leaving the old life and starting a new one ([Romans 6:1-4](#); [Colossians 2:12](#)). It also shows a Christian's spiritual connection with Jesus and his Church ([Galatians 3:27](#)).

Baptism is the ceremony for entering the Christian community. Many see Christian baptism as the replacement for circumcision, which marked entry into Israel under the old covenant (see [Colossians 2:11-12](#)). Regardless of its link to Old Testament circumcision, baptism represents a changed will and "a clear conscience" that comes from God's forgiveness ([1 Peter 3:21](#); compare [Deuteronomy 10:16](#); [30:6](#); [Jeremiah 4:4](#); [Romans 2:28-29](#); [Philippians 3:3](#)).

Christian baptism is a ceremonial cleansing that symbolizes the forgiveness of sins ([Acts 2:38](#); [10:43](#); [13:38](#); [26:17-18](#)). It also represents receiving the Holy Spirit ([2:38](#); [9:17-18](#); [10:47-48](#); [11:15-17](#); [19:5-7](#); [Luke 3:16](#)). Many believe baptism is an outward sign of the Spirit's inner "seal," which is a "pledge" of the eternal inheritance for God's faithful people ([2 Corinthians 1:21-22](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#); [4:30](#); [Titus 3:5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 3:6-16](#); [21:25](#); [28:19](#); [Mark 1:4-9](#); [10:38-39](#); [11:30](#); [16:16](#); [Luke 3:3-22](#); [7:29-30](#); [12:50](#); [20:4](#); [John 1:25-36](#); [3:22-23](#); [26](#); [4:1-2](#); [10:40](#); [Acts 1:5](#); [22](#); [2:38](#); [41](#); [8:12-13](#); [16-17](#); [36-38](#); [9:18](#); [10:37](#); [47-48](#); [11:16](#); [13:24](#); [16:15](#); [33](#); [18:8](#); [25](#); [19:1-7](#); [22:16](#); [Romans 6:3-4](#); [1 Corinthians 1:13-17](#); [10:2](#); [12:13](#); [15:29](#); [Galatians 3:27](#); [Ephesians 4:5](#); [Colossians 2:12](#); [Hebrews 6:2](#); [1 Peter 3:21](#); [1 John 5:6](#)

Basic Laws

In Scripture, the one true God is the highest authority. God's laws include both positive and negative commands. Two main laws summarize the positive commands:

- "You shall love the LORD your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your strength" ([Deuteronomy 6:5](#); [Matthew 22:37](#); [Mark 12:30](#); [Luke 10:27](#)).
- "Love your neighbor as yourself" ([Leviticus 19:18](#); [Matthew 19:19](#); [Mark 12:31](#); [Luke 10:27](#)).

We can see these two laws in the positive commands of the Ten Commandments ([Exodus 20:2-17](#); [Deuteronomy 5:6-21](#)):

- "Remember the Sabbath day"
- "Honor your father and mother"

The negative commands make a boundary between good and evil. The first two of the Ten Commandments are key:

- "You shall have no other gods before Me" ([Exodus 20:3](#)).
- "You shall not make for yourself an idol in the form of anything ... You shall not bow down to them or worship them" ([Exodus 20:4-5](#)).

These forbidden actions go against the basic command to love God.

The prophets' books show that God uses these laws to judge the Israelites' actions. God also uses them to judge any ruler, group, or person at any time or place. Those who violate these main laws reject the one true God. This leads to divine judgment and disasters for sinners.

Sections for Additional Study

[Exodus 20:2-17](#); [Leviticus 19:18](#); [Deuteronomy 5:6-21](#); [6:5](#); [Jeremiah 2:7-13](#); [3:8-11](#); [5:1-9](#); [6:10-21](#); [7:16-29](#); [8:9-13](#); [11:6-14](#); [17:1-4](#); [22:1-9](#); [23:10-12](#); [34:8-20](#); [Matthew 19:19](#); [22:37](#); [Mark 12:30-31](#); [Luke 10:27](#); [1 Corinthians 13:13](#)

Beauty in Nature

At the end of God's work of creation, God said that everything he made was "very good" ([Genesis 1:31](#)). Scripture often considers the beauty and wonder of God's creation, especially in the psalms (see, for example, [Psalm 8:3-4](#); [Psalm 104:1-35](#)).

Nature and imagery from nature are important in the Song of Solomons (or Song of Songs). The man and woman often express their love in the countryside ([Song of Solomon 2:8-17](#); [4:12-5:1](#); [6:2-3](#), [11-12](#)). This is a place with pleasant smells and private spots. The garden, vineyard, and orchard create intimate and romantic settings. The mystery of nature gives them a simple, yet unfamiliar and exciting, scene for their love.

The couple uses many nature metaphors to describe each other's physical features and their exciting effects. Their descriptions of each other lead them to use illustrations from God's creation.

Nature directs people to the creator, showing evidence of his power, goodness, justice, and love (see [Psalm 19:1-4](#); [Romans 1:18-20](#)). God's desire for redemption, restoration, and new creation is also evident in nature's beauty. Examples include the changing seasons, plant growth, and the birth of children.

Sections for Additional Study

[Genesis 2:1-9](#); [Psalms 8:3-8](#); [19:1-6](#); [96:5-6](#); [Song of Solomon 2:8-17](#); [4:12-5:1](#); [6:2-3](#), [11-12](#); [7:10-13](#); [Matthew 6:26-30](#)

Belonging to Christ

To many people today, the New Testament seems to present an extreme view of the Christian life. God calls Christians to give up their rights, endure suffering, and even face death for Jesus ([Mark 8:34-36](#)). They must turn away from worldly things that everyone pursues ([1 John 2:15-17](#)). They are to even despise their life in this world ([John 12:24-25](#)). Paul advises Christians to give up the usual desires for marriage and family and remain single for Jesus. Yet, this is only if they have that spiritual gift ([1 Corinthians 7:7](#)).

What is the reason for this extreme view of life? For Paul, it is the understanding that believers belong to Jesus, both body and soul. When Jesus died, he bought them for himself ([1 Corinthians 6:20](#)). They must no longer live only for themselves and their own desires ([2 Corinthians 5:14-15](#)). Having died

to their personal interests, he calls them to live fully for their Lord ([Romans 14:7-9](#)).

For true Christians, obeying Jesus is not a heavy burden. It is a way to show love and loyalty to the one who died for them. For Jesus' people, life is a joyful way to thank God for the grace shown through Jesus Christ. They are glad to dedicate their lives to serve the one who sacrificed everything for them (see [1 John 3:16](#)). By dying to their own desires, Christians allow Christ to live in and through them ([Galatians 2:19-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 9:26, 29; 32:9; 1 Kings 8:53; Psalms 2:8; 28:9; Ezekiel 18:4; Mark 8:34-36; 12:30; Romans 14:7-9; 1 Corinthians 6:19-20; 7:20-24; 7:32-35; 2 Corinthians 5:14-15; Galatians 2:19-20; 1 Peter 2:9-10](#)

Biblical Law

Biblical law is more than lists of rules. It is a system of what God expects about belief and behavior. If people follow it faithfully, they will receive God's greatest blessings. Keeping the law is essential for life ([Deuteronomy 4:1](#); see also [5:32-33](#); [8:1](#); [16:20](#)).

Israel's journey out of Egypt freed them to serve God. God rescued Israel "by a strong hand and an outstretched arm, and by great terrors" ([Deuteronomy 4:34](#)). This was not because Israel deserved it. But it was because God is gracious and keeps his promises to Abraham. The rescue from Egypt was not only to free the Israelites from hard labor ([Exodus 1:11-22; 5:4-23](#)). But it was also to make a covenant (special agreement) with them.

This covenant did not make the Israelites God's people. They already were his people (see [Exodus 4:22-23](#)). Obedience was not a requirement before the covenant. Instead, it was the right response to the covenant. It gave Israel the duty to serve God as "a kingdom of priests and a holy nation" ([Exodus 19:4-6](#)). God gave the law to guide Israel as a nation so that God's people would display his unfailing love and faithfulness.

The covenant promised the people of Israel a good and meaningful life if they followed the law. The covenant document includes broad principles, patterns, and standards. God's instructions are best known in the Ten Commandments ([Deuteronomy 5:6-21](#)). This is shown most briefly in the Jewish

prayer called the *Shema* (a Hebrew word meaning "hear"). This prayer is found in [Deuteronomy 6:4-5](#). All other laws of God interpret and apply these main principles.

The life that came from following the law was not eternal life as described in the New Testament. God promised that if the Israelites obeyed the covenant, the nation would enjoy long and successful days in the promised land ([Deuteronomy 4:1; 5:16, 33](#)). Jesus also urged his disciples to follow the Ten Commandments and the demands of the *Shema* ([Matthew 22:37-40](#)). This was not to gain eternal life but to show their commitment to him (compare [Matthew 5:17-19; John 14:15-21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 19:4-6; Leviticus 18:5; Deuteronomy 4:1-2; 5:6-21, 32-33; 6:1-9; 8:1; 30:1-20; Matthew 5:17-48; 22:36-40; John 14:15-21; Romans 3:19-24; 7:1-12; 1 Corinthians 9:20-21; Galatians 3:1-22; 5:14; Hebrews 7:18-19; 10:1](#)

Biblical Marriage

The story of creation portrays God as present with humanity's first union, set within the sacred space of the garden ([Genesis 2:18-25](#)). Biblical marriage is a binding covenant (special agreement) before God. Violating that covenant, such as through adultery, is a sin against both people and God. God is the divine witness who guarantees the marriage covenant (see [Malachi 2:10-16](#); compare [Genesis 39:6-9; Jeremiah 3:1; 1 Corinthians 6:9-10; Hebrews 13:4](#)). Although marriage is only between two people, it is not private. It is publically and legally declared, with community recognition, witnesses, and accountability (see [Leviticus 20:10-12; Deuteronomy 22:22; Jeremiah 29:20-23](#)).

Marriage is a metaphor for the LORD's relationship with his people (see [Exodus 19:3-6; 20:2-6; 34:14; Isaiah 54:5; Ezekiel 16; Hosea 2:19-20](#)). It is first with Israel and then with the church (see [2 Corinthians 11:2; Ephesians 5:21-33](#)). A marriage symbolizes something greater. God's people (Christ's "bride") await Christ's return (the "groom"). Married Christians should live in unity and dignity as they look forward to "the marriage of the Lamb" ([Revelation 19:6-9](#)). Christ will live forever with his faithful people in glory ([Revelation 19:7; 21:2, 9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:18-25; 24:65-67; Psalm 45:8-15; Isaiah 54:5; Hosea 2:19-20; Malachi 2:10-16; 1 Corinthians 7:1-40; 2 Corinthians 6:14-16; Ephesians 5:21-33; Hebrews 13:4; 1 Peter 3:1-7](#)

Blessing

Before the patriarch Jacob died, he blessed each of his sons and Joseph's sons ([Genesis 49:1-28; 48:3-20](#)). This was also how his father Isaac had blessed him ([27:27-29](#)). A blessing gives, improves, and enriches life, while a curse harms it ([Leviticus 26:14-39](#)). A benefactor (a person who gives help) gives a blessing publicly, providing power for prosperity and success.

Blessings are essential in covenant relationships. This is because they guide and motivate people to follow the covenant's rules ([Leviticus 26:3-13](#)). Obedience leads to blessings, while rebellion results in a curse (see [Deuteronomy 28](#)).

The first area of blessing is creation. God, as creator, gives blessings to animals and humans ([Genesis 1:22; 1:28](#); see [Psalms 104; 128:3-4](#)). God also uses humans also to give divine blessings. God chose Abraham to bless the nations ([Genesis 12:2-3](#)). God supports and purifies the family, government, and religion through blessings ([27:27-29; 14:19; 1 Kings 8:14, 52, 66; Leviticus 9:22](#)). Israel's priests passed on God's blessing to Israel ([Numbers 6:24-26; Deuteronomy 10:8](#)).

Old Testament blessings have three main aspects:

13. A greater group gives them to a lesser one ([Genesis 32:26; Hebrews 7:6-7](#)).
14. They show favor, leading to well-being and success ([Deuteronomy 28:3-7](#)).
15. They recognize that all power and blessings come from the creator. God's love is the source of all blessings ([Deuteronomy 7:7-8, 12-15](#)).

God's blessings in the Old Testament are very different from those in ancient pagan religions. In pagan religions, people believed that wealth and fertility in family, animals, and crops came through "sympathetic" magical ceremonies (special religious rituals) at their worship places. These ceremonies intended to influence the gods to maintain the cycle of life. In the Old Testament, all

life, fertility, and blessings came from God's command, as he is the only true and living God.

In the New Testament, blessings focus more on spiritual matters than material ones. They shift from the Israelite nation to the church and from temporary to eternal ([Matthew 6:25; Ephesians 1:3; 1 Peter 3:9](#)). Through his death, Jesus took on the consequences of sin's curse ([Galatians 3:13](#)). He established God's kingdom ([Matthew 3:2; 5:3-20; John 3:3-5](#)). He gave forgiveness of sin to its citizens ([Romans 4:6-25](#)). Now, God calls Christians to bless the world ([Luke 6:27-28; Romans 12:14](#); see also [Isaiah 19:24; Zechariah 8:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:22, 28; 9:26-27; 12:2-3; 14:19-20; 24:59-60; 27:1-41; 28:1-4; 32:24-30; 46:1-50:26; Leviticus 26:3-13; Numbers 6:22-27; Deuteronomy 7:12-15; 10:8; 28:1-14; 33:1-29; 1 Samuel 2:20-21; Psalm 128:1-6; Matthew 5:3-12; Luke 6:27-28; Romans 12:14; Galatians 3:13-14; Ephesians 1:3; Hebrews 7:6-7; 1 Peter 3:9](#)

Bread from Heaven

When the Israelites left Egypt and entered the wilderness, God provided manna. Manna was a substance like bread that God gave them to eat ([Exodus 16](#)). The LORD gave them enough food for their daily needs (see [Nehemiah 9:20-21](#)). This "bread from heaven" demonstrated God's love and showed his special care for Israel in the wilderness (see [Deuteronomy 8:3, 16; Psalms 78:24; 105:40](#); compare [Revelation 2:17](#)).

Manna was real food, but some passages use it symbolically. It represents a spiritual relationship with God. It is a sign of God's miraculous provision for his people (see [1 Corinthians 10:3-4](#)). At the same time, manna relates to Israel's complaints against God and their lack of trust in his provision ([Numbers 11:1-15](#); see [1 Corinthians 10:5](#)).

Jesus miraculously fed about 5,000 men near the Sea of Galilee, in addition to women and children. Then he taught in the synagogue at Capernaum about the "bread of life" ([John 6:22-59](#)). He called himself the "true bread from heaven" and "the bread of life" ([John 6:32-35](#)). He even connected eternal life with the need to eat "My flesh and drink My blood" ([John 6:50-58](#)). Manna provided food in the wilderness. But Jesus is the true bread from God, who offers spiritual food and strength. Israel's

need for food humbled them in the wilderness ([Deuteronomy 8:3](#)). Now, followers of Jesus must humble themselves and receive the fullness of his life by faith ([John 6:35-40, 47-51, 63-64](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 16:1-36](#); [Numbers 11:1-15](#); [Deuteronomy 8:3, 16](#); [Joshua 5:10-12](#); [Nehemiah 9:20-21](#); [Psalms 78:24](#); [105:40](#); [John 6:1-15, 22-64](#); [1 Corinthians 10:3-5](#); [Revelation 2:17](#)

Bribery and Gifts

The Bible provides clear teachings about bribes (payments given to unfairly influence decisions) and gifts (offerings given to show respect or maintain relationships). Bribes are strongly condemned because they corrupt justice and lead to unfair treatment. For example, [Exodus 23:8](#) commands, "Do not accept a bribe, for a bribe blinds those who see and twists the words of the righteous" (see also [Deuteronomy 16:19](#)).

The book of Proverbs includes several observations about how bribes and gifts operate in society. Some verses describe the effectiveness of bribes in achieving results ([Proverbs 17:8](#); [18:16](#)). These verses describe human behavior but do not endorse bribery.

Other verses in Proverbs explicitly show that bribery is wrong, especially when it corrupts justice ([Proverbs 15:27](#); [17:23](#)).

The Bible distinguishes between bribes and legitimate gifts. Bribes are secret payments meant to gain unfair advantages or pervert justice. Gifts, however, are often given openly to show respect, maintain relationships, or follow cultural customs of hospitality. For example, in [Genesis 32:20](#), Jacob sends gifts to Esau to mend their relationship. Similarly, [1 Samuel 10:27](#) describes people bringing gifts to honor Saul as their new king.

While the Bible recognizes the cultural role of gifts, it consistently condemns bribery, emphasizing justice, fairness, and integrity.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:8](#); [Deuteronomy 10:17](#); [16:19](#); [1 Samuel 8:1-3](#); [Proverbs 17:8, 23](#); [18:16](#); [29:4](#); [Ecclesiastes 7:7](#); [Isaiah 1:23](#); [33:14-16](#); [Amos 5:12](#); [Micah 3:9-12](#); [7:3](#); [Matthew 28:11-15](#)

By Faith

Faith is a key theme in Scripture, but many misunderstand it. Some think faith means any kind of spirituality, like saying someone is a "person of faith." Others think it means a strong belief that good things will happen, like a way to become healthy and wealthy. Some think faith means believing without evidence. None of these ideas represent biblical faith.

[Hebrews 11](#), one of the most loved passages of Scripture, offers a detailed essay on what it means to live "by faith." It describes faith as taking confident action based on what God has revealed. Throughout the chapter, examples show faith in different life situations. What faith produces can vary.

"By faith" some people find rescue, achieve success, and receive some of God's promises during their lives. "By faith" others face mockery, beatings, torture, imprisonment, and death. Faith might have a reward sooner or later. Faithful people hope for rewards because they trust that God is good and true to his promises.

What does it mean to live "by faith?" It means that in different situations, we act on our belief that God "exists and that He rewards those who earnestly seek Him" ([Hebrews 11:6](#)). People who live by faith take confident actions based on what God has shown about his character, intending to do his will in everything.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:6](#); [2 Chronicles 20:20](#); [Habakkuk 2:4](#); [Matthew 9:29](#); [21:21](#); [Luke 8:50](#); [John 3:16, 36](#); [5:24](#); [11:25](#); [12:46](#); [20:30-31](#); [Romans 5:1](#); [10:9, 17](#); [Galatians 3:6](#); [5:6](#); [1 Timothy 1:19](#); [6:12](#); [Hebrews 10:22, 38](#); [11:1-40](#); [James 1:5-6](#); [2:14-26](#); [1 John 3:23](#); [5:4](#)

Calling up the Dead

The Old Testament forbids magical practices like spiritism, divination, and necromancy. Necromancy involves contacting dead spirits, usually to seek future guidance (see [Deuteronomy 18:9-12](#)). Practicing necromancy and consulting a necromancer were crimes punishable by death ([Leviticus 20:6, 27](#); compare [1 Samuel 28:9](#)). Instead, God's people must rely on God for guidance.

God buried Moses in an unmarked grave ([Deuteronomy 34:6](#)). He probably did this to prevent the Israelites from turning Moses' grave into an idolatrous place of worship. God did not want them to present offerings to Moses' spirit, worship him, or try to contact his spirit. There might have been a temptation for the Israelites to do these things. This was because they experienced the Egyptians practice these things. Also, Moses' important role in mediating Israel's covenant with God could tempt them to practice unhealthy veneration of his memory.

The Old Testament states that people cannot contact the dead (see [2 Samuel 12:23](#); [Job 14:10-12](#); [Psalms 88:10](#); [115:17](#)). The prophet Samuel is the only known exception. It seems that God told him to return and speak (see [1 Samuel 28:12-19](#)). When Saul tried to contact Samuel through someone who claimed to speak with the dead (a medium), this sin was very serious. The writer of Chronicles highlights this failure when explaining why Saul lost his kingdom (see [1 Chronicles 10:13-14](#)). There is never a reason practice necromancy (to seek advice from the dead) when we have God's living word to guide us ([2 Timothy 3:15-17](#); [Hebrews 4:12-13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 19:31](#); [20:6-8, 27](#); [Deuteronomy 18:9-12](#); [1 Samuel 28:1-25](#); [2 Kings 21:6](#); [23:24](#); [1 Chronicles 10:13-14](#); [Job 14:10-12](#); [Isaiah 3:1-3](#); [8:19-22](#)

Canaanite Religion

The Canaanites explained creation or nature in relation to their gods. Each god represented a natural force. They considered the moon, sun, important stars, and visible planets as gods or goddesses.

Canaanite gods had two notable aspects:

16. Their personalities could change.
17. Their names related to their roles.

Some of these gods had great influence in the Israelites' interactions with the Canaanite people:

18. *El* means "the powerful one." He was the leader of the Canaanite gods. El lived far from Canaan, "at the source of the two rivers" (this may refer to the garden of Eden). He led a council of gods who were his children. In the Old Testament, *El* (plural *Elohim*) refers to God, but the Israelite God is not the same as the Canaanite god.
19. *Baal* means "lord." He was the great storm god and king of the gods. Though El was the leader, Baal had more active power as El's second in command. He provided all fertility. When Baal died, plants stopped growing and animals stopped reproducing. He was the god of justice and caused fear for those doing wrong.
20. *Dagon* means "fish" or "grain." He is sometimes called the father of *Baal*. *Dagon* was the main god of the Philistine city of Ashdod ([1 Samuel 5:1-7](#)).
21. *Ashtoreth*, *Anath*, and *Asherah* were the three main goddesses in the Canaanite group of gods. They focused mainly on sex and war. Their primary role was to have yearly sexual relations with *Baal*. This maintained *Baal*'s strength and guaranteed the earth would be fertile.

The Canaanites believed that the forces of nature were like people. These gods controlled the changing seasons. From April to October, they saw the dry period as *Baal*'s death after losing a battle each spring. The autumn rains marked *Baal*'s revival as the god of rain and plants, lasting until the next April. They thought the land became fertile again because of *Baal*'s yearly mating with his female partner. Their religious activities included imitating their gods' actions.

The Canaanites worshiped things they believed would bring them material benefits. If this pleased the gods and goddesses, they would provide a good harvest. If a god became angry, the people might offer animal or human sacrifices to calm the god (see [2 Kings 3:26-27](#)). Canaanite worship had its

basis in fear and trying to influence or pacify the gods.

Contact among the many religions of the ancient Near East led to social problems and borrowing religious practices. The Arameans and Philistines who settled in Canaan adopted Canaanite practices. In a similar way, the Amorites included Sumerian religious practices when they moved into Mesopotamia.

In contrast, Israel's God, Yahweh, required complete loyalty. His worship had its basis in faith, not fear. Unfortunately, the Israelites did not keep their belief in one God (monotheism). They adopted pagan ideas and practices, worshiping Canaanite gods in their way. Their culture became corrupted and angered God. As a result, God judged them and sent them into exile (see [2 Kings 17:5-23; 24:18-25:21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 5:1-12](#)

Celebration

God welcomes happy expressions of joy and delight from those who worship and praise him ([Isaiah 30:29](#); [Jeremiah 30:19](#); [31:13](#); [Zephaniah 3:17](#); [Ephesians 5:19](#); [Colossians 3:16](#)).

King David tried two times to bring the ark of God (also called "the ark of the LORD" or "the ark of the covenant") to Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 6:1-11, 12-23](#)). Both times involved celebration.

In the second procession with the ark, three Hebrew words describe "dancing" (see also [1 Chronicles 15:25-29](#)):

22. *karar* ("danced" in [2 Samuel 6:14, 16](#))
23. *pazaz* ("leaping" in [2 Samuel 6:16](#))
24. *raqad* ("dancing" in [1 Chronicles 15:29](#))

These words show a lively physical expression, unlike the Hebrew word for "celebrate" used in David's first attempt ([2 Samuel 6:5](#)). In the first procession with the ark, David celebrated. In the second, he danced joyfully and celebrated with music, shouting, and trumpets.

Musical instruments were important in temple worship. In [1 Chronicles 25:1-31](#), David assigned groups to music ministry. Many psalms mention playing instruments to praise and worship God

(see [Psalms 33:2-3; 57:8; 81:2; 92:1-3; 98:4-6](#)). In [Psalms 149](#) and [150](#), dance and music are combined as a praise offering. In a similar way, music and dancing were present in the father's house in the parable of the lost son ([Luke 15:25](#)). This was because the son's return was a joyful event.

The book of Revelation describes an eternal celebration for the faithful. This celebration involves worship in God's presence ([Revelation 4:1-11; 5:8-14; 15:1-4](#)). It is like a wedding feast where the bridegroom (Jesus Christ) and the bride (his church) unite forever ([Revelation 19:9](#); see also [Matthew 22:1-14](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 5:1; 12:17; 15:20-21; 1 Samuel 18:6; 2 Samuel 6:1-15; 2 Chronicles 7:6-10; Ezra 3:10-11; Psalms 30:11; 69:30; 98:4-6; 107:32; 149:1-9; 150:1-6; Isaiah 30:29; 54:1; Jeremiah 30:18-19; 31:4, 13; Lamentations 5:14-15; Zephaniah 3:17; Luke 15:22-25; 1 Corinthians 5:8; Ephesians 5:18-20; Colossians 3:16; Revelation 18:20](#)

Charismatic Leadership

Scripture describes some leaders as *charismatic* (gifted) because their authority came from God's Spirit. God's Spirit gave them special qualities.

The Old Testament judges are often part of this group. These charismatic leaders emerged during troubled times in response to problems. In the book of Judges, these problems often happened because the Israelites "did evil in the sight of the LORD." This led to enemies oppressing Israel ([Judges 3:12; 4:1; 6:1; Judges 10:6; 13:1](#)).

The leadership of the judges followed a pattern. God's Spirit "came upon" a judge and prophetic support sustained them. At other times in Israel's history, God gave prophetic messages (for example, [1 Samuel 10:6; 2 Samuel 23:2; Isaiah 61:1; Ezekiel 11:5; Micah 3:8](#)). In the time of the judges, the Spirit at times gave physical strength (for example, to Samson in [Judges 14:6, 19; 15:14](#)). The Spirit also sometimes gave skill or leadership power to judges ([Judges 3:10; 6:34; 11:29](#)).

Jesus and the apostles led people through spiritual power. The Jewish leaders often pointed out that Jesus had no "official" title or authority, yet he showed great power and gained many followers. The apostles were appointed to positions we might

call "offices." While the early church had some basic organization, it was not as structured as it would later become. The authority of the apostles was a gift from the Holy Spirit. Peter's healing of the beggar indicates the difference between material wealth, like "silver or gold," and true spiritual power ([Acts 3:1-8](#)).

Throughout history, from ancient Israel until today, many leaders have shown God's power working through them. This kind of leadership depends on God's Spirit giving them special qualities. But if leaders stop following God's Spirit, they can lose these special qualities (see [Judges 16:20-21](#); [1 Samuel 16:14](#); [Isaiah 63:10](#)). Leaders gifted by the Spirit must always remain aware of and rely on that same Spirit.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 31:2-5](#); [Judges 2:16-19](#); [3:10](#), [27-28](#); [6:34-35](#); [11:29](#); [14:6](#), [19](#); [15:14](#); [1 Samuel 10:6](#); [16:13-18](#); [2 Samuel 23:2](#); [Isaiah 61:1](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#); [Micah 3:8](#); [Matthew 3:16-4:2](#); [Acts 6:8](#); [8:4-40](#); [Romans 1:11](#); [12:6-8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:4-11](#); [Ephesians 4:11-12](#)

Children and Parents

Wise children bring great joy to their parents, while foolish children cause them much grief ([Proverbs 10:1](#); [15:20](#); [17:21](#), [25](#)). This motivates parents to guide their children toward wisdom and encourages children to listen to wise advice ([19:26-27](#)).

When children need discipline, parents should not avoid their responsibility, as this can harm the child ([Proverbs 19:18](#); [22:15](#); [23:13-14](#)). Parents should teach their children about the Lord through their own wise and moral behavior ([Deuteronomy 6:1-25](#); [Proverbs 20:7](#); [22:6](#)). They should also tell them about God's great acts in history ([Psalm 78:1-8](#)). This knowledge will guide children to obedience and blessings. Children should respect their godly parents ([Proverbs 20:20](#); [30:11-14](#), [17](#)).

Proverbs focuses on the strength and influence of a united family that loves and obeys God. The book strongly warns against those who would harm a family ([Proverbs 6:16-19](#); [11:29](#)). It greatly praises those who strengthen the family (see [14:1](#)). A family that relies on the Lord can truly thrive ([Psalms 127-128](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 5:16](#); [6:1-9](#), [20-25](#); [7:3-6](#); [Psalms 78:1-8](#); [103:13](#); [127:1-128:6](#); [Proverbs 1:8-9](#); [3:1-2](#); [4:1-4](#); [10:1](#); [11:21](#), [29](#); [12:7](#); [13:22](#); [14:1](#); [15:20](#); [17:21](#), [25](#); [19:18](#), [26](#); [20:7](#), [20](#); [22:6](#), [15](#); [23:13-14](#); [29:15](#), [17](#); [30:11-14](#), [17](#); [Mark 7:9-13](#); [Luke 1:17](#); [18:29-30](#); [Ephesians 6:1-4](#)

Christian Giving

Generous Christian giving shows true grace. We see this in "our Lord Jesus Christ, that though He was rich, yet for your sakes He became poor, so that you through His poverty might become rich" ([2 Corinthians 8:9](#); [Philippians 2:5-8](#)). We have received his undeserved favor in salvation, and we give generously in response to "His indescribable gift!" ([2 Corinthians 9:15](#)).

Jesus taught that generosity shows who follows him ([Matthew 25:34-36](#)). He emphasized the importance of a person's intentions and attitude, not only the amount given ([Mark 12:41-44](#)).

In 2 Corinthians, the apostle Paul emphasizes the theme of giving. He encourages the church at Corinth to give generously to help those in need, especially the poor Jewish Christians in Jerusalem ([2 Corinthians 8:6-7](#); [9:1-5](#)). This generosity would show that gentile Christians and Jewish Christians in Jerusalem are part of the same "body."

Here is a summary of Paul's teachings about Christian giving:

25. Our giving should come from a willing mind and heart ([2 Corinthians 8:12](#); [9:7](#)). Paul emphasizes motives because the reason behind our giving is most important.
26. True giving brings joy, unlike reluctant gifts ([2 Corinthians 9:5](#)). When we give to others, it brings joy, just as a farmer is happy when planting (sowing seed) because they know crops will grow ([9:6-10](#)). Sharing with those in need also brings joy ([9:1-2](#)).
27. Christian giving is generous and may involve sacrifice, as shown by the Macedonians ([2 Corinthians 8:1-5](#)).

28. Handling financial gifts requires honesty, integrity, and care. Paul was careful to protect his colleagues who collected gifts from the churches from suspicion ([2 Corinthians 8:20-21](#)). People managing church donations should have a proven reputation and responsibility.

Christian living should show a generous concern for those in need. Paul instructs Christians to please God, not themselves ([2 Corinthians 5:15](#)). Christians should live under Jesus' leadership and his love should motivate them ([5:14](#)). We can show his love clearly through our giving.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:2; 35:5; Leviticus 25:35; Deuteronomy 15:7-11; 16:17; 1 Chronicles 29:9; Proverbs 3:9-10; 11:24-26; 21:13; 28:27; Malachi 3:8; Matthew 5:42; 6:3-4; 10:8; 19:21; Luke 6:38; 11:41; 12:33-34; 18:22; Acts 11:29; 1 Corinthians 13:3; 16:2-3; 2 Corinthians 5:17-18; 2 Corinthians 8:1-9:15; Philippians 2:3-11](#)

Christian Joy

In the final hours of his life, Jesus wanted his disciples filled with his joy (see [John 15:11; 16:20-24](#)). Joy is a common topic in many of the apostle Paul's letters and is a key theme in Philippians. Paul often encourages Christians to be joyful, especially those facing persecution, like the Christians in Philippi and Thessalonica ([Philippians 3:1; 4:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:16](#)).

Surface-level happiness depends on what is happening around you. Christian joy is different. It comes from a person's relationship with the Lord. It remains strong even during suffering and death. Joy comes from knowing that whatever happens, God will use everything for a Christian's ultimate good (see [Romans 5:3-4; 8:28](#)).

Christians also find joy in the active presence of God's Spirit in their hearts (see [Galatians 5:22](#)). The real secret to a joyful life is "to be filled with the Holy Spirit" (see [Ephesians 5:18](#)). A relationship with the living God forms Christians' attitudes, not external circumstances.

Passages for Further Study

[John 15:11; 16:24; Romans 5:3-4; 8:28; Galatians 5:22; Ephesians 5:18; Philippians 3:1; 4:4; 1 Thessalonians 5:16](#)

Christian Suffering

We should not be surprised when we experience suffering ([1 Peter 4:12](#)). Christians who live differently by obeying God should expect the culture to respond with hostility. We should expect mockery, bad treatment, false accusations, and even violence.

God has a purpose for us in suffering. It unites us further to Christ, who suffered before God glorified him ([1 Peter 4:13](#); see also [Romans 8:17](#)). By suffering with Christ, we can be sure of sharing in the glory he has already achieved.

The Letter of 1 Peter emphasizes Christian suffering, especially unfair persecution by those who are against the Christian faith. These themes of suffering are most clearly explained in [4:12-19](#).

We need to commit to doing what is right when we experience suffering ([1 Peter 4:19](#)). Difficulties can often become excuses for sinning. But during difficult times, we must live as good examples by showing love for others. Our loving response to enemies during times of distress can be a powerful chance to share our Christian faith. When we show love and kindness to those who hurt us, others may become interested in our faith.

We should remember during our distresses that it is "God's will" and he is "faithful" ([1 Peter 4:19](#)). He controls all of life's circumstances. So we do not need to fear any distress as if it could be outside God's oversight or will.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 48:10; 52:13-53:12; 63:7-9; Mark 10:35-40; Acts 5:41; 9:16; 14:22; Romans 8:17-23; 2 Corinthians 1:5-7; 4:10; 12:10; Philippians 1:29; Colossians 1:24; 1 Thessalonians 2:14; 2 Thessalonians 1:5; 2 Timothy 3:12; Hebrews 2:9-10; 5:8; 13:12; James 5:11-13; 1 Peter 4:12-19](#)

Church Leaders

The first church gatherings were spontaneous and God's spirit gave gifts in a special way (see [1 Corinthians 14:26-33](#)). The apostles generally led the Christian communities along with the elders in

Jerusalem ([Acts 6:2](#); [8:14](#); [14:23](#); [Acts 15:4](#), [6](#), [22-23](#)). Jewish synagogue and Greco-Roman models influenced their roles. The titles and roles of Christian leaders outside Jerusalem were flexible (for example [Acts 6:1-6](#); [13:1-3](#)). But local leaders depended on the apostles when possible.

Teachers and prophets had key roles in church meetings (see [Acts 11:27-30](#); [1 Corinthians 14:26-40](#)). Apostles often started churches before they appointed "elders" ([Titus 1:5](#); [Acts 14:23](#)). These appointments were based on spiritual gifts and sometimes on age (see [1 Corinthians 12:28-30](#); [Ephesians 4:11-13](#)).

Community leaders probably existed even without formal titles. In the letters to Timothy and Titus, there is a strong focus on the roles of overseer (*bishop*), elder (*presbyter*), and deacon. How these roles developed over time is unclear. The practices in 1 Timothy and Titus might not have been widespread. Elders in Ephesus and Crete may have had more teaching duties to oppose false teachers.

Otherwise, the issues suggested in [1 Corinthians 14:26-33](#) might have continued. These letters focus on ensuring the gospel is shared accurately.

The apostle Paul influenced and guided the people and places where he shared the good news. But there is no evidence that Paul wanted to create a system to govern all the churches in these areas. Paul expected the overseers to continue the gospel teaching and discipline roles under the broader responsibilities and authority of the apostles. As local church leaders, they held real and unique authority in their communities (see [1 Corinthians 5:3-5](#); [1 Timothy 4:11-16](#); [5:19-22](#); [2 Timothy 2:14-19](#), [25-26](#); [Titus 2:15](#); [3:10-11](#)). Soon after the apostles died, the church's structure became more centralized around the bishop's office, as shown in early second-century Christian writings.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 6:1-6](#); [13:1-3](#); [14:23](#); [15:4-35](#); [1 Corinthians 12:28-30](#); [14:26-33](#); [Ephesians 4:11-13](#); [1 Timothy 3:1-13](#); [4:11-16](#); [5:17-22](#); [2 Timothy 2:2, 25-26](#); [Titus 1:5-9](#); [2:15](#)

Circumcision

Many ancient cultures practiced circumcision, the removal of the male foreskin (see [Jeremiah 9:25-26](#)).

God chose circumcision as a sign of a covenant (special agreement) that focuses on descendants. God promised to make Abraham and his descendants into a great nation and to use them to redeem the non-Jewish nations ([Genesis 12:2, 3](#); [17:3-6](#); see [Galatians 3:8-9](#)). Circumcision was God's mark on the body. It identified Abraham and his descendants as God's people ([Genesis 17:9-14](#)). It reminded them to live faithfully to the covenant.

They performed circumcision on adult males when they joined the covenant community ([Genesis 17:23-27](#); [Exodus 12:48](#); [Joshua 5:3-7](#)). But it was usually for infants ([Genesis 21:4](#); [Leviticus 12:3](#)). Infants received God's promises and joined the covenant community through their parents.

Faith was necessary to receive God's blessings. This was shown by the differences between Ishmael and Isaac, Esau and Jacob, and Joseph and his brothers. Non-Israelites could also join Israel's covenant ([Exodus 12:48](#); compare [Genesis 34:15-24](#)). Circumcision marked their inclusion in the worshiping community (for example, [Exodus 12:44](#)).

Circumcision helped Israel remember to set aside natural impurity. God's people had to stay loyal to the covenant, their family, and their marriages. Marrying uncircumcised people outside the covenant violated the covenant. The people expelled ("cut off") any man who refused circumcision (a symbolic physical *cut*) from the covenant people for disobeying God's command ([Genesis 17:14](#)).

Circumcision symbolizes separation from the world, purity, and loyalty to the covenant. It offers a strong metaphor for the "circumcision of the heart." This refers to a heart committed to God and set apart for him, rather than being stubbornly resistant ([Leviticus 26:41](#); [Deuteronomy 30:6](#); [Jeremiah 4:4](#); [9:26](#); [Ephesians 2:11](#)). Circumcision of the heart shows salvation and fellowship with God (see [Ezekiel 18:31-32](#); [36:25-27](#); [Romans 2:28-29](#); [4:11](#)).

When Jesus Christ created God's new covenant, he fulfilled the old covenant's requirements. Gentile Christians do not need circumcision because faith in Jesus makes them part of God's people ([Acts 15:1-29](#); [Romans 2:25-29](#); [Galatians 2:1-10](#); [6:15](#); [Colossians 2:11-12](#)). One must trust in God and his promises, abandon sinful actions and worldly customs, and live a new life by faith (see [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Romans 8:1-17](#); [Galatians 5:16-6:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 17:9-14](#), [23-27](#); [21:4](#); [34:1-26](#); [Exodus 4:24-26](#); [12:48](#); [Leviticus 12:3](#); [Joshua 5:2-8](#); [Jeremiah 9:25-26](#); [Ezekiel 44:7-9](#); [Luke 1:59](#); [2:21](#); [Acts 15:1-31](#); [16:1-5](#); [Romans 2:25-29](#); [1 Corinthians 7:17-19](#); [Galatians 5:1-6](#), [11-12](#); [6:12-16](#); [Ephesians 2:11-18](#); [Philippians 3:2-7](#); [Colossians 2:11](#); [3:11](#)

Circumcision in the New Testament

Circumcision, which is the removal of the male foreskin, was common in the ancient Near East (see [Jeremiah 9:25-26](#)). For Jews, it held religious importance as a sign of the covenant (special agreement) God made with the people of Israel ([Genesis 17:9-14](#); [Joshua 5:2](#); [John 7:22](#); [Acts 7:8](#); [Sirach 44:20](#)). They usually performed it on the eighth day after a male infant's birth ([Genesis 17:12](#); [Leviticus 12:3](#); [Luke 1:59](#); [Acts 7:8](#)).

The New Testament mentions the circumcision of John the Baptizer, Jesus, and the apostles Paul and Timothy ([Luke 1:59](#); [2:21](#); [Acts 16:2-3](#); [Philippians 3:5](#)). Circumcision also became a symbol for renewing a person's relationship with God ([Deuteronomy 10:16](#); [30:6](#); [Jeremiah 4:4](#); [Romans 2:28-29](#)). In the late 40s AD, some Jewish Christians wanted gentile (non-Jewish) Christians to become circumcised ([Acts 15:1, 5](#); see [21:20-21](#); [Galatians 2:4](#), [11-13](#)). But Paul and Barnabas disagreed ([Acts 15:2](#)). The Church council in Jerusalem decided that gentiles did not need to become circumcised ([15:19-21](#), [28-29](#)).

Paul insisted that it does not matter if a man becomes circumcised ([1 Corinthians 7:19](#)). What matters is faith showing itself through love ([Galatians 5:6](#)). In Galatians, Paul argued against strong Jewish opponents and stated that everyone joins God's family through faith in Jesus Christ ([Galatians 2:14-21](#)). Circumcision is not necessary for God to accept a person ([Galatians 5:6](#)). Jesus' death on the cross is how sinners enter into covenant with God ([Galatians 2:14-21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 17:9-14](#); [Leviticus 12:3](#); [Joshua 5:2-9](#); [Jeremiah 9:25-26](#); [Luke 1:59](#); [Luke 2:21](#); [John 7:22-24](#); [Acts 7:8](#); [Acts 15:1-5](#), [19-21](#), [28-31](#); [Acts 16:2-3](#); [Acts 21:18-24](#); [Romans 2:25-29](#); [1 Corinthians 7:17-19](#); [Galatians 2:3-5](#), [11-21](#); [Galatians 5:6](#); [Galatians 6:15](#); [Philippians 3:5-9](#); [Colossians 2:11-23](#)

Citizenship in the Kingdom

First-century Jews wanted a king like David or leader like Judas Maccabeus to defeat their oppressors. Jesus' idea of the kingdom of God was very different from these hopes ([Matthew 5:43-48](#)).

The Gospel of Matthew shows Jesus as a unique teacher, and the sermon on the mount is his longest and most famous sermon. It is more than just a set of Jesus' teachings about right and wrong. It is a guide for living as a citizen in the kingdom of heaven.

Jesus described the kingdom of heaven as:

- 29. a connection with God,
- 30. a change of heart, and
- 31. relationships with others.

This new message of the kingdom made a strong impact on those who listened to Jesus ([Matthew 7:28-29](#)).

People often make clear distinctions between these three areas, but all are always present. For example, Jesus' instruction on humility seems inward at first, but it also involves our attitude toward God and others ([Matthew 5:5](#)). The command not to resist an evil person appears outward-focused ([5:39](#)). But it often requires active faith in God and inner strength. Jesus' instruction on prayer mainly concerns our relationship with God ([6:5-15](#)). But prayer starts with understanding that you need God's help. It also often involves your relationships with other people.

To be a citizen in the kingdom of heaven, you must follow Jesus and live a God-centered life, not a self-centered one. Trying to be righteous on your own keeps you in darkness because it is still self-focused. Jesus calls for true righteousness, which is the righteousness of God himself ([Matthew 5:20, 48](#)). You cannot achieve this righteousness on your own. Jesus gives it to those who follow him.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 7:24-29](#); [13:1-52](#); [Mark 10:14-16](#); [Luke 8:1-3](#); [9:1-6](#); [John 3:1-21](#); [Acts 8:12](#); [28:23-31](#)

Clean, Unclean, and Holy

The rules about ceremonial cleanness and uncleanness set Israel apart from other nations.

One idea is that unclean things relate to death or the earth (see, for example, [Leviticus 21:1, 11; 22:8](#)). Recent studies suggest the idea of what is "normal." God values order. Things that fit God's order are "clean" and "permitted." Abnormal things are not suitable for food or offerings and are "unclean."

A normal land animal would eat plants (see [Genesis 1:30](#)). A normal human body would have no infections or discharges. A normal piece of cloth would be free of mildew. If something abnormal happened, the animal, person, or cloth was unclean.

What is unclean is not sinful but represents unworthiness and cannot touch what is holy (for example, [Leviticus 11:44-45](#)). Once cleansed, it can become holy and dedicated to God. If people treat holy things, like the Sabbath, as common, they show disrespect to (or blaspheme) God and make it unholy. When something clean becomes unclean, it needs cleansing. Some things, like unclean animals, fish, or birds, are always unclean and can never become holy.

In the new covenant, things once considered unclean are now clean ([Acts 10:15, 28, 45](#)). Yet, God values order and wants orderly worship ([1 Corinthians 14:33, 40](#)). God offers grace to those who repent (turn away from wrong actions and return to God). Yet, some actions still offend his holiness and should not be in his presence (for example, Ananias and Sapphira's offering; see [Acts 5:1-11](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 7:2](#); [Leviticus 11:1-15:33](#); [21:1-23](#); [22:3-8](#); [Numbers 19:1-22](#); [Deuteronomy 14:1-21](#); [21:1-9](#); [Psalms 19:9](#); [24:3-4](#); [51:7-10](#); [Isaiah 52:11](#); [Matthew 8:2-4](#); [John 13:10-11](#); [Acts 10:9-28](#); [Hebrews 9:13-15, 23](#)

Community Identity

In many Western cultures, people often emphasize individual identity and personal independence. In contrast, many Eastern cultures, such as those in China and India, prioritize family and community relationships over individual interests. Similarly, in ancient Israel, a person's identity and importance came from their role in the community. All Israelites were expected to share the community's identity as the "children of Israel" and show the characteristics that defined the group.

In the Old Testament, God often speaks to the whole people in the singular. This emphasizes their unity. The Ten Commandments and Aaron's blessing use singular language ([Exodus 20:2-17](#); [Numbers 6:24-26](#)). One person could represent the group, and the group could have one person as a representative.

For instance, Nehemiah asks for forgiveness of sins that led to the Babylonian exile, saying, "I confess the sins that we Israelites have committed" ([Nehemiah 1:6-7](#)). Nehemiah was the governor of Judea from 445 to 433 BC, about 140 years after Jerusalem's destruction in 586 BC. So, he did not commit those sins. Yet, in his prayer, he identifies himself with his people's sins.

In a similar way, the high priest could represent all the people on the day of atonement ([Leviticus 16](#)). Because individuals had such a close link to the community, one person's sin could become the community's sin if not addressed ([Leviticus 4:3-21](#); [20:1-5](#)).

In a similar way, Paul describes the Christian community as the "body of Christ" ([1 Corinthians 12:27](#); [Ephesians 4:12](#)). Members share Christ's identity through the Holy Spirit. As the body of Christ, they show Christ's life in their own lives. Together, they reveal him to the world. The apostle Paul encourages the Galatian church to help "Carry one another's burdens" and thus follow Christ's example ([Galatians 6:2](#); [Matthew 11:28-30](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 20:5-6, 8-10](#); [Leviticus 4:3-21](#); [20:1-5](#); [Joshua 7:1-26](#); [Nehemiah 1:6-7](#); [1 Corinthians 12:12-27](#); [Galatians 6:2](#); [Ephesians 4:11-13](#)

Community Responsibility: Achan's Sin

Is the whole community responsible for the wrongs of a few people?

Why did many of Israel's soldiers die at Ai due to Achan's sin ([Joshua 7](#))? Why did the Israelites stone Achan's family with him? Understanding community responsibility helps answer these questions.

If Achan's family knew about his theft, they shared his guilt. A community becomes responsible for sin when its members either take part in a sinful act or silently approve of sinful actions or attitudes.

What about Achan's children who were too young to understand or did not know about his theft? What about Israel's soldiers who died at Ai because Achan took what belonged to God?

To understand, we must return to the beginning.

The sin of our first parents, Adam and Eve, had at least two aspects ([Genesis 3](#)):

32. They chose not to trust God, even though they had a close relationship with him. Instead, they listened to a stranger.
33. They tried to become like gods themselves. They declared their independence from God, even though they failed.

Since everyone makes the same choice for themselves, no one is truly innocent (see [Psalm 14:2-3](#); [Romans 3:9-23](#)). As a result, we all face the consequences of sin in the world. We might die because of another person's sin, carelessness, or ignorance, or because of our own actions. When someone drinks alcohol and drives, they can crash and kill other people. When people care more about making money than helping others, they may force their workers to work in unsafe places. When Achan sinned, others in Israel died at Ai.

This situation may not seem "fair." Yet, God promises to bring perfect justice in his own time. God's justice will come through his grace and mercy, brought to us through Jesus' death in our place (see [Romans 5:12-21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 9:24-27](#); [Exodus 20:5](#); [Joshua 7:1-26](#); [2 Kings 14:6](#); [2 Kings 21:10-15](#); [Ezra 9:6-15](#); [Nehemiah 9:16-37](#); [Jeremiah 31:29-30](#); [Ezekiel 18:20](#); [Daniel 9:4-19](#); [Matthew 23:29-36](#); [John 9:1-3](#); [Romans 5:12-21](#); [1 Corinthians 15:21](#)

Compassionate Healer

The New Testament often describes Jesus as someone who "had compassion." This phrase is sometimes translated as "felt sorry" or "took pity."

It appears in complex situations where:

34. Someone shows distress and Jesus resolves the distress ([Matthew 18:23-26](#); [20:29-33](#); [Matthew 18:27](#); [20:34](#)).

35. Jesus displays deep emotion ([Matthew 14:14](#); [15:32](#); [18:27](#); [20:34](#)).

36. There is a contrast with those lacking compassion ([Matthew 9:32-36](#); [18:27-30](#); [20:29-34](#)).

In the Gospels, "had compassion" directly refers to Jesus, but it also appears in parables where it can refer to God the Father or Jesus ([Matthew 18:27](#); [Luke 10:33](#); [15:20](#)).

In the Old Testament, God's compassion refers to his tender mercy, most often toward his covenant people. God withdrew this compassion to judge Israel's stubborn unfaithfulness ([Isaiah 27:11](#); [63:15](#); [Jeremiah 13:14](#)). God restored his compassion when Israel repented ([Deuteronomy 13:18](#); [30:2-3](#); [Proverbs 28:13](#); [Isaiah 55:7](#)).

The Old Testament often describes the messianic age (the time when God's chosen leader would come) as a time of God's compassion ([Isaiah 14:1](#); [49:10](#), [13](#); [54:8](#), [10](#); [60:10](#); [Jeremiah 12:15](#); [33:26](#); [Ezekiel 39:25](#); [Micah 7:19](#); [Habakkuk 3:2](#); [Zechariah 10:6](#)). The Gospels show this idea again, as the messianic age has begun and God's covenant love is active in Israel once again.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 13:18](#); [30:3](#); [1 Kings 8:50-51](#); [Proverbs 28:13](#); [Isaiah 14:1](#); [49:10](#), [13](#); [54:7-10](#); [55:7](#); [60:10](#); [Jeremiah 12:14-15](#); [33:26](#); [Ezekiel 39:25](#); [Micah 7:18-20](#); [Habakkuk 3:2](#); [Zechariah 1:16](#); [10:6](#); [Matthew 9:35-36](#); [14:14](#); [15:32](#); [18:23-30](#); [20:29-34](#); [Luke 10:33-37](#); [15:20-32](#)

Complaints

The Bible teaches that complaining is often wrong. For example, God judged the Israelites for complaining about their difficulties in the wilderness ([Numbers 14:27-37](#)). The Job complained a lot and received God's rebuke. But God still confirmed that Job was righteous and rejected those who tried to silence him ([Job 42:7-8](#)).

Job's main complaint was that God did not give him a fair chance to prove his innocence. Job's friends criticized him for trying to defend himself, but God supported Job's innocence. In a kind yet firm way, God revealed himself and corrected Job for his excessive self-defense that implied criticism of God's fairness. God redirected Job's attention from his problems to God himself ([Job 38-41](#)).

Scripture requires us to rejoice and give thanks in all situations ([Ephesians 5:20](#); [Philippians 4:4](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:16–18](#)). It also urges us to endure suffering and persist in prayer ([James 5:10–18](#)). If we feel the need to complain in prayer, we should follow the example of the psalms, which guide us back to God (see, for example, [Psalm 13](#)). Job's positive example is not in his response to troubles or comforters, but in his response to God ([James 5:11](#); [Job 40:3–5](#); [42:1–6](#)). In difficult and confusing times, we can still recognize God's sovereignty and goodness.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 4:13–14](#); [Exodus 16:2–18](#); [Numbers 14:27–37](#); [1 Kings 19:3–18](#); [Job 3:1–26](#); [Job 6:1–7:21](#); [Psalms 38](#); [Psalms 39](#); [Psalms 44](#); [Psalms 73](#); [Jeremiah 20:14–18](#); [Jonah 4:1–11](#); [Matthew 27:46](#); [John 6:41–59](#); [1 Corinthians 10:1–10](#); [Ephesians 5:20](#); [Philippians 2:14–15](#); [James 5:9–11](#)

Complete Dedication

The Hebrew word *kherem* (related to the verb *kharam*) means something that is “specially set apart.” It has no exact match in modern English. The word can mean either to destroy something completely or to dedicate it fully to the Lord.

In the Old Testament

When Joshua led Israel into Canaan, some items were connected with false gods. These items were called *kherem* because they were opposed to the Lord. God required the Israelites to destroy them (see [Joshua 6:18](#)). Valuable metals, however, were placed in the holy place and became holy to the Lord ([Leviticus 27:28](#); see also [Joshua 6:19, 24](#)).

The same idea applied to Israel's enemies. They and their belongings could be “specially set apart” to God by being destroyed ([Joshua 6:17–19](#); [1 Samuel 15:2–3](#)). God told King Saul to destroy the Amalekites as judgment because they attacked Israel after God led them out of Egypt. ([Exodus 17:8–16](#); [Deuteronomy 25:17–19](#)). This act showed that God curses those who curse his chosen people ([Genesis 12:3](#)).

In [Leviticus 27:21](#) and [28](#), *kherem* refers to a vow dedicating something permanently to the Lord, such as land, items, or even people (see [Numbers 18:14](#)). These became “most holy” and set apart for the Lord's service. They could not be redeemed or taken back.

God required this complete dedication or destruction when people committed serious offenses against him, such as worshiping false gods ([Deuteronomy 7:1–6](#); [13:12–18](#)).

In the New Testament

The idea of complete dedication continued into New Testament teaching. Paul used the Greek word *anathema* (the word the Septuagint uses to translate *kherem*) when speaking of judgment and devotion:

37. In [Romans 9:3](#), Paul was willing to have God curse him if it would lead to the salvation of his fellow Jews.
38. In [Galatians 1:8–9](#), the same Greek word describes the final end of those who preach a false gospel.
39. In [1 Corinthians 12:3](#), Paul warns that no one speaking by the Holy Spirit can say, “Jesus be cursed.” This means that those with God's Spirit will not see the death of Jesus on the cross as a sign of God's rejection, as some Jews of Paul's time did. Instead, they will understand it as an act of atonement for sinful humanity, making things right between God and people.

For Christians Today

In the new covenant, Christians are not called to destroy people. Instead, God calls believers to show mercy to those who wrong them ([Luke 9:51–56](#)). Followers of Christ must “put to death” anything within themselves that opposes him ([Romans 8:12–13](#); [Colossians 3:5](#)). Christians overcome evil not by violence, but through faith, the good news of Jesus, and love ([Ephesians 6:10–20](#); [1 John 2:9–17](#)). Final judgment belongs to God, who will act justly at the right time ([Romans 12:19](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:6–10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 22:20](#); [Leviticus 27:28–29](#); [Numbers 18:8–14](#); [21:2–3](#); [Deuteronomy 7:1–6](#), [26](#); [13:12–18](#); [Joshua 6:17–19](#), [24](#); [7:11–15](#); [1 Samuel 15:2–3](#); [1 Kings 20:42](#); [Isaiah 43:26–28](#); [Malachi 4:5–6](#); [Romans 9:3](#); [1 Corinthians 16:22](#); [Galatians 1:8–9](#)

Complete Destruction

See Complete Dedication.

Completion of the Second Temple

The dedication of Israel's second temple on March 12, 515 BC, was a major event for the Israelites returning from exile in Babylon. They could now worship and praise God as their ancestors did before the exile. This new temple allowed them to fulfill God's requirements for a covenant relationship. The high priest could enter God's presence to sprinkle blood once a year on the day of atonement for the nation's sins. After seventy years apart from God, he restored the covenant community.

This joyful event was not without challenges. With God's help, the returned exiles overcame sixteen years of opposition from those living in the land and Persian officials. Despite their enemies' efforts to discourage them, the Israelites rebuilt the temple. They once again established worship through patience, persistence, and strong prophetic encouragement ([Ezra 5:1-5; 6:14](#)).

The dedication of the temple shows that God can achieve his goals through a small group of people. These people focus on pleasing him and trust him to provide what they need to fulfill his promises (see [Haggai 2:6-9](#)). Instead of worrying about their limited resources, they trusted in what God could provide. They committed to honor God and keeping their relationship with him strong. God demonstrated his control over nations and his ability to influence their leaders to fulfill his plans ([Ezra 5:5; 6:6-12, 22](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 40:1-38](#); [1 Kings 7:51-9:9](#); [Ezra 6:14-22](#); [Haggai 1:8; 2:7-8](#); [Zechariah 4:1-10](#); [Revelation 21:1-27](#)

Concern for the Poor

God instructed Israel to care for its people's well-being. Israel's covenant (special agreement) with God and its view of itself as a large family helped prevent claims to privilege. A family should support members in need. These members included widows, orphans, the poor, and foreigners ([Exodus 22:22; Leviticus 19:10](#)).

Farmers must leave the edges of their fields and leftover crops for the needy (see [Leviticus 23:22](#)). People in poverty should not be exploited. Instead, they must give loans without interest, or the debtor could work off the debt respectfully as a hired worker ([Leviticus 25:35-42](#)). These actions guaranteed the poor had food to eat.

The Bible first shows concern for the poor by adjusting the offering system for those who cannot afford expensive offerings. People could use birds instead of lambs for the whole burnt offering and the sin offering ([Leviticus 1:14-17; 5:7-10](#)). There were also other adjustments in the cleansing ceremonies ([14:21-22](#)). The most notable change is allowing flour as a substitute for the sin offering ([5:11-13](#)). This change meant the offering no longer symbolized giving a life for a life. This was done to help people who could not afford animals. This plainly shows God's desire for the poor to experience forgiveness of sins even if they cannot afford a lamb.

This theme continues with the prophets' concern for the poor and helpless. They called for social justice and compassion (for example, [Isaiah 1:17; Amos 2:6](#)). The prophets spoke strongly against those who oppressed the needy (see for example, [Amos 4:1-3; Amos 8:4-8](#)). God did not accept the people's elaborate worship practices if they were guilty of injustice and oppression at the same time (see [Isaiah 1:15-20; Micah 6:6-8](#)).

Proper attitudes and actions toward God and others are more important than worship ceremonies. This idea appears in the gospels' story of the poor widow's offering. Jesus praises her offering not for its monetary value, but for the devotion it shows ([Mark 12:41-44](#)). Religious practices could even prevent helping those in need (see [Mark 7:9-13](#)).

Jesus and the early Church showed concern for the poor. Jesus said his mission included bringing hope to the poor and freeing the oppressed ([Luke 4:16-21](#)). He warned against ignoring the poor ([Luke 16:19-31](#)). He said helping the poor was necessary for his followers ([Luke 18:18-23](#)). Following Christ's teachings, the early Church made sure to care for those in need ([Acts 2:44-45; Acts 4:32-37; 1 Timothy 5:3-16](#)). Like the prophets, they believed mistreating lowly people made religious practices meaningless ([1 Corinthians 11:17-29; James 1:27-2:17](#)).

God cares for the poor, a theme found throughout Scripture. Christians should adopt this same perspective towards those in need.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 22:22-27](#); [23:6-11](#); [Leviticus 5:7](#), [11:14:21-22](#); [19:9-10](#); [23:22](#); [Deuteronomy 10:17-19](#); [15:4-11](#); [16:9-12](#); [24:6-22](#); [26:12-13](#); [27:17-19](#); [1 Samuel 2:8](#); [Psalm 10:13-18](#); [35:10](#); [68:5](#); [Proverbs 14:31](#); [Isaiah 1:15-17](#); [Amos 2:6](#); [4:1](#); [8:4-7](#); [Micah 6:6-8](#), [12](#); [Mark 12:41-44](#); [Luke 6:20](#); [14:12-14](#); [James 2:1-17](#)

Counsel from Others

The book of Proverbs teaches that having many advisors are good because they provide safety ([Proverbs 11:14](#); [24:6](#)). They increase our chances of success ([Proverbs 15:22](#)). The book of Job shows that advisors can also mislead, even if what they believe about God seems correct ([Job 12:17](#); [26:3](#)).

At first, Job's friends joined him in his suffering, sitting silently in grief for seven days ([Job 2:11-13](#)). Yet, their comfort ended once they spoke. Job's friends often talked about the biblical idea of sowing and reaping, which is an important part of the covenant ([Leviticus 26](#); [Deuteronomy 28](#); [Proverbs 1:31](#); [22:8](#); [Hosea 8:7](#); see also [Galatians 6:7-8](#)). We cannot dismiss their words. This is because much of what they said is correct teaching about God's nature and how he acts towards humans.

Yet, Job's friends misapplied this idea (see [Job 4:8](#)). They did not examine Job's life to find where he had done wrong and then warn of divine judgment. Instead, they ignored Job's faithful life and focused on his suffering. Then they assumed he was suffering because of sin. God eventually called these advisors liars. This reminds us that we must correctly apply true things about God to please God and help others ([Proverbs 15:2-4](#), [23](#); [25:11](#); [Isaiah 50:4](#); [Ephesians 4:29](#)).

It is good to consider advice from different sources. But we should compare it with what we believe is right before God (see, for example, [Acts 20:22](#); [21:4](#), [11](#), [13](#)). God might use human advisors to help us understand his will. But he also guides us through his Spirit ([John 16:13-15](#)).

Jesus Christ is our "Wonderful Counselor" ([Isaiah 9:6](#); see [Isaiah 28:29](#)). He has "all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" ([Colossians 2:3](#)). When

we support others in times of grief, we should be careful and thoughtful in applying teachings from Scripture. Often, our silent presence is the most helpful help we can give.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 17:1-23](#); [1 Kings 12:3-17](#); [22:15-28](#); [Job 2:9-10](#); [4:8](#); [12:17](#); [16:2](#); [Proverbs 1:5](#); [9:9](#); [11:14](#); [12:15](#); [15:2-4](#), [22-23](#); [19:20](#); [20:18](#); [24:6](#); [25:11](#); [27:9](#); [Isaiah 9:6](#); [28:29](#); [50:4](#); [Romans 8:14](#); [Ephesians 4:29](#); [Colossians 2:3](#)

Curses and Blessings

Almost all treaty or covenant texts from the ancient Near East included curses and blessings. The curses focused on those who violated the terms of the covenant. Blessings are for those who remained faithful. This was especially true for suzerain-vassal (great king-lesser king or people) covenants like Deuteronomy (see Deuteronomy Book Introduction, "Literary Form").

Deuteronomy explained to the people of Israel what God expected from them. The covenant required Israel to obey God. The Israelites promised to do this ([Exodus 19:8](#)). The section on curses and blessings explains how God would reward obedience and punish disobedience ([Deuteronomy 27:1-29:1](#)).

The text emphasizes curses more than blessings. This might be because people tend to focus more on promises than warnings. Blessings are often easier to understand. This is because they promise future safety. Judgment is less clear and needs detailed descriptions.

God emphasizes the curses to focus on the consequences of wrongdoing. The warnings Jesus gave about future events align with these warnings ([Matthew 24-25](#)).

Israel's history shows how God fulfilled his promise of blessings and curses. When Israel followed their covenant with God, he blessed them. When they rebelled, he judged them. Israel's rebellion is summarized in [2 Kings 17:7-20](#). When the Israelites broke the first two commandments, they violated the entire covenant ([Deuteronomy 5:7-10](#)). Their rebellion brought the curses of [Deuteronomy 28](#) upon them.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 9:24-27](#); [Leviticus 26:3-45](#); [Deuteronomy 8:7-20](#); [11:29](#); [Deuteronomy 27:1-29:1](#); [Joshua 8:33-35](#); [2 Kings 17:7-20](#); [2 Chronicles 36:17-21](#)

Darkness and Light

Darkness

Darkness means there is no light. There was no light until God commanded it to appear. He then separated light from darkness ([Genesis 1:2, 4-5, 18](#)). The ninth plague he sent against Egypt was three days of deep darkness, with no light at all ([Exodus 10:21-23](#)).

Darkness surrounds God ([Exodus 20:21](#); [Deuteronomy 4:11](#); [5:23](#); [2 Samuel 22:12](#); [Psalm 18:11](#); [97:2](#)). He lives in thick darkness ([1 Kings 8:12](#) and the parallel passage in [2 Chronicles 6:1](#)). Thick darkness is beneath his feet ([2 Samuel 22:10](#) and the parallel passage in [Psalm 18:9](#)). We cannot know God unless he reveals himself.

Darkness often represents distress and anxiety. Or it can refer to the confusion and destruction experienced by the evil people ([Genesis 15:12](#); [Job 12:25](#); [19:8](#); [Psalms 35:6](#); [107:10, 14](#); [Ecclesiastes 5:17](#); [Isaiah 5:30](#)).

For Job, darkness meant emptiness ([Job 3:4-6](#)). It symbolized death, a land of shadow and gloom where the dead live, far from daylight ([Job 10:21-22](#); [17:12-13](#); [Ecclesiastes 6:4](#)).

Evil often happens in the dark ([Job 24:16-17](#)). But darkness cannot hide anything from God ([Psalm 139:11-12](#); [Isaiah 29:15-16](#)). Darkness often represents not knowing God's will. Knowing God is "light," so not knowing is "darkness" ([Job 12:24-25](#); [Matthew 4:16](#); [John 1:5](#); [8:12](#); [12:35, 46](#); [1 John 1:5](#); [2:8-9, 11](#)).

The Bible often uses "darkness" to describe a sinful or evil way of life ([Proverbs 2:13](#); [4:19](#); [Isaiah 5:20](#); [60:2](#)). In the New Testament, darkness can also represent living without the truth of God ([Matthew 6:23](#); [Luke 11:35](#); [Romans 2:19](#); [Colossians 1:13](#)). [Isaiah 9:2](#) speaks of a people living in distress who see a great light (see also [Matthew 4:16](#); [Luke 1:79](#)). This light is Jesus himself. In that context, "darkness" refers more to suffering and need than to spiritual ignorance.

A major theme of the Old Testament prophets was the "Day of the LORD," often linked with darkness ([Ezekiel 32:8](#); [Joel 2:2, 31](#); [Amos 5:18, 20](#);

[Zephaniah 1:15](#)). The New Testament also connects darkness with judgment ([Matthew 8:12](#); [22:13](#); [25:30](#); [2 Peter 2:17](#); [Jude 1:6, 13](#)).

Light

Light was the first thing God created after the heavens and earth ([Genesis 1:3](#); see also [1:16](#)). It naturally symbolizes what is pleasant, good, or cheerful ([Ecclesiastes 11:7](#); [James 1:17](#)). When the Israelites left Egypt, a pillar of cloud and fire gave them light ([Exodus 13:21](#); [14:20](#)). It showed them the way ([Nehemiah 9:19](#)). Light represents the Lord's blessing ([Job 12:22](#); [29:2-3](#); [Psalms 4:6](#); [18:28](#); [44:3](#); [118:27](#)). God's servants can share this blessing by guiding others to God through their obedience ([Isaiah 42:6](#); [49:6](#)). God's light also reveals sin and brings justice ([Psalms 90:8](#); [Isaiah 51:4](#)).

The Bible describes God as light ([Psalm 27:1](#); [Isaiah 60:19-20](#); [Daniel 2:22](#); [1 John 1:5](#)). He "dwells in unapproachable light" (see [1 Timothy 6:16](#)). Yet, he guides his followers into the light ([Micah 7:8-9](#); see also [1 John 1:7](#)).

Jesus said, "I am the light of the world" ([John 8:12](#); [9:5](#); [12:46](#)). He brought a message from God, but he was also that message ([John 1:1-10](#)). Those who receive his message and trust in him, He gives "the right to become children of God" ([John 1:9-12](#)). His light spiritually enlightens them and they come to know God and his salvation ([Matthew 4:16](#); [Luke 2:32](#); [Acts 13:47](#); [26:18](#)).

They are "sons of light" ([John 12:36](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:5](#)). They "walk in the light" ([1 John 1:7](#)). Their actions are like light—by doing what is good and right and true ([Ephesians 5:8-9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:3-5, 14-18](#); [15:12](#); [Exodus 10:21-23](#); [14:20](#); [20:21](#); [2 Samuel 22:10-13](#); [1 Kings 8:12](#); [Job 3:3-7](#); [12:22-25](#); [15:22](#); [17:12-13](#); [34:22](#); [Psalms 18:11, 28](#); [27:1](#); [97:2-6](#); [139:11-12](#); [Proverbs 2:13](#); [4:18-19](#); [Ecclesiastes 11:7-8](#); [Isaiah 5:20](#); [9:2](#); [29:15](#); [51:4](#); [60:2-3](#); [19-20](#); [Daniel 2:22](#); [Micah 7:8-9](#); [Matthew 4:16](#); [6:22-23](#); [8:12](#); [Luke 1:78-79](#); [2:32](#); [John 1:4-9](#); [8:12](#); [9:5](#); [12:35-36, 46](#); [Acts 13:47](#); [26:18](#); [Romans 2:19-20](#); [Ephesians 5:7-14](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:5-8](#); [1 Timothy 6:16](#); [James 1:17](#); [2 Peter 2:17](#); [1 John 1:5-7](#); [2:7-11](#)

David's Response to Unfriendly Leaders

As David became successful, King Saul became his enemy. The Lord rejected Saul because of the king's unfaithfulness, and the Holy Spirit's anointing then rested on David ([1 Samuel 15:1-16:14](#)). When Saul needed someone to calm his mind, David's harp playing soothed him ([16:15-23](#)). When Saul needed someone to encounter the threat of Goliath, David proved to be a capable and successful young warrior ([1 Samuel 17](#)). As others noticed David and praised his success, Saul became frightened and jealous ([18:6-9](#)). His jealousy soon became anger, rage, and murderous hatred.

After King Saul tried to kill David with a spear twice ([1 Samuel 18:10-11](#)), David kept serving him. He led a group of the king's troops ([18:13](#)). He married the king's daughter ([18:17-27](#)). He played the harp in Saul's royal court ([19:7, 9](#)). David kept succeeding in everything he did. This made Saul very fearful and suspicious, and he tried to kill David again ([19:9-11](#)). David had to escape to save his life ([19:11-18; 20:1-42](#)).

For the rest of King Saul's rule, David was a fugitive, hunted by the king he had loyally served. Even then, he refused to harm Saul. On two occasions, David had the chance to kill Saul ([1 Samuel 24:1-22; 26:1-25](#)). But he refused to attack "the LORD's anointed" ([24:6; 26:9](#)).

During these years as a fugitive, David continued to serve the Lord and the people of Israel ([1 Samuel 23:1-6; 25:4-9, 14-16; 27:8-9](#)). When David heard that Saul and Jonathan had died, he mourned deeply for the "beloved and delightful" king and his son ([2 Samuel 1:17-27](#)).

David remained loyal to a king who hated him and wanted him dead. In a similar way, the prophet Jeremiah wrote a prophesy in the royal court where they burned it and put him in a cistern to die ([Jeremiah 36:21-26; 38:1-13](#)). The prophet Daniel and his friends also faithfully served in the royal courts of Babylonian and Persian. They did this even though the kings made decisions against their faith or them personally ([Daniel 3:1-30; 6:1-28](#)).

Being faithful under an enemy's rule does not always lead to success. Jesus is the ultimate example. The Jewish authorities pursued him and eventually had him killed. Jesus did not achieve worldly success, but he trusted his Father in heaven. His success came after death in the resurrection.

We might also die while living under leaders who are against us, and we might not see any good results from our suffering. But in the future world that God will bring, he will fix everything that was wrong. God will reward those who remain faithful even when they suffer under cruel leaders.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 24:1-22; 2 Samuel 1:1-27; 11:1-27; Jeremiah 36:21-27; 38:1-13; Daniel 3:1-30; 6:1-28; John 8:29; Philippians 2:6-11; Hebrews 5:7-10; 1 Peter 2:13-3:7](#)

Dealing with Conflict

God's people often experience conflict. It either comes from those outside of God's people who are against God. Or it comes from those within God's people who cause trouble. Dealing with conflict needs wisdom and care, since small issues can become big problems.

Paul encountered opposition from the government and community leaders ([Acts 16:22-24; Acts 19:23-34](#)). Moses dealt with the complaining and unhappy people of Israel (for example, [Exodus 17:1-4](#)). The book of Nehemiah offers a detailed example of how a godly person can deal with conflict.

Nehemiah

Nehemiah experienced challenges both from those outside and those within God's people as he followed God's guidance.

External Conflict

Foreigners like Sanballat, Geshem, and Tobiah strongly opposed rebuilding Jerusalem's walls and mocked Nehemiah's leadership ([Nehemiah 2:10, 2:19; 4:1-3](#)). The opposition increased to include Arabs, Ammonites, and people from Ashdod, who planned to attack the builders ([4:7-9, 11](#)).

To counter this, Nehemiah set up guards, prayed for God's help, created an emergency alert system, and continued working ([4:6-23](#)). Israel's frustrated enemies tried several times to disgrace or kill Nehemiah ([6:1-14](#)). Yet, Nehemiah wisely avoided or stopped their plans while staying focused on his mission from God.

Internal Conflict

Nehemiah also encountered problems within God's people. Wealthy Jews were mistreating the poor by charging high interest ([5:1-13](#)). Jews had married foreigners who worshiped other gods ([13:23-30](#)). Many did not give tithes or honor the Sabbath day ([10:31-39](#); [13:10-22](#)). Finally, Nehemiah had to oppose the priest Eliashib, who had allowed Tobiah to use one of the temple storerooms ([13:4-9](#)).

Confronting these problems required a firm commitment to the principles in Scripture. He had to be bold by insisting that people follow these divine instructions. He needed to show compassion in restoring people to fellowship after the confrontation.

In each case, Nehemiah bravely followed the example of earlier leaders. Moses opposed the worship of the golden calf ([Exodus 32](#)). The prophet Samuel opposed those involved in Baal worship ([1 Samuel 7:3-8](#)). The prophet Nathan confronted David when he sinned ([2 Samuel 12:1-14](#)). King Jehoshaphat trusted God to defeat a stronger enemy ([2 Chronicles 20:1-37](#)).

Like these earlier men of God, Nehemiah defended what was right. He did not let those he led do what they wanted. He refused to become discouraged or intimidated by internal problems or external threats. He consistently relied on God for wisdom and blessings for his work.

Jesus and the Apostle Paul

Jesus and the apostle Paul both provided strategies for dealing with internal conflict ([Matthew 5:23-26](#); [18:15-17](#); [1 Corinthians 6:1-8](#); [10:23-33](#)). They also strategized how to deal with external conflict ([Matthew 5:43-47](#); [Romans 12:14-21](#)). Unfortunately, the actions of Christians, no matter how good, may still encounter continued or increased opposition. The Bible encourages us deal with opposition like Nehemiah. We must use wisdom, patience, prayer, and determination.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 13:5-13](#); [26:12-35](#); [Exodus 32:1-35](#); [1 Samuel 7:3-8](#); [2 Samuel 12:1-31](#); [19:41-43](#); [2 Chronicles 20:1-37](#); [34:3-7](#); [Nehemiah 2:19-20](#); [4:1-23](#); [5:1-13](#); [6:1-14](#); [13:4-28](#); [Psalm 140:1-2](#); [Proverbs 13:10](#); [17:14](#); [19](#); [25:8](#); [26:17](#); [21](#); [29:22](#); [Habakkuk 1:3](#); [Acts 23:6-11](#); [2 Corinthians 7:5-6](#); [Ephesians 6:10-18](#); [Philippians 2:3](#); [1 Timothy 6:4](#); [2 Timothy 2:14](#); [23-26](#); [Titus 2:15](#); [James 3:13-18](#)

Death

Humans are mortal, and death is the natural end of life on earth ([Psalm 90:1-6](#)). Human identity began when God breathed life into the dust of the earth and made a man ([Genesis 2:7](#)). This state reverses at death when God takes back his breath. Then the human body returns to dust ([3:19](#); [Job 4:19-21](#); [Isaiah 40:6-8](#)). Human life fully depends on the creator. His breath is a gift that sustains us as long as he allows ([Psalm 104:29](#)).

Sin brought death into human life and caused much harm. Death often comes without warning, making people feel very sad. When someone dies, it can feel like their hopes and plans for the future have ended. The death penalty is the strongest punishment that human courts can give. In the Old Testament, the death penalty was for crimes such as murder or blasphemy ([Genesis 9:6](#); [Exodus 21:12](#); [Leviticus 24:16](#); [John 10:30-33](#)). These were crimes that endangered the community.

In the Old Testament, *Sheol* is the opposite of "the land of the living" ([Psalm 27:13](#)). This is the dark and silent place where dead people are ([Job 10:21-22](#); [Psalm 94:17](#); [Jonah 2:6](#)). Even in death, God's people have hope (see [Proverbs 14:32](#)). God is sovereign (in complete control) and rules over death ([Deuteronomy 32:39](#)).

The Old Testament often describes death as joining one's ancestors, without mentioning resurrection (see, for example, [Genesis 49:29-33](#)). Yet, there are some hints of resurrection (see [Job 19:25-27](#); [Isaiah 25:6-9](#); [26:19](#); [Daniel 12:2](#)). Jewish belief in resurrection became more common during the period between the Old and New Testaments.

Resurrection is a key theme in the New Testament. Through Christ, God's redeemed people will overcome death. Death is the last enemy God destroys ([1 Corinthians 15:54-57](#), [26](#)). Death comes from sin ([Romans 5:12](#)). Those who live in a sinful state and do not repent (turn away from sin) will experience punishment in the lake of fire, known as "the second death" ([Revelation 21:8](#)).

But Jesus' death defeated death. When Jesus died and rose again, he showed that death is not the final authority over humanity. His resurrection is a model for all Christians ([Colossians 1:18](#)). He is "the Lord of both the living and the dead" ([Romans 14:9](#)). When someone dies, it is natural to mourn. But it should also be a time to show great trust in God. Those who receive God's promises have hope that they will live after the grave.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:15-17](#); [3:19](#); [6:17](#); [9:5-6](#); [49:29-33](#); [Exodus 21:12-17](#), [28-29](#); [23:7](#); [31:14-15](#); [Leviticus 24:16](#); [Deuteronomy 32:39](#); [Job 10:18-22](#); [19:25-27](#); [Psalms 90:1-12](#); [94:17](#); [Proverbs 14:32](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:1-7](#); [Isaiah 25:6-9](#); [26:19](#); [40:6-8](#); [Daniel 12:2-3](#); [Mark 12:26-27](#); [Romans 5:12-17](#); [1 Corinthians 15:20-26](#), [51-58](#); [Revelation 20:4-6](#), [11-15](#); [21:3-8](#)

Divine Sovereignty and Human Responsibility

The Bible shows that everything is under God's control. In other words, God is sovereign over everything. For example, rain falls on both good and bad people as part of God's plan ([Matthew 5:45](#)).

God is not responsible for our sins. They come from our own desires so we are responsible for them. Scripture shows that people can choose to follow God or reject him (see, for example, [Deuteronomy 30:1-20](#); [Joshua 24:15](#); [John 1:12](#); [Romans 10:9-13](#)). God does not force people to have faith in him.

[Ezekiel 14:9-11](#) describes an interesting situation where God deceives a prophet but still holds the prophet responsible for his actions. This raises a challenging question: How do we explain how God is in control of everything but humans make personal choices for which we are accountable?

When God allowed false prophets to tell untrue messages, he gave them and their listeners what they wanted (see [2 Thessalonians 2:11](#)). Even a false prophet could only mislead people with the Lord's permission or guidance. Without God's restraint, they would choose lies over truth and worship "the creature rather than the Creator" (see [Romans 1:18-25](#)). God allowed them to follow their sinful desires.

The amazing thing is not that God lets some sinners stay in their false beliefs. But it is amazing that he saves sinners. He changes their desires so they want to do good for his glory (see [Ezekiel 36:25-26](#); [Romans 8:1-11](#); [Ephesians 2:10](#)). We cannot fully understand this difficult issue. Yet, we can be sure of God's freely given grace. We can have hope in the new life he offers through his Holy Spirit to all who trust in him.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 2:6-7](#); [1 Kings 22:19-22](#); [2 Chronicles 20:6](#); [Job 1:8-12](#); [2:2-6](#); [Psalms 115:3](#); [135:6-14](#); [Isaiah 45:6-7](#); [Lamentations 3:37-40](#); [Ezekiel 14:9-11](#); [17:24](#); [36:25-26](#); [Daniel 2:20-22](#); [Amos 3:6](#); [4:6-11](#); [Romans 1:18-25](#); [9:8-33](#); [12:2](#); [Ephesians 4:20-24](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:11-12](#); [Hebrews 13:20-21](#); [James 1:13-14](#); [4:12-16](#)

Early Christian Heresies

Heresy

The Greek word *hairesis*, which first means "choice," refers to a *sect* or *faction*. For example, the Sadducees were a sect within Judaism, as were the Pharisees ([Acts 5:17](#); [15:5](#)). They called early believers in Jesus as the Messiah, "the sect of the Nazarenes" ([Acts 24:5](#)). In each of these verses, *hairesis* simply means a sect or denomination.

As the church expanded, they named any divisive group within a local church a *hairesis*. This term refers to a sect with beliefs opposing the truths taught by the apostles. Paul warned the Corinthian church that divisive *sects* would form among them ([1 Corinthians 11:19](#)).

Eventually, the word *heresy* came to mean teaching that departs from the norm and causes people to leave orthodoxy (traditional and established beliefs). Peter warned Christians about false teachers who would try to mislead believers with "destructive heresies" ([2 Peter 2:1](#)). Today, this is how the word *heresy* is usually understood. It refers to false teaching that harms the faith of some Christians and creates divisions within the church.

Two Early Heresies

Two major heresies were common in the church during the apostle John's time: Gnosticism and Docetism.

Gnosticism

Gnosticism claimed to have special and secret spiritual knowledge. Many Gnostics believed in a hierarchy of beings. At the top was an eternal god, from whom came a series of lesser spiritual beings. Among these was the creator god, considered evil. This creator god made the material world, including humans.

Similar to the teachings of the Greek philosopher Plato, these Gnostics believed everything material was evil. A more "real" spiritual realm existed.

Their goal was to find the spiritual "seed" within themselves through secret "knowledge" (Greek *gnōsis*).

This knowledge would help them leave the physical world and join the spiritual realm. This belief led to different responses to the physical world. Some Gnostics strictly avoided physical pleasure. Others freely lived for physical desires, seeing their actions as unimportant.

Gnosticism developed by combining Christianity with Greek philosophy. It stressed the need for special knowledge that changed traditional Christian beliefs and practices. Gnostics often included Christ in their beliefs. They considered Christ as one of many "streams" from a supreme being. Many Gnostics believed that Christ taught some followers to find their inner spiritual "spark" and connect with the spiritual realm.

Many Christian writings from the first two centuries countered Gnostic false teachings.

Docetism

Docetism was a type of Gnosticism. It taught that Christ only seemed to have a human body with physical birth, death, and resurrection. *Dokeō* is a Greek verb meaning "to seem."

An early Docetist named Cerinthus claimed that the spiritual "Christ" joined the human Jesus at his baptism. He stayed during his ministry but left before his suffering and death. This movement hoped to protect God's divinity from being stained by Jesus' human nature. According to early church tradition, the apostle John strongly opposed Cerinthus' teachings (see Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 3.3.4; compare [1 John 5:5-8](#); [2 John 1:7](#)).

True Christians believe in the Incarnation when God became a real human with flesh and blood in the person of Jesus of Nazareth. Jesus' humanity was real. He was truly human, sharing our flesh and blood, so he could save humanity through his own flesh and blood.

Ignatius was a student of the apostle John and later the bishop of Antioch. He wrote letters against Docetism. Ignatius was the first person after the New Testament writers to mention Jesus' virgin birth. He also stressed that the apostles touched the body of their risen Lord. Ignatius said he could face martyrdom (dying for one's beliefs) bravely because of Jesus Christ's real suffering on the cross and his physical resurrection.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 8:9-24](#); [2 Corinthians 11:1-15](#); [Colossians 1:23](#); [2:6-23](#); [1 Timothy 6:20](#); [2 Peter 2:1-22](#); [1 John 4:2-3](#); [5:5-8](#); [2 John 1:7-11](#); [3 John 1:9-12](#); [Revelation 2:2, 14-16, 20-25](#)

Eating Together

For the Pharisees and other practicing Jews, eating meals together was a religious event. Righteous Jews followed many rules to avoid ceremonial pollution during meals. They did this to show their commitment to the law, not to exclude others.

Most Jews obeyed the food laws most of the time. Jesus did as well. Yet, he often ate with people on purpose who were ceremonially unclean or less committed to obeying the law. Sharing a meal could show both covenantal and social equality (compare [Matthew 26:26-29](#); [2 Kings 25:27-30](#)). The Pharisees believed that avoiding such sinners was necessary for righteousness. This is why it offended them when Jesus ate with sinners ([Matthew 9:10-11](#); [11:19](#); [21:28-32](#); [Luke 7:36-50](#); [15:1-2](#); [19:1-10](#)).

Jesus shared meals with sinful people to show God's grace. He extended God's love and forgiveness, inviting everyone to join a new community. Jesus's last meal (called "the Last Supper") anticipates the feast in the kingdom of heaven ([Matthew 26:29](#); see [8:11-12](#)). In the early church, communal meals also played an important role. They expressed communion among Christians and were an opportunity to partake of the Lord's Supper ([Acts 2:46](#); [1 Corinthians 11:17-34](#)).

The apostle Paul continued Jesus's practice to create a bond between Jews and gentiles (people who are not Jewish) in the church (see [Galatians 2:11-21](#)). Jesus tore "down the dividing wall of hostility" between Jews and gentiles ([Ephesians 2:14-18](#)). He calls us to community with all his people.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 18:1-8](#); [Exodus 24:9-11](#); [2 Kings 25:27-30](#); [Matthew 8:11-12](#); [9:10-13](#); [11:19](#); [26:26-29](#); [Luke 7:36-50](#); [15:1-2](#); [19:1-10](#); [22:14-21](#); [Acts 2:46-47](#); [1 Corinthians 11:20-34](#); [Galatians 2:11-16](#); [Ephesians 2:14-18](#)

Empowering Leadership

In [Acts 6:1-7](#), the early Christian community experienced a leadership crisis. The Hellenists were Greek-speaking Jews in Jerusalem. They were upset "because their widows were being overlooked in the daily distribution of food" ([6:1](#)).

This issue threatened the church's growth and needed serious attention. "The Grecian Jews among them began to grumble" ([6:1](#)). The apostles wisely identified the problem ([6:2-3](#)). They called for the selection of seven men to manage the food program ([6:5-6](#)).

Many believe these seven were the first deacons (see study note on [6:2-6](#)). They agreed on a clear division of labor. The twelve apostles focused on preaching and teaching. The other leaders filled with the Holy Spirit dealt with material needs. The apostles showed strong leadership by listening to the community's needs. This wise approach and united action led to spiritual growth and additional Christians ([6:7](#)).

The church recognized different gifts and used them for the common good (see [1 Corinthians 12:4-11](#); [1 Peter 4:10-11](#)). Every Christian has the chance to participate in some form of ministry. This idea of every Christian serving God is called the "priesthood of all believers" ([1 Peter 2:5, 9](#); [Revelation 1:6](#); [5:10](#); see [Exodus 19:6](#); [Isaiah 61:6](#); [Revelation 20:6](#)). While not everyone has the same role, God calls every person to use their gifts in God's service.

God has given the church its leaders, "not lording it over" the people, but to serve the community ([Matthew 20:25-28](#); [Mark 10:42-45](#); [Luke 22:25-27](#); [1 Peter 5:1-4](#)). Church leaders succeed when they understand the community's needs and identify those whom God has prepared to meet those needs. Good leaders recognize talented people and help them grow, enabling members to use their God-given gifts ([Ephesians 4:11-12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 19:6](#); [Isaiah 61:6](#); [Matthew 20:25-28](#); [Acts 6:1-7](#); [1 Corinthians 12:4-11](#); [Ephesians 4:11-12](#); [1 Peter 2:5, 9](#); [4:10-11](#); [Revelation 1:6](#); [5:10](#); [20:6](#)

Encounters with Jesus

Jesus' miracles and parables (symbolic stories with a special meaning) often take away the focus on his encounters with people that changed their lives. In

these encounters, Jesus deals with individuals as they are. He invites people from all backgrounds to accept him as a leader and friend. He invites them to become his followers and messengers of his eternal kingdom.

Yet, following Jesus requires a choice. The world's power and wealth can be too distracting to transfer into kingdom service. Following Jesus means leaving something behind. Those who hold on to worldly things often end up rejecting Jesus. This choice challenges everyone who encounters Jesus in the Gospels and hears his call to follow.

Andrew was a fisherman in Galilee. He hoped for the Messiah (God's chosen one) and his kingdom to come. He followed John the Baptist until John showed him Jesus. Then Andrew followed Jesus and invited others, including his brother Peter, to join him. See [John 1:29-42](#).

Simeon and Anna had waited a long time to see the promised Christ. When they saw the infant Jesus, they recognized him as the Christ. They blessed and thanked God for his arrival and the hope he brought. See [Luke 2:25-38](#).

Nathanael was doubtful when first invited to meet Jesus. Yet, when Jesus demonstrated that he already knew him, Nathanael's attitude changed. He then followed Jesus without hesitating. See [John 1:43-51](#).

A wealthy man approached Jesus and asked how to gain eternal life. This man showed humility and had already carefully followed all of God's laws. "Jesus loved him" but said he needed to sell all his possessions, give to the poor, and follow him. The man was unwilling to give up his wealth and sadly walked away from Jesus. See [Mark 10:17-22](#).

Matthew abandoned his Jewish heritage, betrayed his people by collecting Roman taxes, and chose a life of wealth and luxury. When Jesus called Matthew to follow him, Matthew left his old life. Before traveling with Jesus, Matthew invited his friends to meet him. See [Matthew 9:9-13](#).

Thomas did not believe the other disciples when they said Jesus had come back to life. When Jesus appeared to Thomas, he invited Thomas to touch his wounds. Thomas then bowed before Jesus and declared his belief that Jesus was his Lord and God. See [John 20:19-29](#).

Martha was busy preparing a meal for Jesus at her home. She became upset because her sister Mary was sitting and learning at Jesus' feet. Jesus gently encouraged Martha not to be angry and explained

that Mary had made the better choice by listening to his teaching. Later, Jesus spoke with Martha to affirm her faith in him for eternal life. See [Luke 10:38-42](#); [John 11:17-27](#).

A Roman officer asked Jesus to save his dying slave. He excused Jesus from visiting his ceremonially unclean home since he was a gentile and not a Jew. This was because the officer believed Jesus could heal by simply speaking. Jesus honored the officer's faith by healing the slave from a distance. Jesus also affirmed that many gentiles would enter the kingdom of heaven through trust in him. See [Matthew 8:5-13](#).

Jewish leaders brought a woman accused of adultery to Jesus so he would judge her. Stoning was the expected punishment. Jesus wrote in the dust and asked any accuser without sin to throw the first stone. When they all left, Jesus told the woman to leave and stop sinning. See [John 8:1-11](#).

Nicodemus was a Jewish religious leader and Pharisee. So he was careful about people seeing him with Jesus. So Nicodemus visited him at night. Jesus spoke with Nicodemus and challenged his beliefs about spiritual truth. Nicodemus later defended Jesus at the Jewish council (Sanhedrin). After Jesus' crucifixion, Nicodemus helped bury Jesus, showing his commitment. See [John 3:1-21](#); [7:50-52](#); [19:38-42](#).

James and John thought God's kingdom was near, so they asked for places of honor. This request upset the other disciples. Jesus kindly explained that true leadership is a matter of service, not wealth or power. The disciples would learn this lesson through difficult experiences. See [Mark 10:35-45](#); [John 13:1-17](#).

The people of Nazareth only knew Jesus as Joseph's son. They did not believe he could be the Christ. Their doubt greatly limited Jesus' miracles among them. Their anger at his claims gave him reason to leave. See [Luke 4:14-30](#).

The religious leaders followed detailed laws focused on outward behavior. But they did not show love in more important ways. Jesus repeatedly challenged them about this. But most leaders rejected his criticism and sought ways to harm him. See [Luke 11:37-54](#); compare [Acts 6:8-8:1](#); [9:1-31](#).

Zacchaeus collected taxes for Rome and became rich by taking advantage of his people. He wanted to see Jesus, so he climbed a tree to look over the crowd. Jesus noticed him, visited his house, and

invited Zacchaeus to change his life. Zacchaeus repented and repaid everyone he had wronged. See [Luke 19:1-10](#).

Two followers of Jesus were returning home to Emmaus after Jesus' death. Along the way, the resurrected Jesus joined them and explained from Scripture why he had died. They did not recognize Jesus until he had meal with them. Then Jesus disappeared. The two joyfully left to tell the disciples that Jesus was alive. See [Luke 24:13-35](#).

A Samaritan woman with a bad reputation went to Jacob's well to get water and found Jesus there. Jesus offered her "living water" and a new life. This surprised her but she believed him. Then she invited others to meet the Christ for which they had been waiting. See [John 4:1-42](#).

The Jewish leaders pressured Pilate to kill Jesus. Pilate believed Jesus was innocent and tried to release him. Pilate asked Jesus, "What is truth?" But he did not understand that Jesus was the Truth. In the end, to maintain peace with the Jewish leaders, Pilate gave the order to crucify Jesus. See [John 18:28-19:16](#).

Simon Peter denied knowing Jesus three times. After Jesus rose from the dead, he asked Peter three times if he loved him. Each time, Peter said he loved him. Jesus instructed him to care for his followers (his "sheep" and "lambs"). In this way, Jesus restored Peter to the Christian faith. See [John 21:1-23](#); see also [Matthew 16:15-19](#).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 8:5-13](#); [9:9-13](#); [16:15-19](#); [Mark 10:17-22](#), [35-45](#); [Luke 2:25-38](#); [4:14-30](#); [10:38-42](#); [11:37-54](#); [19:1-10](#); [24:13-35](#); [John 1:29-42](#), [43-51](#); [3:1-21](#); [4:1-42](#); [7:50-52](#); [8:1-11](#); [11:17-27](#); [13:1-17](#); [18:28-19:16](#); [19:38-42](#); [20:19-29](#); [21:1-23](#)

Endurance

When Jesus was about to suffer and die, he told his followers they would also experience great difficulties (see [Matthew 24:9](#)). He emphasized the importance of endurance: "The one who perseveres to the end will be saved" ([Matthew 24:13](#)). Many New Testament writings were for Christians suffering for their faith in Christ (see, for example, [2 Thessalonians 1:4](#); [1 Peter 4:12-19](#)). These Christians needed encouragement to persevere through difficulty while remaining

committed to Christ and sharing their faith with others (see [2 Timothy 4:5](#); [1 Peter 4:1](#)). Through endurance, Christians grow in character and develop spiritual maturity ([Romans 5:3-4](#); [James 1:2-4](#)).

The book of Hebrews spoke to Christians who had encountered many challenges. People harassed them, took their property, and imprisoned them ([Hebrews 10:32-34](#)).

At the time of writing, they had similar issues. They needed to "hold firmly" to their beliefs without wavering ([4:14](#); [10:23](#)). They must endure while waiting for God's promises to come true ([6:12](#); [10:36](#)). Like runners in a race, they needed to "run with endurance the race set out for" them ([12:1](#)). As true children of a loving father, they were to accept the Lord's discipline to grow in holiness ([12:5-13](#)).

The great examples of endurance in Scripture, such as Job and the prophets, can inspire all Christians ([Hebrews 11:35-40](#); [James 5:10-11](#)). Christ, our main model of endurance, "endured the cross," because of "the joy set before Him" ([12:1-3](#)). This same hope for the future inspires us to endure.

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 5:3-4](#); [1 Corinthians 4:12](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:4](#); [Hebrews 6:12](#); [Hebrews 12:1-10](#); [James 1:2-4](#); [James 5:11](#); [1 Peter 2:20](#)

Enjoying God's Gifts

The Teacher (the main speaker) in Ecclesiastes often concludes that we should enjoy life because it is a gift from God (see [Ecclesiastes 2:24-25](#); [3:12-13](#); [2:22](#); [5:18](#); [6:9](#); [8:15](#); [9:7-9](#); [11:7-10](#)). Even when life seems difficult, it is meant for laughter, dancing, love, and peace. Life is especially valuable when old age and death threaten joy ([9:4](#); [10](#); [11:7-9](#); [12:1](#)). We should enjoy our food, drink, health, clothes, loving spouse, children, daily work, and times of rest.

Some people might be surprised to find such joy in Ecclesiastes since this book also talks about sad and frustrating things in life. But this mix of joy and sorrow shows wisdom. A wise person understands life deeply and sees how to live well even in an imperfect world.

When we focus too much on seeking pleasure, we actually make ourselves less happy. The Teacher warns that seeking pleasure alone is unwise and

unprofitable ([2:1-2](#); [7:4](#); [10:16-19](#); see also [Isaiah 22:13](#); [56:12](#); [Luke 12:19-20](#)). The New Testament encourages us to find joy in everything, even during distress and challenges ([Philippians 4:4](#); [James 1:2](#)). One tradition in Christianity says that "the chief end of man is to glorify God and enjoy him forever" (*Westminster Shorter Catechism*, Question 1).

Passages for Further Study

[Ecclesiastes 2:24-25](#); [3:12-13](#); [22](#); [4:6](#); [5:18-20](#); [6:9](#); [8:15](#); [9:7-9](#); [11:7-10](#); [Isaiah 22:13](#); [56:12](#); [Luke 12:19-20](#); [Philippians 4:4](#); [Colossians 2:20-22](#); [James 1:2](#); [4:13-16](#)

Ethnic Hatred

Selfish pride, a desire to keep power, and hatred for those who oppose them have often led to the persecution of racial or religious groups. Many people have died over the centuries because of this hatred.

In the book of Esther, Haman hated Mordecai because Mordecai refused to bow down like everyone else when Haman passed by ([Esther 3:1-5](#)). Haman despised Mordecai, a man of integrity who would not follow laws against his beliefs. This personal hatred for Mordecai, a Jew, became a desire to destroy all Jews ([3:6](#)). The basis for Haman's accusation against the Jewish people was what he did not like in Mordecai:

- They did not act like others,
- they had unique laws and customs, and
- they did not follow some of the king's laws ([3:8](#)).

The Spanish Inquisition in the 1400s and the Holocaust in Nazi Germany during the 1930s and 1940s were terrible attempts to destroy the Jewish people. Religious and ethnic hatred still causes evil plans today.

God does not approve of hatred against any ethnic or religious group. He will eventually hold accountable those who make such evil plans (see [Deuteronomy 30:7](#); [Psalms 21:7-11](#); [34:19-21](#); [44:7](#)). God has often saved the Jewish people and defeated their enemies because he is faithful to all his promises (see [Romans 9-11](#)). He will also protect his church through all persecution (see [Matthew 16:18](#); [Romans 8:26-39](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 46:33-34](#); [Deuteronomy 7:1-6](#); [23:3-8](#); [Esther 3:1-9](#); [Matthew 15:22-28](#); [Luke 4:27](#); [Acts 10:34-35](#); [Romans 9:1-11:36](#); [Galatians 3:26-29](#); [Ephesians 2:14](#)

Faith and Good Deeds

Jesus did not teach that we are saved by doing good things ("works"). Instead, he taught that we need to be changed on the inside. This change (or conversion) happens when God works in us through his grace. When God changes us, we naturally begin to live differently and obey him. When someone has a real relationship with Jesus Christ, they will do good things as a result (see, for example, [Matthew 7:15-20](#); [12:33-37](#); [15:15-20](#)).

The parable of the sheep and the goats shows how faith and actions closely connect. This link between faith, actions, and God's final approval is a common theme in Jesus' teachings (for example, [Matthew 7:13-27](#); [13:3-9](#), [18-23](#); [16:27](#)). For Jesus, actions plainly show faith, which begins with repentance. Repentance is a change of heart and mind that causes a person to stop sinning and become more obedient to God ([Matthew 4:17](#); see also [3:2](#), [8-10](#); [11:20-24](#); [12:38-42](#)).

Some misunderstand what salvation by God's grace means. This has created a false distinction between faith and works. Salvation does not come from works alone, but it also includes them (see [Galatians 5:6](#), [21](#); [Ephesians 2:10](#); [5:5](#); [1 John 1:5-10](#); [Revelation 21:8](#)). Jesus promises blessings and rewards to those who obey God's will ([Matthew 5:3-12](#)). Therefore, righteousness is necessary for those who wish to "enter the kingdom of heaven" ([5:20-48](#); [7:21](#); [22:11-14](#); [23:3](#)). Faith that does not produce works is not saving faith ([James 2:14-26](#)).

The apostle James emphasizes being faithful to God and argues that doing good things shows faith ([2:14-26](#)). A relationship with God cannot rely only on believing a true statement ([2:19](#)). True faith leads to actions ([1:22-25](#); [2:14](#)). Faithful actions imitate God, who generously gives good gifts ([1:5](#), [17](#); [4:6](#)). Faith and good works cannot be separated. Like Abraham, good works show that a person has complete faith and is righteous before God ([2:23](#); see [Genesis 15:6](#)).

Jesus taught and showed that faith involves doing good works (see [Matthew 5:13-16](#)). Paul also

emphasized the importance of good works ([Romans 2:6](#); [Galatians 6:5-10](#); [Ephesians 2:10](#); [Philippians 2:12-13](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:3](#)).

James's letter emphasizes specific actions that show faith. These include:

- Caring for orphans and widows ([1:27](#))
- Not favoring the rich ([2:1-7](#))
- Providing food and clothing for the poor ([2:15-17](#))
- Controlling what one says ([3:1-12](#))
- Promoting peace ([3:17-18](#))
- Not judging others ([4:11-12](#))

These actions are "faith expressing itself through love" ([Galatians 5:6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 17:1](#); [22:1-19](#); [Leviticus 22:31](#); [Habakkuk 2:4](#); [Matthew 3:2](#), [8-10](#); [4:17](#); [5:3-12](#), [20-48](#); [7:13-27](#); [10:32-33](#); [11:20-24](#); [12:33-42](#); [13:3-9](#), [18-23](#); [15:15-20](#); [16:27](#); [25:31-46](#); [John 15:2](#); [Romans 2:6](#); [Galatians 5:6](#), [16-26](#); [6:5-10](#); [Ephesians 2:8-10](#); [5:3-9](#); [Philippians 2:12-13](#); [Hebrews 11:1-40](#); [James 2:14-26](#); [1 John 1:5-10](#); [Revelation 21:6-8](#)

False Prophets

The Bible describes many people who claimed to be prophets without authority and a true calling from God. They spoke as if they represented God. People often found it difficult to tell true prophets from false ones. False prophets usually told people what they wanted to hear (see, for example, [1 Kings 22:10-14](#); [Jeremiah 28:1-4](#)).

Due to this difficulty and the Lord's merciful delay in judging his rebellious people, many doubted that God's message through his true prophets would come true (see [Isaiah 5:19](#)). Others denied that anything would happen during their lifetimes. Could the often-delayed punishment wait a little longer?

Ezekiel prophesied that in the upcoming judgment on Jerusalem, God would remove false prophets. This would help people identify true prophets ([Ezekiel 13:8-9](#)). God's judgment would happen without delay—the Lord would soon fulfill his words ([13:11](#)). Everyone would then know which

words were truly from God and which words false prophets imagined.

Jesus warned that false prophets would appear in the future ([Matthew 24:11-28](#)). His early followers encountered many false prophets (see, for example, [Acts 13:6-12](#); [2 Peter 2:1-3](#)). Christians can often identify false prophets by their incorrect teachings about Christ. These teachings show that God's Spirit does not guide them ([1 John 4:1-3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 13:1-5](#); [18:22](#); [1 Kings 22:8-28](#); [Jeremiah 6:13-15](#); [14:13-16](#); [20:1-6](#); [28:1-17](#); [29:21-32](#); [50:6](#); [Ezekiel 13:1-23](#); [22:28](#); [Micah 3:5](#); [2 Corinthians 11:13-15](#); [2 Timothy 4:3-4](#); [2 Peter 2:1-3](#)

Family, Community, and Sexual Sin

In Israel, the family was the foundation for the unity of the community. Each of the twelve tribes was a mixed group of families and clans. Together, these tribes made up the entire nation of Israel.

While this unified identity might weaken with distance from a person's immediate family, this family concept was present throughout Israelite society. A relative was often called a brother. This showed how close they felt to each other. Extending this family model, the term often translated as "brother" could also mean a fellow Israelite (see [Deuteronomy 1:16](#), "a man and his brother"; [Deuteronomy 3:18](#), "your brothers, the Israelites").

In ancient Israel, the community was like a large family. So, the home's integrity was important. Crimes like incest (sexual relationships between close family members) and adultery (when a married person has a sexual relationship with someone who is not their spouse) had harsh punishments because they harmed family relationships. Incest damaged trust between family members, destroyed the safe environment that a home should provide, and broke the special bonds that family members should share. Adultery harmed families by people giving loyalty to someone other than their spouse. These threats to family unity weakened the clan and tribe, and finally, the nation's unity (see [Leviticus 18:6-23](#)).

Sexual sins, even ones to which both people agree, are not without victims. They can eventually harm the community. Old Testament laws emphasize

these crimes, and the New Testament also warns against sexual immorality (see especially [1 Corinthians 5:1-2](#); [6:13-20](#); [7:2](#); [Galatians 5:19-21](#); [Ephesians 5:3](#); [Jude 1:7](#); [Revelation 2:14-16, 20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 19:30-38](#); [49:3-4](#); [Leviticus 18:6-30](#); [20:14, 21](#); [2 Samuel 13:1-39](#); [Matthew 14:3-5](#); [1 Corinthians 5:1-2](#); [6:13-20](#); [7:2](#); [Galatians 5:19-21](#); [Ephesians 5:3](#); [Jude 1:7](#); [Revelation 2:14-16, 20](#)

Famine

Famine happened early in the lives of the patriarchs Abraham and Isaac ([Genesis 12:10](#); [26:1](#)). When the patriarch Jacob's family experienced famine, God had already placed his son Joseph in Egypt to help God's people through the crisis ([41:56-42:5](#); [45:5, 7](#)). This famine was very severe. But famines were common in the ancient world (see [Ruth 1:1](#); [2 Samuel 21:1](#); [1 Kings 18:1-2](#); [Haggai 1:1-11](#); [Acts 11:28](#)).

Famine was a terrible disaster in farming societies. Drought, crop failure, or siege could cause it ([2 Kings 25:1-30](#)). Famine often came with disease or war, affecting many levels of society ([Jeremiah 14:12](#)). This included animals ([Joel 1:20](#)). People relied on rain, so some people stored food to prepare for famine ([Genesis 41:33-36](#); [47:23-24](#); compare [1 Chronicles 26:15](#); [2 Chronicles 31:11](#); [Nehemiah 10:37-39](#)).

When there was not enough food, many bad things happened ([Genesis 12:10](#); [26:1](#); [2 Kings 6:24-29](#); [Nehemiah 5:1-3](#); [Jeremiah 19:9](#); [Lamentations 2:20-21](#); [4:8-10](#)).

- Food became very expensive.
- People stole from each other.
- The poor were treated unfairly.
- Farms could not grow crops.
- People had to leave their homes to find food.
- In the worst cases, people even ate human flesh to survive.

Sometimes, people considered famine as a punishment from God against the Israelites ([Leviticus 26:14-20](#); [Deuteronomy 11:16-17](#); [28:33](#); [Jeremiah 29:17-18](#)). Therefore, being

faithful to God was very important ([Psalm 33:18-19](#); [37:19](#)). God's blessings on the nation included protection from famine ([Ezekiel 34:29](#); [36:29-30](#)).

Jesus experienced a famine similar to Israel's during his time in the wilderness. He chose not to make bread just for himself ([Matthew 4:1-4](#); see also [Deuteronomy 8:3](#)). His success against the devil's temptation showed that lack of food and hunger can build humility and trust in God's care. Jesus fed five thousand people to show them he is "the bread of life," God's "true bread from heaven" ([John 6:32-35](#)).

Yet, the crowds followed him more for the food than for who he is ([John 6:26-27](#)). While not ignoring physical food, Jesus emphasized spiritual hunger and thirst ([Luke 6:21](#); [John 4:34](#)). Eating serves as both a setting and a symbol for fellowship ([Genesis 43:34](#); [Luke 22:15-16](#); [Revelation 19:9](#)). In heaven, hunger will no longer exist ([Revelation 7:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:10](#); [26:1](#); [41:33-36](#), [56-57](#); [45:6-7](#); [Leviticus 26:19-20](#); [Deuteronomy 8:3](#); [11:16-17](#); [Ruth 1:1](#); [2 Samuel 21:1](#); [1 Kings 18:1-2](#); [2 Kings 8:1-2](#); [Jeremiah 14:11-16](#); [Ezekiel 34:29-31](#); [36:28-32](#); [Joel 1:1-20](#); [Amos 8:11-14](#); [Haggai 1:1-11](#); [Luke 6:21](#); [John 6:32-35](#); [Acts 11:28-30](#); [Revelation 7:16](#)

Fear of the Lord

As Moses gives his final instructions to the people of Israel before his death, he repeatedly urges them to "fear the LORD" (see, for example, [Deuteronomy 6:1-13](#); [10:12-21](#); [31:9-13](#)). Joshua gives the same advice near the end of his life ([Joshua 24:14](#)). *Fear* means respect, a feeling of wonder at something great, and sometimes being very afraid. Fearing the Lord involves always being aware of his authority and power. For the Israelites, fearing the Lord meant recognizing that their success depended entirely on God.

The main theme of Proverbs is summarized in the words: "The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge" ([Proverbs 1:7](#)). This fear makes people humble and less prideful ([3:7](#); [15:33](#)). With this attitude, people will obey God more than rely on their own judgment. Fear of the Lord acknowledges God's central role in the world's order. God is the creator and master of everything.

This is why [Psalm 14:1](#) calls those who reject God "fools." Those who fear the Lord gain wisdom because they understand that everything is under God's rule and serves him. This is more than just an attitude. It is a way of living that respects God's power and authority and our ultimate responsibility to him.

Wisdom is linked to a good relationship with God. Both need choices that match God's character (see [Job 28:28](#); [Proverbs 14:2](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:13](#)). Do you want wisdom? Then you must be in a relationship with the one who has all wisdom (see [1 Corinthians 1:1-2:16](#); [Colossians 2:3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Job 28:28](#); [Psalms 14:1](#); [111:10](#); [Proverbs 1:7](#); [3:7](#); [8:13](#); [9:10](#); [10:27](#); [14:2](#), [26-27](#); [15:16](#), [33](#); [19:23](#); [22:4](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:13](#); [Isaiah 11:1-2](#); [33:6](#)

Fearing People

God promised to be with his people when they encountered opposition (see, for example, [Deuteronomy 20:1-4](#); [Joshua 1:9](#)). As long as they remained committed to him, they had no reason to fear others. Israel's history showed this truth (see [Exodus 14:10-31](#); [Joshua 10:9-14](#)). Yet, for those who seek peace and security elsewhere, God can become "a rock of offense" instead of a "sanctuary" ([Isaiah 8:14](#)).

During King Ahaz's rule in Judah, he became very afraid when he heard that Syria and Israel had joined to fight against him ([Isaiah 7:2](#)). The Lord urged him to have faith, as faith was necessary for the Lord's protection ([7:9](#)). Yet, Ahaz chose not to trust the Lord. Instead, he sought help from the Assyrians. This decision caused the Lord to become "a trap and a snare" for him and for all of Israel and Judah ([8:11-15](#)).

The prophet Isaiah's message intended to show the difference between faith and fear. King Ahaz is an example of fear. King Hezekiah is an imperfect example of faith ([Isaiah 37](#)). Isaiah himself is a better example of faith (chapter [8](#)). Finally, God's "Servant" is the ideal example of faith ([42:1-7](#); [50:4-7](#)).

Jesus told his followers not to fear people who threaten them, even those who want to kill them ([Matthew 10:26-31](#)). God knows every sparrow and the number of hairs on a person's head. God will be with those who trust in him. Christians have

shown this trust throughout history by not fearing what others can do to them, even dying for their faith (see [Acts 6:8-7:60](#)).

People who do not fully commit to God will fear others. But those who trust in the Lord can overcome this fear. They understand that human enemies are temporary, while God's power lasts forever.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 14:1-12](#); [21:34-35](#); [Joshua 1:9](#); [2 Kings 16:5-18](#); [2 Chronicles 28:16-23](#); [Psalm 23:4](#); [Proverbs 29:25](#); [Isaiah 7:1-25](#); [41:10](#); [51:7-8](#), [12-13](#); [54:4](#); [57:11](#); [Jeremiah 10:5](#); [30:10](#); [46:27-28](#)

Fishing in Galilee

Jesus' knowledge of fishing is obvious in the four Gospels. He used fishing in his stories to teach people ([Matthew 7:10](#); [13:47-51](#)). When Jesus called his first followers, he told them, "I will make you fishers of men," meaning they would help bring people to God ([Matthew 4:19](#)). In [John 21](#), after Jesus rose from the dead, he even used fishing to show himself to his followers.

In ancient Galilee, people who fished for a living only used nets. They used three types of nets:

40. The drag net was one of the oldest types of nets. It was like a wall, with weights at the bottom and cork floats at the top. People first pulled it along the coast. Then, a boat dragged the lead rope across the sea and pulled it back to shore.

The drag net caught many fish, including some that Jewish law did not allow for eating. People sorted the fish. They kept the good ones and removed the bad ones. Jesus used the drag net as a symbol for the day of judgment ([Matthew 13:47-51](#)).

41. The cast net was circular and measured fifteen to twenty feet across. They attached lead weights to its edges. A lone fisherman tossed it into the sea. It landed, sank, and caught unsuspecting fish. The fisherman then dove into the water and either pulled the fish out one by one or gathered the net and lifted it into the boat. Simon and Andrew used cast nets when Jesus called them ([Matthew 4:18-20](#); [Mark 1:16-18](#)).
42. The trammel net is the only type still used today. It is made of three layers. The two outer nets are the same and have wide openings. The inner net is finely meshed and loose, moving easily in and out of the outer nets. Fishermen spread the net in the water in a long line, usually at night, and hold it while others scare fish toward it.

Fish enter the first outer net easily, push against the fine mesh inner net, and then carry the fine net into the second outer net, becoming hopelessly entangled. The fishermen then haul the net ashore. They untangle the net and sort the fish, and repair the many breaks in the net. When Jesus called James and John to follow him, they were repairing their trammel nets ([Matthew 4:18-22](#); [Mark 1:19-20](#)).

When Jesus told Simon to lower his net again after fishing all night, Simon caught a miraculous number of fish ([Luke 5:1-11](#)). A similar thing happened in [John 21:1-11](#) when Simon Peter came back from an unsuccessful night of fishing. Jesus instructed him to throw out his net again. Peter probably used a cast net, which then filled with so many fish that it was hard to pull in.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 4:19-22](#); [7:10](#); [13:47-48](#); [Mark 1:19-20](#); [6:41](#); [Luke 5:1-7](#); [John 21:1-14](#)

Following Jesus

The Gospels (books about Jesus's life) were written to help people understand and accept Jesus' invitation to follow him by "taking up their cross." This invitation is not just for Jesus' closest

followers, called apostles. It is for everyone who wants to follow him ([Mark 3:13-19](#); see also [1:16-20](#); [2:14](#)). It is for all who wish to follow him ([Mark 8:34](#); see also [2:15](#); [10:21](#), [52](#)). Some people find it very challenging to follow Jesus, but God offers help through his grace ([Mark 10:17-25, 27](#)). Others find it easy to respond to Jesus' invitation ([Mark 2:14](#); see also [Luke 7:36-50](#)).

To "follow Jesus" means fully committing to leave behind selfish behaviors ([Mark 8:34-35](#)). "Taking up one's cross" means being willing to give up everything for Jesus, even one's life. For example, Peter, Andrew, James, and John left their homes and jobs to follow Jesus ([Mark 1:16-20](#)). A rich man had to sell everything and give the money to the poor to stop being selfish ([Mark 10:21](#)).

Following Jesus also involves publicly acknowledging him and being faithful to his teachings ([Mark 8:38](#); compare [Romans 10:9](#)). It means removing anything that stops you from following Jesus, no matter how difficult ([Mark 9:43-48](#)). It involves trusting Jesus completely and refusing to sin ([Mark 1:15](#); [6:12](#)). It even requires being more loyal to Jesus than one's parents ([Matt 10:37](#); [Luke 14:26](#)).

Jesus clearly told his disciples to share his message ([Matthew 28:18-20](#); [Luke 24:47-49](#); [Acts 1:8](#)). Throughout the New Testament, we see that Jesus' followers told people about the good news wherever they went. This led many more people to become followers of Jesus (see [Acts 2:14-41](#); [3:12-26](#); [4:1-2, 20](#); [8:4](#); [9:20](#); [11:19-26](#); [13:1-3](#); [Romans 1:1-16](#); [10:14-15](#); [15:18-21](#); [1 Corinthians 9:16](#); [Colossians 1:23](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:9](#); [2 Timothy 4:2](#)).

Following Jesus brings both responsibilities and rewards. Those who follow him receive:

- A place in God's kingdom ([Mark 9:43-48](#); [10:23-31](#))
- Forgiveness for their sins ([Mark 2:10-11](#); see also [3:28](#); [11:25](#))
- A place in God's family ([John 1:12](#))
- Protection from God's judgment ([Mark 8:35](#); [13:13](#))
- Eternal life ([Mark 9:43](#); [10:29-30](#); [1 John 5:11-12](#))

Passages for Further Study

[Hosea 6:3](#); [Matthew 10:37-39](#); [28:18-20](#); [Mark 1:15-20](#); [2:14-15](#); [3:13-15](#); [5:18-20](#); [6:6-13](#), [30-32](#); [8:34-38](#); [9:38-50](#); [10:17-31](#); [11:22-25](#); [13:9-13](#); [Luke 14:25-35](#); [24:47-49](#); [John 8:12](#); [10:27](#); [12:26](#); [Acts 1:8](#); [2:42-47](#); [4:16-20](#); [8:4](#); [9:19-30](#); [11:19-24](#); [13:1-3](#); [Romans 1:1-16](#); [10:7-15](#); [1 Corinthians 9:16](#); [Ephesians 5:1](#); [Colossians 1:23](#); [2 Timothy 4:2](#); [1 Peter 2:21](#)

Four World Empires

The book of Daniel describes two important visions that show how God rules over all of history. King Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon had the first vision (chapter [2](#)), and the prophet Daniel had a similar one (chapter [7](#)). Each vision shows four world kingdoms.

People have sometimes disagreed about which kingdoms these visions described, but many important teachers throughout history have shared the same understanding. Hippolytus, an early Christian teacher (or "church father") who lived from AD 170 to 236, identified the four kingdoms as:

- Babylonia,
- Media-Persia,
- Greece, and
- Rome.

Eusebius of Caesarea, another church father and historian who lived from AD 260 to 340, thought the first kingdom was Assyria (which had ruled over Babylon). However, he later agreed with Hippolytus's view. Most other early Christian teachers also accepted this understanding. Later, two other church fathers, Jerome and Augustine, agreed with this same explanation. Many Bible teachers today still accept this view of the four kingdoms.

In ancient times and today, some people have argued that Greece is the fourth empire. They consider Media and Persia as separate kingdoms. These teachers often believe this because they think the book of Daniel was written before the Roman Empire existed and could not have predicted future events. However, people usually consider Media and Persia to be one empire. By the time King Cyrus II conquered Babylon in 539 BC, the Persians had mostly combined the Median kingdom.

People generally consider Rome to be the fourth kingdom. But the evil and inhuman qualities described in the vision go beyond just the historical Roman Empire. The visions show a view of the world and its governments. The kingdom of God will destroy and replace all. It is "a stone ... cut out" ([Daniel 2:34](#)). In chapter [2](#), the statue's metals become less valuable. While in chapter [7](#), the animal imagery becomes more fierce and violent. These features show a decline in human civilization over time, even as the kingdom of God increases in power and size ([2:35](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 2:1-49; 7:1-28](#)

Giving up Rights

The apostle Paul never tells Christians to defend their rights. Instead, he emphasizes that Christians should be willing to give up their rights for the benefit of others. Christians are free from many rules that others follow. But they should be ready to give up their freedoms if their actions might lead someone else to sin ([Romans 14:13-23](#); [1 Corinthians 8:1-13](#); [10:23-33](#)). Paul sees little value in defending personal rights.

Paul, like Jesus, views loving others as a key principle in life ([Romans 13:8-10](#); [1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#); [Galatians 5:6](#); see [Matthew 5:43-44](#); [22:36-39](#)). True Christian love is always sacrificial, like Christ's love ([1 Corinthians 13:4-7](#)). Christians should focus on what is best for others, not themselves ([1 Corinthians 10:32-33](#)). Christ's sacrificial death for sinners shows the nature of true love ([Romans 5:6-8](#); [15:1-5](#); [1 John 4:9-12](#)). A Christian's life should express Christ's sacrificial love. This is challenging because it requires people to deny their own desires (see [Mark 8:34-35](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 5:38-48](#); [16:24-27](#); [22:37-39](#); [Romans 5:6-8](#); [13:8-10](#); [14:15-22](#); [15:1-5](#); [1 Corinthians 8:1-13](#); [9:1-23](#); [10:23-24](#); [31-33](#); [13:4-7](#); [Galatians 5:6](#); [Philippians 2:3-4](#); [2 Timothy 2:9-13](#); [Hebrews 11:24-26](#); [1 John 4:9-12](#)

God as Holy Warrior

The Arabic term *jihad*, now familiar in English, refers to a "holy war" where men fight for God. Yet, the Bible describes a "holy war" differently. In the

Bible, a holy war is a conflict where God fights for his people as they trust in him. In these wars, victory relies on obedience to God, not on weapons.

During a war, King Jehoshaphat of Judah declared a fast and prayed to God with a lament ([2 Chronicles 20:3, 5-12](#)). This prayer included calling on God, complaining, confessing trust, and requesting.

Jehoshaphat and the people showed their humility by bowing with their faces to the ground ([2 Chronicles 20:18](#)). It is surprising to see an army led by a choir praising God as they march into battle ([20:21](#)). Usually battlefields are not for worship and praise. Yet, worship helps people understand God's will and invites him to save his people. God rewards trust in him. In Jehoshaphat's case, God defeated a large enemy alliance without Israel needing to fight at all ([20:22-24](#)).

The New Testament shows Jesus as the conqueror of all forces against God's kingdom (see [Ephesians 1:19-21](#)). In the end, Jesus will defeat all enemies ([1 Corinthians 15:24-28](#); [Revelation 19:11-20:15](#)). This victory will make God's rule and worship complete: "Hallelujah! For the Lord our God the Almighty reigns" ([Revelation 19:6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Joshua 6:1-20](#); [10:7-15](#); [Judges 7:7-22](#); [2 Kings 19:14-37](#); [2 Chronicles 6:34-35](#); [20:5-7, 20-24](#); [Isaiah 26:21-27:6](#); [Jonah 3:4-10](#); [Matthew 16:18](#); [2 Corinthians 10:3-6](#); [Ephesians 1:19-23](#); [6:10-20](#); [Revelation 19:11-21](#)

God or Satan?

Who is responsible for trials and difficulties? It might seem strange, but Scripture sometimes says God, sometimes Satan, and sometimes both. How is this possible? Understanding this requires looking at these situations from different points of view.

The Bible tells the story of King David's census in two different books, and they describe what happened in different ways. [Second Samuel 24:1](#) says God "stirred up David against them" by taking a census. In contrast, [1 Chronicles 21:1](#) says "Satan rose up against Israel and incited David to take a census of Israel." [Second Samuel 24:1-25](#) tells the census story from God's perspective. God allowed Satan's actions to achieve his purpose.

This is common in Scripture. [Matthew 4:1](#) says the Holy Spirit led Jesus into the wilderness where Satan would test him. This shows how God and

Satan can both be involved in the same event but with different purposes.

A notable example is Job's suffering. God had praised Job for being a faithful person. Then he gave Satan permission to cause Job great suffering ([Job 1:6-2:7](#)). Despite the difficulties, Job remained righteous. He resisted Satan's attempts to make him curse God.

Similarly, [2 Corinthians 12:7](#) teaches that God can send an affliction through a messenger from Satan. When Paul mentioned his "thorn," he used a passive verb, showing that God gave this "torment." The way Paul describes this shows that God allowed this trouble to happen, even though it came through a messenger from Satan.

Satan tries many different ways to hurt and discourage people who follow God. But God is in control of everything. God does not create evil but sometimes he uses the evil actions of others to accomplish his good purposes ([Genesis 50:20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 24:1-25](#); [1 Chronicles 21:1-30](#); [Job 1:8-2:10](#); [Matthew 4:1-11](#); [12:22-37](#); [Mark 8:31-33](#); [John 13:21-31](#); [Romans 8:28](#); [1 Corinthians 5:1-5](#); [2 Corinthians 12:6-10](#); [Ephesians 2:1-7](#); [Revelation 20:1-3, 7-10](#)

God Protects His Servant

When God called the prophet Jeremiah as his messenger, he promised to protect him. This protection was spiritual, as the Lord gave Jeremiah inner strength "like a fortified city" ([Jeremiah 1:18](#)). God's protection was also physical: "They will fight against you but will never overcome you" ([1:19](#)).

During King Josiah's rule (from 640 to 609 BC), Jeremiah was safe and did not experience serious threats to his life. Things changed when Jehoiakim became king (from 609 to 598 BC). The king and his officials quickly became hostile, putting Jeremiah's life at risk. But the Lord promised to protect him (see [Jeremiah 11:18-23](#)).

This promise seemed broken when Pashhur arrested, whipped, and put Jeremiah in stocks ([Jeremiah 20:1-2](#)). Jeremiah questioned the Lord for misleading him. But soon he regained his trust ([20:7-13](#)). Early in Jehoiakim's rule, he arrested Jeremiah and put him on trial (chapter [26](#)). The

Lord strengthened Jeremiah internally, helping him stay calm.

Some elders who served under King Josiah protected him. They reminded others of King Hezekiah's response to danger a century earlier. Ahikam saved Jeremiah's life ([Jeremiah 26:24](#)). Jeremiah went into hiding when Jehoiakim's officers tried to kill him. The Lord kept him hidden until after Jehoiakim's death ([36:19-20, 26](#)).

The new king, Zedekiah, treated Jeremiah more kindly. Yet, Jeremiah encountered danger several times during the attack against Jerusalem. At one point, the king's officials threw him into a muddy well (cistern). God protected Jeremiah by inspiring a foreigner named Ebed-melech, to save him. Zedekiah then put Jeremiah in protective custody ([Jeremiah 38](#)).

Jeremiah survived when the Babylonians captured Jerusalem. Although he was almost taken captive to Babylon. God influenced the Babylonian general to free Jeremiah. He offered him a choice. He could go to Babylon as a free man or stay with Gedaliah, the new governor of Judah ([Jeremiah 39:11-14](#); [40:1-6](#)). God also protected Jeremiah from Johanan and his group, who forced Jeremiah and Baruch to go to Egypt ([43:1-7](#)).

God kept his promises to Jeremiah. He continues to keep his promises to all his people. He does not always promise to physically protect those who serve him (see [2 Corinthians 6:4-5](#); [2 Timothy 2:10-13](#); [3:11-13](#); [1 Peter 2:21-23](#); [3:14-17](#); [Revelation 14:12](#)). But he promises eternal salvation to those who trust in him ([James 1:12](#); [1 Peter 1:6-9](#); [4:12-19](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 20:3-7](#); [31:24](#); [Numbers 14:10-35](#); [2 Kings 6:14-20](#); [Job 1:9-11](#); [Psalm 91:1-16](#); [Jeremiah 1:18-19](#); [11:18-23](#); [20:1-2, 7-13](#); [26:24](#); [36:19-20, 26](#); [39:11-14](#); [Matthew 2:13-22](#); [10:28-31](#); [John 15:20](#); [Acts 12:1-11](#); [2 Corinthians 6:4-5](#); [2 Timothy 2:10-13](#); [3:11-13](#); [Hebrews 11:4-37](#); [James 1:12](#); [1 Peter 1:6](#); [3:14-17](#); [4:12-19](#); [Revelation 14:12](#)

God Works through Prayer

God has authority and control over all creation. But he wants people to share their concerns with him through prayer. The Bible shows examples of God responding to people's prayers. Prayer is

important for living a godly life and effective Christian service. It helps people submit their will to God.

The short book of Nehemiah tells the story of a man devoted to prayer. When he saw Jerusalem's poor condition, Nehemiah prayed intensely for four months (see [Nehemiah 1:1; 2:1](#)). His prayers praised God for his power and love. Nehemiah confessed the nation's sins and asked God to help ([1:4-11](#); see also [Ezra 9:6-15](#); [Daniel 9:4-19](#)). Nehemiah's based his prayer for Jerusalem on God's "covenant of loving devotion with those who love Him and keep His commandments" ([1:5](#)).

The Israelites had not followed the instructions God gave to Moses ([1:7](#)). As God had warned, this disobedience resulted in their exile. Yet, Nehemiah firmly believed that God would restore the nation if the people repented ([1:8-9](#); see [Deuteronomy 4:25-31](#); [30:1-5](#)).

God gave Nehemiah a chance to speak to the Persian king about returning to Jerusalem. Nehemiah prayed for guidance ([Nehemiah 2:4](#)). He understood that only God could change the king's will. Later, Nehemiah responded to threats against the builders of Jerusalem's wall by posting guards and encouraging the people. Yet, he also prayed for protection and strength ([Nehemiah 4:4-5, 9; 6:9, 14](#)). He needed God's help and blessing both then and in the future as he dealt with those who behaved wrongly.

Nehemiah returned to Jerusalem after a short visit to Persia. He learned that some Jews were not giving their tithe ([Nehemiah 13:10-12](#)). Some were not observing the Sabbath ([13:15-16](#)). Some had married non-Jews ([13:23-24](#)). When he confronted them about their actions, Nehemiah prayed for God to show him compassion and remember his efforts ([13:14, 22, 31](#)). Nehemiah understood that only God's power could change people.

Jesus knew well the Father's will, yet his ministry had its basis in prayer (see, for example, [Luke 5:16; 6:12-16; 9:18](#)). Following his example, early Christians prayed often, believing firmly in its power (see, for example, [9:36-41; 12:3-11](#)). God often responds powerfully to prayers. God wants Christians to pray with confidence, expecting him to answer (see [James 5:16-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 24:10-20](#); [Judges 15:18-20](#); [Ezra 9:6-15](#); [Nehemiah 1:4-11](#); [2:4-5](#); [4:4-5, 9](#); [Psalms 18:1-30](#);

[22:4-5](#), [24](#); [30:2-3](#); [31:22](#); [34:4](#); [40:1-2](#); [81:7](#); [106:1-48](#); [107:6-7](#), [13-14](#); [116:1](#); [118:5](#); [Daniel 9:4-19](#); [Jonah 2:1-10](#); [Acts 4:24-31](#); [James 5:16-18](#)

God's Absolute Holiness

Holiness is one main way to describe God. It is not just one of his many traits, it is central to who he is. Calling God "the Holy One" emphasizes how he is completely different than anyone or anything else. Creation exists within the limits of time, but nothing limits God.

God calls himself, "I AM WHO I AM" ([Exodus 3:14](#)). This means he defines himself by himself. God is entirely different, completely self-sufficient, and separate from what he created.

God's holiness also refers to his character. People often describe God's holiness as his separation from sin and his anger against it. Yet, holiness includes all aspects of God's character, such as his mercy. God revealed himself to Moses as the "God of compassion and mercy." He is, "slow to anger, abounding in loving devotion and faithfulness, maintaining loving devotion to a thousand generations, forgiving iniquity, transgression, and sin. Yet He will by no means leave the guilty unpunished" ([Exodus 34:6-7](#)).

God's holiness can be dangerous to those who approach without permission and respect ([Isaiah 6:3, 5](#); see [Exodus 28:35](#)). His endless holiness is overwhelming for imperfect humans. It would completely destroy them without God's mercy.

When we understand God's holiness, it should fill us with deep respect and wonder. We must not treat God's holiness casually or without proper honor. This might have been the mistake that led to Nadab and Abihu's deaths ([Leviticus 10:1-3](#)). Only by recognizing the awesomeness of God can we truly appreciate his love for us and worship him rightly and sincerely.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 3:14](#); [34:6-7](#); [Leviticus 10:3](#); [Leviticus 11:44-45](#); [1 Samuel 2:1-2](#); [Isaiah 6:3-5](#); [52:10](#); [Hosea 11:9](#)

God's Anger

God is just and righteous in his judgment ([Psalm 7:11](#)). He responds with righteous anger toward sin and injustice. God's anger is not like human anger. It is not an emotional outburst or loss of control. It is his perfect, holy response to evil. Wicked people persist in doing wrong and deserve his judgment (see [2:5](#), [12](#), [21:9](#), [56:7](#), [59:13](#), [69:24](#), [79:6](#); see also [Romans 1:18](#)). Even though God is patient and slow to become angry, he will not allow evil to continue forever without stopping it ([86:15](#), [103:8](#), [145:8](#)).

The writers of the psalms saw Israel's escape from Egypt as a lesson about God's anger. God showed his anger against the Egyptians while protecting his people ([Psalm 78:49–50](#)). But during their journey through the wilderness, Israel's disobedience led to God's anger, and they faced his judgment ([78:31](#), [106:29](#), [32](#)).

Because of this, God promised that disobedient generation would not enter his place of rest ([Psalm 95:8–11](#)). So they died in the wilderness. But God held back his anger and did not destroy Israel completely ([78:38](#)).

In the same way, throughout the time of the judges and kings, God's people often disobeyed and did evil things. As a result, in his anger, God allowed foreign powers to control them and send them into exile ([2 Kings 17:5–23](#), [24:20–25:21](#)). But again, God did not allow his people to be completely destroyed.

When God's people sin and feel his anger, it can lead them to repent. This emotionally painful experience can bring great joy in God's mercy and goodness ([Psalm 30:5](#); see also [Hebrews 12:5–11](#)).

The New Testament makes clear that all people were subject to God's wrath because of sin ([Ephesians 2:1–3](#)). But in his love, God sent his Son, Jesus Christ, who gave his life for our sins so that we could be reconciled to God ([Romans 5:6–11](#), [Ephesians 2:4–5](#)). Those who turn to God in faith will escape the punishment that is coming at the future judgment of the world. In the end, Jesus, who is both Savior and Judge, will bring God's justice against the wicked ([Psalms 2:5–9](#), [Revelation 6:15–17](#), [19:11–16](#)). God will deal decisively with all evil, including his ultimate enemy, the devil ([Revelation 20:7–15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 2:5–9](#), [12](#), [6:1](#), [7:6](#), [11–13](#), [21:9](#), [27:9](#), [30:5](#), [38:1–10](#), [74:1](#), [78:18–64](#), [79:5–6](#), [80:4](#), [85:2–7](#), [86:15](#), [90:9–11](#), [95:8–11](#), [102:10–11](#), [103:8–9](#), [106:21–43](#), [110:5–7](#), [145:8](#), [Isaiah 64:9–12](#), [Lamentations 5:19–22](#), [Romans 2:5–11](#), [Ephesians 5:6](#), [Revelation 6:15–17](#), [11:18](#), [19:11–16](#)

God's Change of Mind

The Old Testament describes God 34 times as “changing his mind” or “being sorry” (the Hebrew word *nakham*). What does this mean? Does God relent, feel pity, experience sorrow, or grieve?

One thing is clear: God never repents of sin or moral failure because he is perfect (see [1 Samuel 15:29](#), [Numbers 23:19](#)). God may “change his mind” about disaster or judgment that he started. This means God may decide to change his plans in response to:

- when people pray with repentance ([Jeremiah 18:7–10](#), [Joel 2:14](#), [Jonah 3:9–10](#));
- when a human speaks to God on behalf of others ([Exodus 32:11–14](#), [Amos 7:2–6](#)); or
- without any clear human involvement ([Judges 2:18](#), [2 Samuel 24:16](#)).

A few times, God regrets something he has already done. For example, God regretted choosing Saul as king ([1 Samuel 15:11](#), [35](#); compare [Genesis 6:6](#)). But God is not admitting he made mistakes in the past. He is showing sadness about lives that have gone wrong.

Theologians debate how much God, who is all-wise and all-powerful, can “change his mind.” In the Bible, when it seems like God changes his mind, it shows a human view of God's actions. Any change that God seems to show is how humans experience God. God is constant in his love, mercy, faithfulness, and holy will. God's power, all-knowing nature, foreknowledge, wisdom, and holiness do not change.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 6:6–7](#), [Exodus 32:11–14](#), [Numbers 23:19](#), [Deuteronomy 32:36](#), [1 Samuel 15:10–11](#), [29](#), [35](#), [2 Samuel 24:15–16](#), [Jeremiah 4:28](#), [18:7–10](#), [26:2–19](#), [Ezekiel 24:14](#), [Joel 2:13–14](#), [Amos 7:2–6](#), [Jonah 3:9–4:11](#)

God's Commitment to His People

Sometimes, God's people have had to wait what seems like a long time to see God's promises come true. Here are some examples from the Bible:

- God first promised Abraham and Sarah he would make them a great nation. Yet, they had to wait twenty-five years from the time God first promised to make them a great nation until their son Isaac was born.
- God promised David the kingship. Yet, David encountered many challenges during King Saul's rule before God finally made him king.
- God promised to bring a remnant of people back to the promised land after the exile to Babylon. Yet, the Jewish captives waited seventy years to return. But, in each case, God fulfilled his promises.
- Zechariah prophesied while the people rebuilt the temple after the exile. During the reconstruction, God told Zechariah not to despise "the day of small things" ([Zechariah 4:10](#)). God had acted in the past for the ultimate good of his people, even during the exile to Babylon (see [7:12-14](#)). God would achieve his plans for Israel's well-being in his own time and way. The people of Israel could find courage in the present and hope for the future. This was because God keeps his word and fulfills his promises ([4:9](#)).

God wants patience and faith from his people, not loud demands. He kept his promises by guaranteeing his people would return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple.

About five hundred years after Zechariah, God fulfilled his promise of bringing salvation to all nations by sending Jesus the Messiah. Similarly, we can trust Jesus' promise that he will return to fully establish his kingdom (see [Matthew 24:27, 30](#); see also [Acts 1:6-11](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 15:29](#); [2 Samuel 7:28-29](#); [2 Chronicles 36:21](#); [Isaiah 42:1-9](#); [49:15](#); [Zechariah 2:13](#); [4:9-10](#); [14:3](#); [John 14:1-4](#); [17:17](#); [Acts 1:6-11](#); [Titus 1:2](#); [Revelation 21:5](#)

God's Covenant Love

The Bible talks about God's love in two main ways. First, there is the common understanding that God deeply cares about and has great affection for all people. Second, in some parts of the Bible, like Deuteronomy (where God makes special agreements with his people), God's love means his faithful promise to stay with his people and take care of them.

In the ancient Near East, a conquering king often described his relationship with conquered peoples (vassals) with terms of love. This meant he chose them to enjoy his favor and protection in exchange for their loyalty.

In a similar way, God chose Israel to be his servant nation. This was not because they deserved it, but because he chose to love them ([Deuteronomy 7:6-11](#)). In other words, he loved them because he had chosen them. The strongest example of this is in [Malachi 1:2-3](#). God chose Jacob but rejected Esau (see also [Romans 9:13-26](#)).

God extended the special covenant relationship with Israel to include both Jews and non-Jews (gentiles) through Jesus Christ ([Acts 10:1-11:18](#); [Ephesians 2:11-22](#)). God established this new covenant through the ultimate demonstration of his love in the suffering and death of his son Jesus ([Luke 22:20](#); [John 3:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 7:6-11](#); [33:3](#); [Isaiah 49:14-18](#); [Hosea 11:1-11](#); [Malachi 1:2-3](#); [Matthew 3:16-17](#); [Luke 15:1-32](#); [John 3:16](#); [16:25-27](#); [Romans 5:6-8](#); [9:13-26](#); [Ephesians 1:4](#); [2:4-7](#); [Hebrews 12:6-11](#); [1 John 3:1](#); [4:8-9](#), [16](#)

God's Covenant with Abraham

God started a relationship with Abraham before making a formal covenant (agreement) with him ([Genesis 12:1-9](#); [15](#)). God started the relationship with Abraham by speaking to him in a vision. God promised that the elderly Abraham would have a

son. He said that he would have as many descendants as there are stars in the sky. Abraham trusted God ([15:6](#)). God considered Abraham's faith to be an act of righteousness (see [Habakkuk 2:4](#); [Romans 1:17](#); [4:3](#), [17](#); [Galatians 3:6](#), [11](#); [Hebrews 10:37-38](#)).

In the ancient Near East, kings sometimes gave land or other gifts to loyal subjects. The covenant of [Genesis 15](#) includes a royal gift ([15:18-21](#)). God, the king, gave land to Abraham, his subject, to possess and inherit it. By the end of that day, Abraham knew that his future and the future of his descendants was secure. His covenant God would take care of him. Later, the land would belong to his descendants.

God later confirmed his covenant with Abraham ([Genesis 17:1-22](#)). He gave circumcision as its sign and requirement ([17:9](#), [10](#)). God again visited Abraham and gave him a special privilege ([17:1-2](#)).

The covenant was not between equals, but both sides had duties. God willingly committed to Abraham and his descendants, while expecting Abraham's faithfulness ([17:1](#), [9-14](#)). The new name God gave him showed the blessing Abraham received as God's partner ([17:5-6](#)).

God's covenant with Abraham also included his descendants ([Genesis 13:15-16](#); [15:3-5](#); [17:6-10](#)). It promised blessings soon to come when his descendants would own the land ([15:12-16](#)).

Much later, Abraham's faith blessed everyone through his descendant, Jesus Christ. Through Jesus, all families on earth can share in God's blessing to Abraham ([12:3](#); see [Romans 4:11-25](#); [Galatians 3:8-9](#), [16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1-3](#); [15:1-21](#); [17:1-14](#); [21:1-2](#); [22:15-18](#); [Exodus 2:24](#); [Deuteronomy 1:8](#); [Nehemiah 9:7-8](#); [Psalm 105:7-45](#); [Luke 3:7-9](#); [Acts 3:24-26](#); [7:2-8](#); [Romans 4:11-25](#); [9:7-8](#); [11:16-17](#); [Galatians 3:6-9](#), [29](#); [Hebrews 6:13-15](#)

God's Covenant with David

God made five special agreements (called covenants) with his people in the Old Testament:

43. God promised Noah, his family, and the creation that a flood would never again destroy the world ([Genesis 6:18](#); [9:1-17](#)). This is called the Noachian covenant.
44. God promised Abraham the land of Canaan and that he would become a great nation ([Genesis 15:1-21](#); [17:1-27](#)). This is called the Abrahamic covenant.
45. God began a special relationship with Israel at Mount Sinai through Moses ([Exodus 19-23](#)). This is called the Mosaic covenant.
46. God promised Aaron's son Phinehas that his descendants would be priests ([Numbers 25:10-13](#)). This is called the Priestly covenant.
47. God promised David that he and his descendants would be kings ([2 Samuel 7:4-17](#)). This is called the Davidic covenant.

God also promised through Jeremiah to make a future "new covenant" ([Jeremiah 31:31-34](#)).

In [2 Samuel 7](#), God's promise to David is not called a covenant. But other passages do call it a covenant (see [23:5](#); [2 Chronicles 7:18](#); [21:7](#); [Psalms 89:3-4](#), [28-29](#); [132:11-12](#); [Isaiah 55:3](#); [Jeremiah 33:20-21](#)). God's promise to David that his "loving devotion will never be removed" suggests a covenant relationship ([2 Samuel 7:15](#)). Like God's promise to Abraham, his covenant with David is unconditional. It ultimately relies on God's unchanging love, not on human obedience or faithfulness.

The most important part of God's covenant with David is God's promise to always continue David's descendants and to be like a father to them (compare [1 Kings 11:36](#); [15:4](#); [2 Kings 8:19](#)). God's blessing on David's son Solomon partly fulfills this promise (compare [2 Samuel 7:10-11](#) with [1 Kings 8:56](#); see also [1 Kings 8:20](#), [24](#)). God was patient with the kings of Judah, even when they did evil things. This was because of his promise to David (see [1 Kings 11:12-13](#); [15:3-5](#)).

The complete fulfillment of God's promise to David is in the Messiah, Jesus Christ, the "Son of David" (see [Matthew 9:27](#); [20:30-31](#); [21:9](#), [15](#)). Isaiah prophesied that someone who would "reign from

the throne of David and over his kingdom ...forevermore" ([Isaiah 9:7](#)). He called him the "shoot" growing "from the stump of Jesse" ([Isaiah 11:1](#)). These references point to the coming Messiah (God's chosen one).

Four passages in the New Testament show that Jesus fulfills the promises made to David by directly referring to [2 Samuel 7:1-29](#) ([Luke 1:32-33](#); [Acts 2:29-31](#); [13:22-23](#); [Hebrews 1:5](#)). The New Testament begins and ends by calling Jesus "the son of David," the heir to his throne ([Matthew 1:1](#); [Revelation 22:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 7:5-16](#); [1 Kings 8:20-24](#); [11:9-13](#); [15:1-5](#); [2 Kings 8:18-19](#); [2 Chronicles 7:17-22](#); [Psalms 89:3-4](#), [18-51](#); [132:10-12](#); [Isaiah 9:6-7](#); [11:1-10](#); [Jeremiah 33:20-26](#); [Matthew 1:1](#); [20:30-31](#); [21:1-9](#); [Luke 1:30-33](#), [67-79](#); [Acts 2:22-36](#); [Revelation 22:16](#)

God's Covenant with Israel's Kings

Solomon understood his role as David's successor ([1 Kings 3:7](#)). The elderly King David advised Solomon to follow all of God's laws from Moses to "prosper in all you do and wherever you turn" ([2:3](#)). Solomon's faithfulness would fulfill God's promises to David ([1 Kings 2:4](#); see [2 Samuel 7:5-16](#)). Early in his rule, he intentionally showed his father's love and faithfulness to God ([1 Kings 3:3](#)). He saw that God had kept his promises to David ([8:23-26](#)).

Several times during Solomon's rule, God communicated the permanent nature of his covenant (special agreement) with David ([1 Kings 3:14](#); [9:4-5](#); [11:38](#)). God judged Solomon and later kings based on their faithfulness to that covenant compared to David ([11:12-13](#); [14:8](#); [15:3-5](#), [11](#)). God's approval and blessings or disapproval and judgment depended on whether people obeyed or violated his law (see [Deuteronomy 28](#)).

During the time of the kings, God condemned the people of Israel for intentionally rejecting the Lord's written rules in the law and those spoken by God's prophets ([2 Kings 17:13-17](#)). Their rejection of God led to judgment ([2 Kings 17:18-23](#); [21:11-15](#)).

How God dealt with the kings of Israel serves as an example for those in a covenant with God through Jesus. Today, God's people must love Jesus and

follow his commandments ([John 14:21](#)). They must remain faithful in all things ([Matthew 25:21](#); [Luke 16:10-12](#); [2 Timothy 3:14](#); [4:7](#)). Those who follow David's example of faithfulness will receive God's praise (see [Acts 13:22](#)). Those who confess the name of Jesus, David's heir, and are devoted to God and his word will try to live pure and pleasing lives for God ([Acts 13:32-37](#); [Hebrews 13:20-21](#)). They know they will receive many good gifts from God that will last forever ([2 Timothy 4:8](#); [Revelation 2:10](#); compare [Galatians 5:19-21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 7:5-17](#); [1 Kings 2:2-4](#); [3:3-15](#); [8:22-26](#); [9:1-9](#); [11:1-13](#), [29-39](#); [14:7-16](#); [15:1-5](#), [11](#); [2 Kings 17:13-23](#); [21:11-15](#); [Acts 13:21-23](#)

God's Covenant with Noah

A covenant is a special agreement or promise between two groups or individuals. In the Bible, covenants are often made between God and humans. These agreements typically include promises, obligations, and sometimes signs or symbols to remember the covenant. The first clear mention of a covenant in Scripture appears right after the great flood ([Genesis 9:1-17](#)).

God saw that humans had become very wicked and were doing evil things. This grieved God, and God regretted making humans on the earth ([Genesis 6:5-7](#)). God punished humans because of their corruption and violence ([Genesis 6:11-13](#)). But God still showed kindness to Noah ([6:8](#)). God told Noah to build an ark (a large boat) to survive the coming flood ([6:13-17](#)). Although humanity was unfaithful, God promised to make a covenant with Noah, his family, and all creation ([6:1-7](#); [9:8-13](#)).

God guaranteed a relationship with Noah's family, even as other relationships between God and humans ended ([Genesis 6:18](#)). God's promise to Noah included the command to build an ark ([6:14](#)). For Noah to receive the blessing from the covenant, he had to obey this command ([6:22](#); [7:5](#)).

After the great flood, Noah made an offering to God ([Genesis 8:20-22](#)). God then explained his covenant with Noah. This covenant was universal, including humans and all living creatures ([9:8-10](#)). God promised never to send another flood as a judgment on the world ([9:15](#)).

This covenant helps us understand what God's covenants mean. Even though people deserve

punishment for their wickedness, God withholds complete destruction. God's covenant with Noah did not establish a close relationship between God and every living being. Instead, it remade moral and earthly life as God intended ([Genesis 9:1-7](#)). This allowed for a more intimate covenant in the future ([17:1-21](#)). Although they do what is wrong, people can live in God's world and seek a deeper relationship with the Creator during their lives. God's later covenants made a close relationship with him available to everyone ([Acts 2:22-40; 3:17-26](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 9:1-17; Ezekiel 14:12-23; Matthew 24:37-39; Hebrews 11:7](#)

God's Covenants

The word "covenant" (from the Hebrew word *berith*) means "bond." A covenant is a binding relationship based on a commitment that includes promises and duties. The covenant relationship requires faithfulness and enables peace and harmony.

Covenants can be between:

- individuals (for example, [Genesis 21:27](#))
- entire nations (for example, [Joshua 9:15-18](#))
- God and humans

The covenant theme in the Old Testament starts with the patriarch Noah. Through Noah, God made a promise to all creation. God promised he would keep taking care of the world he created. He gave the rainbow as a sign to show he would keep this promise ([Genesis 9:1-17](#)).

God later made a covenant with the patriarch Abraham and his family. The sign of this covenant was circumcision ([Genesis 12:1-9; 15:1-21; 17:9-14](#)). (Circumcision is the process of removing the foreskin of the male reproductive organ.) God's covenant with Abraham promised descendants, land, rulers, and blessings for all nations. These promises became the basis for future covenants God made with his people.

God's covenant with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai was a national agreement. The sign of this covenant was the Sabbath day, a weekly day of rest

([Exodus 19-24](#)). It explained how Israel would be God's chosen people. This covenant was like a suzerain-vassal treaty. This was an ancient agreement between a powerful king (called a suzerain) and loyal subjects (called a vassal; see study note on [Exodus 20:1-23:33](#)).

God renewed the covenant at Mount Sinai in the book of Deuteronomy and in [Joshua 24:1-28](#). The renewed covenant emphasized God's promise of land and how Israel should behave while living there. Through this covenant, God confirmed that he was their God and they were his people. This meant he required their complete loyalty ([Jeremiah 11:4; 24:7; Ezekiel 11:20; 14:11](#)). God, as the great king (the suzerain), would bless and protect the nation of Israel (the vassal). Israel's duty was to be loyal to God's commands, decrees, and regulations ([Exodus 19:5, 8; 24:3, 7; Deuteronomy 30:15-20](#)).

God later made a covenant with King David ([2 Samuel 7:5-16](#)). This covenant related to the family line of kings promised to Abraham and Jacob ([Genesis 17:6, 16; 35:11](#)).

Years later, during a difficult time in Israel's history, the prophet Jeremiah spoke of a "new covenant" for Israel in the future ([Jeremiah 31:31-33](#)). This covenant would finally fulfill the promises of the covenants with Abraham and Israel. Jeremiah's prophecy came true through the life and work of Jesus Christ (see [Luke 22:20; Hebrews 8:6-13; 12:24](#)). This new covenant fully realized the earlier promises made to God's people.

God made these covenants because of his faithful love (from the Hebrew word *khesed*). This love made it possible for God and his people to keep having a close relationship with each other. God started this relationship, set its terms, and rewarded his people if they obeyed. These covenants were divine gifts, not rewards. God might exclude people from the covenant (see [Hosea 1:9](#)). But he will not violate or cancel his covenants.

If humans failed to keep their part of the covenant or rejected it completely, God's faithful love is the only thing that can renew it ([Exodus 34:6-9; Jeremiah 31:31-33](#)). While God's love maintains the relationship, his people must not mock his grace ([Isaiah 54:7-10; 55:3; 61:8; 1 Corinthians 6:9-10; Galatians 6:7](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 9:1-17; 12:1-9; 15:1-21; 17:9-14; Exodus 6:2-5; 19:1-24:18; Leviticus 26:1-46;](#)

[Deuteronomy 7:7-15](#); [29:2-29](#); [Joshua 8:30-35](#); [24:1-8](#); [2 Samuel 7:5-16](#); [Ezra 10:1-17](#); [Isaiah 59:20-21](#); [Jeremiah 31:31-34](#); [33:19-26](#); [34:12-20](#); [Ezekiel 16:1-63](#); [Luke 22:20](#); [Galatians 4:21-31](#); [Ephesians 2:11-13](#); [Hebrews 8:6-13](#); [10:11-18](#); [12:24](#)

God's Faithfulness to His People

God made a special agreement (called a covenant) with the people of Israel. It included blessings for obedience and curses for disobedience (see [Deuteronomy 28:1-68](#)). Many years later, after King Solomon dedicated the temple, the Lord appeared to him. He reminded Solomon that if the people were unfaithful to this covenant, judgment would come ([1 Kings 9:6-9](#)). But, if they were faithful, God would live among them and never abandon them ([6:12-13](#)).

God chose the nation of Israel as his covenant people ([Exodus 19:5-6](#); [1 Kings 8:53](#)). Despite this special role, the people of Israel often rebelled against God (see, for example, [Exodus 32:1-6](#); [Numbers 14:1-12](#); [Judges 2:10-15](#)). Even during the peak of God's blessings under Solomon's rule, they "were still sacrificing on the high places" ([3:2](#)). They showed their ongoing commitment to pagan worship (see also [1 Kings 11:4-13](#)).

Both the northern and southern kingdoms later committed this sin ([12:31-32](#); [13:2](#), [32-33](#); [14:22-24](#); [15:14](#); [22:43](#)). Every ruler of the northern kingdom led the people into false religious practices. This caused Israel's exile by Assyria in 722 BC. The southern kingdom had occasional religious reforms. But these were temporary, and Judah was eventually exiled by the Babylonians in 586 BC.

Yet, God kept a faithful group among his people (see, for example, [1 Kings 19:18](#); [Isaiah 10:20-34](#)). He had plans for their future well-being (see [Isaiah 4:2-6](#); [Isaiah 40:1-11](#); [Jeremiah 30:1-24](#)). Despite their unfaithfulness, God remained loving and faithful and wanted to restore them ([Hosea 2:1-23](#)).

God still has a group of people who belong to him ([1 Corinthians 1:2](#); [1 Peter 1:1](#)). Those who follow Jesus are his "chosen people" ([1 Peter 2:9-10](#)). They are "the temple of the living God" ([2 Corinthians 6:14-7:1](#)). God promises that he will never abandon them. He will always keep his promises to them ([John 14:16](#); [2 Timothy 2:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 32:10](#); [Exodus 3:13-17](#); [34:6](#); [Deuteronomy 7:9](#); [31:6](#); [Joshua 1:5](#); [21:45](#); [2 Samuel 7:16](#); [1 Kings 6:12-13](#); [8:29-53](#); [9:3-9](#); [Psalms 31:1-5](#); [91:4](#); [Isaiah 40:1-11](#); [54:8](#); [Lamentations 3:22-24](#); [Micah 7:18-20](#); [John 14:16](#); [Romans 3:3-4](#); [11:25-29](#); [1 Corinthians 10:13](#); [2 Corinthians 1:20](#); [2 Timothy 2:13](#); [Titus 1:2](#); [Hebrews 10:23](#); [11:11](#); [1 Peter 4:19](#); [Revelation 1:4-5](#); [19:11](#)

God's Glory with His People

In ancient Israel, God's glory was especially visible at the main holy places built for him. When the Israelites finished building the Tent of Meeting, "the glory of the Lord filled the tabernacle" ([Exodus 40:34-35](#)). In a similar way, after they completed the temple and brought in the ark of the covenant, "the glory of the LORD filled the house of the LORD" ([1 Kings 8:10-11](#)).

The presence and absence of God's glory is a key theme in the book of Ezekiel. God's glory appears to the prophet Ezekiel while he is in exile in Babylon. This means God's glory was no longer at the temple in Jerusalem. Ezekiel's vision in [Ezekiel 8-11](#) explains why God's glory left the temple. The prophet sees the terrible acts that had spiritually polluted the temple. Without God's presence, the temple became an empty framework, waiting for destruction.

God did not leave the temple because the Babylonian army forced him out. He left because of his people's spiritual pollution. Their sin made him leave the land promised to Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob. For a time, the Lord moved from Jerusalem to Babylon to be a holy place for the exiles there (see [11:16](#)).

God would not leave his temple forever. After fully punishing the people, he would bring a small group back to their land and make them holy by his Spirit. This would allow him to live among them in a new holy place ([Ezekiel 37:26](#)). The idea of God's glory living among his people forever is central to Ezekiel's vision of their restoration ([43:1-5](#)).

The glory of God lives among his people fully through Jesus Christ. The apostle John says, "We have seen His glory, the glory of the one and only Son from the Father" ([John 1:14](#)). The elderly Simeon saw baby Jesus in the temple and called him "a light for revelation to the Gentiles, and for

glory to Your people Israel" ([Luke 2:32](#)). While Jesus lived on earth, his glory was hidden from view. However, something special happened on a mountain called the Mount of Transfiguration. There, for a brief time, Jesus let his closest disciples see his true heavenly brightness and glory ([Matthew 17:2](#)).

When dying on the cross, Jesus carried the curse for our sins. In his human nature, Jesus felt abandoned by God ([Matthew 27:46](#)). But now, Jesus has been given the highest honor and power. God has given him the most important place next to himself, "seated... at His right hand" ([Ephesians 1:19-20](#)). Through the Holy Spirit, he promises to remain with us until the end of time ([Matthew 28:20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 15:11](#); [33:18-34:8](#); [40:34](#); [Psalm 19:1-11](#); [Isaiah 4:5-6](#); [6:3](#); [40:5](#); [42:8](#); [43:7](#); [58:8](#); [60:1-2](#); [Ezekiel 1:1-28](#); [11:16](#); [37:26](#); [43:1-5](#); [44:4](#); [Habakkuk 2:14](#); [Matthew 17:2](#); [28:20](#); [Luke 2:32](#); [John 1:14](#); [2 Corinthians 4:4-6](#); [Hebrews 1:3](#); [Revelation 21:10-11](#), 23

God's Grief over Apostasy

The God of the universe feels sorrow when his people suffer ([Judges 10:16](#); [Hosea 11:8-9](#)). Even when people reject him, God's love is stronger than his justice. His compassion is greater than his judgment. Yet, this does not mean his love cancels his justice. People will face judgment for their choices and actions in the end (see [2 Timothy 4:1](#); [Revelation 20:11-15](#)).

The era of the Israelite judges shows how God responds when his people repeatedly reject him. There comes a time, like when Noah lived, when God no longer exercises patience ([Genesis 6:5-7](#)). For the Israelites living at the time of the judges, that moment had arrived.

After they worshiped other gods, God let their enemies oppress them. He told them, "Go and cry out to the gods you have chosen. Let them save you in your time of trouble" ([Judges 10:14](#)). Yet, when Israel asked for mercy again, removed their idols, and accepted the Lord's justice, God helped them ([10:10](#), [15-16](#)).

God wants people to repent because he does not want to destroy anyone ([2 Peter 3:9](#)). He does this "to justify the one who has faith in Jesus" ([Romans 3:26](#)). "He bore the sin of many" and offers us the

chance to receive his grace (see [Isaiah 53:3-12](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19-21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 6:5-7](#); [Judges 10:6-16](#); [Isaiah 5:1-7](#); [53:3-12](#); [63:10](#); [Hosea 11:8-9](#); [Ephesians 4:30](#)

God's Inscrutable Purposes in History

God directs people and events to achieve his purposes in history. He does not need to explain himself, but he always has a purpose. He guides individuals, nations, and events to achieve his will. This view of history stays consistent throughout biblical history. God uses human actions to achieve results that only his planning can explain.

The writer of the book of Chronicles explains the division of Israel's kingdom in a simple way. Rehoboam and his followers "listened to the words of the LORD and turned back from going against Jeroboam" ([2 Chronicles 11:4](#)). The reason for the division was Rehoboam's unreasonable response to the people's request. This was already explained earlier: "This turn of events was from God, in order that the LORD might fulfill the word that He had spoken through Ahijah the Shilonite to Jeroboam son of Nebat" ([10:15](#)). Rehoboam might have easily defeated the rebels, but the Lord's will stopped him.

Obedying God's will brought positive results for Rehoboam. He strengthened cities, appointed military leaders, and stocked equipment and food supplies. Loyal citizens moved to his territory, and he had a large family. God's will was clear, and Rehoboam benefited greatly. Yet, the writer of the Chronicles could not explain God's purposes. Readers today still wonder why God allowed the kingdom to stay divided.

The prophet Isaiah reveals the mystery of God's ways: "For My thoughts are not your thoughts, neither are your ways My ways," declares the LORD. "For as the heavens are higher than the earth, so My ways are higher than your ways and My thoughts than your thoughts" ([Isaiah 55:8-9](#)). Those who revere God learn not to rely on human understanding. Instead, they obey God's word, even when it opposes earthly values.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 8:56-61](#); [2 Chronicles 10:1-11:4](#); [Job 42:1-6](#); [Psalm 115:1-3](#); [Isaiah 40:9-31](#); [42:1-17](#); [55:8-13](#); [Romans 8:26-30](#); [Ephesians 1:9-14](#)

God's Instructions

The common Hebrew word *torah* is usually translated "law" in most English versions. This translation comes from the Greek word *nomos*, which often means "law." The Septuagint (the ancient Greek Old Testament) used *nomos* to translate *torah*. Yet, *torah* basically means "teaching," "instruction," or "doctrine."

The term *law* often makes people think of rules enforced by an outside authority, like a government. It is often considered to be strict and rigid. Yet, the *torah* of Moses gives instructions including:

- Rules
- Stories ([Leviticus 10:1-3](#))
- Poetry ([Deuteronomy 32:1-43](#))
- Lists of family lines ([Exodus 6:14-25](#))
- Other literary forms

Other words translate as "law" and are part of the instructions given to the Israelites. For example, *khoq*, meaning "statute," refers to a law given by a lawgiver (for example, [Leviticus 6:22](#)). It states a general principle, allowing context or courts to interpret how to apply it.

In [Leviticus 18:4-5](#) and [19:37](#), the Hebrew word *khuqqah* (meaning "decrees") is paired with *mishpatim* (meaning "regulations"). These are case laws. It is impossible to write laws for every situation. A case law refers to a court's previous interpretation of a statute in certain cases. The court's past decisions guide similar cases in the present time.

Law is necessary because there will always be people who need it to restrain them from sinning. "Law" can describe much of the Old Testament Torah. More generally, the Torah teaches God's people about him and what their relationship is to him. In a similar way, teaching doctrine and how to live godly are key parts of the Christian church and its life-giving message to the world ([Colossians 3:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 26:5](#); [Exodus 16:4](#); [Leviticus 6:9](#), [14](#); [Deuteronomy 17:8-13](#), [18-20](#); [2 Kings 10:30-31](#); [22:8-20](#); [Job 22:21-23](#); [Psalms 40:8](#); [78:9-12](#);

[Proverbs 6:20-23](#); [13:14](#); [28:9](#); [Isaiah 8:20](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Timothy 3:14-17](#)

God's Judgment of His People

The kings of Israel and Judah were very important in the history of the divided kingdom. But the people also influenced events. They followed their wicked rulers ([2 Kings 3:3](#); [17:22](#); [21:9](#), [11](#), [16](#)). They stopped obeying God ([12:3](#); [14:4](#); [15:4](#), [35](#); [17:9-11](#); [18:4](#); [22:17](#)). They took part in the religious practices started by Jeroboam I ([10:28-31](#); [17:21-22](#)). They worshiped at pagan shrines (holy places) ([12:3](#); [14:4](#); [15:4](#), [35](#); [18:4](#)).

During this time, the Scripture sometimes describes God's people positively. The people of Judah celebrated when they removed Queen Athaliah and Joash became king ([2 Kings 11:12](#), [18-20](#)). Sometimes, the people helped choose new kings or followed good leaders ([14:21](#); [23:30](#); [11:17](#); [18:36](#); [23:1-3](#), [21-23](#)).

God continued to warn his people through his prophets ([2 Kings 17:13](#)). Yet, the people of both kingdoms continued to rebel against God ([17:14-19](#), [22](#)). As a result, God judged them as he promised ([17:22-23](#); [21:10-15](#); [22:17](#); [23:26-27](#); [24:20](#); [25:21](#)). God acted according to the terms of his special agreement (called a covenant) with them ([Leviticus 26:27-39](#)).

Yet, he still loved his people and wanted to restore them (see [Hosea 11:1-11](#)). God always cared for his people. He saved them from Sennacherib ([2 Kings 18:17-19:37](#)). He promised that a small group would thrive again in the land ([19:30-31](#)). The good treatment King Jehoiachin received in Babylon probably renewed hope among the repentant people ([25:27-30](#)).

God promised to restore his people from exile. He would give them fellowship with him in the land again. He would rule over them through his chosen king, a descendant of David ([Jeremiah 23:3-6](#); see also [Isaiah 11](#); [Romans 11:5-36](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 26:27-39](#); [2 Kings 17:7-23](#); [21:9-16](#); [23:26-27](#); [24:20-25:21](#); [Psalm 62:12](#); [Proverbs 11:31](#); [Isaiah 3:10-11](#); [Jeremiah 1:16](#); [17:10](#); [23:3-6](#); [Ezekiel 7:1-9](#); [33:18-20](#); [34:17-24](#); [39:23-24](#); [Hosea 11:1-11](#); [Amos 3:2](#); [Matthew 25:24-30](#); [Luke 12:47-48](#); [13:6-9](#); [John 5:45-47](#); [Romans](#)

[11:5-36](#); [Colossians 3:23-25](#); [Hebrews 12:25](#); [James 2:12-13](#); [1 Peter 1:17](#); [Revelation 2:1-3:22](#)

God's Justice

God is just ([Psalm 9:7-8](#)). He hates sin and fairly rewards people and nations based on what they do ([Psalm 67:4](#); [Isaiah 1:27](#); [Jeremiah 46:28](#); [Joel 3:1-8](#); [Acts 17:31](#)). God has complete control over the natural world and all nations ([Nahum 1:4-6, 8](#); [1:3, 6-10, 15](#)). The world and its people are powerless when opposing him ([Job 41:10-11](#); [Isaiah 40:22-24](#)).

The Lord's justice, known as *mishpat* in Hebrew, is part of his divine order. A world without justice ignores the creator's plan. Since the creator is just, his rule will also be just and righteous ([Deuteronomy 32:4](#)). His Messiah (God's chosen one) will bring about a just world ([Isaiah 9:7](#); [11:2-5](#); [16:5](#); [32:1-2](#)). His Spirit will change the world into a place of justice, fairness, and peace ([32:15-17](#)). This is good news for the oppressed, whose rights powerful people in society have denied (see [25:4-5](#)).

God's justice may sometimes appear slow ([Nahum 1:3](#)). This delay is due to his patience and mercy toward people ([Jonah 3-4](#); [2 Peter 3:9-15](#)). God does not give justice without care. He provides justice with love and intends to bring those who deserve judgment into a relationship with him.

The theme of God's justice is key in the prophets, especially in the book of Isaiah. God wants his people to treat others justly ([Micah 6:8](#); [Zechariah 7:9](#); [Isaiah 1:17](#); [5:7](#); [58:6-7](#)). He often criticizes the people of Israel for acting unjustly, especially to the poor and needy (for example, [Amos 5:11-12](#); [Malachi 3:5](#); [Isaiah 3:12-15](#); [5:7-8](#); [10:1-4](#); [29:21](#)). Many prophets of Israel announce God's judgment on his people for their injustice. They also share prophecies against other oppressive, proud, and unjust nations. God's punishment for these actions is just (see [Isaiah 3:9-11](#); [13:11](#); [59:18](#)).

The book of Nahum specifically shows God's justice toward Nineveh ([1:14](#); [2:13](#); [3:4](#)). Nahum's "good news" is that those who trust in God will one day enjoy peace and well-being when evil is finally defeated ([Nahum 1:15](#); see also [Isaiah 11:1-9](#); [Zephaniah 3:13](#)). This promise began its fulfillment through the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ ([Acts 10:34-43](#); [Romans 10:9-15](#)). Those who trust in the Lord Jesus experience some

blessings of salvation now. Yet, they wait for God's final judgment of evil and the complete arrival of his kingdom (see [Revelation 20:7-22:5](#)).

All humanity is condemned because of sin before the just and holy God. Yet, God offers grace that we do not deserve. Through Jesus Christ, God placed his judgment against sin on a willing substitute. Jesus' death is a substitute for humanity's death. Jesus' death encourages people to turn away from sin and live by God's righteousness ([Romans 6:22-23](#); [1 Peter 3:18](#)). When God finally establishes his kingdom through Jesus, the world will also be just and righteous ([Isaiah 1:26](#); [28:6](#); [2 Peter 3:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 18:17-19, 25](#); [Exodus 34:6-7](#); [Leviticus 19:15](#); [Deuteronomy 16:18-20](#); [17:8-13](#); [32:4](#); [Psalms 9:7-8](#); [67:4](#); [89:14](#); [119:75](#); [Proverbs 21:3](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:14](#); [Isaiah 1:17-28](#); [5:7](#); [11:1-9](#); [16:5](#); [32:1-2](#), [16-17](#); [40:22-24](#); [61:8](#); [Jeremiah 46:27-28](#); [Lamentations 3:25-39](#); [Ezekiel 34:15-16](#); [36:22-36](#); [37:24-27](#); [Joel 3:1-2](#); [Amos 5:21-24](#); [Jonah 3:1-4:11](#); [Micah 6:6-8](#); [Nahum 1:3-10](#); [3:4](#); [Zechariah 7:9-10](#); [Matthew 5:6, 10, 20](#); [Luke 1:74-75](#); [Acts 10:34-43](#); [17:30-31](#); [2 Peter 3:11-14](#); [Revelation 20:11-15](#)

God's Love for Israel

The prophet Malachi begins his message to the people of Israel with, "I have loved you," says the LORD" ([Malachi 1:2](#)). God's love for Israel is clear throughout the Old Testament. Malachi tells people to look at history to see God's love and power. This connects his book to the Bible's larger story of salvation.

The writer of Psalm 78, for example, declares God's great acts to future generations, so each one might "put their confidence in God... keeping His commandments" ([Psalm 78:2-4, 7](#)). The key event in Old Testament history is the exodus from Egypt (see [Psalms 78:12-13](#); [105:26-38](#); [106:7-12](#)). This was when God freed the Israelites from slavery in Egypt and led them out of the country. Israel remembered this event every year during the Feast of Passover. They used formal instruction (catechism) to teach the next generation about God's mighty acts ([Exodus 12-13](#)). This guaranteed they would always remember his loving actions.

Unfortunately, the people of Israel often abandoned God and broke their covenant (special agreement) with him. Even so, his love for them

never fully disappeared (see [Hosea 3:1](#)). Their rebellion resulted in God's judgment, leading finally to exile from their land. But even during this disaster, he saved a small group of his people (called a "remnant") and promised to restore them to the land ([Isaiah 65:8-9](#)).

The Old Testament prophets told of a future when God would show his love for Israel by sending:

- a Branch of David ([Isaiah 11:1-5](#));
- a righteous King ([Zechariah 9:9-10](#)); and
- a Sun of righteousness ([Malachi 4:1-3](#)).

Jesus Christ fulfilled these prophecies. His death created another important event for God's people. Christians commemorate his death with a meal, "the Lord's Supper" ([1 Corinthians 11:20-34](#)). This act of redemption showed God's ultimate love for Jews and even non-Jews (gentiles).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 12:1-13:16](#); [Psalms 47:4](#); [78:2-4](#), [7, 12-13](#); [98:3](#); [105:26-27](#), [37](#); [106:7-8](#); [Hosea 3:1](#); [11:1](#); [Malachi 1:2](#); [1 Corinthians 5:7](#); [11:20-34](#); [15:1-4](#)

God's Name on His Temple

In his prayer of dedication, King Solomon said the temple was the house where God would put his name ([2 Chronicles 6:20](#); compare [6:5-6](#)). God said that King David would build "a house for My Name" in Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 7:4-17](#)). When God puts his name on a place, it means it belongs to God.

For the people of Israel, the temple represented the land God promised to them and was marked by God's name. It was the ultimate symbol of God's relationship with Israel. Solomon prayed that God would remember this relationship and listen to their prayers at the temple.

In many English Bible translations, Yahweh is represented as "LORD" written in all capital letters (see [Exodus 3:13-15](#)). Solomon's prayer uses God's personal name. This made the temple the main symbol of Israel's faith. The temple was the chosen place where the people kept and remembered God's covenant (the special agreement that God made with the Israelites). This is where the people of Israel called on God's name and acknowledged him in confession and praise.

The fulfillment of God's promise to put his name on his temple is now found in the "living temple," which is the community of God's people. The apostle Peter urges believers to come to "the living stone, rejected by men but chosen and precious in God's sight, you also, like living stones, are being built into a spiritual house to be a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God through Jesus Christ" ([1 Peter 2:4-5](#)).

Just as God's name was connected to the temple, the center of God's presence and worship in the Old Testament, God's name now rests on the church, God's people, who are the new temple in the New Testament.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 3:13-15](#); [2 Samuel 7:12-13](#); [2 Chronicles 6:3-42](#); [Psalm 23:3](#); [1 Peter 2:4-5](#)

God's New Covenant

A covenant is a promise or agreement between two groups or people that usually includes responsibilities for each side. God made a covenant with the people of Israel through Moses and the giving of the law ([Exodus 19-24](#)). Later, God promised to establish a new covenant with his people ([Jeremiah 31:31-34](#)). Jesus started this new covenant (see [Luke 22:19-20](#)). He removes "the veil" of the old covenant ([2 Corinthians 3:14](#)). The apostle Paul uses the creation story from [Genesis 1-2](#) to explain that the God of creation is also the God of "a new creation" ([2 Corinthians 4:4-6](#); [5:17](#)). God now reveals himself in Jesus Christ, who brings God close to us.

In the new covenant, God, the Father of our Lord Jesus the Christ, is also our Father because he has spiritually adopted us ([2 Corinthians 1:3](#); [Galatians 3:26-4:7](#)). He is the faithful God whose Old Testament promises come true in Christ ([2 Corinthians 1:18-22](#)). He is the author of reconciliation. Christ became the way God reconciled the sinful world with himself ([5:18-21](#)). Jesus Christ became a human being (see [8:9](#)). He released God's saving power and righteousness to restore the relationship between God and the world.

Under the new covenant, God sends his Spirit to live among his people. The Spirit gives Christians life, freedom, and the ability to obey Christ ([3:6](#), [17-18](#)). The Spirit unites us to Christ and guarantees our complete salvation in the

resurrection ([1:22](#); [5:1-5](#)). This is when Christians' mortal bodies will change into glorified bodies ([1 Corinthians 15:42-57](#)). Paul fully explains this hope in [2 Corinthians 5:1-10](#). This will be the final result of the new covenant that God has made with his people.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 9:1-17](#); [12:1-9](#); [15:1-21](#); [Exodus 19:3-6](#); [2 Samuel 7:5-16](#); [1 Chronicles 10:13-14](#); [Isaiah 59:20-21](#); [65:17-25](#); [Jeremiah 2:1-3:10](#); [31:31-34](#); [Matthew 26:27-29](#); [Luke 22:20](#); [1 Corinthians 11:23-32](#); [2 Corinthians 3:4-18](#); [4:4-6](#); [Hebrews 8:6-13](#); [9:11-28](#); [10:1-25](#); [12:18-24](#)

God's Plan to Restore

One of the best-known verses in the book of 2 Chronicles explains God's plan for Israel: "And if My people who are called by My name humble themselves and pray and seek My face and turn from their wicked ways, then I will hear from heaven, forgive their sin, and heal their land" ([2 Chronicles 7:14](#)). This verse shows the how the writer of the Chronicles views the way God works with his people. Some call this idea a "theology of immediate retribution." This means that each person experiences the results of their actions during their lifetime.

The words humble, pray, turn, seek, and heal often appear in the Chronicles. The writer of Chronicles shows how these actions affected the kings of Judah. One clear example is the celebration of Passover during King Hezekiah's rule. In the first month of his rule, Hezekiah began restoring the temple ([2 Chronicles 29:3](#)). He invited all of Israel, including the northern kingdom, to the Passover feast in Jerusalem ([30:1](#)).

Hezekiah's messengers urged the people to "return to the LORD" ([2 Chronicles 30:6](#)). Many from the north humbled themselves and came to Jerusalem ([30:11](#)). So many people came that the Judeans could not accommodate them. Those from the north did not ceremonially prepare themselves to observe the Passover.

Hezekiah prayed for the people as they decided to seek the Lord ([2 Chronicles 30:18-19](#)). The Lord healed the people, allowing everyone to participate ([30:20](#)). The festival was so successful that they extended it for another seven days ([30:23](#)). Hezekiah followed the principles Solomon had

stated in his prayer. King Manasseh is another example of God's redemption at work ([33:11-23](#)).

Israelites who knew the themes of Chronicles would understand the message of John the Baptist. He called for repentance and healing ([Matthew 3:5-12](#)). If you do not repent, you will experience judgment. Yet, God will redeem those willing to humble themselves before him.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Chronicles 7:13-15](#); [12:5-12](#); [14:1-7](#); [15:1-19](#); [25:14-28](#); [26:5](#); [16](#); [29:3-31:21](#); [32:24-26](#); [33:10-17](#); [34:3-33](#); [Matthew 3:5-12](#); [Romans 5:8-11](#), [19-21](#)

God's Presence in the Psalms

The writers of Scripture often express the desire to experience God's presence. In this close experience, God's goodness and love are all people need (see [Psalm 21:6](#)). In a similar way, when God is absent, it causes distress and harm.

The poets of Israel often spoke as if God has a "face" to show his presence or absence. They sought his "face" ([Psalms 4:6](#); [105:4](#)). When God caused "His face to shine" or turned toward his people, they felt his presence. This came through blessings, provision, and protection ([67:1](#); [80:3-19](#)).

When God hid his "face," it represented divine abandonment ([Psalms 13:1](#); [27:9](#); [44:24](#); [69:17](#); [88:14](#); [89:46](#); [102:2](#); [104:29](#); [143:7](#)). It was as if God did not see or hear them ([10:11](#); [42:3](#)). God's absence causes fear, shame, and chaos, and could even lead to death ([30:7](#); [44:24](#); [104:29](#)).

The psalmists (the people who wrote the psalms) prayed for God's presence when they wanted a change in situation ([Psalms 31:15-16](#); [67:1](#); [69:17](#); [80:3](#), [7](#), [19](#)). They recognized that his presence helped them ([44:3](#)). Faithful people desire to be in God's presence ([11:7](#); [16:9-11](#); [17:15](#)). His presence alone fulfills their deepest desires ([17:15](#)). It brings them lasting joy ([37:4](#); [43:4](#); [73:25](#)). Everything about God brings them joy.

People experience God's favor and goodness through his presence ([Psalm 23:6](#)). Blessings, abundant crops, and prosperity indicate his presence ([21:3](#); [65:11](#); [68:10](#); [85:12](#); [106:5](#); [128:2](#)). God's goodness closely connects to the temple, where his presence is especially obvious ([65:4](#)). His presence brings health and life to his people and provides their needs ([107:9](#)). For the psalmists,

God's presence was necessary for living well and thriving.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 4:6; 13:1; 21:6; 24:3-6; 27:9; 44:3, 24; 67:1; 69:17; 88:14; 89:46; 102:2; 104:29; 143:7](#)

God's Promised Kingdom

God promised that his kingdom would come through King David ([1 Chronicles 17:4-14](#)). During his rule, David prepared for building the temple, which would be the center of God's kingdom ([28:11-19](#)). He urged Israel's leaders to "keep and seek out all the commandments of the LORD" ([28:8-10](#)). He encouraged the community of Israel to be strong and brave in trusting God to provide ([28:20-21](#)).

The writer of the Chronicles used King David's words to encourage the people of Judea after the Israelite exile. He urged them to keep trusting that God would restore the kingdom. He wanted them to know that God's promise to David, later confirmed to King Solomon, was also true for them.

After the exile, Judah was no longer an independent kingdom ruled by David's family. Instead, Judea was a small area with limited freedom under the control of a Persian governor. Still, the people of Judea could receive God's blessings, just like during the times of kings Hezekiah and Josiah. The writer of the Chronicles did not know exactly how God's promise to David would come true. Yet, he fully trusted in God's power, sovereign control, and justice. He believed that God would keep his promise and that his kingdom would eventually rule over all.

After the time of the writer of the Chronicles, the people became discouraged. The Greeks took control of Israel from the Persians. The Greek rulers were not friendly to the Jewish people and their beliefs. One Greek ruler, Antiochus IV (who called himself "Epiphanes"), was especially cruel during his rule from 175 to 163 BC. He tried very hard to destroy the Jewish faith and way of life. The prophet Daniel had predicted this would happen ([Daniel 11:21-39](#)).

The priestly family of the Maccabees resisted Antiochus, restored the temple, and preserved Judea's identity. Yet, the community became disunited under the Maccabees' successors. Israel divided into groups like the Pharisees, Sadducees,

and Essenes. Eventually, the Romans controlled them. When Jesus was born, Roman governors ruled Israel.

God's promises to David came true in an unexpected way. Jesus was the anointed king (the Christ or Messiah) from David's line. He established his Kingdom not by defeating the Romans in battle but by defeating the power of sin and death. His kingdom expands through his followers, and hell's powers will never conquer it. Ultimately, his kingdom will fully triumph over evil, and he will rule as king forever (see [Revelation 19:11-20:15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Chronicles 17:9-14; 28:1-21; Isaiah 2:1-4; 60:1-22; 65:17-25; Ezekiel 37:21-28; Daniel 2:31-45; 7:1-28; Micah 4:1-5; Zechariah 9:9-10; 14:1-21; Matthew 4:17; 6:33; 13:11-50; 16:16-19; 18:3-4, 23-35; 19:14, 23-30; 20:1-16; 22:2-14; 25:1-46; Luke 1:30-33; Ephesians 5:5; Revelation 19:1-21:27](#)

God's Sabbath Rest

The idea of God's Sabbath rest (as described in [Hebrews 4:1-11](#)) has been difficult for many scholars to understand. It includes ideas from the Old Testament, like the promised land as a place to rest from slavery and wandering. It also speaks of the Sabbath day as a weekly day of rest. In [Hebrews 3:7-19](#), the author explains [Psalm 95:7-11](#). He uses the Israelite wilderness wanderers as an example of those who did not enter God's rest because they disobeyed.

What is the "rest" they failed to enter, which still remains for God's people ([Hebrews 4:1-3](#))? The author of Hebrews meant more than just the physical land of Canaan as the place of "Sabbath rest" ([4:8-9](#)). [Genesis 2:2](#) describes God's rest as something prepared "since the foundation of the world" ([Hebrews 4:3-4](#)). God's rest involves stopping one's own work, just as God did ([4:10](#)). Those who "hear His voice," do not harden their hearts, and believe the good news about Jesus can "enter that rest" ([4:1-3, 7](#)).

The Old Testament calls the Day of Atonement "a Sabbath of complete rest" ([Leviticus 16:29-31](#)). On that day, people stopped all their work. In the new covenant, Jesus, our Great High Priest, offered a one-time sacrifice that did "away with sin" ([9:7-28](#)). He was the final atoning sacrifice, making

peace between God and people. Jesus offers people spiritual rest. They can enter this rest by trusting and obeying this good news.

God's rest through Jesus has two aspects:

48. Those who follow Jesus stop trying to earn God's acceptance through their own efforts. They trust in Jesus' completed work ([Ephesians 2:8-9](#)). They enjoy peace with God ([John 14:27](#); [Acts 10:36](#); [Romans 5:1](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19-21](#)).
49. They anticipate eternal rest and joy in God's presence ([Isaiah 26:19](#); [Revelation 14:13](#)). Jesus Christ gives complete and perfect rest ([Matthew 11:28-30](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:1-3](#); [Exodus 16:21-29](#); [20:8-11](#); [31:13-16](#); [Leviticus 16:29-31](#); [Isaiah 52:7](#); [54:13-14](#); [56:2](#); [4](#); [57:2](#); [21](#); [58:13](#); [Ezekiel 20:20](#); [Matthew 11:28-30](#); [Mark 2:23-28](#); [Luke 8:48](#); [John 14:27](#); [Acts 10:36](#); [Romans 5:1](#); [15:13](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19-21](#); [Ephesians 2:17](#); [Colossians 1:20](#); [2:16](#); [3:15](#); [Hebrews 4:1-11](#); [2 Peter 1:2](#)

God's Servant

In [Isaiah 40-66](#), God's servant is very important and appears often. The servant announces a new order of justice and righteousness to the world ([42:3-4](#)). He prepares the world for God's arrival ([52:7](#)).

Who is the Lord's servant? Isaiah identifies the servant as "Israel," who acts as God's witness and a "light" to other nations ([Isaiah 41:8](#); [44:1-2](#); [43:10](#)). Yet, the nation of Israel could not fully complete this mission because it was spiritually deaf and blind, and needed God's forgiveness ([42:19](#); [44:21-22](#)). Israel failed repeatedly.

In contrast, God's servant is faithful and waits for redemption (see [Isaiah 61:1-3](#); [62:1-5](#)). The servant represents the godly people in Israel. The servant is God's faithful witness to humanity and opposes idolatrous practices of pagan religion.

The prophet Isaiah describes the servant as obedient and suffering. Jesus Christ fulfilled the idea of the "suffering servant." He was an Israelite who was perfectly faithful and suffered for others.

Through his suffering, God's blessings reached many, including other nations (see [Acts 26:22-23](#)).

United with Christ, the apostles shared God's message as God's servants with both Jews and gentiles ([Acts 13:47](#); [26:14-18](#)). All who trust in Jesus share the mission of the "servant." They act as God's servants in the world (for example, [Colossians 1:7](#); [4:12](#); [1 Timothy 4:6](#); [2 Timothy 2:24](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 25:42](#); [55](#); [1 Kings 11:36](#); [2 Kings 9:7](#); [Psalms 89:20-29](#); [113:1](#); [Isaiah 41:8-10](#); [42:1-4](#); [19-20](#); [43:10](#); [44:1-5](#); [21-22](#); [49:1-7](#); [52:7](#); [13-53:12](#); [61:1-3](#); [Jeremiah 30:10](#); [33:20-22](#); [26](#); [46:27-28](#); [Ezekiel 28:25](#); [34:23-24](#); [37:24-25](#); [Zechariah 3:8](#); [Matthew 12:15-21](#); [Acts 2:18](#); [2 Timothy 2:24](#)

God's Unified Plan of Salvation

God reveals his plan for salvation throughout Scripture. It is a key theme in the letter to the Romans. In [Romans 3:21](#), the apostle Paul emphasizes two important points about being "made right" with God through Jesus Christ:

50. It does not rely on following Old Testament laws and regulations.
51. It was "attested by the Law and the Prophets" ([Romans 3:21](#); see also [1:2](#)).

God always intended to save the world through Jesus. The Old Testament prepared people for this important moment in salvation history. Paul often returns to this theme of scriptural continuity (the idea that the message and actions of God in the Bible are consistent and connected throughout all of Scripture). This is especially true of [Romans 9-11](#). There, Paul explains how God's relationship with Israel fits into this ongoing plan.

Paul wants to help us understand the changes in God's single plan for salvation. This plan unfolds in parts. Now that the final part in Christ has arrived, the earlier part has ended. The law of Moses no longer rules God's people. Paul often stresses that our new relationship with God is separate from the law of Moses (see [6:14](#); [7:4-6](#); [10:4](#)).

A similar idea appears in [John 1:17](#) and [Hebrews 10:1](#). Paul's focus in Romans on God's plan helps us understand the Bible's story in a way that respects all parts of this plan.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 1:21-23](#); [Luke 1:46-55, 67-79](#); [Acts 4:10-12](#); [10:34-43](#); [13:23-41](#); [Romans 1:3-5, 16-17](#); [3:21-26](#); [5:6-11](#); [8:1-4](#); [10:5-13](#); [11:26-27](#); [1 Corinthians 15:1-4](#); [Galatians 2:14-21](#); [3:5-14](#); [Ephesians 1:3-14](#); [Colossians 1:15-22](#); [1 Timothy 2:3-6](#); [2 Timothy 1:9-10](#); [Hebrews 9:27-28](#)

God's Uniqueness

As Creator, God is separate from what he has made. God is not part of nature. He created nature and governs it. He has always existed as the living God. God planned how everything in the universe would work according to his rules. He gave life to every living thing. Because he is God, he is everywhere at all times and knows everything. He is the living God who shows perfect love, holiness, justice, and power.

The people who lived in lands near Israel worshiped many different gods. They often made these gods to look like things in nature, such as the sun, moon, or storms. But these gods were not real. They were just lifeless statues that could not move or do anything (see [Jeremiah 10:1-5](#)). These false gods could not communicate with people or have any relationship with them. They had no power at all, not even enough to move themselves.

Sadly, the people of Israel often copied their neighbors and started worshiping these false gods too. When this happened, God sent prophets (people who spoke God's messages) to remind the Israelites that the true God was completely different from these lifeless statues. The prophets taught that there was only one real God who had true power.

Unlike lifeless idols, the one, true, living God connects personally with humans, even though he is different. He involves himself in people's lives and shows his will so each person can understand his desires and respond to him. The Lord, who created everything, surprisingly seeks a personal relationship with his people.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:1-2:4](#); [Exodus 15:11](#); [20:2-6](#); [Deuteronomy 4:32-39](#); [33:26](#); [Job 38:1-41:34](#); [Psalms 86:8](#); [115:4-7](#); [139:1-18](#); [Isaiah 42:8](#); [44:9-20](#); [Jeremiah 10:1-16](#); [14:22](#); [Amos 4:13](#); [5:8-9](#); [Revelation 15:3-4](#)

God's Word

A basic truth of Scripture is that God has spoken. The author of the letter to the Hebrews, like other Jewish preachers of the time, presents the Old Testament as words from God. He often starts passages with "God says..." or similar phrases. God may speak a promise or a warning ([Hebrews 6:13-14](#); [3:11](#); [4:11-12](#)). He may tell us about himself or his son or reveal his will (see [1:5-12](#); see [8:7-13](#); [10:5-7](#)). God's word created the universe and still controls it ([Genesis 1:3-28](#); [Hebrews 1:3](#); [11:3](#)).

In the past, God's word came mainly through angels or prophets. Now, it comes mainly through Jesus, God's son ([Hebrews 1:1-4](#); [2:3-4](#); compare [John 1:1-14](#)). People must hear, listen to, obey, and believe this word as a source of hope.

Through his word, God starts a relationship with us. He wants us to listen and respond with faith (see [Genesis 15:6](#); [John 1:12](#)). His word is powerful and purposeful, offering deep hope because God keeps his promises ([Hebrews 6:13-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:3-28](#); [Deuteronomy 8:3](#); [Psalms 12:6](#); [19:8](#); [119:11](#), [89](#), [105](#); [Isaiah 40:8](#); [Jeremiah 15:16](#); [23:29](#); [36:2](#); [Matthew 5:18](#); [7:24](#); [John 1:1-14](#); [5:24](#); [2 Timothy 3:16](#); [Hebrews 1:1-4](#); [4:12](#); [6:13-20](#); [11:3](#); [1 Peter 1:25](#); [2 Peter 1:19-21](#)

God's Rule and Power Over All Nations

In ancient times, most people thought each nation had its own god or gods. For example, the king of Aram thought Israel's gods were only powerful in the hills ([1 Kings 20:23](#)). When the judge Jephthah talked about the false god Chemosh giving land to the Ammonites, he was showing he still thought like people who worshiped many gods ([Judges 11:24](#)).

In contrast, the prophet Amos knew that God alone brought the Philistines from Crete and the Arameans from Kir ([Amos 9:7](#)). God created the entire universe, not just Israel ([4:13](#); [5:8](#)). So, he had the right to demand that nations act with justice and mercy ([1:3-2:3](#)).

A common false belief (heresy) among the people of Judah and Israel was that despite their sins, God would eventually support them because of his covenant with them (see [Jeremiah 7:4](#); [Amos 3:1-2](#); [9:10](#)). They mistakenly believed that the "day of the Lord" meant automatic rescue for them and

destruction for their enemies. Amos directly challenged this false sense of privilege ([9:7](#); see also [5:18-20](#)). The day of the Lord would not forgive sinful Israel. Instead, God would use it to punish them.

Israel's privileged position among nations made them more responsible. While nearby nations experienced punishment for severe sins, God punished Israel for all their sins ([Amos 3:2](#)). The New Testament expands on this idea: "Everyone who has been given much" has greater responsibility ([Luke 12:48](#); [James 3:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 15:18](#); [Deuteronomy 32:8](#); [1 Chronicles 29:11-12](#); [2 Chronicles 20:6](#); [Psalms 2:1-12](#); [7:6-8](#); [10:16](#); [22:28](#); [47:2](#); [83:18](#); [93:1-5](#); [103:19](#); [Daniel 2:20-21](#), [47](#); [4:34-37](#); [Amos 9:7](#); [Matthew 28:18-20](#); [Acts 17:24-26](#); [1 Timothy 1:17](#); [6:15](#); [Revelation 15:3-4](#); [17:14](#); [19:16](#)

God's Word at the Center

After God told Moses the law at Mount Sinai, God wrote it in stone ([Exodus 34:1](#)). He intended the Israelites to teach it to their children ([Deuteronomy 6:7](#)). People attached it to their hands and foreheads. They even wrote it on the doorposts of their homes to remind them of God's words ([Deuteronomy 6:8-9](#)).

Every seven years, the priests read God's instructions to the people to help them remember to revere God ([Deuteronomy 31:9-13](#)). Success came from studying and obeying God's word ([Joshua 1:7-8](#); [Psalms 1:2](#); [119:15](#)). Obedience was more important than offering sacrifices ([1 Samuel 15:22](#)).

When God's people ignore the Scriptures and lose sight of his truth, they often stop living how he wants. During King Josiah's time, even the priests had lost and forgotten the book of the law. When they found it in the temple, the young king read it and tore his clothing in grief. He realized the nation had abandoned the covenant ([2 Kings 22:8-13](#)).

In the fall of 445 BC, Nehemiah managed the completion of the rebuilding of Jerusalem's wall. Five days later, on the first day of the seventh month, the settlers in Judah gathered to celebrate the Feast of Trumpets. During and after the feast, the priest and scribe Ezra read from the law God gave Moses.

As the people listened, they mourned and wept because they realized they had not obeyed God's law. They confessed their sins, studied God's word to learn what he required, and obeyed what they learned. The book of the law of Moses transformed their lives and behavior.

These events dramatically remind us that God's word is central to the lives of his people. The Scriptures are an essential guide for life and death ([Genesis 2:16-17](#)). God's promises always come true (for example, [17:15-21](#); [18:10-14](#)).

God's word is perfect. It can restore, make people wise, and bring joy ([Psalm 19:7-9](#)). Godly people love the Scriptures ([119:97](#)). It lights their paths and helps them avoid sin ([119:105, 9](#)). God's word achieves its purpose ([Isaiah 55:11](#)). It remains forever ([Matthew 5:17-19](#); [24:35](#); [2 Timothy 3:14-17](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 24:7](#); [34:1](#); [Deuteronomy 4:2](#); [6:4-9](#); [31:9-13](#); [Joshua 1:7-8](#); [1 Samuel 15:22](#); [Nehemiah 8:1-10:39](#); [13:1-3](#); [Psalms 1:2-3](#); [19:7-9](#); [119:9, 15, 97, 105](#); [Isaiah 55:10-11](#); [Matthew 5:17-19](#); [13:3-23](#); [24:35](#); [2 Timothy 3:14-17](#)

Hardened Hearts

The book of Exodus often mentions that the Lord caused Pharaoh to act stubborn or "hardened Pharaoh's heart" ([Exodus 4:21](#); [9:12](#); [10:1, 20](#); [11:10](#); [14:4, 8](#)). These statements can be difficult. Did God make Pharaoh sin?

These factors are important to consider:

52. The Lord knew Pharaoh would be stubborn ([3:19](#)).
53. Pharaoh himself became stubborn ([8:15, 32](#)).
54. Pharaoh stayed stubborn despite clear warnings ([8:19](#)).

Pharaoh was not a well-meaning person, simply misguided and not allowed to repent. Although God controlled the situation, Pharaoh was responsible for his actions.

This interaction between human choice and divine control (God's sovereignty) appears in other parts of Scripture. The Israelites became stubborn and did not trust God in the wilderness ([Psalm 95:8-10](#)). God hardened the hearts of the Canaanites, so

they did not seek peace with the Hebrews ([Joshua 11:20](#)). The message God gave to the prophet Isaiah caused his listeners to become stubborn ([Isaiah 6:9-10](#)).

In a similar way, in the New Testament, many people stubbornly refused to respond with faith to the good news about Jesus ([Matthew 13:15](#); [John 12:40](#); [Acts 28:27](#)). People are responsible for their choices, but they do not make them in isolation. They make choices within the world God created and guides.

The book of Exodus emphasizes God's control over Pharaoh. It shows a clear contrast between two belief systems. Pharaoh thought he was a god and could do anything he wanted. But God proved this was not true. Like all created beings, Pharaoh's choices were limited. God showed that only he is truly independent. The Lord is the eternal "I Am" (see [3:6-14](#); [6:2-8](#); [20:2](#); [34:6-7](#); [Isaiah 45:3-7](#); [48:17](#); [Mark 14:62](#); [John 8:23-28](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 8:21](#); [Exodus 3:19](#); [4:21](#); [8:15](#), [19](#), [32](#); [9:12](#); [10:1](#), [20](#); [11:10](#); [14:4](#), [8](#); [Joshua 11:19-20](#); [2 Chronicles 36:11-13](#); [Psalm 95:8-11](#); [Isaiah 6:9-10](#); [Ezekiel 11:18-21](#); [36:22-27](#); [Matthew 12:34-35](#); [13:10-17](#); [Luke 8:4-15](#); [John 12:37-40](#); [Acts 28:23-28](#); [Romans 2:14-16](#); [11:7-12](#); [2 Corinthians 3:13-18](#); [Ephesians 4:17-24](#); [Hebrews 3:6-19](#); [6:4-8](#)

Holiness and Sexual Purity

The Bible teaches that people should be holy in their sexual relationships. God created humans as sexual beings. The first command God gave to Adam and Eve was to "Be fruitful and multiply" ([Genesis 1:28](#)). This means they should have children. After sin entered the world, the good things God created (including sex) became easily misused or corrupted.

Scripture contains many examples of sexual sin. God called his people to be holy. The Israelites received many commands that linked sexuality with holiness (see, for example, [Leviticus 18:1-30](#)). The sexual purity of God's people faced serious challenges in the land of Canaan, where many wrong sexual practices were common. Many times, the Israelites failed to follow God's standards for sexual purity.

The believers who received Paul's letters also lived in places where wrong sexual behavior was common. Unlike the sexual freedom of the Greco-Roman world, God's people were called to be faithful and pure in their sexual lives ([1 Thessalonians 4:3-8](#)). Sexual relationships should only happen within marriage ([1 Corinthians 7:1-9](#), [36-37](#)).

God has made Christians holy through the work of his Holy Spirit ([1 Corinthians 6:11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:13](#)). Because of this, Christians are called to live as God's holy people ([1 Corinthians 1:2](#)). God has given them everything they need to live a holy life in this world ([2 Peter 1:3-4](#)). As a result, Christians should live differently from the unholy world around them. Every part of their life should show the changing work of the Holy Spirit ([Romans 12:2](#)).

Sexual relations outside of marriage are not right for anyone who is united with Christ. This kind of behavior harms the Christian's body, which has become a holy place where God lives and therefore belongs to God ([1 Corinthians 6:12-20](#)).

Though homosexual activity was accepted in Greco-Roman culture, the church has traditionally understood the Bible to condemn it. In both the Old Testament and the New Testament, homosexual activity is described as going against God's plan for men and women ([Leviticus 18:22](#); [20:13](#); [Romans 1:25-27](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#); [1 Timothy 1:8-11](#)).

Paul strongly warns that people who freely persist in wrong sexual relations, whether homosexual or heterosexual, will not inherit the kingdom of God but will face God's judgment ([1 Corinthians 6:9-10](#); [Galatians 5:19-21](#); [Colossians 3:5-6](#); see also [2 Peter 2:1-3:13](#)). However, like all sins, forgiveness and cleansing are offered to anyone who turns to Christ with faith and repentance ([Acts 2:38](#); [Romans 3:21-26](#); see [1 Corinthians 6:11](#)). Those who follow Jesus Christ are called to show love, kindness, and mercy to others ([Matthew 7:1-2](#); [Ephesians 4:32](#); [Colossians 3:12-14](#)). God's people should live in holiness and godliness, in agreement with the desires of their Creator and Judge ([2 Peter 3:11-13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:18-25](#); [Leviticus 18:1-30](#); [Leviticus 20:10-24](#); [Romans 12:1-2](#); [1 Corinthians 1:2](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-20](#); [1 Corinthians 7:1-9](#), [14](#); [Galatians 5:16-24](#); [Colossians 3:1-6](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:3-8](#); [1 Peter 1:13-16](#); [2 Peter 1:3-4](#)

Holiness by Relationship

Holiness refers to God's transcendent nature and moral purity ([Leviticus 10:3](#)). God is completely set apart from everything else. God is pure, perfect, and greater than all. But we are limited creatures who sin. So how can we be holy as God is holy?

We can never become transcendent like God. We will always be finite creatures, and our holiness will never be absolute like God's. Therefore, our holiness does not come from our own nature or character. Instead, it comes from our union with God and the transformative power of God's grace.

When God declares a place to be holy, it is because God makes his presence known there (see [Exodus 3:5](#)). God declared objects holy, like the altar in the tabernacle ([Exodus 29:44-46](#)). The objects are holy because God instructed them to be built a certain way and accepted them for his service. Their connection to God makes them holy in a unique way.

It is the same for people. We are told to be holy because God is holy ([Leviticus 19:2](#); [1 Peter 1:15-16](#)). Only God can give holiness to humans. Without a relationship with God, true holiness is impossible, no matter how good, religious, or disciplined someone's life is. Only God can make people holy ([Exodus 31:13](#); [Leviticus 20:8](#); [22:32](#)). God promises to be with his people and make their holiness possible ([Hosea 11:9](#); see [Isaiah 35:8-10](#)).

The church, like Israel in the Old Testament, has a special relationship with God. Because we are adopted as God's children, we can become godly people (see [Exodus 4:22](#); [Romans 8:14](#); [Galatians 3:26](#); [1 John 3:2](#)). Jesus, the Holy One, died for us, making it possible for everyone who believes in him to have a right relationship with God ([Romans 5:12-21](#)). This relationship is the foundation of our holiness (see [1 Corinthians 6:11](#)). We can be holy in our relationship with God and in how we treat others. But it can only happen through our connection to the holy God.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 3:5](#); [20:8-11](#); [28:29-35](#); [29:44-46](#); [31:13](#); [Leviticus 11:44-45](#); [19:1-3](#); [20:3-8](#); [22:32](#); [Psalm 24:3-6](#); [Isaiah 35:8-10](#); [Daniel 4:8-9](#); [Romans 8:5-14](#); [Galatians 3:2-3](#); [5:16-26](#); [1 Peter 1:13-16](#); [1 John 3:2-3](#)

Holy War

The Israelites' total destruction of their enemies raises difficult questions about right and wrong. What reasons made Israel invade, conquer, and destroy Canaan and its people? From a human perspective, Israel's aggressive invasions to conquer Canaan seem illegal and immoral. The Bible provides some insights into this issue. While these insights do not answer all our questions, they help us understand the situation better.

First, God commanded and led the war against the Canaanites, not humans. God was uniquely present with Israel ([Exodus 19:5-6](#); [40:34-38](#)). After Israel crossed the Jordan River, it was obvious that God fought against the Canaanites ([Joshua 6](#)). When God did not fight, Israel lost ([Joshua 7](#)). God defines morality based on his character. For ancient Israel, this meant removing evil to keep God present ([Deuteronomy 7:1-6](#); [Deuteronomy 20:16-18](#); see also [Numbers 25](#); [Judges 2:1-15](#)).

Second, the people of Canaan had turned against God and become very evil (see, for example, [Genesis 34:1-2](#)). During the time of the patriarch Abraham, God said that the Canaanites' sins did not yet justify their destruction ([Genesis 15:16](#)). Now, several hundred years later, they did.

They were committing terrible crimes against God and humans. This included idol worship, child sacrifice, adultery, incest, murder, and oppression (see [Leviticus 18](#)). These sins completely defiled the land and its people, making them spiritually unclean ([Leviticus 18:24-25](#)). The holy God was exercising his justice against extreme evil.

It is important to understand that the war God allowed Israel to fight was limited to a specific time, place, and people. Wars fought in the name of religion are not justified by this example. For instance, the Crusades (military attacks by Europeans (who called themselves Christians) against Muslims in the Middle East during the years AD 1095-1291) were wrong. The same is true for recent violent attacks by people claiming to act for Islam (called *jihad*s by those who carry them out).

Jesus plainly said, "Blessed are the peacemakers" ([Matthew 5:9](#)). He also said, "all who draw the sword will die by the sword" ([Matthew 26:52](#)). The Jews expected Jesus, as the Messiah (God's chosen leader), to lead Israel to military victory over the Romans. Instead, he sacrificed his life to defeat sin, death, and Satan.

God has reserved the right of judgment for himself ([Romans 12:19](#)). In the final judgment, he will express his holy anger and justice toward all the wrong and sinful actions of humanity (see [Revelation 19:11-21](#); [20:7-10](#)). Therefore, no one can now rightly claim that God has commanded the killing of a specific group of people. In the modern world today, it is never just to commit genocide (killing or destroying an entire group of people on purpose).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1](#); [13:14-17](#); [15:16](#), [18-21](#); [Deuteronomy 1:30](#); [Deuteronomy 7:1-6](#), [16-26](#); [20:1-4](#), [10-18](#); [32:8-9](#); [Judges 3:27-30](#); [1 Samuel 7:7-11](#); [2 Chronicles 13:12-19](#); [20:20-24](#); [Isaiah 13:1-5](#); [Joel 3:1-16](#); [Matthew 5:9](#); [26:50-54](#); [Revelation 19:11-21](#); [20:7-15](#)

Hope Beyond Judgment

In the Bible, the prophets often proclaim messages of judgment and doom, but sometimes they also provide hope.

In the prophecy of Jeremiah, the first sign of hope is the Lord's command for Israel reject idolatry and obey the Lord God and the special agreement (the covenant) made at Mount Sinai ([Jeremiah 3:11-4:2](#)). If they responded correctly, there would be a positive future for them. They could experience healing salvation ([3:22-23](#)). Israel would become a blessing to all nations ([4:1-2](#)). The people's repentance would end God's punishment, and the nation would not face destruction. Even during difficulties before the destruction of Jerusalem, God promised a wonderful future that gave hope to the nation (see [16:15](#); [23:3-8](#); [29:10-14](#); [30:1-33:26](#)).

Even after God allowed the destruction of Jerusalem, he provided hope to the exiles in Babylon. After seventy years, those who obeyed the Lord would return to the promised land to rebuild the temple and Jerusalem. An active community would experience peace and prosperity (see [Jeremiah 46:27-28](#); chapters [50-51](#)). After Persians conquered Babylon, the Jewish exiles would return to Judah. These events happened in 539-538 BC.

Hope for God's people extended far into the future, as God promised a righteous descendant of King David to rule over his people ([Isaiah 11:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 23:5-6](#); [33:15-17](#)). Jesus Christ is that righteous descendant. Through his death on the

cross, he became "the mediator of a new covenant" ([Hebrews 9:13-15](#); [12:22-24](#)). Those who trust in him now hope for his eternal kingdom beyond God's judgments in this age.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 2:3-4](#); [4:2](#); [11:1-16](#); [35:1-10](#); [52:11-12](#); [Jeremiah 3:11-4:2](#); [16:14-15](#); [23:3-8](#); [29:10-14](#); [30:1-33:26](#); [46:27](#); [Hosea 3:4-5](#); [Amos 9:11-15](#); [Hebrews 9:13-15](#); [12:22-24](#)

Hope for the Messiah

In the first century, many Jews hoped the Messiah (God's chosen one) would come. They thought this rescuer would defeat Israel's enemies and bring peace and prosperity to God's people.

The Hebrew word "Messiah" and the Greek word "Christ" both mean "anointed one." This term comes from the tradition of anointing Israelite kings with oil at their coronation. This act confirmed their role as God's representative to rule the nation. Later, the term referred to the future king for which Israel hoped.

Many people hoped for a king from David's family line to restore David's dynasty and rule with righteousness and justice in Jerusalem. This hope came from the special agreement (the covenant) God made in [2 Samuel 7:11-16](#). God promised King David that his descendants would rule forever. As Israel's kingdom decreased and eventually ended, Old Testament prophets predicted the coming of the Christ ([Isaiah 9:6-7](#); [11:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 23:5-6](#); [33:15-16](#); [Ezekiel 37:24-25](#)). This Christ would rescue God's people and rule forever as David's successor.

The gospel writers focus on showing that Jesus is the promised Christ (see, for example, [Matthew 1:21-23](#); [Luke 1:32-33](#), [69-70](#)). Yet, he fulfilled these promises in an unexpected way. After Peter said Jesus is "The Christ of God," Jesus began teaching about the Christ's suffering ([Luke 9:20-22](#)). As Jesus neared Jerusalem for the last time, people recognized him as, "the King who comes in the name of the Lord" ([Luke 18:36-38](#); [19:36-38](#)). Yet, later these same people rejected him ([Luke 22:66-71](#)). They crucified and mocked him as "THE KING OF THE JEWS" and "the Christ of God" ([Luke 23:35-39](#)).

On the third day, Jesus rose from the dead just as he said he would. During his appearances to the

disciples, he explained that the Scriptures always prophesied that the Christ (or Messiah) would have to "suffer these things and then to enter His glory" ([Luke 24:26](#)). Jesus' death and resurrection confirm that he is truly the Christ. His death brings "repentance and forgiveness of sins" ([24:46-47](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 7:11-16](#); [Isaiah 9:6-7](#); [11:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 23:5-6](#); [33:15-16](#); [Ezekiel 37:24-25](#); [Luke 2:25-32](#); [3:15](#)

Human Confusion and God's Purpose

God is not missing or only occasionally involved in human lives. He actively determines events in the world to fulfill his purpose ([Habakkuk 2:3, 14](#); see also [Psalm 47:9](#); [Acts 17:24-26](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#)). The Lord is holy and merciful, acting in history to save his people ([Habakkuk 3:2-15](#); see also [Ephesians 1:3-10](#); [2 Peter 3:15](#)). This is so that everyone can eventually experience his glory ([Habakkuk 2:14](#)).

Often, how God achieves his goals can confuse his people. This confusion is obvious in the prophetic book of Habakkuk. Habakkuk had an open relationship with God. The prophet felt free to share his honest concerns with the Lord. God did not criticize him for it.

From Habakkuk's perspective, God seemed inactive in the presence of violence and social injustice in Judah ([Habakkuk 1:2-4](#)). God then revealed that he would act by bringing the Babylonians to punish Judah. They were a nation even more wicked than Judah ([1:5-11](#)). This confused Habakkuk even more. Yet, God's promise of justice and a vision of God's glory led the prophet to a firm faith and praise ([3:16-19](#)).

Habakkuk's spiritual journey is similar to many Christians. During times of doubt and discouragement, Christians can talk to the Lord and share their questions and concerns. He may not give all the answers, and the answers he gives might not be what we want. Yet, like Habakkuk, we might gain a new understanding of who God is, helping us renew our trust in the one who is in control.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 29:29](#); [Psalms 47:9](#); [139:6](#); [145:3](#); [Isaiah 55:8-9](#); [Daniel 4:25, 35](#); [Habakkuk 1:2-11](#); [2:2-20](#); [3:2-19](#); [Acts 17:24-26](#); [Romans 11:33-34](#);

[13:1](#); [Ephesians 1:3-10](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#); [2 Peter 3:15](#)

Human Sexuality

When God created the first humans in his own image, he created them male and female ([Genesis 1:27](#)). God gave them the ability to have children through their sexuality. This was so they could fill the earth with people and take care of it ([1:28](#)). God also created sexuality so that husbands and wives could share deep friendship and closeness in marriage ([2:18-25](#)). Being male or female is a basic part of what makes us human. When God looked at everything he had created, including human sexuality, he said it was "very good" ([1:31](#)).

Sexual intimacy united the first man and woman as one. It still does today. Biblical sexuality involves the whole person (physical, emotional, and spiritual). It is meant to reflect the union of body and soul within the context of marriage, which is designed for mutual love and commitment. It supports sexual relations only within a permanent commitment to each other's well-being. The Bible describes sexual relations as "knowing" another person intimately (see study note on [Genesis 4:1](#)).

Since creation, God intended sexual activity to occur within marriage. Marriage means a permanent and loving commitment between a man and woman ([Genesis 1:27-28](#); [2:23-24](#)). The sexual relationship strengthens the marriage bond and reflects the deep, covenantal union that God designed for husband and wife, with reproduction as one important but not exclusive outcome.

Sexuality existed before sin, but human rebellion affected it. Sexuality is powerful and can easily become corrupted if not guided carefully (see [Leviticus 18](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:3-8](#)). Sexual intimacy outside of marriage distorts the order God intended for sexuality. Incest, for example, violates sexual boundaries (see [Leviticus 18:7-18](#)). It ruins family structures and harms the community (see [Genesis 19:30-38](#)).

Distorted sexuality causes harm and weakens the community (see [Genesis 38:1-30](#); [39:7-9](#); [Judges 19-20](#)). It overemphasizes the individual (see [2 Samuel 13:1-14](#)). But, biblical sexuality strengthens both partners and the community.

Human sexuality was affected when the first humans sinned, leading to brokenness, shame, and distorted desires ([Genesis 3](#)). Sin distorts God's

good design and leads to the misuse of sexual relations outside of marriage, as well as selfishness and harm in relationships. But God redeemed human sexuality through Jesus Christ's death and resurrection (see [1 Corinthians 6:12-20](#); [Ephesians 5:31-33](#)). He restores sexual wholeness in those who trust in his work by the Holy Spirit ([1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#), [15-20](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:1-8](#)). Those who commit their sexuality to Christ's work in their lives can demonstrate to others God's love for his people ([Ephesians 5:25-33](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:27-28](#); [2:18-25](#); [Leviticus 18:1-30](#); [Deuteronomy 22:13-29](#); [Ruth 4:11-13](#); [2 Samuel 11:2-27](#); [Psalm 127:3-5](#); [Ecclesiastes 2:8-11](#); [Song of Solomon 1:8-8:14](#); [Malachi 2:15-16](#); [Matthew 19:3-12](#); [1 Corinthians 6:12-7:40](#); [Ephesians 5:31-33](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:3-8](#)

Infertility

Almost all of the wives of the patriarchs suffered infertility (they were unable to have children) before eventually having children. The only possible exception was Leah, and even she could not have children for some time ([Genesis 11:30](#); [25:21](#); [29:31](#); see also [1 Samuel 1:1-18](#)). Children continued the family line, protected the tribe, and provided labor. They guaranteed that property stayed within the family, they had help in old age, and performed proper funeral ceremonies.

Therefore, infertility was a serious disgrace for a woman in that culture ([Psalm 113:9](#); [Proverbs 30:15-16](#); [Isaiah 54:1](#)). She understood herself to be created as a vessel of life ([Genesis 1:28](#); [3:20](#)). So, people considered it as a denial of blessing, purpose, and desire ([1:28](#)). Infertility brought shame, ridicule, and intense jealousy ([1 Samuel 1:7](#); [Genesis 16:4](#); [30:1](#)).

In the Old Testament, childlessness is an issue related to God. The creator controls fertility ([Genesis 20:17-18](#); [30:2](#), [22-23](#); [1 Samuel 1:6](#), [27](#)). He decides who can have children based on his plans and promises ([Genesis 17:19](#); [30:2](#); [Psalm 113:9](#); [Luke 1:11-20](#); [Romans 4:19](#)). God often used infertility before the birth of a promised or special child, to show it was his work.

Not being able to have children tests patience and encourages prayer and faith ([Genesis 25:21](#); [1 Samuel 1:11](#)). Abraham learned to trust God's promise long before his child was born ([Genesis](#)

[15:4-6](#); [17:15-21](#); [Romans 4:20-22](#)). When an infertile couple has a child, it shows God's faithfulness and creative power.

God's delays do not always mean denial. They remind people to use challenges for growth and to appreciate children as gifts. A childless home can focus on devotion to God, accepting his will. Some couples may remain unable to have children for their entire lives. God's people should not isolate those experiencing infertility. Instead, they should offer love and support.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 16:1-6](#); [17:15-21](#); [20:17-18](#); [25:21](#); [29:31](#); [30:1-2](#), [22-24](#); [Exodus 23:25-26](#); [Deuteronomy 7:12-15](#); [Judges 13:2-5](#); [1 Samuel 1:2-28](#); [2:5-7](#); [Psalm 113:5-9](#); [Isaiah 54:1-3](#); [Luke 1:5-25](#); [Romans 4:19-22](#); [Galatians 4:24-28](#); [Hebrews 11:11-12](#)

Inheriting the Land

Is the physical world bad? Are spirit, soul, and energy the pure good we seek on our life journey? Will we only be truly spiritual and happy when we are free from our earthly bodies?

The Bible answers these and similar questions with an emphatic "No!" The universe, including earth and all living creatures, came from the skilled hand of a loving creator. He considered it "very good" ([Genesis 1:31](#)). Because of human sin, this physical world needs redemption. By God's grace, it will share in God's redemption at the end of time (see [Romans 8:19-21](#)).

Scripture shows the goodness and importance of the world with a focus on what God says about land. All land belongs to God. God removed the Canaanite people from the promised land because of their evil. He brought Israel into that land because of his promises to the Israelite patriarchs. He also wants humans to care for the earth in harmony with its creator.

In ancient Israel, each household received a portion on which to live. God's assignment of the land, not the land itself, was what he entrusted for them to manage. Fathers passed this land assignment to their sons as the main part of family inheritances.

Following these principles and God's instructions, Joshua divided the land among the tribes. The tribes then divided it among clans, families, and individual households. God's gift of management

over a specific land portion was essentially a gift of life to each household.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:31; 12:7; 13:14-17; 15:12-21; 17:7-8; 35:11-13; 50:24; Joshua 13:1-21:45; Psalm 37:9-34; Luke 12:22-34; 16:9-11](#)

Intermarriage and Divorce

God had warned his people not to marry foreigners ([Deuteronomy 7:1-6](#)). The problem was not marrying someone from another country or race. The issue was marrying people who followed other gods. Moses himself married a Cushite woman ([Numbers 12:1](#)). Other foreigners joined Israel through marriage, like Rahab the Canaanite and Ruth the Moabite (see [Matthew 1:5; Ruth 4:1-22](#)). These women trusted in God, and God blessed them. However, King Solomon married many foreign wives. Their devotion to other gods influenced him to worship idols, just as God had previously warned his people would happen ([1 Kings 11:1-5](#)).

In the Bible, marriage is viewed as a binding promise (or covenant) made before God. This covenant includes commitments to faithfulness, love, and loyalty between the married couple. But it was even more important for Israel to remain faithful to the Lord's covenant with them as a people. Mixed marriages could produce children not fully committed to Israel's faith. They would become influenced by the idolatry of their foreign parent. This compromise would cause Israel to become totally unfaithful to God and embrace false religions, as they did before the exile to Babylon (see [Judges 3:3-7; 14:1-9; 1 Kings 11:1-8; 2 Kings 17:7-17](#)).

In [Ezra 9 and 10](#), the Jews who returned from exile married people who worshipped other gods. Ezra's solution was divorce but this is not a rule for Christians today. Under the new covenant with Jesus, the faith of a believer makes his or her marriage and children holy. So, marrying an unbeliever does not threaten the identity or purity of God's community ([1 Corinthians 7:14-16](#)). The apostle Paul understood that divorce might happen if believers married non-believers. But he did not advise believers to divorce in such cases ([1 Corinthians 7:10-13](#)).

To avoid these issues, it is wise to follow Paul's advice for believers not to marry unbelievers. God's

people should stay separate from what is unholy: "For what partnership can righteousness have with wickedness? Or what fellowship does light have with darkness? What harmony is there between Christ and Belial? Or what does a believer have in common with an unbeliever?" ([2 Corinthians 6:14-15](#)). Yet, those married to an unbeliever today have God's assurance that God can use that difficult situation for his glory (see also [1 Peter 3:1-2](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 7:1-6; Joshua 2:1-14; 6:23-25; Judges 3:3-7; 14:1-9; Ruth 4:1-22; 1 Kings 11:1-8; 2 Kings 17:7-17; Ezra 9:1-10:44; 1 Corinthians 7:10-16; 2 Corinthians 6:14-15; Hebrews 11:31](#)

Invasion

In the ancient world, foreign invasions were common. They caused great difficulty. If invaders succeeded, they brought destruction and suffering. Victorious invaders killed adult men, raped women, enslaved children, stole valuables, and destroyed everything else. The threat of invasion made the people afraid.

In the final decades of the kingdom, the people of Judah and Jerusalem lived under the threat of Babylon's conquest. Over a century earlier, the Assyrians had destroyed the northern kingdom of Israel, invaded Judah, and attacked Jerusalem. These events stayed clearly in the memories of the people of Judah. The prophet Jeremiah warned of another coming invasion and the destruction it would cause.

When invasion threatened, people wanted to find ways to avoid the coming suffering. Prophets like Jeremiah urged God's people to abandon false gods and obey the Lord. They advised against relying on powerful allies for rescue. Instead, they encouraged seeking the Lord's protection.

The prophets sometimes described in detail what would happen during an invasion. Their goal was not to scare or discourage God's people. God sent them to encourage obedience to him. They wanted people to trust in the Lord for salvation and experience his rescue. This is how King Hezekiah reacted to the Assyrian invasion a century earlier. He trusted the Lord, and the Lord rescued him and his people.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 14:1-16](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [18:13-19:37](#); [Isaiah 6:8-13](#); [36:1-37:38](#); [65:21-23](#); [Jeremiah 6:22-26](#); [19:7-15](#)

Israel's Geography as Theology

The division of the land in [Ezekiel 47:13-48:35](#) combines spiritual ideals with a practical message. It reinforces themes from earlier parts of the vision ([Ezekiel 40-46](#)). The prophet Ezekiel envisioned a future closely linked to the past. The land of Israel remained the special land promised to Israel's patriarchs.

The map in this vision is different from the earlier tribal divisions in Joshua's time. In Ezekiel's vision, each tribe receives an equal portion of land. These portions are in east-to-west strips. They align the entire land with the temple at its center. These strips do not match the actual geography of the land. They are symbolic. The idea is that old tribal rivalries and hatreds will disappear, as each tribe will have equal status.

The monarchy (the system of being ruled by God's chosen king) is not abolished in this vision, but it is transformed. The ruined city from earlier chapters of Ezekiel becomes a new holy city of unity and harmony for the tribes. A life-giving river restores, bringing blessings from God's temple to every part of the people's lives.

The vision in [Ezekiel 40-48](#) encourages people to repent for past sins, stay faithful in difficult times, and hope for a better future through God's power and grace. The final chapters of Revelation show this vision fulfilled in Jesus ([Revelation 21-22](#)). Jesus began the spiritual reality Ezekiel described. It is a heavenly city "whose architect and builder is God" ([Hebrews 11:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 40:1-46:24](#); [47:13-48:35](#); [Revelation 22:1-2](#)

Jerusalem

Jerusalem was an active city as early as four hundred years before the time of King David. The Israelites never fully captured it when they conquered Canaan or during the time of the judges ([Joshua 15:63](#); [Judges 1:8, 21](#)). Israel established peaceful relations with the independent area of the Jebusites ([Judges 19:10-12](#)). Jerusalem was so

difficult to capture that the Old Testament mentions only three successful invaders: David, Jehoash, and Nebuchadnezzar of Babylon ([2 Kings 14:11-14](#); [2 Kings 25:1-10](#)).

King David captured Jerusalem, possibly through a water tunnel (see study note on 5:8). He made Jerusalem the political capital of Israel. Then later it became the spiritual capital. [Psalm 48](#) gives a beautiful and powerful description of Jerusalem as a fortress. It had towers, walls (bulwarks), and easily defended heights (citadels) on rugged terrain. This could have deceived those living there with a false sense of security or even idolatry. [Psalm 48:1-3](#) reminds readers that Jerusalem's landscape did not make it safe, but because God was present.

Both the Old Testament and the New Testament call Jerusalem a "holy city" (see [Nehemiah 11:1, 18](#); [Isaiah 52:1](#); [Daniel 9:24](#); [Matthew 4:5](#); [27:53](#); [Revelation 21:2](#)). It is the only city described this way in the Bible. Why is this city considered holy? It is certainly not because of the holiness of its people. In fact, the Babylonians destroyed the city in 586 BC because the people were so unholy.

It was also not holy because it was Israel's capital for many centuries. Jerusalem was a holy city because God chose it ([1 Kings 8:44, 48](#); [11:13, 32, 36](#); [2 Chronicles 6:5, 34](#)). Because he chose it, he placed his glory and his name there (see [1 Kings 14:21](#); [2 Chronicles 12:13](#); [Ezekiel 8-10](#); [43:1-27](#)).

In the gospels and book of Acts, Jerusalem remained very important. Herod the Great was king of Judea from 37-4 BC. He expanded the city of Jerusalem and led major building projects, including the temple. It was still the center of Israel's spiritual life (see, for example, [Acts 2:46](#); [3:1-26](#); [5:12](#)). Many events in the lives of Jesus and his followers happened in Jerusalem.

Jesus spoke harshly about Jerusalem (see [Matthew 23:37-39](#)). He was especially harsh towards its leaders. They eventually killed him in Jerusalem. Jesus warned that God would judge the city (see [Mark 13:1-2](#); [Luke 21:20-24](#)). His words came true when the Romans destroyed Jerusalem in AD 70.

The New Testament also introduces "the new Jerusalem," a heavenly city formed by God's holy people ([Hebrews 11:10](#); [Revelation 3:12](#); [21:2](#)). The earthly Jerusalem was where God and his rule were partly present through King David and his successors. The new Jerusalem represents the government of Jesus Christ, the final royal heir of David. The New Jerusalem also represents Jesus'

eternal presence with his people (compare [John 1:14](#); [Revelation 21:3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Joshua 15:63](#); [Judges 1:8, 21](#); [2 Samuel 5:6-9](#); [1 Kings 8:1](#); [2 Kings 18:13-17](#); [25:1-10](#); [2 Chronicles 3:1](#); [12:1-12](#); [26:9, 15](#); [32:1-5](#), [27-30](#); [Ezra 1:1-6](#); [Nehemiah 1:1-6:19](#); [Psalm 48:1-3](#); [125:2](#); [Isaiah 14:32](#); [52:1-3](#); [Galatians 4:25-26](#); [Hebrews 12:22-24](#)

Jesus and Satan

Satan is a personal agent of sin and evil who opposed Jesus ([Matthew 4:1-11](#)).

The Gospel of Matthew refers to this being as:

- "Satan," which means *adversary* or *opponent* ([4:10](#))
- the "devil" ([4:1-11](#); [13:39](#))
- the "tempter" ([4:3](#))
- the "prince of demons" ([9:34](#))
- "Beelzebul" ([12:24](#))
- the "evil one" ([6:13](#); [13:19](#))
- "the enemy" ([13:39](#))

Jesus' mission to announce and bring the kingdom of God on earth led to conflicts with Satan's forces. This included removing demons who possessed people (exorcism) (see [Matthew 8:16-17](#); [9:32-34](#); [10:1, 7-8](#); [12:22-29](#); [Mark 5:1-20](#)). Matthew notes that Satan has power over kingdoms ([Matthew 4:8-9](#); [12:26](#)). He also commands angels ([25:41](#)).

Satan's main method of causing harm is temptation. His purpose is to make people disobey God ([Matthew 4:1-11](#); [6:13](#); [16:23](#)). As God's agent for human salvation, Jesus encountered strong attacks from Satan ([Matthew 4:1-11](#); [John 13:27](#)). Yet, Jesus has defeated Satan and will eventually remove all his powers ([Matthew 25:41](#); [John 12:31](#); [Revelation 20:1-10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Job 1:6-12](#); [2:1-7](#); [Zechariah 3:1-2](#); [Matthew 4:1-11](#); [13:19](#); [16:23](#); [Luke 10:17-20](#); [13:16](#); [22:3](#), [31-32](#); [John 12:31](#); [13:27](#); [Acts 5:3](#); [26:17-18](#); [2 Corinthians 4:4](#); [11:13-14](#); [1 Timothy 2:14](#); [5:15](#); [Revelation 12:9](#); [20:1-10](#)

Jesus' Ascension

When Jesus went up to heaven, he gave his apostles their final instructions and authority for their work ([Acts 1:6-11](#); [Luke 24:45-53](#)). This event (the ascension) marked the start of the Holy Spirit's powerful work through the church ([Luke 24:49](#)).

Jesus' ascension to heaven shows that he now has ultimate power and authority as God and man ([Ephesians 1:19-23](#); [Philippians 2:9-11](#)). Other passages also mention Jesus going to the Father ([John 6:62](#); [13:1-3](#); [13:31-14:3](#), [14:28](#); [16:5-10](#), [16, 28](#); [20:17](#); [Ephesians 4:8-10](#)). This happened during Jesus' last physical appearance. After this, he would stay in heaven until "the restoration of all things" ([Acts 3:21](#)).

The ascension reminds Christians of Jesus' promise to return ([Acts 1:11](#); see [Matthew 24:30](#); [Mark 13:26](#); [John 14:3](#)). Those present at the ascension returned to Jerusalem with joy and excitement, praising and worshiping Jesus ([Luke 24:52](#)). They trusted that Jesus would return again, both physically and personally ([1 Thessalonians 4:16](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:7-10](#); [2 Peter 3:10](#)).

The ascension of Jesus anticipates the Christian's future entrance into God's presence. Jesus has gone ahead to "prepare a place" ([John 14:1-3](#); [2 Corinthians 5:4](#); [Philippians 3:21](#); [Hebrews 6:19-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 24:30](#); [Mark 13:26](#); [Luke 24:45-53](#); [John 6:62](#); [13:1-3](#); [14:1-4](#), [27-28](#); [16:10](#), [16, 28](#); [20:17](#); [Acts 1:6-11](#); [3:20](#); [7:54-56](#); [2 Corinthians 5:4](#); [Ephesians 1:19-23](#); [4:8-10](#); [Philippians 2:9-11](#); [Hebrews 6:19-20](#)

Jesus' Final Night

When Jesus went to Jerusalem to celebrate the feast of Passover, he knew it was his last night before death. He came to Jerusalem to "suffer many things and ... be killed" ([Mark 8:31](#)). His disciples prepared the meal, but he needed to prepare them for what was coming.

Jesus celebrated the Passover with his disciples. During this meal, he showed them what a true servant is by washing their feet ([John 13:1-20](#)). He gave them his final teachings, told them about the coming of the Holy Spirit, and prayed for his followers ([John 14:1-17:26](#)). Jesus also established the new covenant ([Mark 14:22-24](#)). Jesus replaced

the Passover lamb. His body and blood became the sacrifice that saves God's people from judgment, just like the lamb at the first Passover.

During Passover, God killed all the firstborn males of the Egyptians but spared those of Israel. Now, Jesus would become the sacrifice to save his people. The prophets predicted this would happen (for example, [Zechariah 12:10](#); [13:7](#)). Jesus warned his disciples that this would soon happen and that they would abandon him ([Mark 14:27](#)). He also warned them that one of them would betray him ([Mark 14:18](#)).

After the meal, Jesus and his disciples walked to the garden of Gethsemane on the Mount of Olives. There, Jesus was deeply troubled as he prayed, accepting God's will ([Mark 14:26-42](#)).

Judas was the disciple who betrayed Jesus. He arrived with soldiers who arrested Jesus ([Mark 14:43-49](#)). Jesus' disciples ran away ([Mark 14:50-52](#)). Then they took Jesus to the high priest's house for a trial at night. During this time, Peter denied knowing Jesus three times ([Mark 14:53-72](#)).

Jesus already knew what would happen on his last night, the good and bad. It all happened according to God's plan. These events were necessary to fulfill what Scripture prophesied and for what followed. This included his death and resurrection.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 26:17-56](#); [Mark 14:12-52](#); [Luke 22:7-46](#); [John 13:1-18:11](#); [1 Corinthians 11:23-34](#)

Jesus' Prayers

In Luke's gospel, Jesus prays during important moments in his life:

55. At his baptism ([Luke 3:21](#)).
56. Before choosing the twelve apostles ([6:12](#)).
57. At the transfiguration, when Jesus' appearance changed to reveal his glory ([9:28-29](#)).
58. On behalf of Peter before he denied Christ ([22:32](#)).
59. On behalf of those who killed him while he hung on the cross ([23:34](#)).

Sometimes, Jesus went away from others to pray alone ([Matthew 14:23](#); [Mark 1:35](#); [Luke 5:16](#)). He

also taught the disciples how to pray ([Luke 11:1-4](#); see also [Matthew 6:5-13](#)). He shared stories about the importance of constant prayer ([Luke 11:5-13](#); [18:1-8](#)).

In the Gospel of Luke, Jesus' prayers emphasize the intimate relationship between the Father and the Son. Jesus lived in harmony with his Father, followed his purpose, and remained faithful to his will.

In Gethsemane, Jesus was deeply troubled about the suffering to come. But he prayed, "not My will, but Yours be done" ([Luke 22:42](#)). On the cross, he showed complete trust in the Father. His last words were, "Father, into Your hands I commit My Spirit" ([Luke 23:46](#)). Jesus showed us how to live a life of trust and dependence on our heavenly Father.

The apostle John writes about a prayer Jesus said on his last night with the disciples ([John 17:1-26](#)). This is often called the "high priestly prayer." In this prayer, Jesus prays to God on behalf of his followers. He asks God to protect them, help them understand, make them holy, and keep them united as one group.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 6:9-13](#); [Luke 3:21](#); [6:12](#); [9:28](#); [11:1-13](#); [18:1-8](#); [22:32](#), [39-46](#); [23:34](#), [46](#); [John 17:1-26](#)

Jews and Gentiles (Non-Jews)

A key theme of the New Testament is that God has included non-Jewish people (called gentiles) in his people while keeping his promises to Israel. In [Romans 11:11-32](#), the apostle Paul explains God's plan to save all nations in four clearly defined stages:

60. The apostles share the good news about Jesus with the Jews. Most of them do not believe it.

Paul uses an olive tree as a metaphor. He says, "some branches have been broken off" ([Romans 11:17](#)). This stage had already happened and Paul personally experienced it. He shared the good news with Jews in their places of worship (synagogues) across the eastern Mediterranean region. But, many Jews rejected Paul's message (see [Acts 13:42-49](#); [18:4-6](#); [28:23-28](#)).

61. Many non-Jews accept the message and trust in Jesus.

After God removes the "natural branches," he grafts in "a wild olive shoot" ([Romans 11:17](#)). Paul and the other apostles encountered resistance in the synagogues. So they preached to non-Jews, and many accepted the good news (see [Acts 13:48-49; 26:15-18](#)). By the time Paul wrote the letter to the Romans, the church in Rome was mostly a non-Jewish community.

62. Many Jews accept the good news and trust in Jesus.

As for the "natural branches," God can "graft them again" ([Romans 11:23](#)). Paul argues that the Jews are not "beyond recovery" and can turn to Christ ([11:11](#)). Paul hopes that as non-Jews receive the blessings of salvation, Jews will feel inspired and respond to the good news ([11:11-15](#)).

63. God gives great blessings to the world, including the resurrection of the dead.

Paul suggests that when many Jews trust in Christ, it will greatly bless the world ([Romans 11:12, 15](#)). Those who accept God's offer of salvation, whether Jews or non-Jews, experience "life from the dead" (see [11:15](#)). They will one day experience "the resurrection of the dead" (see [1 Corinthians 15:20-26](#)). At the end of history, a large community of Jews and non-Jews will praise God for his mercy. Then everyone will see and understand God's great wisdom and love ([Romans 11:33-36](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 7:7-8; 32:19-21; Isaiah 9:1-3; 49:6; Matthew 4:15-16; 8:10-12; 15:21-28; Luke 21:20-24; Acts 2:38-39; 10:45-46; 11:12-18; 13:42-49; 18:4-6; 26:15-18; 28:23-28; Romans 1:5-6, 16-17; 2:9-10, 24-27; 3:9, 29-30; 9:25-33; 10:11-13; 11:11-36; 15:7-13, 27; 1 Corinthians 12:13; Galatians 2:8-21; 3:8-9, 26-29; Ephesians 2:11-22; 3:6; Colossians 3:11](#)

Job's Innocence

Job's comforters could not accept the idea that any human could be truly innocent ([Job 4:17-19; 15:14-16; 25:4-6](#)). They believed suffering was a direct result of sin. So, Job must have done something wrong to deserve his fate. Job's claim to innocence seems to contradict the biblical teaching that "there is no one righteous, not even one... all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God" ([Romans 3:10, 23](#)). Was Job correct in declaring his innocence?

Eliphaz and the others misunderstood Job's position. When they denied that Job could be right or pure, they were referring to the absolute difference between the Creator (God) and the creature (humans). But Job was not claiming to be completely pure. He admitted he had sinned when he was young ([Job 13:26](#)). And he knew he needed God to forgive his sins and remove his guilt ([14:16-17](#)).

At the same time, Job often stated his honesty and his innocence in his relationship with God ([Job 13:14-18; 23:10-12; 27:3-6; 31:1-40](#)). Even Eliphaz admitted that Job lived an upright life ([4:6](#)). Job's faith led him to seek an audience with God, believing in God's justice despite his suffering. Job continued to hope for a Redeemer ([19:25](#)).

God's justice might require a mediator, and it might not be clear before death ([Job 9:33-35; 19:26](#)). But Job trusted that he would be proven innocent. He lived "by faith, not by sight" ([2 Corinthians 5:7](#); see also [Romans 8:24; 1 Corinthians 13:12; 2 Corinthians 4:18; Hebrews 11:1-2; 1 Peter 1:6-8](#)).

When compared to the perfect righteousness of Jesus Christ, Job is a sinner like all of us. Job was not made right with God by his own deeds but by his faith in God. On that basis, God declared Job to be "blameless and upright, fearing God and shunning evil" ([Job 1:1, 8; 2:3; 42:7-8](#)). God does the same for us when we, like Job, put our complete trust in him (see [Romans 4:4-5; James 2:23](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 8:46; Job 1:1, 8-11; 2:3-5; 4:6; 9:33-34; 13:18; 14:16-17; 15:14; 19:25-26; 23:10; 25:4; 27:5-6; 42:7-8; Psalms 25:7; 37:37; 51:17; Ezekiel 4:14; Romans 3:10, 23, 25; 4:4-5; 6:23; 1 Corinthians 13:12; 2 Corinthians 4:18](#)

John's Profile of Discipleship

In the first half of his Gospel, the apostle John describes various people who show true discipleship (see [John 1:19-51; 4:1-42; 9:1-41](#)). Through these examples, John outlines the qualities of a mature follower, or "disciple," of Jesus.

What are the qualities of a disciple?

64. *Disciples know who Jesus is.* In each of these three stories, they identify Jesus correctly (see, for example, [John 1:34, 36, 38, 41; 4:19, 29, 31; 9:2, 17, 35-38](#)).

65. *Disciples trust in Jesus.* They witness Jesus' powerful acts, listen to his wise words, and trust (see [1:49](#); [4:39-42](#); [9:35-38](#); see also [20:8](#), [24-29](#)).
66. *Jesus' disciples understand that they must follow him for their discipleship to succeed* ([1:37-43](#); [8:12](#); [10:4-5](#), [27](#); [12:26](#); [21:19-22](#)). "Following" means true devotion, leaving what we have to join Jesus on his journey.

John shared this example of true discipleship to inspire readers to join these brave men and women and become disciples of Jesus too (see [John 20:30-31](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 9:9-10](#); [10:16-22](#); [16:24-28](#); [Luke 14:26-33](#); [John 8:31-32](#); [9:1-41](#); [12:25-26](#); [13:35](#); [18:36](#); [Acts 9:2](#); [Romans 15:5](#); [1 Corinthians 3:4-11](#)

Kingship

Israel wanted a king to be "like all the other nations." By the time of Saul and David, kingship in the ancient Near East was nearly two thousand years old. This was especially true in the Egyptian and Babylonian empires. Even smaller nations like Philistia, Moab, and Edom had kings with permanent governments and armies. People believed kings were chosen by the gods to rule human affairs. Kings ruled either for the gods or as gods themselves.

The Israelites wanted to be like other nations and ignored the long-term effects of having a king, despite the prophet Samuel's warnings ([1 Samuel 8:10-18](#)). Over several hundred years, having kings proved Samuel right. Bad kings led God's chosen people into foreign control and exile. Yet, God used the monarchy to achieve his plans, as he provided the Messiah (God's chosen one) through David and his family line, creating an eternal kingdom (see [2 Samuel 7:8-16](#); [Matthew 21:1-11](#); [Revelation 5:5](#); [11:15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 17:14-20](#); [33:5](#); [Judges 17:6](#); [21:25](#); [1 Samuel 8:5-22](#); [10:1](#), [24-25](#); [2 Samuel 7:8-16](#); [Psalm 89:35-37](#); [Ecclesiastes 8:2-5](#); [Isaiah 33:22](#); [Matthew 21:1-11](#); [22:42-46](#); [27:11](#); [1 Timothy 1:17](#); [1 Peter 2:13-14](#); [Revelation 5:5](#); [11:15](#); [15:3](#)

Knowing God

We often think of knowledge as information, facts, and concepts. In biblical times, knowledge focused on personal relationships. To know someone meant having a close relationship with them. Knowing God involves more than just learning facts about him. It goes beyond discussing God's nature and character, though those things are important.

Knowing God means forming a close relationship with him. It involves seeing things as God does and learning to imitate him. Knowing God changes our thoughts, actions, priorities, values, and relationships with others. It is more important than religious ceremonies, sacrifices, or any other religious activities (see [Jeremiah 9:23-24](#); [31:34](#)).

The prophet Hosea emphasizes the importance of knowing God. He shows that God would destroy Israel because they did not know God ([Hosea 4:1,6](#)).

This theme is also common in the New Testament Gospel of John. Jesus often emphasizes the need to know God. He affirms that people can engage in religious practices but lack a true relationship with God (see [John 7:25-29](#); [8:14-19](#), [54-55](#); [14:6-11](#); [17:1-3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 33:8](#), [11](#); [Numbers 12:6-8](#); [Isaiah 11:9](#); [43:10](#); [Jeremiah 9:24](#); [31:33-34](#); [Hosea 6:3](#), [6](#); [John 17:3](#); [Philippians 3:10](#); [Titus 1:16](#); [Hebrews 8:10-13](#); [1 John 2:4](#); [4:6](#), [8](#); [3 John 1:11](#)

Laziness and Hard Work

God created Adam and Eve and placed them in the garden of Eden to care for it, not just to relax and enjoy it ([Genesis 2:15](#)). Work is not a punishment from when humans first sinned. Instead, God made work to be a good and valuable part of his creation from the beginning.

The book of Proverbs often condemns laziness (being unwilling to work or make an effort when you should). Proverbs compares lazy people to a door that moves back and forth but never goes anywhere ([Proverbs 26:14](#)). It also teaches that lazy people are foolish ([22:13](#)). Their lack of work leads to poverty and death ([6:6-10](#); [10:26](#); [15:19](#); [18:9](#); [19:15](#), [24](#); [20:4](#); [21:25](#); [22:13](#); [24:30-34](#); [26:13-16](#)). In contrast, hardworking people are wise. Their work leads to having enough money

and a good life ([10:4–6](#); [12:11](#); [13:4](#); [20:13](#); [31:10–27](#)).

Ultimate meaning and fulfillment do not come from hard work ([Ecclesiastes 2:17–26](#)). We should not forget God's ability to provide ([Psalm 127:2](#)). But, we have no excuse to be lazy. God designed us to use our gifts and abilities to be productive and provide for ourselves and others ([Ephesians 4:28](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:11–12](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:6–13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:12](#); [Proverbs 6:6–11](#); [10:4–6](#), [26](#); [12:11](#), [24](#), [27](#); [13:4](#), [11](#); [14:4](#), [23](#); [15:19](#); [18:9](#); [19:15](#); [21:5](#), [25](#); [24:30–34](#); [26:13–16](#); [28:19](#); [31:10–31](#); [Ecclesiastes 2:18–26](#); [4:5–6](#); [5:12](#); [9:10](#); [11:4–6](#); [Romans 12:11](#); [Ephesians 4:28](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:11–12](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:10–15](#)

Legalism

The law was very important to the Jewish people. Their understanding of religion often focused on following rules and ceremonies. This was natural to them because God had given his law to the Jewish people. He did this to show he had chosen them as his people. God also gave them the law as a way for them to confirm and keep the covenant agreement he had made with them.

Yet, many Jews added to God's laws, creating rules for almost every situation. They often did this to avoid breaking any of God's laws. As Jesus often pointed out, these extra rules sometimes made it hard to follow God's instructions ([Mark 7:1–15](#)). In addition, many Jews believed that simply following the law would make them favored by God.

The apostle Paul often encountered issues with strict legalism in the early churches. For example, in Colossae, false teachers influenced by Jewish beliefs insisted that Christians follow certain rules to express their faith ([Colossians 2:16–23](#)). Paul criticized this, emphasizing faith in Christ. Christ is the fulfillment of all God's plans and purposes and is the center of true devotion.

This does not mean that rules for behavior are bad in themselves. Some rules, like the prohibition on lying, plainly show an aspect of Christ's character ([Colossians 3:9](#)). Paul also did not mind if individual Christians set rules for themselves that they believe will help them better obey Christ (compare [Romans 14:5](#); [1 Corinthians 8](#)). Yet, they

must not force others to follow these self-imposed rules.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 23:13–33](#); [Mark 7:1–15](#); [Galatians 2:14–21](#); [Colossians 2:16–23](#)

Letters to the Seven Churches

In the letters to the seven churches of Asia, the apostle John uses a single literary pattern ([Revelation 2–3](#)). Each letter starts with an address to the "angel of the church" in a specific city. It then mentions an aspect of Jesus' appearance from the vision of "the Son of Man" ([1:12–18](#)).

Jesus says that he knows each church and describes its condition. He gives advice or judgment and promises a reward for obedience. Each time, Jesus emphasizes the importance of paying full attention to the Holy Spirit's message to the churches.

Interpreters often divide the seven letters into separate messages, symbolizing seven types of people or time periods. Yet, these letters were first from Jesus to specific local churches in Asia. Jesus knows each local gathering of Christians and encourages them to follow him faithfully.

Together, these letters form a unified message for the church at all times and places, knowing its weaknesses. Any local gathering of Christians might resemble one of these churches, and each community has people similar to those Christians. Jesus invites every community of Christians to examine itself using all these messages.

Passages for Further Study

[Revelation 2:1–3:22](#)

Life After Death

Writers in the Old Testament describe the place where dead people are as beneath the earth's surface ([Ezekiel 26:20](#)). Sometimes, the earth swallows them alive ([Numbers 16:31–33](#); [Psalm 55:15](#)). But usually, "the cords of death" take them down "and swallows them" ([Psalm 18:4–5](#); [Numbers 16:30](#); [Job 24:19](#); [Psalm 49:14](#); [Isaiah 5:14](#); [14:11](#)). In the Old Testament, the afterlife is often considered a gloomy, hopeless place of no return ([Job 7:9](#); [Isaiah 38:18](#)).

In the book of Job, the main images of the place of the dead include:

- *Sheol*, which is described as dark and dusty ([Job 11:8](#); [14:13](#); [17:13](#), [16](#); [24:19](#); [26:6](#));
- a pit filled with decay (Hebrew *shakhat*; see [9:31](#); [17:14](#); [33:18](#), [22](#), [24](#), [28](#), [30](#)); and
- the grave (Hebrew *qeber*; see [3:22](#); [5:26](#); [10:19](#); [17:1](#); [21:32](#)).

The Old Testament sometimes suggests rescue from the grave (see [1 Samuel 2:6](#); [Psalms 16:10-11](#); [30:3](#); [49:15](#); [56:13](#); [73:24-26](#); [86:13](#); [139:7-10](#); [Isaiah 26:19](#)). Job hopes *Sheol* might ease his troubles ([Job 3:13-22](#); [14:13-17](#)). He hopes a redeemer might defend him after death ([19:25-26](#)). Yet, only the New Testament fully promises redemption from death ([1 Corinthians 15:50-58](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 2:6](#); [28:11-15](#); [1 Kings 17:20-22](#); [2 Kings 4:32-35](#); [Job 3:13-22](#); [7:9](#); [14:13-17](#); [17:13-16](#); [19:25-27](#); [Psalms 6:5](#); [16:10-11](#); [17:15](#); [49:15](#); [86:13](#); [88:11](#); [139:8](#); [141:7](#); [Proverbs 1:12](#); [15:11](#); [Isaiah 26:19](#); [38:18](#); [Ezekiel 26:20](#); [Matthew 22:31-32](#); [Romans 8:23](#); [1 Corinthians 15:50-58](#); [Philippians 3:21](#)

Little Faith

The Greek term translated as "little faith" and related terms appear five times in the Gospel of Matthew ([Matthew 6:30](#); [8:26](#); [14:31](#); [16:8](#); [17:20](#)). It also appears once in Luke ([Luke 12:28](#); compare [James 1:6-7](#)). This term refers to a specific event, not a permanent failure.

In Matthew, "little faith" occurs when Jesus' disciples lack knowledge or act without faith in a certain situation ([Matthew 16:8-11](#)). If someone always lacks faith, it is called "unbelief" (see [13:58](#)).

Some examples of "little faith" include:

- when the disciples do not understand their worth or God's protection ([6:30](#));
- when the disciples do not trust God's protection during danger ([8:26](#); [14:31](#));
- when the disciples misunderstand Jesus' teaching about yeast ([16:8](#)); and
- when the disciples fail to cast out a demon ([17:20](#)).

These are failures in specific situations, not a total lack of faith.

The term *faith* includes two ideas: *trust* (personal reliance on the Lord) and *belief* (acceptance of truths). Matthew's concern with "little faith" is about a follower of Jesus lacking trust in a specific situation, rather than failing to believe in Jesus as Lord and Savior. Jesus wants his followers to not only believe in him but also to trust, love, and obey him (see [Matthew 7:21-29](#); [22:34-40](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 6:30](#); [7:21-29](#); [8:26](#); [13:58](#); [14:31](#); [16:8](#); [17:20](#); [22:34-40](#); [Luke 12:28](#); [James 1:6-8](#)

Living for Christ

The apostle Paul writes from prison, "For to me, to live is Christ" ([1:21](#)). Why should Christians commit their lives to Jesus Christ?

67. *Christians recognize that they owe everything to Christ.* This includes their salvation. They show their gratitude by committing their lives to his service (see [Romans 12:1](#)).
68. *Christians accept Christ as their master and Lord.* They obey Christ's guidance in their lives. They understand that they belong to the Lord and do not live only for themselves (see [Romans 14:7-9](#); [2 Corinthians 5:14-15](#)).

69. *Christians now share in Christ's death and resurrection.* They have "died with Christ" and are "alive to God in Christ Jesus" (see [Romans 6:3-14](#); compare [Galatians 2:19-20](#)). They have a new identity in Christ ([Romans 8:14-17](#); [Ephesians 1:11, 14](#); [Philippians 3:20](#)).
70. *Christians understand that all valuable things are in Christ.* Worldly things that once seemed important have lost their appeal. Nothing compares to the immense value of knowing Christ ([Philippians 3:7-11](#); [Ephesians 1:3-3:21](#); [Colossians 1:15-3:4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 6:3-14](#); [8:14-17](#); [12:1](#); [14:7-9](#); [1 Corinthians 6:19](#); [2 Corinthians 5:14-15](#); [Galatians 2:19-20](#); [Ephesians 1:11, 14](#); [Philippians 1:21](#); [3:7-11, 20](#)

Living Water

Israel was a land often experiencing drought. People were very aware of water sources and quality. There were few year-round springs and rivers. So, people relied on a deep hole built underground to collect and store winter rain. These are called cisterns. They used wells to access underground water.

In Jewish culture, "dead water" meant standing or stored water. "Living water" meant moving water, like rivers, springs, and rainfall. This water was valuable because it was fresh. Since it came directly from God, people used it for ceremonial washings (see [Leviticus 14:5-6, 50-51](#); [15:13](#); [Numbers 19:17-19](#)).

The difference between "dead" and "living" water explains the confusion of the woman of Samaria when Jesus offered her "living water" ([John 4:12](#)). Samaria does not have a permanent river. If Jacob had to dig a well there, how could Jesus offer better water?

Jesus spoke about living water again in Jerusalem during the autumn Feast of Tabernacles ([John 7:37-39](#)). This feast, held in a dry season, focused on water. In this context, Jesus stepped forward and made a bold claim. Anyone seeking living water should come to him and drink. Jesus is the

source of living water. He came directly from God and brought divine renewal through the Holy Spirit.

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 14:5-6, 50-51](#); [15:13](#); [Numbers 19:17-19](#); [Song of Solomon 4:15](#); [Jeremiah 2:13](#); [17:13](#); [John 4:10-14](#); [7:38-39](#); [James 3:11-12](#)

Love in the Community of Christ

Living in a community is not always easy. The community of Jesus Christ (the church) has often experienced disunity and division throughout its history. Even in its earliest days, the church struggled with unity issues (see [1 Corinthians 1:11-17](#); [Galatians 2:11-16](#)).

To solve conflicts in the Christian community, Christians must show love to one another. Jesus taught this ([Matthew 22:37-40](#); [John 13:34-35](#); see [Leviticus 19:18](#)). The apostle Paul emphasized it ([Romans 13:8-10](#); [1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#)). It appears throughout the New Testament ([1 Peter 1:22](#); [1 John 2:7-11](#); [3:10](#); [4:7](#)). Loving others in the Christian community is key to Christian values ([Romans 12:9-10](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:9](#); [2 Peter 1:5-8](#)).

This kind of love is not just a feeling but a promise to help others, shown through actions. Followers of Christ should treat each other in such a way that their faith communities are famous for acts of love. The author of Hebrews gives examples of showing love in real ways within Christian communities ([Hebrews 13:1-6](#)).

These include:

71. Being welcoming
72. Helping those persecuted or imprisoned
73. Remaining faithful in marriage
74. Not letting money control their lives

Many people misunderstand love and the character of the church. So, the church must obey the Lord's command to "continue in brotherly love" ([Hebrews 13:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 19:18](#); [Matthew 22:39](#); [John 13:34](#); [Romans 12:10](#); [Romans 13:8](#); [1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:9](#); [Hebrews 6:10](#); [Hebrews](#)

[10:24](#); [Hebrews 13:1-6](#); [1 Peter 1:22](#); [2 Peter 1:7](#); [1 John 2:10](#); [1 John 3:10](#); [1 John 4:7](#)

Loving Others

Jesus said that loving your neighbor is the second most important commandment in the Old Testament ([Mark 12:31](#)). The command to love sums up the entire Old Testament law ([Matthew 22:40](#); compare [7:12](#); [9:9-13](#); [12:1-13](#); see [Romans 13:8-10](#)). Jesus criticized the Pharisees for not showing love ([Matthew 9:13](#); [12:7](#); [23:4](#), [13-14](#), [23](#)). Love identifies a true follower of Jesus ([John 13:34-35](#)). It indicates a real experience of God ([1 John 2:9-11](#); [3:11-18](#); [4:7-21](#)).

For the apostle Paul, love is more important than any spiritual gift and is the most important virtue. Love “is the bond of perfect unity” ([Colossians 3:14](#)). Without love, Christian ministry has no value ([1 Corinthians 13:1-3](#)). Paul summarized Christian ethics as “faith expressing itself through love” ([Galatians 5:6](#)).

Love naturally comes from Christian faith. It is the primary fruit of the Holy Spirit ([Galatians 5:22](#)). It is the most important motivation for Christian ministry. As Christians spiritually grow, they will desire to love others as Christ did.

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 19:18](#); [Hosea 6:6](#); [Matthew 7:12](#); [9:9-13](#); [12:1-13](#); [22:37-40](#); [23:2-4](#), [13](#), [23](#); [John 13:34-35](#); [Romans 13:8-10](#); [1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#); [Galatians 5:6](#), [22-23](#); [Colossians 3:12-14](#); [1 John 2:7-11](#); [3:11-18](#); [4:7-21](#)

Making Sense of the Exile

The kings and people of Israel repeatedly disobeyed God and failed to keep their special agreement (the covenant) with him. As a result, God announced that he would bring the covenant curses upon them (see [Deuteronomy 28:15-68](#); compare [Jeremiah 4:13](#); [Amos 5:11](#); [Micah 6:14-15](#)). God sent the Assyrian and Babylonian armies to carry out this punishment, and many Israelites went into exile (see [2 Kings 24:1-25:21](#)). They were forced to leave their land.

The exile of Israel influenced many psalms, impacting their images and themes.

In [Psalm 89](#), the psalmist expresses the sadness, pain, and confusion the Israelites experienced when they were living in exile through questions:

- Has God abandoned David's royal family line ([89:38-39](#))?
- How long will God's anger last ([Psalm 89:46](#))?
- Does God understand human weakness ([89:47-48](#))?
- Is God true to his nature ([89:49](#))?
- Is God fair by not avenging his people ([89:50-51](#))?

During and after the exile, God's people had many questions. Some doubted God's ability to rule. Instead of ignoring these doubts, wise readers listen, think about, and study the answers in Scripture.

The final answer came through the Lord Jesus Christ (see [Isaiah 52-54](#); [Luke 1:46-55](#), [67-79](#); [4:18-19](#); [Romans 6:6](#), [16-23](#); [Hebrews 12:22-24](#)). Yet, those who lived during the exile could only partly imagine a hopeful future. They asked difficult questions and lived without clear answers.

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 26:27-45](#); [Deuteronomy 28:36-37](#), [63-68](#); [30:1-5](#); [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); [24:1-25:21](#); [Ezra 5:12](#); [Psalms 89](#); [107](#); [126](#); [Isaiah 5:13](#); [27:13](#); [52:1-12](#); [59:10](#); [Jeremiah 2:37](#); [3:18](#); [4:13](#); [Ezekiel 6:9](#); [20:41](#); [37:1-14](#); [Amos 5:11](#); [Micah 6:14-15](#)

Marriage and Sexuality

Scripture considers marriage holy from the very beginning. Sexual expression is an important part of it ([Genesis 2:23-25](#)). The first human sin caused a disruption in all relationships. This first happened between God and humans, then between husband and wife, and even between humans and creation ([Genesis 3](#)). The division between Adam and Eve showed in their sexuality. They could no longer be naked in the garden without feeling shame.

In Proverbs, the wise teacher often warns young men to avoid sexual temptations outside of marriage ([Proverbs 2:16-22](#); [5:1-23](#); [6:20-7:27](#)). While a young man might find other women attractive, acting on these temptations can have

severe consequences. His family and career goals might become destroyed. Proverbs advises young men to build a strong relationship with their wives. The Scripture encourages men to have a healthy marital relationship instead of being with other women ([5:15-20](#)).

Although this section of Proverbs was first written to teach young men, everyone can think about these issues of marriage and sexuality. The book of Proverbs encourages everyone to recognize the holiness and beauty of marital love as God, the wise Creator, planned it.

The New Testament emphasizes the holiness of sexuality and its proper expression within marriage. Jesus refers to the creation story in Genesis to emphasize the intended permanence of marriage. After quoting [Genesis 2:24](#), he says, "So they are no longer two, but one flesh. Therefore what God has joined together, let man not separate" ([Matthew 19:3-6](#)). The apostle Paul talks about the importance of maintaining sexual intimacy in marriage to prevent temptation by Satan ([1 Corinthians 7:3-5](#)). God wants those who marry to stay faithful to each other and avoid harmful sexual activities that could damage their holy relationship (see [Hebrews 13:4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:18-25](#); [Proverbs 2:16-22](#); [5:15-20](#); [6:20-35](#); [7:1-27](#); [Jeremiah 5:7-11](#); [Hosea 2:20](#); [Malachi 2:14-16](#); [Matthew 19:4-6](#); [22:30](#); [1 Corinthians 6:15-20](#); [Hebrews 13:4](#)

Material Reward

In the Old Testament, people often believed that good people would always become wealthy. They saw wisdom from books like Proverbs as a universal rule. Some people still believe this today. But this teaching can cause problems.

If someone does not become rich, they might feel guilty or be judged by others. People may think they did something wrong. And if someone does become rich, they might feel proud or stop depending on God.

The suffering of Job provides as an example. His friends accepted a traditional theological view that said Job's troubles were evidence against him ([19:5](#)). They claimed his suffering was punishment for his sin ([4:7-9](#)). They believed Job's penalty was probably less than he deserved ([11:6](#)). Yet, God's

analysis of Job's life proved this idea false ([42:7-8](#)). God testified to his special relationship with Job and restored Job's good reputation as his servant.

Material well-being does not always conflict with spiritual blessings. Yet, when we see blessings as material gain, "the worries of this life, the deceitfulness of wealth, and the desire for other things" often distract us from spiritual blessings ([Mark 4:19](#); see also [Luke 6:25](#)). We can easily become greedy, envious, and lustful. Our self-worth might depend on what we own, even if we still owe money on it. This perspective is not Christian but reflects a worldly way of thinking ([1 John 2:15-17](#)).

In his suffering, Job went from complaining to showing humility. He recognized God's righteous power ([Job 40:4-5](#); [42:2-6](#)). We can also regard difficulties as chances for spiritual growth ([James 1:2-4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 13:2](#); [1 Kings 10:23](#); [Job 4:7-9](#); [11:6](#); [19:5](#); [Psalms 49:16-20](#); [73:1-28](#); [Proverbs 14:20](#); [18:11](#); [28:11](#); [Ecclesiastes 5:10-20](#); [Jeremiah 17:11](#); [Zephaniah 1:18](#); [Matthew 27:57](#); [Mark 4:19](#); [10:17-25](#); [Luke 6:24-25](#); [16:10-31](#); [1 Timothy 6:17](#); [James 1:2-4](#), [9](#); [5:1](#); [1 John 2:16](#); [3 John 1:2](#)

Messages Against the Nations

Why did Israel's prophets speak to nations who were unlikely to hear their messages? Why did the prophets care about these nations' thoughts and actions?

The real audience was God's people. These messages reminded them that God does not have a double standard. He judges the sins of his people and those of other nations. Judgment begins "with the family of God" ([1 Peter 4:17](#)).

But it does not stop there. God will judge everyone, both inside and outside Israel, who rebels against him. Everyone must recognize the Lord as the one true and sovereign God.

The people of Judah often trusted nations like Egypt to save them from foreign enemies. They did not realize that God used other nations to judge them. The prophets reminded the people that no nation on earth can replace God. In the end, all nations will bow before him in worship.

The messages against foreign nations reminded the covenant community that even though God judged

them for their sins, they remained his precious people. The main accusation against these foreign nations was that they persecuted and insulted God's chosen people. This offended God. The negative part of God's covenant with Abraham was still active. God says he will "curse those who curse you" ([Genesis 12:3](#)).

God's main goal in history is to bring glory to himself. By exiling his sinful people and judging their arrogant oppressors, God showed his power and holiness. Despite the exile to Babylon, there was still hope for the positive side of the covenant to be fulfilled: "all the families of the earth will be blessed through you" ([Genesis 12:3](#); see also [Romans 11:1-27](#)). God had not finished the plans for his people. He would ultimately glorify himself by returning them from the distant lands where he had scattered them.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:3](#); [Deuteronomy 23:3-6](#); [Isaiah 13:1-23:18](#); [Jeremiah 25:29](#); [46:1-51:64](#); [Ezekiel 9:6](#); [25:1-32:32](#); [36:23](#); [39:7](#); [Daniel 4:17](#); [Amos 1:1-2:3](#); [3:2](#); [Obadiah 1:1-16](#); [John 15:18-24](#); [Acts 3:25-26](#); [Romans 2:9-10](#); [11:1-27](#); [Ephesians 1:3-14](#); [1 Peter 4:17](#); [Revelation 18:1-24](#)

Miracles

Miracles often happened in the Bible. They were especially common during the time of Moses and the ministries of Elijah, Elisha, Jesus, and his apostles. The Bible does not try to prove miracles. It just reports them. Miracles show God's power over creation and his compassion for human needs.

Miracles can lead people to believe in God ([John 2:23](#)). But true belief requires more than just witnessing a miracle (see [John 12:37](#)). Miracles remind us that anything is possible for God ([Mark 9:21-23](#); compare [Matthew 19:26](#); [Mark 10:27](#); [Luke 1:37](#); [18:27](#)).

Jesus performed many miracles during his ministry, including healing the sick, casting out demons, controlling nature, and resurrecting the dead. He showed deep love for people by meeting their needs. Many followed him because of these miracles ([John 6:2](#)). Yet, he warned against following him only for the miracles ([John 6:26](#)).

The three greatest miracles related to Jesus are:

75. His arrival as "the Word" of God in human flesh ([John 1:14](#)).

76. His resurrection from the dead ([Matthews 28](#); [Mark 16:1-8](#); [Luke 24:1-53](#); [John 20:1-31](#); [Acts 1:3](#); [1 Corinthians 15:3-8](#); see also [Acts 23:6](#); [26:8](#)).
77. The miracle of spiritual rebirth ([John 3:3-8](#); [Galatians 2:20](#); [Ephesians 2:8-10](#)).

Jesus came into the world to save it and to die for sins, showing God's great love for humanity ([John 3:16](#); [Romans 5:8](#); [8:32](#); [Ephesians 2:4-5](#); [1 John 3:1-2](#)). God resurrecting Jesus from the dead shows his power over death and gives us hope for eternal life ([1 Peter 1:3-9](#)). Anyone who trusts in Jesus Christ as Savior and Lord is reborn as a child of God and receives eternal life ([John 1:12](#); [3:36](#); [Romans 5:1-2](#); [1 John 5:11-13](#)).

The miraculous work of Jesus continued through his followers, as shown in the book of Acts (for example, [Acts 3:1-11](#); [5:12-15](#); [6:8](#); [8:6-7](#); [9:32-42](#); [14:3](#)). Filled with the Holy Spirit, the apostles and other Christian leaders performed these miracles to show the power and truth of the Christian message ([14:3](#); see [John 3:2](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 19:23-26](#); [28:1-20](#); [Mark 10:23-27](#); [Luke 1:30-38](#); [18:24-27](#); [24:1-53](#); [John 1:12-14](#); [3:2-8](#); [16](#); [20:1-21:25](#); [Acts 4:29-31](#); [5:12-16](#); [6:8](#); [8:4-23](#); [9:32-42](#); [14:3-4](#); [26:8](#); [Romans 5:1](#); [8](#); [8:32](#); [Ephesians 2:4-5](#); [8-10](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#); [1 Peter 1:3-5](#); [1 John 5:12-13](#)

Miraculous Signs in the Gospel of John

The Gospels use three words to describe Jesus' miraculous works. In Matthew, Mark, and Luke, the Greek word *dunamis* means "power." It describes an act of raw force that amazes people and makes them realize that God is working through Jesus (see [Mark 6:2](#)).

The apostle John does not use the popular term *dunamis* for Jesus' miracles. Instead, he calls each miracle a "sign" (Greek *sēmeion*). This means an event with deeper significance. John also refers to Jesus' miracles as "works" (Greek *erga*, see [John 10:38](#); [7:3](#); [9:3](#)). Jesus' miracles were part of the work God gave him to do to show the Father to the world ([17:4](#)).

John's Gospel records seven miraculous signs during Jesus' ministry:

78. Jesus changed water into wine ([John 2:1-11](#)).
79. Jesus healed an official's son ([4:46-54](#)).
80. Jesus healed a paralyzed man ([5:1-17](#)).
81. Jesus fed five thousand people ([6:1-15](#)).
82. Jesus walked on water ([6:16-21](#)).
83. Jesus healed a blind man ([9:1-41](#)).
84. Jesus raised Lazarus from the dead ([11:1-44](#)).

John also notes a miraculous catch of fish after Jesus' resurrection ([John 21:4-14](#)). Most of these signs led people to trust in Christ ([2:11](#); [4:53](#); [11:45-48](#)).

Yet, Jesus' goals went beyond the signs. The miraculous signs were like road markers. They pointed to a greater truth. A miraculous sign often comes with a talk from Jesus, explaining the truth it reveals.

For example, Jesus fed the five thousand men, not just to meet their physical needs. But he showed that he is "the bread of life." He would give himself for them when he died on the cross ([John 6:35](#); [6:51](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 4:8-31](#); [7:3](#); [Numbers 14:11](#), [22](#); [Deuteronomy 4:34](#); [Psalms 74:9](#); [78:43](#); [Matthew 12:38-39](#); [John 2:1-11](#), [18](#), [23](#); [3:2](#); [4:48](#), [54](#); [6:2](#), [14](#), [26](#), [30](#); [7:31](#); [9:16](#); [10:41](#); [11:47](#); [12:18](#), [37](#); [15:24](#); [20:30](#); [Acts 2:43](#); [4:16](#), [22](#), [30](#); [5:12](#); [8:6](#); [14:3](#); [15:12](#); [Romans 15:19](#)

Misunderstanding in the Gospel of John

In John's Gospel, people often misunderstood Jesus (see [John 3:4](#); [4:11](#), [33](#); [7:35](#); [11:12-13](#)). They disagreed about who Jesus was. When they realized what he truly meant, some wanted to arrest him, while others wanted to follow him ([7:40-44](#)). Only later, after the disciples received the Holy Spirit, did they fully understand his importance (see [16:12-13](#)).

The world remains in spiritual darkness and struggles to understand life or God ([John 1:5](#), [10](#)). People cannot understand God's messages on their own unless God helps them understand. God's spiritual light enters the darkness, revealing the world's flaws. Many people retreat further into spiritual darkness because they prefer it over the light ([3:19-20](#)). Only God's Spirit can transform and help people see plainly as God's children do ([3:21](#); [8:12](#); [12:35-36](#), [46](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 6:8-13](#); [56:10-11](#); [Matthew 13:11-17](#); [John 1:10-11](#); [3:19-20](#); [John 7:32-36](#); [9:40-41](#); [12:40](#); [Romans 1:21](#); [2 Corinthians 3:13-18](#); [4:3-4](#); [1 John 2:9-11](#); [Revelation 3:17](#)

Music in Ancient Israel

The earliest people who moved from place to place (called nomads) made music. The first musician mentioned in the Bible is "Jubal," who played the harp and flute ([Genesis 4:21](#)).

Music was important from the beginning of Israel's worship in the tabernacle. In [Exodus 28:34-35](#), Aaron's robe had bells on the lower hem that sounded as he entered the holy place. Scripture records several songs created by God's people (for example, [Exodus 15:1-21](#); [Deuteronomy 31:30-32:44](#); [Judges 5:1-31](#)).

The first liturgical music in the Old Testament appears during the transfer of the ark of the covenant. King David and the Israelites sang, played instruments, and danced to honor the Lord ([2 Samuel 6:5](#)). David is famous for creating the musical instruments used in the temple ([2 Chronicles 7:6](#)). In the time after the exile (when the people of Israel returned from being captives in Babylon), the singers from the tribe of Levi were descendants of Asaph. Asaph was the chief musician appointed by David ([Ezra 2:41](#); [Nehemiah 7:44](#); [11:22-23](#)). In simple terms, Israel's worship music and how it was organized began during the time of David.

The formal ceremonies in Solomon's Temple were different from the excited and spontaneous worship of David's time ([2 Chronicles 7:1-6](#)). Singers and musicians for temple worship were chosen from the tribe of Levi ([1 Chronicles 25:1](#), [7](#)). These musicians took turns participating in services held on weekdays, Sabbaths, and special holy days.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 4:21](#); [Exodus 28:34-35](#); [2 Samuel 6:5](#); [2 Chronicles 7:6](#); [Psalm 71:22-23](#)

Natural Revelation

When God speaks directly to people, we call it *special revelation*. God also speaks to everyone indirectly through *natural revelation* (also known as *general revelation* because it is given to all). This happens through the natural world God created. For example, [Psalm 19](#) says that knowledge of God in creation is available to everyone everywhere (see [Psalm 19:1-4](#)).

Sadly, not everyone responds positively to God. Paul explains in [Romans 1-3](#) that because of Adam's sin, all people turn away from the knowledge of God found in creation. Without God's grace, natural revelation only condemns people. As Paul says in [1:20](#), people "are without excuse."

God can use creation to help people realize he is the one true God. When God's grace supports and empowers this natural revelation, the world's beauty and complexity can inspire a search for the Creator. Paul appealed to natural revelation when he was in Athens as a way to introduce the good news about Jesus ([Acts 17:16-31](#)). God's revelation in the natural world and in human nature can encourage people to search for him. And then, through the special revelation God has ultimately given in his Son, Jesus Christ, people can truly know him and experience salvation.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 19:1-4](#); [Acts 14:15-17](#); [Acts 17:24-29](#); [Romans 1:19-21](#)

Nehemiah's Confidence in God

God gave the prophet Nehemiah favor with a powerful Persian king. The king agreed to all of Nehemiah's requests ([Nehemiah 1:11](#); [2:8, 18](#)). Nehemiah then confidently shared his bold plan to rebuild Jerusalem's walls. The people of Jerusalem trusted God would help them succeed and protect them from enemies ([2:18](#); [4:4-5, 9](#)).

They continued their work despite opposition. They knew God fights for his people and disrupts evil plans ([4:14-15, 20](#)). When they completed the walls, Nehemiah acknowledged that the

challenging project succeeded only with God's help ([6:16](#)).

The book of Nehemiah shows that God is all-powerful and can achieve his plans in both personal lives and nations. The prayer in [Nehemiah 9](#) praises God for his powerful acts. God created the heavens and earth, called Abram from Ur, and gave the land to Israel ([9:6](#); [7-8, 22-25](#)).

God demonstrated his power over people and creation to show care for his people in three main ways ([9:9-15](#)):

85. The miraculous signs in Egypt.

86. The parting of the Red Sea.

87. The provision of guidance, food, and water in the wilderness.

The Lord sent the Israelites into exile after many generations of sin ([Nehemiah 9:32-37](#)). Now, he was fulfilling his promise to restore them ([1:8-9](#)). Nehemiah prayed and led with confidence because he knew everything was part of God's plan.

This same trust in God led Abram to leave Ur and go to an unknown land ([Genesis 12:1-3](#); [Hebrews 11:8-10](#)). It caused Rahab to trust God ([Joshua 2:9-14](#); [Hebrews 11:31](#)). It prompted King Hezekiah to resist the king of Assyria, Sennacherib ([2 Kings 18:1-19:37](#)). Confidence comes when people trust God will keep his promises and complete the work he started in their lives ([Philippians 1:6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1-4](#); [Joshua 1:10-18](#); [2:9-14](#); [2 Kings 18:1-19:37](#); [Nehemiah 1:8-9, 11](#); [2:8, 18, 20](#); [4:4-5, 9, 14-15, 20](#); [6:16](#); [9:6-31](#); [Psalms 4:5](#); [9:10](#); [37:3](#); [40:3](#); [44:6-7](#); [56:3-12](#); [112:1-9](#); [Proverbs 3:5-12](#); [16:20](#); [28:1, 25](#); [Isaiah 26:3](#); [Hebrews 11:8-10, 31](#); [1 John 4:17](#)

Oppression of God's People

God does not want his people to suffer under oppression. From the time when God freed the Israelites from slavery in Egypt under Moses (the exodus), to when Joshua led them to conquer the promised land, and through David's battles, God's goal for Israel was complete victory over their enemies (see [Joshua 1:1-9](#)). In a similar way, the New Testament often speaks of freedom from the oppression or control of sin as an essential blessing of a relationship with Jesus ([Romans 6:1-14](#); [Galatians 5:1-15](#)).

Why does oppression exist? The book of Judges suggests it is because of human disobedience. If Israel obeyed God he promised victory in the conquest. Yet, at best they only partially obeyed him ([Judges 1:19–36](#)). With the rewards of victory available, why did God's past people fail as well as the church today?

In Judges, a new generation grew up that did not participate in the exodus from Egypt or Joshua's conquest of Canaan. Their faith relied on stories of divine acts from the past. They had not personally witnessed "all the great works that the LORD had done for Israel" ([Judges 2:7](#)). This generation "did not know the LORD or the works that He had done for Israel" ([2:10](#)).

God allowed enemies to remain in the land "to test all the Israelites" ([3:1–4](#)). But Israel did not expel these enemies as God commanded. The rest of the book of Judges shows the tragic results of that failure.

God allows his people to experience the consequences of turning away from him ([Judges 2:12–14](#)). But God remains faithful and does not ultimately abandon those who truly worship him. Even in judgment, God punishes for good. He teaches his people obedience.

The enemies who took Israel's blessings became part of God's test of Israel's faithfulness. We can learn from oppression, as both physical and spiritual battles need discipline. This experience can lead to a "a harvest of righteousness and peace" (see [Hebrews 12:5–11](#)).

Through Jesus Christ, God provided undeserved salvation from the worldwide oppression of sin, "while we were still sinners" ([Romans 5:8](#)). The Israelites experienced salvation from their enemies when they turned in repentance to the Lord. So, we can experience salvation from the greatest oppressive force when we turn to God in repentance.

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 26:14–39](#); [Deuteronomy 8:19–20](#); [28:15–68](#); [Judges 2:2–3](#), [10–15,18](#); [3:1–8](#); [2 Kings 17:5–23](#); [Ezekiel 22:27–29](#); [Amos 4:1](#); [James 2:1–7](#)

Our Advocate

In the Gospel of John, the Greek word *paraklētos* refers to the Holy Spirit. This word literally means "called alongside" and describes him as "Advocate"

([John 14:16](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7](#)). This term appears in other Greek texts, where it refers to a legal advocate. This is someone who speaks in a person's defense in court and gives legal advice.

"Counselor" is a common translation, but its modern meaning related to psychology can be misleading. The older legal sense of a lawyer giving advice is more accurate.

"Comforter" is another common translation, but it can also be misleading. The older English meaning of someone who strengthens, or an "encourager," aligns better with the New Testament idea of *paraklētos*.

Jesus described the Spirit as *another* "Advocate" ([John 14:16](#)). Jesus, the first advocate, sent the Holy Spirit as the second Advocate (see [1 John 2:1](#)). Every task of the Spirit described in [John 14–16](#) is a task Jesus performed elsewhere in the gospel stories. Jesus promised that the Holy Spirit would come to encourage, instruct, and strengthen his followers. The Spirit would maintain Jesus' presence among his disciples. Five promises about the Spirit show different works the Spirit does ([John 14:16–17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7–8](#), [13–14](#)).

The Spirit became available to Jesus' disciples after his death (see [John 7:39](#); [20:22](#)). The Spirit now continues Jesus' work and presence in the lives of Christians ([14:16–26](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 2:25](#); [24:15](#); [2 Samuel 15:12](#); [1 Kings 12:6–14](#); [1 Chronicles 27:32](#); [Job 16:18–22](#); [Isaiah 1:26](#); [9:6](#); [John 14:1–16:15](#); [Galatians 3:19–20](#); [6:13](#); [1 Timothy 2:5](#); [Hebrews 8:6](#); [9:15](#); [12:24](#); [1 John 2:1](#)

Overcoming the Devil

The New Testament writers believed in the reality of evil and the dangers of the spiritual world. They saw Satan, also known as "the evil one" or "the devil," as a serious threat. The devil blocks the work of God's people (see [1 Thessalonians 2:18](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)). He "prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour" ([1 Peter 5:8](#)).

The entire world that does not trust in Christ is under the power of sin and the devil (see [Ephesians 2:2](#); [1 John 5:19](#)). Paul calls the devil "the god of this age has blinded the minds of unbelievers" (see [2 Corinthians 4:4](#); compare [Matthew 13:19](#)). Satan opposes God and tries to destroy his people

([Revelation 12:12, 17](#)). But Jesus came to destroy "the works of the devil" ([1 John 3:8](#)).

God changes into good what the devil intends for evil. Following this idea, the apostle Paul tells the church at Corinth to remove someone from the Christian community. This way, by encountering the devil's destructive power, that person would repent and find salvation (see [1 Corinthians 5:5](#)).

Christians should submit to God and resist the devil ([James 4:7](#)). They should pray for God's help ([Matthew 6:13](#)). They should use the spiritual armor God provides for protection ([Ephesians 6:10-20](#)). Those who obey Satan experience consequences (see [Acts 5:1-5](#)). Obedient Christians are safe because they know Christ's death on the cross has stopped the devil's power (see [Romans 8:38-39](#); [1 Corinthians 15:24](#); [Colossians 1:13](#); [2:10, 15](#); [1 Peter 3:22](#)).

The Lord protects them (see [1 John 5:18](#)). They also know the Holy Spirit within them is stronger than the devil (see [1 John 4:4](#)). Through God's word, they can defeat the evil one (see [1 John 2:14](#); compare [Revelation 12:11](#)).

Christians should be cautious of the devil and guard against his influence. But they should not live in fear. God's power is much greater than the devil's. In the end, God will completely defeat the devil (see [Revelation 20:7-10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 6:13](#); [13:19](#); [Acts 5:3-5](#); [Romans 8:38-39](#); [1 Corinthians 5:5](#); [15:24](#); [2 Corinthians 4:4](#); [Ephesians 2:2](#); [4:27](#); [6:10-20](#); [Colossians 1:13](#); [2:10, 15](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:18](#); [James 4:7](#); [1 Peter 3:22](#); [5:8](#); [1 John 2:14](#); [3:8](#); [4:4](#); [5:18-19](#); [Revelation 2:10](#); [12:7-9](#), [11-12](#), [17](#)

Passing On Authority and Responsibility to a New Leader

The role of a Christian leader is to serve and endure difficulties for those they guide ([Mark 10:35-45](#)). For the apostle Paul, good leadership meant setting an example like Jesus Christ. Jesus's death on the cross was the most important thing to Paul, and it completely shaped how he lived his life. He said, "I want to know ... the fellowship of His sufferings, being conformed to Him in His death" ([Philippians 3:10](#); see [Colossians 1:24](#)).

He meant more than emotional struggles or dealing with sin. He meant experiencing violent physical

suffering. Paul endured difficulties for those with whom he shared the good news. He always made their salvation a priority over his own safety ([2 Timothy 2:10](#); [2 Corinthians 4:8-12](#)).

A Christian leader's life shows others about Jesus' death on the cross. It shows how God works powerfully even through weak human beings ([2 Corinthians 12:8-10](#)). It also shows God's wisdom despite human foolishness ([1 Corinthians 1:18-31](#)). When Paul called the apostle Timothy to lead, he also called him to "endure hardship" ([2 Timothy 4:1-5](#); [1:8](#); [2:3](#); [4:5](#)). Paul told Timothy not to be ashamed of the cross ([1:8](#)).

True Christian leadership must follow Jesus Christ's example of putting others first. When leaders focus on themselves instead of Christ, they fail to live out the good news of Jesus. A good leader follows Jesus's example by serving and caring for others, not seeking their own benefit (see [Philippians 2:3-8](#)). These leaders are ready to experience difficult times. They know that those who share in Jesus' death will also share in his life, and those who remain faithful through difficulties will share in his rule ([2 Timothy 2:11-12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[John 13:15](#); [Acts 20:35](#); [2 Corinthians 4:8-12](#); [Ephesians 5:2](#); [Colossians 1:24](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:6-7](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:9](#); [1 Timothy 1:16](#); [4:12](#); [2 Timothy 1:8](#), [12](#); [2:3](#), [10-12](#); [4:1-5](#); [Titus 2:7](#); [Hebrews 6:12](#); [13:7](#); [1 Peter 2:21](#); [5:1-4](#)

Paul's Role as an Apostle

To understand Paul's role as an apostle of Jesus Christ, a good place to read is the description in the second letter to the Corinthians. In this letter, Paul shares the core of his ministry. Paul was God's special messenger to establish and care for churches in the non-Jewish (gentiles) world. He served with seriousness and sincerity. His message dealt with life and death issues ([2 Corinthians 2:15-17](#)). As an early Christian missionary, he brought the good news about Jesus (the gospel) to places where people had not heard about Jesus (see [Romans 15:20-21](#)).

Paul's message of good news was plain and direct (see, for example, [2 Corinthians 5:1-21](#)). He modeled it by his own life. He always intended to serve with truth and honesty ([2:17](#); [4:2](#)). As Paul shared the message of Christ, the self-sacrifice of

Christ's cross was his pattern of service to others ([11:16-33](#)).

Some people questioned Paul's authority. So he shared how God called him to be an apostle and established his ministry in Corinth ([2 Corinthians 10:12-18](#)). Some wanted proof that Christ choose him and criticized Paul's weaknesses ([13:3](#)). So, he pointed to the cross of Jesus and the lessons he learned from it (see [13:4](#); [4:10](#)). Paul knew his own limitations and that he needed God's grace to do his work. An apostle's true authority shows itself in human weakness supported by God's strength ([12:1-10](#)).

Paul performed miraculous works to support his claim to apostleship ([Hebrews 12:12](#)). Yet, these works did not stop doubts among the young church at Corinth. Paul showed great patience in his ministry and did not give up when the Corinthians challenged him. This patience mirrors that of Jesus, who encountered much opposition from others ([Hebrews 12:2-3](#)).

Paul's example offers lessons for everyone involved in Christian service:

88. Christian leaders should regard criticism as an opportunity to evaluate themselves and check if any accusation is true.
89. Christian leaders should remain patient when encountering undeserved opposition and stay focused on their work.
90. It is important to provide a logical defense and explain one's motives, while also acknowledging that the Lord is the ultimate judge.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 10:5-42](#); [28:18-20](#); [Mark 1:17](#); [2:14](#); [3:14-15](#); [John 21:15-17](#); [Acts 1:2-8](#), [20-26](#); [2:42-43](#); [4:33](#); [5:12](#); [6:2-4](#); [10:39-43](#); [14:3](#); [Romans 1:5](#); [15:17-21](#); [1 Corinthians 4:8-13](#); [12:28-29](#); [2 Corinthians 2:17](#); [4:2](#); [6:3-12](#); [10:12-18](#); [Ephesians 2:20](#); [3:4-5](#); [4:11-13](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:7-12](#)

Persecution

Persecution refers to systematic mistreatment, harassment, or oppression of an individual or group because of their identity, beliefs, or

practices. In religious contexts specifically, persecution involves the targeting of people for their religious faith or practices.

Persecution is a common experience for God's people. God's servants have often faced hostility and opposition (for example, [Deuteronomy 30:7](#); [1 Kings 18:13](#); [Nehemiah 4:1-3](#); [Jeremiah 37:11-38:28](#); [Matthew 23:34-37](#); [Luke 11:49-51](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:14-16](#)). Jesus himself faced persecution ([Luke 4:28-30](#); [John 5:16](#)).

At the end of his earthly life, he suffered mocking, beating, and a terrible death by crucifixion. He told his disciples to expect similar treatment ([Matthew 10:16-25](#); [24:9](#); [Mark 13:9-13](#); [Luke 21:12-17](#); [John 16:2](#)). He prepared his followers for these times, telling them that the Holy Spirit would give them the courage they needed ([Luke 12:11-12](#); [21:14-15](#); [Acts 1:8](#)).

The book of Acts describes how the earliest Christians faced persecution. It started with the Jewish high council's (Sanhedrin) hostility. Saul of Tarsus persecuted the early church before he met Jesus in a vision near Damascus ([Acts 8:1-3](#); [9:1-13](#), [21](#); [22:4](#); [26:9-11](#); see [1 Corinthians 15:9](#); [Galatians 1:13](#); [Philippians 3:6](#)). The apostles Peter, John, Stephen, James, Paul, and Barnabas all suffered persecution ([Acts 4:15-18](#); [5:17-18](#); [7:54-60](#); [12:1-4](#); [14:5-6](#)).

In his parable of the farmer and the seed, Jesus explained how persecution affects those with weak faith ([Matthew 13:20-21](#); [Mark 4:16-17](#)). Persecution purifies God's people and helps them become more like Jesus. The apostles' experiences in the book of Acts support Paul's statement: "Indeed, all who desire to live godly lives in Christ Jesus will be persecuted" ([2 Timothy 3:12](#); see [Mark 10:29-30](#)).

Jesus told his disciples to be ready to defend their faith in difficult situations ([Matthew 10:18-20](#); [Luke 21:12-15](#)). The apostles and other leaders did this with courage and boldness (for example, [Acts 4:8-12](#), [31](#); [5:29-32](#); [6:8-10](#); [8:4-40](#); [9:27](#)). The Scriptures encourage Christians to defend their faith bravely and kindly. They must be able to explain their beliefs to those who ask questions ([Colossians 4:6](#); [2 Timothy 2:24-25](#); [1 Peter 3:15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 18:2-15](#); [19:1-18](#); [Nehemiah 4:1-3](#); [Jeremiah 37:1-38:28](#); [Matthew 10:16-39](#); [13:20-21](#); [23:34-38](#); [24:9-14](#); [Mark 10:29-31](#); [13:9-13](#); [Luke 11:47-51](#); [12:11-12](#); [21:12-19](#); [John 16:1-4](#);

[Acts 4:13–31](#); [5:17–42](#); [6:8–8:4](#); [9:1–31](#); [12:1–19](#); [14:1–7](#); [22:3–29](#); [23:12–31](#); [26:9–11](#); [Galatians 1:13](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:14–16](#); [2 Timothy 3:11–14](#); [1 Peter 3:13–18](#)

Praise and Rejoicing in Luke–Acts

In Luke's Gospel, those who receive God's grace praise him for his wonderful acts ([Luke 1:44](#), [46](#), [64](#), [68](#); [2:13](#), [38](#); [5:25–26](#); [7:16](#); [13:13](#); [17:15–18](#); [18:43](#); [19:37](#); [24:53](#)). In the book of Acts, praise follows healings and the salvation of non-Jews (gentiles) ([3:8–9](#); [4:21–22](#); [Acts 11:18](#); [13:48](#); [21:19–20](#)).

This theme of praise closely links to a key idea in Luke's Gospel. The fulfillment of God's promise through Jesus the Messiah brings joy. This idea appears early in the book in the songs of Mary and Zechariah ([Luke 1:46–55](#), [67–79](#)). The Old Testament prophets predicted that creation would sing when God's salvation arrived (see [Isaiah 55:12](#)).

When Jesus entered Jerusalem at the end of his ministry, his disciples shouted. They "began to praise God joyfully in a loud voice for all the miracles they had seen" ([Luke 19:37](#)). The Pharisees asked Jesus to silence his disciples. But he replied, "if they remain silent, the very stones will cry out" ([19:37–40](#)).

At the end of the book, the disciples "returned to Jerusalem with great joy, praising God continually in the temple" ([24:52–53](#)). The arrival of God's marvelous salvation is a reason for joy and praise.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 55:12](#); [Luke 1:44–47](#), [64](#), [68](#); [2:13–14](#), [38](#); [5:25–26](#); [7:16](#); [13:13](#); [17:15–18](#); [18:43](#); [19:37–40](#); [24:51–53](#); [Acts 2:47](#); [3:8–9](#); [4:21](#); [11:18](#); [13:48](#); [21:20](#)

Praise Psalms

The Hebrew title of the book of Psalms means "Praises." This idea fits many of the psalms. The psalms praise God for his nature and great acts in creation and history. People wrote praise psalms for both personal and community use.

Individual praise ([Psalms 9](#); [18](#); [32](#); [34](#); [116](#); [138](#)): In temple worship, people often gave thanks aloud in front of everyone when they made a vow or

thank offering (see, for example, [22:22–26](#); [66:13–20](#); [116:17–19](#)). These moments of personal praise and testimony added warmth and meaning to worship. Each rescue and experience of God's mercy became part of the continuing story of salvation. Worship was more than just remembering God's acts from the past.

Communal praise ([Psalms 103](#), [113](#), [124](#), [129](#), [136](#)): When the community gathered, they sang to praise the Lord for his historical acts ([Psalm 103](#)). Or they would praise him for a recent display of his mercy ([Psalms 124](#), [129](#)).

In [Psalm 103](#), the psalmist praises God for his mercy to individuals and the entire community (verses [1–5](#), [6–14](#)). Human weakness contrasts with God's reliability (verses [15–18](#)). His universal and absolute rule deserves praise from everyone and everything (verses [19–22](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 9](#); [18](#); [32](#); [34](#); [46–48](#); [93](#); [96–99](#); [103](#); [113](#); [116](#); [124](#); [129](#); [136](#); [138](#)

Prayers for Vengeance

Vengeance is punishment inflicted in return for a wrong suffered. It is the act of causing harm to someone as a response to harm they have caused. The writers of the psalms (called psalmists) sometimes asked God to punish their enemies. It was common for them to pray for the violent destruction of their enemies as a sign of God's justice. How can this type of prayer be acceptable?

These prayers for the destruction of the evil people come from a desire for justice and trust in God. [Psalm 1:6](#) explains divine justice. God protects the righteous and destroys evil people. The evil people are corrupt and committed to what is wrong. They oppose God and everything God does. They oppose morals, society, and God's kingdom.

The psalmists argued that evil does not align with God's nature. Removing evil is necessary for his kingdom to thrive. Yet, the poets of Israel did not call for God's judgment on anyone they disliked. Instead, the psalmists followed God's standards of justice and righteousness, which God expects all humans to follow.

The psalmists knew grief well. They suffered and experienced oppression from bullies, leaders, and kings both within and outside Israel. Their prayers were full of faith and hope. They questioned how

long God would allow their suffering. They affirmed that only the Lord could save them from evil.

They deeply longed for his redemption. They asked God to make the wicked suffer as they had, following the principle of revenge ([Psalm 5:10; 6:10; 7:9; 9:19-20; 28:4; 56:7; 104:35; 137:7-9; 139:19](#)). Through these prayers for justice and salvation, the faithful can find peace as they wait for God's rescue.

Do we truly see evil as evil, or do we think of it only as an inconvenience? It is right to pray for the end of evil as long as we recognize that God is the one who decides, judges, and carries out judgment. When we pray for God's Kingdom to come, we are also asking for evil to be removed.

But now the harsh punishment that was meant for sinful people has been changed through Jesus Christ's painful death on the cross. This action by God shows us how we should pray for those who oppose us. Jesus will indeed judge and bring a final end to evil (see [Revelation 19:11-21](#)). But while Christians wait for that final judgment, they are to love as Jesus loved ([John 13:34](#)). They should pray for their enemies and forgive them ([Matthew 5:38-48; Colossians 3:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Chronicles 24:22; Nehemiah 4:5; Psalms 3:7; 9:19-20; 10:15; 12:3; 41:10; 55:15; 69:22-28; 79:6; 109:6-20; 110:5-6; 137:1-9; Isaiah 61:2; Jeremiah 11:20-23; 18:19-23; 51:35; Lamentations 1:22; 3:64-66; Acts 1:20; Romans 11:9-10; Revelation 6:10](#)

Preaching to a Tough Crowd

Sometimes God asks people to share the good news about Jesus with a difficult audience. The listeners might resist God's truth and reject both the message and the messenger. This was especially true for the Old Testament prophets, who often shared messages that people did not want to hear (see [Jeremiah 26:7-9; 38:1-6; Amos 7:10-13](#)).

The prophet Malachi preached to a difficult audience. His congregation included people who were:

- disappointed ([Malachi 1:2](#))
- distrusting ([1:7; 2:2](#))
- uncaring ([2:13-16](#))
- dishonest ([3:5](#))
- disinterested ([3:14-15](#))
- doubting, skeptical, and the truly wicked (see [4:1](#))

What should a preacher say to such a group?

Malachi used conversation to engage his audience in a series of debates. The prophet gave a strong correction that cleverly answered the objections people might raise before they could speak. His message was powerful and made people pay attention: "those who feared the LORD spoke with one another, and the LORD listened and heard them" ([Malachi 3:16](#)).

Like the prophets, both Jesus and his followers shared messages with audiences who resisted them (see, for example, [Luke 4:16-30; John 10:22-40; Acts 5:26-40; 22:30-23:10](#)). Yet, this resistance did not stop them from fulfilling their God-given duty to share the good news about Jesus (see [Acts 5:41-42](#)). Those who preach the Lord's message can hope for a positive response like Malachi did. But, that is not always guaranteed.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 19:6-11; Exodus 17:1-13; Judges 9:1-21; 1 Kings 22:8-28; Jeremiah 28:1-17; Malachi 3:14-18; John 10:24-39; Acts 22:30-23:10](#)

Pride and Humility

Pride is a feeling people naturally have when they succeed or achieve something. Many people in the world value being recognized and famous (see [1 John 2:16](#)). However, pride comes from thinking too much about yourself, and often leads to making others seem less important. The Bible often warns against pride and the harm it can cause. Instead, the Bible encourages people to be humble.

The book of Proverbs connects humility with wisdom (see [Proverbs 11:2](#)). Wisdom begins with revering or fearing the Lord ([1:7](#)). Wisdom recognizes God's power and importance. A humble person admits mistakes and accepts correction from others ([10:17; 12:1](#)). But pride can prevent

learning from others. It can cause conflict ([13:10](#)). It leads to disgrace ([11:2](#)).

In the divine plan, pride leads to downfall and shame, while humility brings honor ([Proverbs 11:2; 18:12; 29:23](#)). People asked Jesus, "Who then is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven?" He indicated that the model was the pure humility of a child ([Matthew 18:1-5](#)).

In another story, Jesus shared a parable comparing the proud prayer of a religious leader with the humble prayer of a tax collector. He concluded with the words, "For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted" ([Luke 18:9-14](#); see also [Matthew 23:8-12; Luke 14:7-11](#)).

Jesus showed the ultimate example of humility. Even though he is God's son, "he did not consider equality with God something to be grasped." Instead, "taking the form of a servant," he "became obedient to death—even death on a cross" ([Philippians 2:6-8](#)). God commands us to humble ourselves with the same self-sacrifice ([Philippians 2:3-5; 1 John 3:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 3:5-14; 2 Chronicles 26:14-20; Proverbs 10:17; 11:2; 12:15; 15:5; 22:4; 29:23; Matthew 5:5; 18:4; 21:5; Luke 18:9-14; Ephesians 4:2; Philippians 2:3; James 1:21; 3:13; 4:10](#)

Promised Land

God gave the first man and woman the task of governing the earth and ruling over creation. This was to meet their needs and honor the creator ([Genesis 1:28-30](#)). But when humanity sinned, they became separated from God, each other, and the land on which they lived ([3:17-19](#); see [4:3-16](#); compare [5:29](#)).

God called Abram to follow him by faith and receive Canaan as a special homeland. This land was a promised place for his descendants as God's people ([Genesis 12:1-3, 7; 13:14-18; 15:7-21; 17:7-8](#)). Later, God freed Israel from slavery in Egypt. At Mount Sinai, he made a covenant (special agreement) with them to be his people. Then they received the land promised to their ancestors.

Keeping the land depended on obedience. If Israel violated the covenant, they would encounter its curses. The worst curse was exile from the promised land ([Leviticus 26:32-33](#)). This

eventually happened because of Israel's continued rebellion against the Lord. He sent them into exile to Assyria and Babylon. They lost their land, and their enemies destroyed the temple of God ([2 Kings 17:5-23; 25:1-21](#)).

Yet, God also promises that when the people repent, "then I will remember My covenant ... and I will remember the land" ([Leviticus 26:42](#)). During the exile to Babylon, the prophet Jeremiah and other prophets saw God's future restoration of his people and their return to the land ([Jeremiah 32:36-44](#)). This happened during the rule of King Cyrus the Great of Persia (see the books of Ezra and Nehemiah).

The promises about the land still wait for their final fulfillment. God plans to prepare an eternal homeland for his people. In this homeland, God will rule directly and justly as king. Everyone and everything will follow God's will. Death and sin will no longer exist. The needs of God's people will be fully met ([Hebrews 11:13-16; Revelation 21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:28-30; 3:15-19; 4:3-16; 12:1-3, 7; 13:14-18; 15:1-21; 17:7-8; Exodus 6:1-13; Leviticus 26:1-46; 1 Kings 8:22-53; 9:1-9; 2 Kings 17:5-23; 25:1-21; Jeremiah 32:36-44; Hebrews 11:13-16; Revelation 21:1-27](#)

Prophetic Sign Acts

The prophets of Israel sometimes used sign acts to share their messages. Sign acts were dramatic actions performed in public to make their message stronger. These visual demonstrations helped people not only *hear* the truth but also *feel* it deeply. The purpose of these actions was to create a message that people would not forget.

These acts were unusual and strange—not just to people today but also to people in ancient times. However, unlike people today (who might think the prophet had mental problems), people in ancient times understood that these sign acts were a normal way prophets communicated their messages.

The prophet Ezekiel often acted out his messages more than any other prophet. This was probably because he spoke to a very stubborn audience ([Ezekiel 2:6-7](#)). These actions emphasized his message and showed his deep commitment. For instance, he ate God's word ([Ezekiel 2:8-3:3](#)). Then

Ezekiel demonstrated it to the exiles through a series of judgment scenes ([Ezekiel 3:4-9](#); see also chapters [4-6](#)). This dramatic communication is hard for even an angry audience to ignore or forget.

Jesus Christ performed the ultimate sign act on the cross (see [Matthew 27:32-54](#)). There, God showed his judgment against sin with darkness, an earthquake, and the suffering of his sinless Son who seemed abandoned by his Father. God also showed his deep love for the world by choosing to die rather than lose his people. The cross is a powerful message of God's love and judgment that is hard to ignore or forget.

Passages for Further Study

[Jeremiah 13:1-11](#); [19:1-15](#); [25:15](#); [Ezekiel 2:6-3:3](#); [3:4-9](#); [4:1-17](#); [5:1-6:14](#); [12:1-28](#); [21:19-23](#); [24:1-14](#); [16-27](#); [37:15-28](#); [Hosea 1:2-9](#); [3:1-3](#); [Matthew 26:26-28](#); [27:45-54](#); [Mark 6:11](#); [11:12-21](#); [Luke 22:17-20](#); [Romans 6:3-5](#); [1 Corinthians 10:16-17](#); [11:23-32](#)

Prophets in 1 Kings

A prophet is a person chosen by God to speak on God's behalf to people. Prophets receive special messages directly from God and then share these messages with others. God's prophets were important in the Old Testament kingdoms of Israel and Judah. They helped with daily needs, challenged kings and priests about their unfaithfulness, and performed many miracles. They shared God's future plans, especially messages of judgment ([1 Kings 11:29-32](#); [17:1](#); [13:1-2](#); [20:42](#); [21:20-23](#); [22:20-22](#)).

Several examples from 1 Kings show the role of prophets:

- The faithful prophet Nathan corrected King David about his sin with Bathsheba ([2 Samuel 12:1-12](#)). Nathan played a key role in stopping Adonijah from stealing David's rule ([1 Kings 1:5-49](#)).
- The prophet Ahijah told Jeroboam that God planned to divide Solomon's kingdom after his death ([1 Kings 11:29-39](#)). Later, God used an unnamed prophet to condemn Jeroboam's false religion and the altar at Bethel ([13:1-10](#)). He also showed the results of disobeying the Lord's command ([13:11-32](#)). Ahijah returned to announce the Lord's judgment against Jeroboam and his descendants ([14:1-16](#)).
- The prophet Jehu announced judgment on King Baasha because he continued to sin like Jeroboam ([1 Kings 16:1-4](#)).
- Much of 1 Kings focuses on the prophet Elijah ([17:1-19:21](#); [21:17-28](#)). He was God's main spokesman during King Ahab's rule (though other prophets were also active; see [20:38-43](#); [22:17-28](#)).

In 1 Kings, the prophets received different reactions from the kings of Israel and Judah. The story shows the importance of listening to God's prophets and the risks of ignoring them. Through the prophets, God tried to stop the disasters that would come from the people's disobedience. Sadly, many kings did not listen to the prophets, leading to the prophesied destruction.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 11:29-39](#); [13:1-32](#); [14:1-16](#); [16:2-4](#); [17:1-18:46](#); [19:1-21](#); [20:35-43](#); [21:17-28](#); [22:10-28](#); [2 Kings 17:13-15](#)

Psalms of Suffering

The four psalms of suffering (Psalms 16, 22, 40, and 69) describe the intense distress experienced by God's servant. They are also called "Passion Psalms."

[Psalm 22](#) uses some of the most powerful language about suffering in the psalms. In this psalm, God's servant suffers even though he is righteous. There is no mention of any sin, so the psalmist's suffering seems completely unfair. Despite being treated very badly, there is no prayer for revenge (see [Psalm 137](#)).

This psalm has important connections to Jesus' death on the cross (for example, [Psalm 22:6-8, 14-18](#)). In fact, Jesus quoted part of [Psalm 22](#) while hanging on the cross ([22:1](#); see [Matthew 27:46](#)). The sinless Christ even prayed for those who killed him ([Luke 23:34](#)).

Other psalms of suffering also became linked with Jesus. [Psalm 16:10](#) anticipates Jesus' victory over death (see [Acts 2:24-31](#)). [Psalm 40:6-8](#) suggests Jesus' selfless, redemptive work ([Hebrews 10:5-10](#)). [Psalm 69](#) speaks of isolation because of commitment to God's cause ([69:8-9](#)). It also predicts the disciple Judas' role in God's work through Christ ([69:25-26](#); see [Psalm 109:8](#); [Isaiah 53:10](#); [Acts 1:20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 16](#); [22](#); [40](#); [69](#); [102](#); [109](#); [Isaiah 42:1-9](#); [52:13-53:12](#); [Matthew 27:46](#); [Luke 23:34](#); [Hebrews 10:5-10](#)

Pure Worship

From the start of God's relationship with Israel, he provided ways for their worship of him to be pleasing to him ([Exodus 20-40](#); [Leviticus 1-8](#)). One of the Lord's main goals for his people is to guarantee they offer him pure worship.

When King Solomon built the temple as a permanent place for worship, he carefully created "a house for the Name of the LORD my God" ([1 Kings 5:3-5](#)). He followed the given design, correctly placed the ark of the covenant in the inner holy place, and offered the temple to the Lord ([8:1-11](#); see [Deuteronomy 16:13-17](#)). Solomon obeyed the law's rules (see, for example, [Exodus 25:10-22](#)). These rules intended to keep Israel's worship focused on the Lord and his commands.

People often worship based on their own desires instead of following God's instructions. Israel was no exception. In his later years, Solomon was unfaithful to the Lord by worshiping other gods ([1 Kings 11:4-8](#)). After Solomon died, Jeroboam created a rival, idol-worshiping religion in the

northern kingdom. He plainly violated God's law ([14:9-10, 15-16](#)).

False worship was common in the northern kingdom throughout its history (for example, [1 Kings 15:26](#); [16:13, 25-26, 30-33](#); [21:25-26](#)). Meanwhile, in the southern kingdom of Judah, local pagan altars were a constant spiritual distraction ([15:14](#); [22:43](#)). Neither Judah nor Israel were faithful in their worship of the Lord.

There is one God, and his people must worship only him ([1 Kings 8:23](#); see [Deuteronomy 5:7, 9](#); [6:4](#); [John 14:6](#); [Acts 4:12](#)). Our worship must come from a pure heart. We must stay completely faithful to the Lord in committed service to him ([1 Kings 15:14](#); [17:1](#); see [Deuteronomy 10:12, 20](#); [Psalm 24:3-4](#); [Matthew 4:10](#); [John 4:24](#)). In our daily and weekly worship of God we should feel his presence, bringing genuine joy ([1 Kings 8:56](#); compare [Psalm 63:1-3](#); [Philippians 4:4](#)).

Israel's temple was a holy place meant to attract all people to worship ([1 Kings 8:41-43](#)). So, Christians, who are the temple of the living God, should live in a way that attracts and motivates others to know the Lord and worship him ([1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [Matthew 5:16](#); [Acts 2:40-47](#); [2 Timothy 4:5](#); [1 Peter 2:12](#)). Our whole lives should include daily worship of Christ, recognizing him as Lord ([1 Peter 3:15](#)). We must not let any idol take God's place in our lives ([1 John 5:21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 8:20](#); [Exodus 4:31](#); [25:10-22](#); [Leviticus 1:1-8:36](#); [Deuteronomy 5:7-9](#); [6:4-9](#); [10:12, 20](#); [16:13-17](#); [26:1-15](#); [1 Kings 5:3-5](#); [Psalms 24:3-6](#); [51:1-19](#); [Hosea 6:6](#); [14:1-2](#); [Micah 6:6-8](#); [Matthew 4:10](#); [5:16](#); [6:1-18](#); [John 4:19-24](#); [5:23](#); [14:6](#); [Acts 2:40-47](#); [Romans 12:1-2](#); [1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [14:1-40](#); [Philippians 3:3](#); [Hebrews 10:1-25](#); [1 Peter 3:15](#); [1 John 5:21](#); [Revelation 5:9-13](#); [15:3](#)

Purim

The Feast of Purim is the only Old Testament feast not established during the time of Moses. Its name comes from a word meaning *lots* or *dice* (Hebrew *purim*, from Akkadian *puru*). In ancient times, people often cast *purim* to see if God approved of an action. A good number meant approval, while a bad number meant disapproval.

Near the king's throne room at Susa in Persia, archaeologists found a small four-sided object with

numbers on each side. A similar die with the word *pur* dates back to the 800s BC. In the book of Esther, Persian astrologers used *purim* to decide the best time to attack the Jews ([Esther 3:7](#)).

On March 7, 473 BC, God saved his people from certain death, similar to the rescue from Egypt during Passover. Mordecai and Esther established an annual celebration to remember God's rescue for future generations ([Esther 9:28](#)). Later in history, Jews widely celebrated the feast (see 2 Maccabees 15:36; Josephus, *Antiquities* 11.6.13; possibly [John 5:1](#)).

When God saved his chosen people, the day intended for the destruction of the Jews became a day of their victory over their enemies. It was followed by celebration. Today, Jewish people fast and pray to remember how Queen Esther fasted before she bravely approached the king. This fast comes right before Purim, which happens on the fourteenth day of the month of Adar (in February or March).

During the joyful holiday of Purim, Jews read the story of Esther, loudly booing Haman and cheering for Mordecai. They enjoy special meals, exchange food gifts with friends, and give to people in need. Purim celebrates how God protected the Jewish people from harm and shows how God continues to watch over and care for his people throughout history (see also [Genesis 45:5](#); [Psalm 91](#); [Proverbs 16:9, 33](#); [Daniel 2:21](#); [Acts 1:6–7](#); [2:22–23](#); [4:28–30](#); [17:24–27](#); [Romans 8:28](#); [1 Peter 3:12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Esther 9:1–32](#); [Psalms 37:23](#); [91:1–16](#); [Proverbs 16:9, 33](#); [Romans 8:28](#); [1 Peter 3:12](#)

Purity and Identity

God is holy, and he made a covenant (special agreement) with Israel to establish a holy nation ([Exodus 19:4–6](#); [Leviticus 19:2](#)). Being God's people meant Israel needed to be pure in worship and social relationships. God knew that if his people became part of the culture of their pagan neighbors, they would adopt evil worship practices (see [Numbers 25:1–9](#)). Their failure to stay pure and their blending with these cultures eventually led to their destruction and exile ([2 Kings 17:5–23](#)).

When the priest and scribe Ezra wrote to the Jews who had returned to Jerusalem, he intended to remind them to remain pure to their beliefs and

commitments. After arriving in Jerusalem, Ezra discovered that the people had married pagan foreigners, which was against God's law (see [Deuteronomy 7:3–4](#); [Joshua 23:12–13](#)). This threatened their identity as God's holy nation ([Ezra 9:1–2](#)).

The book of Ezra emphasizes the need to separate from foreigners. It recounts how those who first returned to Jerusalem refused to cooperate with the pagan people around them ([Ezra 4:1–5](#)). These people claimed to worship the same God but actually worshiped several gods in addition to the Lord. If the Jews had joined them, they would have compromised their beliefs and become ungodly, as Israel had before the exile to Babylon (see [Exodus 34:15–16](#); [1 Kings 11:1–5](#); [2 Kings 16:3](#)).

The early Jewish leaders in Judea understood the danger of tolerating these foreigners. They learned from their ancestors' experiences and refused to compromise the purity of their faith for the sake of so-called peace. They carefully followed God's instructions in everything they did ([Ezra 3:2, 9; 6:18](#)). To identify as "servants of the God of heaven and earth," they needed to please and serve him alone ([5:11](#)).

Today, Christians are God's holy people ([1 Peter 2:9](#)). This is a title that indicates purity. The apostle Paul advised the Corinthians not to marry non-Christians, as Christ and Satan have nothing "in common" ([2 Corinthians 6:14–15](#)). Righteousness and unrighteousness do not mix. God's people must avoid behavior that corrupts. Instead, they must adopt attitudes and actions that match their holy status ([Colossians 3:5–15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 27:46–28:5](#); [Exodus 19:4–6](#); [34:15–16](#); [Leviticus 19:2](#); [Deuteronomy 7:3–4](#); [Joshua 23:12–13](#); [1 Kings 11:1–5](#); [Ezra 4:1–5](#); [5:11](#); [9:1–10:11](#); [Malachi 2:15](#); [1 Corinthians 6:15–20](#); [2 Corinthians 6:14–18](#); [2 Timothy 2:21–22](#); [1 Peter 2:9–10](#)

Questions and Doubt

The writers of the psalms (called "psalmists") are not afraid to ask questions and express their doubts. The number of questions in a psalm shows how intense the mood is or how important the issue is. The psalms with the most questions address key issues like when God seems to abandon his people and why evil people are

successful ([Psalm 13](#); [Psalms 42-43](#); [74](#); [89](#); [Psalm 73](#)).

The writers of the psalms ask questions that help clarify problems in life. Some questions ask if the Lord is the true God ([Psalm 94:9-10](#)). Some ask why he seems to have abandoned godly people ([77:7](#)).

Other questions in the psalms emphasize:

- the success of evil people ([10:13](#));
- the weakness of godly people ([11:3](#));
- God's choice of Zion ([68:16](#));
- God's power ([114:5-6](#); [147:17](#));
- the foolishness of the nations ([2:1](#)); and
- the problem of injustice ([82:2](#)).

The psalmists question, examine, challenge, doubt, and sometimes despair over God's seeming lack of concern.

The questions of the psalmists can lead to praise and worship: "Who can describe the mighty acts of the LORD or fully proclaim His praise?" ([Psalm 106:2](#)). For many questions, the answer brings praise to the Lord: "Whom have I in heaven but You? And on earth I desire no one besides You" ([73:25](#); see also [89:8](#)). Questions may also express amazement at God's grace ([8:4](#); [130:3](#); [144:3](#)).

Asking good questions can be the beginning of a conversation with the Lord. This conversation can lead us along the path of wisdom and result in worship and praise.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 2:1](#); [4:2](#); [6:3](#); [10:1](#); [11:3](#); [13:1-6](#); [22:1](#); [35:17](#); [42:1-11](#); [43:1-5](#); [44:23-24](#); [53:6](#); [60:9-10](#); [68:16](#); [73:1-74:23](#); [77:8-9](#); [79:5](#); [80:4](#), [12](#); [82:2](#); [83:2](#); [85:5-6](#); [88:14](#); [89:1-52](#); [90:11](#), [13](#); [94:3-4](#), [16](#), [20](#); [101:2](#); [108:10-11](#); [114:5-6](#); [119:82](#), [84](#); [137:4](#); [147:17](#)

Rebuilding of Jerusalem

The wall of Jerusalem held great political, social, and religious importance for the people of Judah (see [Nehemiah 2:10](#), [19](#); [4:1-15](#); [6:1-14](#)). In ancient and even modern times, a city without walls cannot last long. Walls protected cities from invading armies and common criminals.

By Nehemiah's time, Jerusalem's walls had been in ruins for over a hundred years, since the city's destruction in 586 BC. The ruined wall was a shameful reminder that God had punished the city, fulfilling the covenant curses due to the people's sins ([Nehemiah 1:2-7](#); [2:17](#)). Rebuilding the wall would show God's blessing and prove that he was restoring the covenant people. Israel's enemies knew that if they rebuilt the wall, the Jews would gain political power, security, and self-rule. Therefore, they strongly opposed the rebuilding.

Under Nehemiah's leadership, the people of Judea rebuilt the entire wall in just fifty-two days during the fall of 445 BC. This quick and successful reconstruction can encourage Christians that with God's help, they can achieve remarkable things (see [Nehemiah 2:18](#); [4:14-15](#), [20](#); [6:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Nehemiah 1:2-4](#); [2:10-20](#); [3:1-32](#); [4:1-23](#); [6:1-16](#); [Psalm 51:16-18](#); [Isaiah 22:5](#); [26:1-3](#); [Revelation 21:10-27](#)

Religious Hypocrisy

Religious hypocrisy happens when people selectively obey rules and only pretend to follow God's law without real change in their motives and lives. Those who boast about their religious commitment often lack a true desire to obey God.

The prophet Isaiah preached to people who seemed to be very religious. They fasted, prayed, celebrated holy days, and brought sacrifices to Jerusalem. Yet God rejected these practices.

Why? These acts had value because the Lord himself had prescribed them! But the people's worship was not sincere. It lacked the personal holiness and social justice that God requires (see, for example, [Leviticus 19:13-17](#)). The people of Judah had become religious hypocrites.

Many years after Isaiah, Jesus addressed the hypocrisy of the Pharisees. He urged them to obey all of what God had revealed, not just the parts that made them popular ([Matthew 23:1-36](#), especially [Matthew 23:23](#)). The apostles Paul and James also emphasized the difference between performing religious acts and having true spirituality ([1 Corinthians 3:1-23](#); [James 1:21-2:13](#)).

Jesus' criticism of the Pharisees also warns us. We should not imitate them (see [Matthew 6:1-18](#); [1 Peter 2:1](#)). Instead, Jesus tells us to be genuine with

God and others and obey all his commands. In our worship of God, we must go farther than religion forms with a focus on outward actions.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 50:16-23](#); [Proverbs 15:8](#); [26:23](#); [Isaiah 1:11-15](#); [29:13-15](#); [58:2-7](#); [Jeremiah 7:4-10](#); [12:2](#); [Ezekiel 33:30-31](#); [Hosea 8:13](#); [Amos 5:21-24](#); [Micah 3:11](#); [Zechariah 7:5-6](#); [Malachi 2:13-14](#); [Matthew 6:1-18](#); [23:1-36](#); [Titus 1:15-16](#); [James 1:21-27](#); [1 Peter 2:1](#); [1 John 2:4](#), [9](#); [4:20](#)

Remaining in Christ

The Greek term *menō*, often translated as “remain,” “stay,” or “abide,” appears often in Jesus’ teachings about deep, intimate, and lasting relationships. For example, Jesus said, “If you continue in [*menō en*, ‘stay in’] My word, you are truly My disciples” ([John 8:31](#)). This means the life of a follower of Jesus (a disciple) is fully shaped by Jesus’ message.

Jesus also explained how the Son is in the Father and the Father is in the Son ([John 14:10-11](#)). In a similar way, when we remain in Jesus, the Son is in us, and we are in the Father and the Son ([17:21-23](#)). Both the Father and the Son come and make their “home” within disciples.

This mutual “living inside” shows what it means for a disciple to remain in Jesus. We cannot make our relationship permanent by ourselves. Only God’s gracious action through his Holy Spirit makes the relationship lasting. Both God and the disciple must commit. The connection between God and the disciple is not temporary. It is a lasting and eternal relationship (see [1 John 2:14](#), [17](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 33:11](#); [34:28](#); [Joshua 7:11-12](#); [1 Samuel 16:22](#); [Psalms 22:11](#), [19](#); [101:7](#); [Daniel 1:21](#); [2:49](#); [Haggai 2:5](#); [Luke 15:31](#); [22:28](#); [John 6:56](#); [8:31](#); [15:1-17](#); [Philippians 4:1](#); [1 John 2:19](#), [27-28](#); [3:24](#); [2 John 1:9](#); [Revelation 2:10](#); [13:10](#)

Remember Him

God saved the Israelites from slavery in Egypt and made them his people. Yet, God knew they would forget him ([Deuteronomy 31:16-21](#)). Moses warned the people entering the promised land to always remember what the Lord had done for them ([Deuteronomy 8:1-20](#)). The Israelites eventually

forgot the Lord, which led to their exile from the land God had given them (see [2 Kings 17:5-23](#); see also [Jeremiah 2:32](#)).

The Teacher in the book of Ecclesiastes emphasizes the importance of remembering the Lord. Throughout the book, the Teacher reflects on how many aspects of life are temporary and useless or meaningless. He concludes by urging readers to remember the one who is eternal ([Ecclesiastes 12:1-7](#)). No one stays young forever, aging and death are universal.

Therefore, the Teacher encourages people to focus on God while they are young, before it is too late. All people are accountable to God for their actions ([Ecclesiastes 12:13-14](#)). Our present lives should be guided by the reality of his future judgment.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 8:1-20](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:1-7](#), [13-14](#); [1 Corinthians 3:12-14](#)

Remove the Evil

Sin is so opposed to God’s holiness that it cannot exist with him. The same should be true for God’s people. God is holy, and he expects his people to show his holiness ([Leviticus 11:45](#); [19:2](#)).

God required severe responses to remove sin from the covenant community. God offered forgiveness, but only to those who were truly repentant. Those who became stubborn could expect God’s judgment. This judgment was a cleansing process that consumed sinners and their sins, leaving nothing behind (see [Deuteronomy 9:3](#); [13:5](#); [Isaiah 33:14](#); [Hebrews 12:28-29](#)). This cleansing is meant to heal the community of believers in the Lord and discourage others from rebelling against him ([Deuteronomy 17:13](#)).

In the Old Testament, God often judged his people immediately (see, for example, [Numbers 11:1-3](#); [16:1-50](#); [Joshua 7](#)). This made his people very aware of his demand for obedience and the consequences of disobedience.

God’s final punishment is set for the future day of justice when he will reveal and judge the sins of all people ([Romans 14:10](#); [2 Corinthians 5:10](#); [Hebrews 9:27](#); [1 Peter 4:5](#)). Yet, some disasters can be seen as God’s judgment on his disobedient people (for example, [Acts 5:1-11](#); see [1 Corinthians 11:27-30](#)). It is still “a fearful thing to fall into the hands of the living God” ([Hebrews 10:31](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 19:1-2](#); [Deuteronomy 9:3-6](#); [13:5](#); [17:2-13](#); [Joshua 7:1-26](#); [2 Chronicles 34:3-8](#); [Isaiah 1:24-26](#); [4:2-6](#); [33:14](#); [Ezekiel 20:32-38](#); [Matthew 18:8-9](#); [Acts 5:1-11](#); [Romans 14:10](#); [1 Corinthians 11:27-30](#); [2 Corinthians 5:10](#); [Hebrews 9:27-28](#); [10:31](#); [12:28-29](#); [James 5:19-20](#); [1 Peter 4:5](#)

Resurrection in the Old Testament

Many Old Testament passages suggest that the place where dead people are is a location from which people do not return (see, for example, [Job 7:6-21](#); [Psalm 6:5](#); [Isaiah 38:18-19](#)). Yet, some passages suggest the idea of that people can live again after death (see, for example, [Job 19:25-27](#); [Psalm 16:10-11](#); [Isaiah 26:19](#)). [Daniel 12:1-3](#) teaches that God will bring the dead back to life. God told the prophet Daniel that he would be part of this resurrection ([12:13](#)). Belief in the resurrection of the dead became more common during the period between the Old and New Testament writings. This was shown by the popularity of the idea during the time of Jesus.

According to this passage from Daniel, the resurrection will be different for people.

Two groups will resurrect:

91. Those who will experience new life.
92. Those who will experience shame.

These groups have different beliefs about right and wrong, different standards for behavior, and different ways of following God. The resurrection will reveal a person's true nature. Everyone will be accountable to God Most High in a moral and spiritual way.

The first group will have a new life called "everlasting life." In the Old Testament, this phrase appears only in [Daniel 12:2](#). Here it seems to refer more to the quality of life than its length. God will cleanse and purify those who experience this life. The similes "shine like the brightness of the heavens" and "shine like the stars forever and ever" describe their moral glory.

The second group will encounter everlasting shame and disgrace because they are not morally or spiritually renewed. The New Testament book of Revelation expands on these two groups from Daniel's vision (see [Revelation 20:4-6](#), [11-15](#)).

God's people will finally escape death. Those resurrected to life have their names written in the Book of Life (see [Daniel 7:9-10](#); [10:21](#); [Revelation 20:12](#)). The Judge, known as the Ancient One, declares them righteous.

Passages for Further Study

[Job 19:25-27](#); [Daniel 12:1-3](#), [13](#); [Matthew 27:50-53](#); [28:1-20](#); [1 Corinthians 15:1-58](#); [Revelation 20:1-15](#)

Retribution

God gave humans the task of having children and taking care of the world ([Genesis 1:28](#)). Yet, as the population increased, so did spiritual evil, violence, and murder ([4:8](#), [23](#); [6:5](#), [11-13](#)). This led to a corrupt world that required cleansing.

The purpose of the great flood during the time of Noah was to cleanse the world and retribution against those who did wrong. *Retribution* means "giving what is due" and usually refers to a penalty for bad actions. Retribution comes from the belief that the world has a moral order, which must be maintained or restored (see [Psalm 7:14-16](#); [Proverbs 11:17-21](#); [26:27](#)).

God keeps moral order by giving justice, punishing evil actions, and rewarding good behavior ([Galatians 6:7-8](#)). Since God oversees the world, it never becomes totally overcome by moral disorder. People are accountable to God for their actions.

Some examples of God's justice are:

- The judgment and exile of Adam and Eve from the garden of Eden ([Genesis 3:8-24](#));
- Cain's punishment for killing his brother Abel ([4:10-15](#)); and
- The worldwide flood ([chapters 6-7](#)).

These events show a God who rules over everything and gives fair punishment as part of his good plans for the world (see also [Numbers 16](#); [Deuteronomy 30:15-20](#); [Joshua 7](#); [Micah 2:1-3](#)).

Retribution is one way God shows his righteousness. It cleanses the world for his kingdom of peace. Through retribution, God announces his rule over all and exercises justice against those who reject his rule or defy his commands ([Deuteronomy 7:10](#); [Psalm 149](#);

[Proverbs 15:25](#); [Micah 5:15](#); [1 Corinthians 16:22](#); [Galatians 1:8-9](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:5-10](#)).

For God's people, retribution acts as his discipline. It intends to restore their covenant relationship with him (see [Isaiah 44:22](#); [Jeremiah 3:12-14](#); [Lamentations 3:19-33](#); [Hosea 14:1-2](#); [Joel 2:12-13](#); see also [Hebrews 12:5-11](#)). When God's people experience his discipline, they can respond with hope because God's truth and righteousness will win ([Psalm 58:10-11](#)). God will redeem and restore those who trust in him ([Leviticus 26:40-45](#); [Hosea 2:2-23](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 6:1-7:24](#); [Leviticus 26:14-39](#); [Psalms 7:6-17](#); [57:6](#); [95:8-11](#); [Proverbs 6:27-35](#); [26:27](#); [Micah 2:1-3](#); [Romans 2:5-16](#); [Galatians 6:7-8](#); [Hebrews 10:26-31](#); [12:5-11](#), [25-29](#)

Returning to the Lord

The Old Testament prophets often told the people of Israel to return to the Lord, both before and after the exile to Babylon (see, for example, [Isaiah 55:6-7](#); [Hosea 6:1-3](#); [Haggai 1:12](#); [Malachi 3:7](#)). This meant a renewed commitment to obey God. They had abandoned the true God and started worshiping other gods, which led to his judgment. This judgment resulted in the destruction of the temple and their exile. The future restoration and blessing of God's people depended on their obedience to him.

The prophet Zechariah's main message to those returning to Jerusalem from exile is plain in his opening statement: "Return to Me, declares the LORD of Hosts, and I will return to you, says the LORD of Hosts" ([Zechariah 1:3](#)). Zechariah urged the people of Israel to renew their commitment to their special agreement with God (the covenant). He warned them to learn from their ancestors who were unfaithful to the covenant. This had severe consequences ([7:11-14](#)).

Zechariah cared about Israel's covenant with God and social justice. Returning to the Lord leads to obedience and practicing justice, honesty, fairness, mercy, and kindness ([Zechariah 7:9-10](#); [8:16-17](#)). Zechariah's focus on right relationships with God and others anticipated Jesus' teaching. He said the greatest commandments are to love God above everything and to love your neighbor as yourself ([Matthew 22:34-40](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 7:2-11](#); [Isaiah 1:16-20](#); [55:7](#); [Hosea 6:1-3](#); [14:1-7](#); [Haggai 1:12](#); [Zechariah 1:3](#); [7:9-14](#); [8:16-17](#); [Malachi 3:7](#); [Matthew 3:2-10](#); [22:34-40](#); [Acts 17:24-31](#)

Rich and Poor in the Gospel of Luke

In Luke's Gospel, entering or becoming excluded from the kingdom of God involves a reversal of worldly wealth. Mary, the mother of Jesus, proclaimed that God would elevate the poor and humble while humbling the rich and powerful ([Luke 1:52-53](#)). Jesus declared in Nazareth that the gospel is "good news to the poor" ([4:18](#)). He blessed the poor and hungry and warned the rich and satisfied ([6:20-26](#)). This challenged the common belief that God blessed rich people and cursed poor people.

Several of Jesus' parables strongly warn about the danger of wealth. The parable of the rich fool shows what happens when someone stores up treasures on earth instead of building a strong relationship with God ([Luke 12:13-21](#)). The parable of the rich man and Lazarus illustrates the eternal consequences of ignoring the poor and helpless while enjoying life's comforts ([16:19-31](#)). The rich man who asked Jesus how to gain eternal life felt devastated when Jesus told him to sell all he had and give to the poor ([18:18-23](#)).

Who are the poor in Luke's Gospel? Are they physically poor people or those poor in spirit (compare [Matthew 5:3](#))? It is probably both. The physically poor, who have very little, naturally depend on God for their needs. Rich and powerful people often rely on themselves, forgetting their need for God. Rich people cannot enter God's kingdom if they trust in their wealth to get them there ([16:25-26](#)). God accepts those who trust only in him.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 5:3](#); [Luke 1:52-53](#); [4:18](#); [6:20-25](#); [12:13-34](#); [14:12-23](#); [16:19-31](#); [18:18-30](#)

Righteousness by Faith

A key question in the early church was whether gentiles (non-Jewish people) who accepted the good news about Jesus needed to follow Jewish

rules (including circumcision) to become part of God's family.

For the apostle Paul, the answer was simple. People cannot make themselves right with God by their own efforts. Only Jesus could accomplish (and has accomplished) what was necessary for reconciliation with God. Salvation is a gift of God's grace received through faith. Our response is to trust in Christ, give thanks for what he has done, and live in a way that reflects his love and truth.

For Jewish Christians in the first century, it was hard to accept this answer. From the time of Abraham, right relationship with God had been marked by circumcision, the ceremony of cutting off the male foreskin ([Genesis 17:9-14](#)). Every male who was part of God's family had to be circumcised, and those who neglected to do so were cut off from God's people. Those who had received circumcision were also expected to keep the rest of the law, including the Sabbath and dietary rules about food.

When Christianity spread from Jews to non-Jews, it was natural for questions to arise. Do Christians need to be circumcised (and keep God's law in general) to be accepted as part of God's family? Or does God accept people because of their faith in Christ's work on the cross? As Paul's mission to gentiles advanced, these questions became urgent.

The apostle Peter understood from his vision in Joppa and his experience in Caesarea that God had accepted gentiles *as gentiles*, because of their faith in Christ's finished work ([Acts 10:9-11:18](#)). They did not have to become Jewish by practicing circumcision or the ceremonial laws. Christ provided them open access to God by faith. Peter and the Jerusalem church therefore welcomed gentile believers into fellowship. But later, Peter temporarily stopped eating with gentiles when some Jewish Christians criticized him ([Galatians 2:11-13](#)). In response, Paul rebuked Peter for suggesting that gentiles must become Jews in order to be accepted by God ([2:14-21](#)).

No one is made right with God by keeping the law ([Galatians 2:16](#)). Even Abraham was counted as righteous because of his faith ([Genesis 15:6](#); [Galatians 3:6](#); [James 2:21-24](#)). It was not because of circumcision, which came later ([Genesis 17:9-14](#)). Both Jews and gentiles are brought into right relationship with God through faith, which is a response to his grace.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:6](#); [Habakkuk 2:4](#); [Acts 10:1-11:18](#); [Romans 1:17](#); [Galatians 2:14-21](#); [Galatians 3:11](#); [Hebrews 10:38](#)

Royal Psalms

The *royal psalms* all mention the king, his rule, and his relationship with God. Most scholars consider [Psalms 2, 18, 20, 21, 45, 61, 72, 89, 101, 110, 132, and 144](#) as royal psalms.

Belief in God's rule is the foundation of the royal psalms (see [Psalm 2](#)). Each king in David's family line (King David's dynasty) acted as a messianic agent. This means they represented God's rule. As God's representative, kings descended from David had the obligation to practice justice, righteousness, faithfulness, and peace ([Psalm 72:1-3](#)).

The royal psalms express the hopes and dreams of King David's dynasty. Because of its corruption and failure, the dynasty seemed to come to an end ([Psalm 89:38-45](#)). Yet, hope continued for a future king from David's family line to serve as God's Christ. The royal psalms keep this hope alive for a king whose perfect obedience would guarantee the dynasty's continuation and the lasting benefits of his rule.

In this sense, one could also call the royal psalms *messianic psalms*. This is because they express hope in a Christ figure, the ideal king descended from David. Jesus stated that the writers of the psalms wrote about him ([Luke 24:44](#)). Other New Testament writers confirm that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen one).

Some of the most important connections to Christ are as follows:

- [Psalm 2](#) is associated with Israel's king, the descendant of David. Yet, it describes a global victory and rule that surpasses the time of David or Solomon's rule (see [Acts 13:33](#); [Hebrews 1:5](#); [5:5](#)).
- [Psalm 45](#) is a wedding song for a king descended from David, maybe Solomon. It also mentions a lasting rule ([45:6](#)).
- [Psalm 110](#) is the most quoted messianic psalm in the New Testament about Christ (see [Matthew 22:43-45](#); [Acts 2:34-35](#); [Hebrews 1:13](#); [5:5-10](#); [6:20](#); [7:21](#)). This psalm contains several key prophetic elements that were later understood as references to the Messiah. It describes the privileges, universal victory, and continual royal priesthood of David and his successors.

This language might seem exaggerated or misleading, except that it finds fulfillment in Jesus. The angels stand in God's presence (see [Luke 1:19](#)). But Christ the Son sits in a position of power and authority over everything at God's "right hand" ([Hebrews 1:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 2](#); [18](#); [20](#); [21](#); [45](#); [61](#); [72](#); [89](#); [101](#); [110](#); [132](#); [144](#); [Acts 2:34-35](#); [13:33](#); [Hebrews 1:5](#), [13](#); [5:5-10](#)

Salvation in Isaiah

The prophet Isaiah's name means *Yahweh is salvation*. He urges people to turn from false saviors to God who is the only true savior and protector. Salvation affects all parts of life, including physical and spiritual aspects. For example, the word *salvation* sometimes appears in the book of Isaiah with *righteousness* to show a peaceful order where injustice, disgrace, and mourning do not exist ([Isaiah 45:8](#); [51:8](#)).

Isaiah often shares the gospel (the good news about Jesus) that the Lord will come to help his people (for example, [4:2-6](#); [10:24-34](#); [40:9-11](#)). Although God promised punishment and exile because of the wrongdoing of the Israelites, the

Lord would not abandon them. Instead, he would save them. Babylon's power and the suffering and shame of the exile would end. Chapters [1-39](#) prophesy this message, while chapters [40-66](#) explain it plainly.

Isaiah talks about the salvation God would bring through Jesus Christ. He prophesies "a Branch" from King David's family line who would have the Holy Spirit and bring justice and righteousness ([11:1-5](#)). He also mentions God's servant who would suffer for the people's sins ([52:13-53:12](#)). Jesus fulfilled Isaiah's prophecies and saved humanity from sin and death.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 27:1](#); [Isaiah 49:8](#); [Isaiah 59:15-21](#); [Isaiah 61:1-3](#); [Luke 4:18-21](#); [John 3:16-17](#); [John 12:47](#); [Romans 10:9-13](#); [2 Corinthians 5:18-21](#); [Titus 2:11-13](#); [Hebrews 9:27-28](#); [1 Peter 3:18-21](#); [Revelation 7:9-10](#)

Salvation in the Psalms

The writers of the psalms (called psalmists) considered God's salvation as a rescue from evil in the world. They had suffered a lot. During difficult times, they felt God had abandoned them. Meanwhile, evil people used this supposed injustice to mock godly people ([Psalm 3:2](#); [71:10-11](#)).

The psalmists called out for help, knowing they relied entirely on the Lord ([31:15](#); [35:17](#); [69:13](#)). While waiting for help, they trusted that the Lord was present, watching over them ([Psalms 46](#), [121](#)). He would not abandon them ([16:10](#); [94:14](#); see also [7:10](#); [31:2](#); [62:6-7](#); [144:2](#)).

God graciously rescues his needy servants and answers their prayers ([20:6](#); [28:8](#); [34:6](#), [18](#); [40:1-2](#); [76:9](#); [107](#); [145:19](#); [149:4](#)). When the Lord rescues his people, he gains glory when they thank, praise, and witness of him ([50:15](#); [79:9](#); [85:9](#)). The Bible records God's mighty acts. This is so that his people will praise him for what he has done and trust him to rescue them.

The psalms encourage Christians to relate to these stories of salvation. For example, in [Psalm 18](#), the psalmist talks about his distress, his cries, and the Lord's rescue ([18:17](#), [19](#), [20](#), [43](#), [48](#)). This invites all humble people to hope in the Lord (see [72:12](#)). The Lord has saved his people throughout history and will do so again.

Salvation does not include evil people ([69:27](#); [119:155](#)). Evil people mock those who trust in the Lord's rescue ([22:8](#)). Evil people might cry for help to the Lord during judgment, but he will not save them ([18:27](#); [50:22](#)). Hoping for God's salvation requires living by trust and love for the Lord ([119:123](#); [60:5](#); [108:6](#)). This kind of faith removes fear, knowing that the Lord acts righteously ([34:4](#); [71:2](#)).

The Lord Jesus came to save sinners. He helped those in need and on the edges of society. He provided physical relief to many. He died under oppression to bring spiritual freedom to the world. He saves people from themselves, from Satan, from death, and from difficulty.

He has the power to support the faithful, judge sinners, and fully save all of God's children. He will renew everything while excluding evil people from his eternal salvation.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 3:7-8](#); [6:4](#); [7:10](#); [14:7](#); [16:9-11](#); [17:7](#); [18:1-50](#); [20:6](#); [22:4-5](#); [25:4-14](#); [27:1](#); [31:1-2](#); [15-16](#); [32:1-5](#); [33:18-19](#); [34:6-7](#); [17-19](#); [40:16-17](#); [43:5](#); [46:1-11](#); [62:1-8](#); [70:4-5](#); [72:12-14](#); [80:1-19](#); [91:1-16](#); [98:1-3](#); [107:1-43](#); [121:1-8](#); [149:4](#)

Security and Obedience

The Book of Life is a divine record that contains the names of those who belong to God and will receive eternal life ([Revelation 20:12](#)). The idea of removing a name from the Book of Life may raise questions about whether salvation can be lost ([Revelation 3:5](#)). Does not the New Testament tell believers that their salvation is secure?

The New Testament offers many words of comfort (for example, [John 10:27-30](#); [1 Corinthians 10:13](#); [Hebrews 6:18-20](#)). But it also gives strong warnings (for example, [John 15:6](#); [1 Corinthians 10:6-12](#); [Hebrews 6:4-8](#); [Revelation 2:4-5](#); [3:11](#)). We often dislike and avoid these warnings because they make us feel less secure. Yet, this concern for security is exactly why the New Testament writers gave these warnings. They emphasized the need for obedience, faithfulness, and endurance.

This call to obedience was not new. God repeatedly called the people of Israel to be faithful (for example, [Genesis 12:1-2](#); [15:1-18](#); [22:16-18](#); [28:13-14](#); [1 Samuel 12:19-25](#); [15:10-11](#); [28:16-19](#); [2 Samuel 7:11-16](#); [1 Kings 9:4-9](#)). All of God's

promises and prophecies depend on faithfulness and obedience (see especially [Jeremiah 18:7-10](#)). The apostle Paul understood that Israel's disobedience led to some being "broken off" from God's people ([Romans 11:17](#)). He warned non-Jewish (gentile) Christians not to be overconfident of their position ([Romans 11:13-32](#)). God's promise remains the same, but human disobedience leads to judgment. True security comes from humble obedience and reliance on God.

During New Testament times, being a Christian was difficult and dangerous. The book of Revelation offers hope for Christians, even when threatened by death. This hope comes with warnings about judgment ([Revelation 21:8](#); [27:22:15](#)). The call to faithfulness and obedience are major themes in Revelation (see [2:5](#); [10-11](#); [16-17](#); [26-29](#); [3:2](#); [12](#); [17-19](#); [21-22](#); [7:14](#); [13:9-10](#); [12](#); [16:15](#); [18:4](#); [20:12](#); [21:7](#); [22:3](#); [7](#); [11-12](#)). The New Testament affirms that with God's help, faithful Christians will persevere to the end (see [Hebrews 13:6](#); [James 1:25](#); [Revelation 3:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 15:1](#); [13-16](#); [1 Samuel 12:22-25](#); [1 Kings 9:4-9](#); [Jeremiah 18:7-10](#); [John 10:27-30](#); [15:6](#); [Romans 11:13-32](#); [1 Corinthians 10:6-12](#); [Hebrews 6:4-8](#); [18-20](#); [13:6](#); [James 1:25](#); [Revelation 2:5](#); [10-11](#); [16-17](#); [3:5](#); [10-12](#); [18:4](#); [20:12](#); [21:7-8](#); [22:11-12](#)

Seeking the Lord

As Israel was about to enter the promised land, Moses instructed the people to "seek the place the LORD your God will choose from among all your tribes" ([Deuteronomy 12:5](#)). Moses told the Israelites to stop pagan worship practices and focus on worshipping God. In the wilderness, they built the tabernacle where God would show his presence and where the people would worship him. Once settled in the promised land, Moses told them to build a permanent holy place.

During the time of the judges, the people of Israel often worshipped the gods of nearby nations instead of the one true God. When the kingdom began, there was hope that the whole nation would unite in worshipping God. Yet, the first king, Saul, lost the kingdom and his life partly because "he consulted a medium for guidance" instead of the Lord ([1 Chronicles 10:13-14](#)). Many kings in Israel's history followed Saul's example of

disobedience and led the nation into pagan religious practices.

King David, in contrast, was "a man after His own heart" ([1 Samuel 13:14](#)). As king, one of David's main goals was to restore the importance of the ark of the covenant. The Israelites had ignored it during Saul's time ([1 Chronicles 13:3](#)).

David failed in his first attempt to bring the ark to Jerusalem. This was because he and the Levites did not ask for the Lord's guidance on how to transport it ([13:1-14](#); [15:13](#)). David later succeeded in bringing the ark to Jerusalem ([15:1-16:1](#)).

The holy place and worship in Jerusalem were essential for seeking the Lord. After placing the ark in its tent in Jerusalem, David created a new role for the Levites as music ministers ([1 Chronicles 16:4-6](#)). David often urged leaders to "seek the Lord your God" while building the temple ([22:19](#); compare [28:8-10](#)).

King Solomon's first action to strengthen the kingdom was to gather all the leaders at the altar in Gibeon to seek the Lord ([2 Chronicles 1:1-6](#)). The Lord met Solomon there and gave him unmatched wisdom and wealth. Later, Solomon finished the temple and established it as a place to seek the Lord ([2 Chronicles 6](#)).

Isaiah the prophet encouraged people waiting for God's promises to seek him. "Seek the LORD while He may be found; call on Him while He is near" ([Isaiah 55:6](#)). God's covenant and promise are certain, and they are for those who seek the Lord ([55:3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Chronicles 10:13-14](#); [13:3](#); [16:11-13](#); [22:19](#); [28:8-10](#); [2 Chronicles 6:19-40](#); [7:14](#); [Psalms 27:4-8](#); [105:4-6](#); [Isaiah 55:6-7](#); [Jeremiah 29:13-14](#); [Matthew 6:31-33](#); [Romans 2:7](#)

Shechem

Shechem was in an important location at the entrance to the passage between Mount Ebal and Mount Gerizim. It could control several important roads through the central hill country. Jacob bought land near Shechem ([Genesis 33:18-19](#)).

While there, the local prince named Shechem raped Jacob's daughter, Dinah. In response, Dinah's brothers, Simeon and Levi, killed all the men in the area ([Genesis 34](#)). Later, Shechem became part of

Joseph's inheritance ([Joshua 24:32](#)). It was also one of the special cities where people could go to find protection if they accidentally killed someone (see [Deuteronomy 19:1-13](#); [Joshua 20:7](#)).

During the time of the judges, Gideon's son Abimelech ruled from Shechem ([Judges 9](#)). King Solomon later strengthened Shechem as a provincial capital. But Shishak of Egypt probably destroyed it when he invaded Israel in 926 BC (see [1 Kings 14:25](#)). Jeroboam I then rebuilt the city and made it the capital of the kingdom of Israel ([1 Kings 12:25](#)). The Assyrian king Shalmaneser V destroyed Shechem again in 724 BC. This was shortly before Samaria's destruction. The ruins remained mostly uninhabited for about four hundred years.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 33:18-19](#); [Joshua 8:30-35](#); [20:7](#); [24:1-32](#); [Judges 9:1-56](#); [1 Kings 12:1, 25](#); [John 4:5](#)

Sin Enters the World

[Genesis 3](#) explains how humans lost their moral innocence by rebelling against God. What God called "very good" was no longer perfect ([Genesis 1:31](#)). The man and woman ate the fruit that promised knowledge of good and evil, disobeying God's command ([2:16-17](#)). They tried to become like God (see [3:5](#)). By doing this, they gave up their sinless state. They became separated from God, each other, and creation. They also experienced death.

As a result, all humans are "fallen," meaning they are born into a corrupt world that causes a tendency to sin ([Genesis 8:21](#); [Job 4:17-21](#); [Psalms 51:5](#); [103:10](#); [143:2](#); [Proverbs 20:9](#)). All humans also now experience death. When the first man and woman disobeyed God by eating the fruit, they lost their innocence. Their descendants and the entire human race now inherit a cursed world ([Romans 5:12-14](#); [1 Corinthians 15:21-22](#), [45-49](#)).

The term "original sin" describes how the effects of the first sin of Adam and Eve have spread into individual lives and society because of human rebellion. As people submit to their tendency to sin, they become accountable for their own actions ([Ecclesiastes 7:20](#); [Romans 3:23](#)).

The first man, Adam, brought sin into the world, but the "second Adam," Jesus Christ, is the solution to sin ([1 Corinthians 15:3](#); [2 Corinthians 5:21](#)).

When Christ died as redeemer, he offered God's salvation from sin to everyone ([John 3:16](#); [Romans 1:16](#))

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 3:1-19](#); [8:21](#); [Exodus 34:7](#); [Job 4:17-21](#); [Psalm 51:5](#); [Proverbs 22:15](#); [Ezekiel 36:16-36](#); [John 8:1-11](#); [Romans 1:18-3:20](#); [5:12-21](#); [1 Corinthians 15:21-22](#); [Galatians 3:22](#); [5:17-24](#); [Ephesians 2:1-10](#); [1 John 3:14](#)

Slavery

Slavery was common in the Roman world. Prisoners of war often became slaves, many were born into slavery, and some chose slavery temporarily to pay off debts. A large part of the population, including many Christians, were slaves or former slaves (see [Acts 6:9](#)). So, why did the apostle Paul not speak against slavery?

There are two reasons. First, slavery in the Roman world was different from the slavery familiar to the modern western world. It was not based on race and was rarely lifelong. Most slaves expected freedom by age thirty. Some people even sold themselves into slavery to increase social status. Some slaves were well-educated and held important roles in their households and society. Many had friendly relationships with their masters. In the Roman world, Christians like Philemon did not feel guilty about owning slaves.

Second, Paul did not oppose slavery because it was not his mission to change society's structures but to build the church. He wanted people to convert and transform spiritually. For Paul, whether a Christian is a slave or not is not very important, just like other external circumstances. The key is serving Jesus Christ, no matter one's life situation. In other words, Paul focused more on Christian life and witness than on physical freedom.

Even slaves can do their work as an act of worship ([Ephesians 6:5-8](#); [Colossians 3:22-24](#); compare [1 Timothy 6:1-2](#)). When Paul speaks to Christian slaves, he encourages them to see their situation as a calling where they can serve Christ. Christ is their true master, and in him, they are truly free ([1 Corinthians 7:20-24](#)).

Every Christian, whether slave or free, has been freed from the worst kind of slavery, slavery to sin. They can now experience true freedom by living as a servant of God and righteousness ([Romans 6:6-](#)

[22](#)). For Paul, this is the only kind of slavery and freedom that truly matters.

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 6:6-22](#); [1 Corinthians 7:20-24](#); [9:19](#); [Ephesians 6:5-8](#); [Colossians 3:22-24](#); [1 Timothy 6:1-2](#); [Philemon 1:8-21](#)

Social Chaos in Judges

The book of Judges emphasizes divine rescue through heroes but also shows the problems of their current situation. During this time, personal commitment to God decreased while social problems increased. This is especially true in chapter [5](#) (for example, [5:6-8](#)).

Three main issues stand out:

93. The tribes struggled to work together, even against a common enemy (see, for example, the stories of Gideon and Jephthah; chapters [8](#), [12](#)). The conflicts within each tribe and between different tribes show disobedience to the covenant.
94. The book shows the collapse of civil society. Abimelech kills Gideon's sons, Jephthah seems to sacrifice his daughter, and Samson seeks revenge against the Philistines. These acts emphasize the moral corruption and lack of social politeness during this time.
95. Abandoning the Jewish faith was common in those days. The Israelites often did "evil in the sight of the LORD," which linked to idol worship ([Judges 2:11-13](#); [3:7](#); [10:6](#)). The altar to Baal and the Asherah pole in Gideon's town of Ophrah show an obvious abandoning of the Lord ([6:25-30](#)). This is similar to the worship of the golden ephod made by Gideon and the return to worshipping Baal after Gideon's death ([8:27](#), [33-35](#)). Samson's marriage to a Philistine woman also went against the covenant commands (see [Deuteronomy 7:1-4](#)).

Social chaos peaks in the final chapters ([Judges 17–21](#)). The story of Micah, the Levite, and the Danites mixes religious problems with lawless raids, theft, and violence (chapters [17–18](#)). The intense final section tells of a tragic civil war and the complete loss of social politeness (chapters [19–21](#)).

Marital problems, lack of hospitality, rape, and murder almost wiped out the Benjamites (chapters [Judges 19](#) and [20](#)). They survived only because the Israelites destroyed a historic city, Jabesh-gilead. Then a fake ceremony allowed the Benjamites to take young virgins as wives ([21:6–23](#)). It is no surprise that the book ends with, “In those days there was no king in Israel; everyone did what was right in his own eyes” ([21:25](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Judges 5:6–8; 6:25–27; 8:1–35; 12:1–15; 17:1–21:25; Psalms 11:2–7; Proverbs 28:2–3; Jeremiah 5:7–9; 12:1–17; Micah 3:9–12; 7:2–7; Romans 1:21–32; Galatians 5:19–23](#)

Social Justice

In the Old Testament, prophets often challenged evil in society and called for social justice (fair treatment of all people, especially the poor and vulnerable). An early example is the prophet Elijah's response to Naboth's murder and his rebuke of King Ahab ([1 Kings 21:16–24](#), 800s BC). The social focus of the prophetic message grew stronger among the prophets of the 700s BC. The prophets Hosea and Amos emphasized this social focus in Israel, and the prophets Micah and Isaiah in Judah. The prophet Amos was the most vocal about social justice.

Israel's bad treatment of the powerless shocked the prophet Amos ([Amos 2:6–8; 3:10](#)). Unlike nearby nations, Israel had a special relationship with God, but they abandoned him ([2:9–12; 3:1–2](#)). The people of Israel refused to worship God properly and oppressed the powerless, so God would judge them without mercy ([4:12](#)). God wants his people “to let justice roll on like a river” ([Amos 5:24](#)). Those who resist it will be swept away.

The New Testament emphasized the importance of social justice. Jesus linked true worship with practicing social justice. He warned about judgment for those who do not show their faith through loving actions (see [Matthew 25:31–46](#)). Understanding must link to action, proving one's

faith (see [Luke 10:25–37; John 13:35](#)). The followers of Jesus understood that social justice was essential in early Christian communities (see [Acts 2:44–45; Galatians 2:9–10; 1 Timothy 5:3–16; James 1:27–2:26; 1 John 3:17–19](#)).

Scripture shows God's compassion for those who suffer. As followers of Jesus, we must help those in need. Like the prophets, we must stand against injustice wherever we find it.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:1–12; Leviticus 19:9–18; Deuteronomy 10:17–20; 16:18–20; 24:10–22; 1 Kings 21:1–24; 2 Chronicles 19:4–11; Psalms 94:20–23; 146:3–9; Proverbs 22:8–9; 31:8–9; Ecclesiastes 5:8–9; Isaiah 1:17; 5:7; 9:6–7; 10:1–2; 42:1–4; 58:4–12; Amos 2:6–8; 5:7–17, 23–24; Matthew 12:15–21; 23:23; Luke 10:25–37; Hebrews 1:8–9](#)

Solomon's Wisdom

When God gave King Solomon the chance to ask for anything, Solomon chose wisdom. He wanted to govern God's people well and know right from wrong ([1 Kings 3:9](#)). Because of this unselfish choice, God granted him the wisdom he wanted and the rewards of using it properly ([3:12, 13–14; 2 Chronicles 1:14–17](#)).

Solomon's actions quickly showed his wisdom. He solved a dispute over a child so wisely that it amazed the people ([1 Kings 3:16–28](#)). Later, the queen of Sheba visited to challenge him with difficult questions. She found his wisdom greater than she had heard ([10:1–9](#)).

Many things showed Solomon's wisdom, including:

- how he organized and managed his government and officials ([4:1–28](#));
- how he handled relationships with other nations and kings ([5:1–9](#));
- the structures he built, especially the temple and his palace ([5:10–7:51](#)); and
- his business dealings and trade with other nations ([9:26–28; 10:14–29](#)).

Solomon gained vast knowledge ([4:29–33](#)). He wrote proverbs (much of the book of Proverbs) as well as songs ([Psalms 72; 127](#)). He also wrote love poetry (see the Song of Songs) and philosophical

works (see Ecclesiastes). He used his wisdom to build the temple ([2 Chronicles 2:12](#)). This was like Bezalel who had been given wisdom to build the tabernacle ([Exodus 31:1-3](#)).

Jesus emphasized Solomon's great wisdom and told his listeners that, "One greater than Solomon is here" ([Matthew 12:42](#)). Jesus is the true wisdom of God, where one can find ultimate wisdom ([1 Corinthians 1:24](#)). A wise life is centered in Jesus and in Scripture ([1 Corinthians 1:18-25](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Peter 3:18](#); [2 Timothy 3:14-17](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 31:1-6](#); [1 Kings 3:5-14](#); [3:16-28](#); [4:29-34](#); [5:2-7](#); [10:1-13](#); [2 Chronicles 1:7-12](#); [Psalms 72:1-20](#); [111:10](#); [127:1-5](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:9-14](#); [Isaiah 11:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 9:23-24](#); [Matthew 12:42](#); [James 1:5](#)

Speaking

Some people think words do not cause harm. Scripture offers a different perspective. Words hold the power of "life and death" ([Proverbs 18:21](#)).

Proverbs lists many things we say that cause harm:

- lies ([Proverbs 14:5](#), [25](#))
- arguments ([Proverbs 26:17](#))
- insults or curses ([Proverbs 20:20](#))
- speaking falsely about someone to damage their reputation ([Proverbs 10:18](#))
- spreading private information about others or unverified stories passed from person to person ([Proverbs 11:13](#); [18:8](#))
- excessive or insincere praise given to manipulate someone ([Proverbs 7:21-22](#))
- speaking too proudly about oneself ([Proverbs 26:23](#); [27:2](#))

The book of Proverbs often emphasizes that foolish people say foolish things. "The woman named Folly" symbolizes these people ([9:13-18](#)). She lies and deceives to harm her listeners. Words show the heart's condition ([16:23](#); [18:4](#)).

Someone might hide an evil heart with pleasant words ([26:23](#)). But true character will eventually appear ([26:24-26](#)). Foolish words harm others and eventually hurt the speaker. The tongue is full of wickedness that can ruin your life ([James 3:6](#)).

In contrast, wise people speak words that give life, as shown by wisdom ([Proverbs 8:7-9](#); [10:11](#)). Wise people use their words carefully and are usually gentle ([17:27-28](#); [15:4](#); [16:24](#)). Yet, a wise person also knows the right time to speak ([15:23](#); [25:11](#)). This person understands that sometimes even harsh criticism is necessary (see [27:5](#)). The book of Proverbs wisely reminds readers to pay attention not only to what they say but also to how and when they say it.

Passages for Further Study

[Proverbs 7:21-22](#); [8:7-9](#); [9:13-18](#); [10:11](#), [18](#); [11:13](#); [14:5](#), [25](#); [15:4](#), [23](#); [16:23-24](#); [17:28](#); [18:4](#), [21](#); [20:20](#); [25:11](#); [26:17](#), [23-26](#); [27:2](#), [5](#); [Matthew 12:33-37](#); [James 3:1-12](#)

Spirit Empowerment

Throughout the Bible, when needed, God gives special abilities to those committed to serving him. The story of Moses and the seventy elders is an early example. It shows that God has acted in special ways among his people throughout history. When Moses had no more patience for rebellious Israel, God instructed him to choose seventy men to assist him ([Numbers 11:1-15](#), [16-17](#); see also [Exodus 18:14-26](#)). Then, God shared the Holy Spirit that Moses had with these men, empowering them for service ([Numbers 11:24-25](#)).

God's Spirit-empowered Joshua to succeed Moses ([Numbers 27:18](#); see also [Deuteronomy 34:9](#)). During the time of the judges, the Spirit of God helped Israel's leaders. This included:

- Othniel ([Judges 3:10](#));
- Gideon ([Judges 6:34](#));
- Jephthah ([Judges 11:29](#)); and
- Samson ([Judges 13:25](#); [14:6](#), [19](#); [15:14](#)).

King David drew strength from God's presence. His understanding of God's actions in history and his life made him a great leader (for example, [1 Samuel 16:13](#); [17:45](#); [18:12](#), [28](#)). The prophets knew their special work was possible because of the Spirit's

presence and power (for example, [Isaiah 61:1](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#); [Zechariah 4:6](#)).

God's Spirit anointed Jesus and empowered for a special mission (see [Matthew 12:18](#); [Luke 4:1, 14, 18](#); [John 3:34](#); [Acts 10:38](#)). He spoke about the Spirit's important role in the church ([Acts 1:8](#)). The Spirit's arrival allowed the gathered Christians to speak with power on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:4-5, 16-18](#); compare [Joel 2:28-29](#)).

After Pentecost, the Spirit gave the church courage and strength ([Acts 4:31](#); [19:6](#); [20:28](#); [1 Corinthians 12:1-31](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#)). The Holy Spirit still remains with God's people today. The Spirit acts as needed to renew and strengthen God's people. He continues to prepare them for the tasks God calls them to do.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 11:16-30](#); [24:1-9](#); [27:18-23](#); [Deuteronomy 34:10-12](#); [Judges 3:9-10](#); [6:34](#); [11:29](#); [14:5-6](#), [19](#); [15:14](#); [1 Samuel 16:13](#); [Psalms 23](#); [46:1](#); [94:16-19](#); [116:1-9](#); [121:1-8](#); [143:10-12](#); [Isaiah 61:1](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#); [Joel 2:28-29](#); [Zechariah 4:6](#); [Matthew 12:18](#); [Luke 4:1, 14, 18](#); [John 3:34](#); [Acts 1:8](#); [2:4, 16-18](#); [4:31](#); [10:38](#); [19:6](#); [20:28](#); [1 Corinthians 12:1-31](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#)

Spiritual Maturity

When someone trusts in Jesus Christ for salvation, it marks the beginning of a journey that will continue the rest of their life. They do not stay the same. They transform and grow to be more like Jesus. This process is called "sanctification." Like newborn babies need milk to grow before they can eat solid food, new Christians need "pure spiritual milk" to fully experience salvation ([1 Peter 2:2-3](#)). Eventually, they will be ready for the "solid food" of deeper teachings ([Hebrews 5:11-14](#)).

Spiritual maturity involves the ability to understand spiritual wisdom ([1 Corinthians 2:6](#)). The apostle Paul commands Christians to think maturely ([1 Corinthians 14:20](#)). The body of Christ matures as Christians become spiritually equipped and learn about the Son of God ([Ephesians 4:11-16](#)). This leads to a united faith community where love and truth strengthen the body of Christ.

The audience of Hebrews was spiritually immature. The author wanted to provide them with substantial spiritual teachings. But they behaved like spiritual infants who needed basic

nourishment instead of deeper lessons ([Hebrews 5:12](#)). They had not been attentive to God's teachings. They had been Christians long enough to teach others, but their growing insensitivity made them spiritually dull ([5:11-12](#); compare [1 Corinthians 3:1-3](#)).

They lacked the maturity to understand the basic difference between right and wrong ([Hebrews 5:14](#)). Therefore, the author challenged them to grow into maturity. This was so he could share deeper truths of the faith, instead of repeatedly covering the basics ([6:1-3](#)).

Spiritual maturity does not happen automatically over time. It comes from actively listening to the word of God and living it out with a community of Christians.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Corinthians 2:6](#); [3:1-3](#); [14:20](#); [2 Corinthians 13:9-11](#); [Ephesians 4:11-16](#); [Colossians 4:12](#); [Hebrews 5:11-14](#); [6:1-3](#); [10:14](#); [12:1-2](#); [1 Peter 2:1-3](#)

Spiritual Renewal in the Later Prophets

The prophet Haggai commanded his audience to think about how failing to pay attention to their relationship with God affected their current situation ([Haggai 1:5-7](#); [2:15-18](#)). God sent natural disasters as a warning to encourage repentance ([2:17](#)). Haggai understood that spiritual renewal needed to happen at the same time as rebuilding the temple ([1:12](#)).

The theme of spiritual renewal connects the prophets Haggai, Zechariah, and Malachi. They all came after the exile to Babylon. God returned his people to their land, as promised by earlier prophets. Yet, the people needed to focus on their spiritual condition to avoid more problems. The risk of disobeying God during this time shows the need for the Lord's "servant" to come (see [Haggai 2:23](#)).

This servant first referred to Zerubbabel but later became regarded as the Messiah (God's chosen one). A righteous shepherd-king was coming ([Zechariah 9:9](#); see also [Malachi 3:1](#)). God's presence would return in an obvious way. God would restore creation. The worship of the Lord would become universal.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 30:2-4](#); [Psalm 22:27](#); [Isaiah 11:9-12:6](#); [44:22, 26-28](#); [61:6-7](#); [Jeremiah 24:4-7](#); [Amos 4:6-12](#); [Haggai 1:7-15](#); [Zechariah 9:9](#); [14:9](#); [Malachi 3:1](#)

Suffering in Following God

Sometimes, people urge others to accept Jesus Christ because they promise that he will solve their problems. Yet, Jesus did not promise to solve all problems. He often warned people to think about the cost of following him (see, for example, [Luke 14:28](#)). He also emphasized the difficulties that would come from choosing to follow him (see, for example, [Mark 8:34](#)).

[Exodus 5](#) gives us an example of how following God can sometimes lead to more challenges at first. In the beginning, Pharaoh made the Hebrew people slaves because he was afraid they were becoming too numerous and might cause problems for Egypt ([1:8-22](#)). In chapter [5](#), the situation changes. Moses and Aaron had given the people hope by telling them that God would rescue them ([4:29-31](#)). When Moses and Aaron first met with Pharaoh, they told him that God was the true ruler over all ([5:1-3](#)). As expected, Pharaoh saw this as a challenge to his power as king, and he responded by making life even harder for the Israelites ([5:4-21](#)).

When God's kingdom opposes God's enemies, conflict and suffering often occur for God's people. This should not surprise us. When someone becomes a Christian, they leave behind a life controlled by evil and darkness. They begin a new life guided by God's goodness and light ([Colossians 1:11-14](#)). Those ruling the kingdom of darkness will not let us leave without a fight. We must stand firm in our faith, knowing that God will secure the final victory for us ([Exodus 6:1-8](#); see also [Matthew 5:11-12](#); [John 16:33](#); [Romans 16:20](#); [Ephesians 6:10-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 39:6-20](#); [Exodus 5:1-23](#); [18:8](#); [1 Kings 18:3-4](#); [19:1-10](#); [Psalms 6:6-7](#); [22:11-18](#); [Matthew 5:11-12](#); [Mark 8:34](#); [John 15:20](#); [16:33](#); [Romans 16:20](#); [2 Corinthians 11:23-29](#); [Ephesians 6:10-18](#); [2 Timothy 3:12](#); [Hebrews 10:32-36](#); [1 Peter 1:6-7](#); [3:9-17](#); [4:12-19](#)

Symbolic Numbers

Numbers in Scripture have often led people to strange conclusions. Understanding ancient number symbolism can help us interpret the Scriptures better. Yet, this symbolism is not precise. We must be careful when using numbers in interpretation to avoid making unrealistic predictions about the future.

In the Bible, numbers often have special meanings:

- The number *one* can refer to God's unity ([Deuteronomy 6:4](#); [Galatians 3:20](#); [James 2:19](#)).
- *Two* is the minimum number of people needed to provide a valid witness in court ([Deuteronomy 17:6](#); [Revelation 11:3](#)).
- *Three* can imply divine presence ([Genesis 18:1-2](#); [2 Corinthians 13:14](#); [Revelation 1:4-5](#)).
- *Four* can represent the known world. The book of Revelation indicates this with living creatures, horsemen, winds, and angels ([Revelation 4:6-8](#); [6:1-8](#); [7:1](#)). [Genesis 2:10-14](#) indicates this with *four* rivers.
- Adding *three* and *four* to make *seven* represents perfection or divine fulfillment. This shows harmony between God and the world.
- Multiplying *three* by *four* gives *twelve*, the number linked to God's people ([Genesis 35:22-26](#); [Exodus 24:4](#); [28:21](#); [Numbers 17:2](#); [Joshua 4:3-8](#); [1 Kings 18:31](#); [Matthew 10:1-4](#); [19:28](#); [James 1:1](#); [Revelation 12:1](#); [21:12-22:2](#)).
- The number *five* and its multiples, like *ten*, represent human completeness. For example, there are *five* fingers per hand.
- *Six* has a negative meaning, suggesting imperfection. It is neither humanly complete (*five*) nor divinely complete (*seven*).
- Multiples of *ten* represent *many* (for example, *forty*). In contrast, *three sixes* or "666" suggest extreme evil ([Revelation 13:18](#)).

- *One thousand* is the basic large number. The number 12,000 represents a large group of God's people ([Revelation 7:5-8](#)). One hundred and forty-four thousand represents all of God's people ([Revelation 7:4; 14:1](#)). The Greek transliteration *myriads* best represents what some translations call "10,000." This is because it is really a huge number, rather than an exact count.

Some numbers in the Bible have symbolic meanings. Yet, it is extremely doubtful to use them to guess when Christ will return or when the world will end. Only God knows these things ([Mark 13:32](#)). God did not intend for the symbolic numbers in Revelation to predict the future. Instead, they explain the importance of the visions.

Translating these numbers into modern sizes, distances, or quantities can sometimes lose their theological meaning. These symbolic numbers can show how a vision relates to the world or to God's people.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:2-3; 4:15; 15:13; 41:53-54; Exodus 20:6; 25:31-37; 32:15; Leviticus 16:14; 23:16; 2 Samuel 24:13; 1 Kings 4:26; 17:21; 18:31, 43-44; Job 1:2; Psalm 90:4; Jeremiah 15:3; 49:36; Ezekiel 14:21; Daniel 4:16, 23-25; 7:3, 17, 24; Zechariah 4:2; 6:1; Matthew 10:1-5; 12:40; 18:21-22; Mark 6:7; Luke 15:8; Acts 6:3; 10:16; 1 Corinthians 8:6; Ephesians 4:4-6; 2 Peter 3:8; Revelation 1:16; 2:10; 4:4; 6:1; 7:1, 4-8; 12:1, 3; 13:1; 17:3-14; 20:2-7; 21:12-21](#)

Temple Design as a Picture of God's Truth

The temple plan in [Ezekiel 40-43](#) does not seem possible to build, nor was it meant to be. The plan lacks enough detail for construction, as shown by the different diagrams scholars have created. Unlike the tabernacle, the plan does not specify materials ([Exodus 25:10-40:33](#)). There is also no evidence that anyone tried to build the second temple using this plan. Therefore, Ezekiel's temple plan is not a blueprint for future construction.

Ezekiel's temple vision shows God's message through a building design. It intends to shame

Ezekiel's generation for their past and encourage future faithfulness ([Ezekiel 43:10-12](#)). The vision describes a new world where obvious boundaries between the holy and unholy exist, and standards are higher. This allows God to return to his temple and live among his people again (see [10:3-4, 18; 11:22-23](#)).

Access to the holy area is much more limited. Faithful individuals from the past gain renewed access, while God rejects unfaithful people. There is a stronger focus on sacrifices for atonement and purification for the people.

This new temple represents Jesus Christ, who reveals God's glory. His body was a temple that others would destroy and he would rebuild in three days ([John 2:19](#)). In Jesus, God's holiness shone brightly in the darkness, and the darkness could not overcome it ([John 1:5](#)). His body was the perfect, one-time sacrifice that purified the people ([Hebrews 10:12](#)).

Those united to Christ now have the privilege of accessing the Most Holy Place in heaven in the new Jerusalem. Its doors are always open to those who "have washed their robes and made them white in the blood of the Lamb" (see [Revelation 21; 22:14](#)).

Since God unites us Christians with Christ and we are part of his body, the new temple, we cannot live as we did before. The Holy Spirit lives in and among us, and our bodies now belong to him as parts of his new temple ([1 Corinthians 6:15-20](#)). A holy life is proof that we are God's children ([1 Peter 1:13-16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:10-40:33; Leviticus 10:9-11; Ezekiel 22:26; 40:1-43:27; John 2:19; 1 Corinthians 6:15-20; Hebrews 9:22-10:19; 1 Peter 1:13-16; Revelation 21:1-27](#)

Temple Legislation as Theology

The religious teachers of Judaism (called "rabbis") spent much time trying to make the laws of [Ezekiel 44-48](#) agree with those laws of the Torah (the law given to Moses). They failed because these chapters do not intend to match the law of Moses. This is similar to how the vision of the temple building was not designed to look like the tabernacle or Solomon's Temple ([Ezekiel 40-43](#)). The temple rules describe a theological message of change, similar to the earlier description of the temple's architecture.

These rules emphasized the need to separate the temple from the palace. Sacrificial ceremonies would increase and focus more on purification. Holy people would again make offerings to the holy God. These practices intended to separate the holy from the unholy and purify God's people. Pollution of the temple and idol worship had caused the Lord to leave ([Ezekiel 8-11](#)).

So, they needed a new situation for God to live among his people again. These rules intended to make the prophet's listeners aware of their past wrongs that confused what was holy and unholy. It also encouraged them that God would restore their worship to its proper condition.

These rules also put the prince, the king descended from King David, in a position of submission to the Lord. The arrival of Jesus fulfills this element. Jesus came as a servant king who was happy to do what the Father wanted ([Matthew 4:1-11](#); [20:25-28](#)). He offered the perfect sacrifice that cleanses sin, purified the heavenly sanctuary once for all time, and ensured that God could live among his people forever ([Hebrews 9:11-12, 23](#)). His blood cleanses us from all sin. It allows sinners to confidently enter most holy place of heaven without fear of rejection or punishment.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 56:7](#); [Ezekiel 8:1-11:25](#); [40:1-43:27](#); [44:1-46:18](#)

Temple Worship

In the ancient Near East, kings had to provide for their nation's temple. King David, who started the family line (dynasty) of Judah's kings, made Jerusalem the capital of Israel ([2 Samuel 5:4-10](#)). He also made it the main place of worship. King Solomon built the temple, but David prepared for its construction and worship practices.

Solomon took seven years to build the temple in Jerusalem. He started in the fourth year of his rule (967 BC). The temple was large. It was 27 meters long (90 feet), 9 meters wide (30 feet), and almost 13 meters high (45 feet). Its entrance court (portico or vestibule) was 4.5 meters deep (15 feet), spanning the width (see [1 Kings 6:2-10](#)).

He used the most advanced building techniques of the time. The cost was not a concern for construction, decoration, or equipment. Even so,

Solomon admitted it was not good enough to house the eternal God ([1 Kings 8:27](#)).

The temple, next to the king's palace, represented God's rule over creation and all nations. "The LORD is in His holy temple; let all the earth be silent before Him" ([Habakkuk 2:20](#)). It taught Israel about God's unique rule and their complete reliance on him. Although no building can contain God, he chose the temple as the main place for his presence on earth. Thus, the temple was central to Israelite worship and the personal relationship between God and his people.

God gave the kings the task of committing themselves to him and promoting proper worship at the temple. The temple confirmed that God authorized the human king to represent divine rule. [Psalm 132](#) expressed this role by celebrating David's return of the ark of the covenant to Jerusalem ([Psalm 132:6-12](#)). Solomon used this psalm at the end of his prayer when he established the temple ([2 Chronicles 6:41-42](#)).

Later, Christ and the church fulfilled the temple's role in showing God's presence. Jesus indicated the shift from the temple buildings to his own body as the spiritual temple (see [John 2:19](#)). The disciples began to understand this change after Christ's resurrection ([John 2:21-22](#)).

The apostle Paul described the church as the new holy space where Jews and non-Jews (gentiles) are reconciled. Using temple imagery, he explained how Jesus "has torn down the dividing wall of hostility" in the body of Christ (the church) to create one people ([Ephesians 2:14-15](#)). The church is God's holy temple, built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets ([Ephesians 2:20-22](#)). It is made from "living stones," Christians, who God joins together around Jesus Christ, the cornerstone ([1 Peter 2:4-5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 8:27-53](#); [1 Chronicles 22:1-19](#); [2 Chronicles 5:2-14](#); [6:41-42](#); [7:12-16](#); [Psalm 48:9](#); [65:4](#); [66:13](#); [138:2](#); [Jeremiah 7:3-11](#); [11:15](#); [Ezekiel 8:6-16](#); [44:1-31](#); [Joel 1:14](#); [2:17](#); [Habakkuk 2:20](#); [Haggai 2:7](#); [John 2:19-22](#); [Ephesians 2:14-15](#), [20-22](#); [1 Peter 2:4-5](#)

The Antichrist

The term *antichrist* appears only in the apostle John's letters ([1 John 2:18, 22](#); [4:3](#); [2 John 1:7](#)). John

believed many antichrists would appear throughout history ([1 John 2:18](#)). These antichrists would deny that Jesus is both divine and human ([1 John 2:22; 4:2-3; 2 John 1:7](#)).

The apostle Paul mentions "the man of lawlessness" who will appear in the last times to start a rebellion against God ([2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)). This person will "will be accompanied by the working of Satan." This is mainly through deception. Revelation does not specifically call him "antichrist." But this "man of lawlessness," like the "antichrists" in John's letters, will oppose the truth.

In [Revelation 13](#), a spirit opposing Jesus Christ is "another beast" serving the dragon (Satan) and the first beast. The number of this antichrist, 666, probably represented Emperor Nero and possibly Emperor Domitian (see study note on 17:8). Emperor worship, which declared "Caesar is Lord!" was a false religion opposing the proclamation of Jesus Christ as Lord.

It is uncertain if John expected a final antichrist even greater than leaders like Nero or Domitian. Nevertheless, Christians must recognize the presence of evil. They must also recognize its opposition to Christ in people and power structures worldwide. Resisting these enemies may lead to persecution and even death. But our hope is in ultimate victory through Christ.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Thessalonians 2:3-10](#); [1 John 2:18, 22; 4:2-3](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:11](#)

The Ark of the Covenant

The ark of the covenant was a wooden chest covered with gold, located in the Most Holy Place of the Jewish tabernacle, and later the temple. It reminded Israel of God's covenant with them. Inside were the tablets of the covenant, known as the "Ten Commandments." On the day of atonement, the high priest sprinkled blood on the ark's cover to purify the people ([Leviticus 16:2-17](#)).

During Israel's time in the wilderness, God's glory appeared over the ark, where he met with his people (see [Exodus 25:22](#)). Throughout Israel's history, the ark represented God's presence. The people carried it as they traveled ([Numbers 10:33-36](#)). When they brought it to the Jordan River, the

water stopped so the Israelites could cross on dry ground ([Joshua 3:4-6](#)). They carried the ark around Jericho before the city was invaded. It was present during the siege of the Ammonite city of Rabbah in King David's time ([2 Samuel 11:1-11](#)).

The Philistines considered the ark as equal to Israel's God ([1 Samuel 4:6-8](#)). This made sense because the Philistines took images of their gods into battle ([2 Samuel 5:21](#)). The Israelites did not use images of God. So they considered the ark as God's "footstool" and temporary home, not his image (see [1 Chronicles 28:2](#)).

Yet, the Israelites developed a false view of the ark. They treated this holy object like a magic box and tried to use God's presence for their own gain. They thought "it may go with us to save us from the hand of our enemies" (see [1 Samuel 4:3](#)). Their defeat that day showed that non one can control God ([4:1-11](#)). He is the leader of his people, and they must obey and trust him (compare [Joshua 5:13-15](#)).

King David eventually moved the ark to Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 6:1-17](#)). When King Solomon built the temple, he placed the ark in the most holy place. It remained the center of Israelite worship ([1 Kings 8:1-11](#)).

The Hebrew scriptures do not mention the ark after the early kingdom or monarchy. It was probably destroyed by the Babylonians along with the temple in 586 BC. Yet, a tradition from the apocrypha (or deuterocanon) claims that the prophet Jeremiah hid the ark during the exile in Babylon ([2 Maccabees 2:4-8](#)) (The apocrypha is a set of ancient texts not included in the Hebrew Bible but accepted by some Christian groups as Scripture.) Still, God's presence through Jesus Christ and his complete sacrifice made the ark unnecessary (see [Hebrews 9:1-10:18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:10-22; 40:20-21](#); [Leviticus 16:2; Numbers 10:33-36; Deuteronomy 31:25-26; Joshua 3:4-6; 6:6-13; Judges 20:26-28; 1 Samuel 4:3-11; 5:1-7; 2 Samuel 6:1-17; Jeremiah 3:16-18](#)

The Birth of Christ

The stories of the birth of Jesus show contrasts show a clear contrast between humble circumstances and divine importance ([Matthew 1:18-2:12; Luke 2:1-20](#)).

On one side, we see the humble nature of his birth. A poor couple travels to Bethlehem, the home of their ancestors. They go to register for a census (a government count of all the people living in a country or region) ordered by the Roman Empire, which ruled over their land at that time. Their journey from Galilee to Bethlehem was long and difficult. When they arrived, they could not find any place to stay. They had to use a place where animals were kept.

The whole situation showed poverty, rejection, and lack of attention from others. When Jesus was born, the news was not sent to important kings or wealthy people. Instead, the announcement went to simple shepherds who were watching their sheep in a field nearby.

Yet beside this humble setting is a message of amazing power and greatness. The baby placed in a feeding trough (manger) is the Messiah, the long-awaited descendant of King David. He will rule victoriously over the people of Israel, and his kingdom will never end.

He is the one all the prophets spoke about. All of history had been pointing forward to its most important moment in him. A group of wise men from eastern countries traveled to honor him. And an army of powerful angels came from heaven to announce his birth.

These contrasts give us a first look at what will come later. In Jesus, the God of Israel and Lord of all the earth has come to visit and save his people. God comes down from heaven to meet people in their everyday lives and circumstances. Throughout the Gospels, Jesus shows special concern for the humble, the poor, the rejected, and sinners. He comes to save them because they recognize their need for him. They receive the message of salvation with joy and happiness.

The contrast between humility and greatness also connects to Jesus' mission. Evil people reject him and kill him. Yet, God proves Jesus right at his resurrection and raises Jesus to his "right hand."

There at his throne, he rules as Lord and Messiah. From there, he sends the Spirit of God to lead and guide his church. Through his life, death, resurrection, and rise to glory, Jesus offers forgiveness of sins. He gives eternal life to all who respond to him with a faithful life.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 1:18-2:12](#); [Luke 2:1-20](#)

The Blessings of Jesus

The Beatitudes are the blessings Jesus gave to his followers. They get their name from the word *beati* (which means blessed) in the Latin translation of the Bible (the Vulgate). No single word can fully express what Jesus means here. He describes God's special favor toward his people, both physically and spiritually, and the outcomes of living in that favor.

The Beatitudes describe how a follower of Jesus should live and behave. Jesus invites people to follow him as he shares the message of the kingdom with Israel (see also [Matthew 11:6](#); [13:16](#); [16:17](#); [24:46](#)). Those who Jesus blesses have repented from their sins in response to the kingdom's message ([Matthew 4:17-22](#)). The Beatitudes relate to [Isaiah 61:1-3](#). The Holy Spirit gives power and leads people to share the good news about Jesus. The Holy Spirit blesses the poor, the humble, and the righteous.

In the Bible, the word "blessed" suggests:

- These blessings come from God and show his approval (see [Matthew 25:34](#)).
- The blessings show God's promises coming true (see [Matthew 11:6](#); [13:16](#); [16:17](#)).
- The blessings change things in surprising ways, making life better for those who trust God (see [Luke 1:1-2:52](#); [6:20-26](#)).
- To receive these blessings, people need to obey God (see [Psalms 1:1, 3-6](#); [106:3](#); [112:1-2](#); [119:1-2](#); [Proverbs 8:32](#); [Isaiah 56:2](#)).

These blessings began when Jesus the Messiah came to earth. Christians can be confident that they will enjoy these blessings fully and forever.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 1:1-3](#); [106:3](#); [112:1-2](#); [119:1-2](#); [Isaiah 56:1-2](#); [Matthew 5:3-12](#); [11:6](#); [13:16](#); [16:17](#); [24:46](#); [25:34](#); [Luke 6:20-26](#)

The Broken Covenant

After God rescued the Israelites from Egypt, he made a special agreement (called a covenant) with them (see [Exodus 20–24](#)). In this covenant, God gave them the Ten Commandments and other laws. The people promised to follow these laws, and God promised to bless them if they did. But the Israelites broke the terms of the covenant.

A central issue in God's relationship with Israel was whether the covenant made at Mount Sinai was still valid after the people had broken it. In ancient Near Eastern politics, covenants were common. When one of the partners in a covenant broke the terms of the agreement, the result was usually war.

The covenant was special because God was one of the partners. It followed the pattern of non-religious covenants and required both God and Israel to confirm the agreement with oaths promising to be faithful ([Exodus 24:1–11](#); [Deuteronomy 29–30](#); [Joshua 8:30–35](#); [24:1–28](#)).

God always remained faithful to his covenant, but the Israelites continued to break it. Canaanite worship of many gods tempted them away from the Lord. They worshipped idols and engaged in immoral sexual ceremonies. They treated the poor and needy badly and ignored God's rules for righteousness.

For centuries, the Israelites either worshiped God (Yahweh) or Canaanite gods. Whenever they repented and obeyed God, he mercifully accepted them back into the covenant relationship. Yet, by the mid-700s BC, the Israelites of the northern kingdom of Israel had become stubbornly committed to idol worship. So God allowed the Assyrians to destroy the kingdom and take many people into captivity.

The prophet Jeremiah's ministry was over one hundred years later. Now Judah was committing idolatry. Jeremiah compared this situation to a marriage divorce, similar to Hosea's earlier story about Israel ([Jeremiah 2–3](#); compare [Hosea 1–2](#)). The Scriptures compare Israel's relationship with God to a marriage where the bride committed adultery.

God accused his people of breaking the marriage bond and behaving like a prostitute ([Jeremiah 3:1](#)). He warned them to repent or encounter destruction. God could no longer say of the Israelites, "I will be their God, and they will be My people" (see [Jeremiah 31:33](#); see also [Exodus 6:7](#); [Hosea 1:9](#)).

Breaking the covenant led to the northern kingdom's destruction and later the destruction of the kingdom of Judah. Babylon destroyed Jerusalem and the temple. This punishment deeply pained God. The ever-merciful God promised a new covenant to replace the Sinai covenant that Israel had broken ([Jeremiah 31:31–34](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 6:7](#); [Jeremiah 2:1–3:10](#); [4:4](#); [22:8–9](#); [31:31–34](#); [Ezekiel 16:1–63](#); [Hosea 2:2–13](#); [3:1](#); [4:1–5:15](#)

The Bronze Snake

[Numbers 21:4–9](#) describes an event where the Israelites complained against God and Moses. They were unhappy about the food and water and said, "We detest this wretched food!" ([21:5](#)). In response, the Lord sent poisonous snakes that bit and killed many people (see [Deuteronomy 8:15](#)). Realizing their mistake, the Israelites asked Moses to pray for the removal of the snakes. God told Moses to make a bronze snake. Anyone bitten could look at it and God would heal them ([Numbers 21:8](#)).

This was not a typical medical treatment. The healing came from God and required faith to look at the bronze snake and trust in God's healing power. The snake bites were a result of God's punishment. But he also provided a way for their salvation through his mercy (see *Wisdom of Solomon* 16:5–7).

When Hezekiah became king of Judah in 715 BC, the Israelites started using Moses' bronze serpent as an idol (see [2 Kings 18:1–4](#)). They probably kept the image to remember God's power. This was similar to other holy things from the wilderness period (see [Deuteronomy 10:5](#); [Hebrews 9:4–5](#)). Yet, they began worshiping it as another god. So they had to destroy it like other pagan worship items and pillars. Such idolatry threatens the worship of the one true God (compare [Exodus 32](#)).

Jesus mentioned the bronze snake incident to prophesy how he would die. He would "be lifted up" on the cross like Moses lifted the snake on a pole ([John 3:14–15](#); see also [8:28](#); [12:32–33](#)). The metal snake image acted as a cure for snake bites. Similarly, those who look to Christ's cross and accept Jesus' sacrifice receive an eternal promise ([John 3:14–16](#)).

The Lord sent snakes to punish Israel for complaining about the manna in the wilderness ([Numbers 21:4-9](#)). Jesus called himself "the true bread from heaven," the spiritual manna that gives eternal life to his people ([John 6:32-40](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 21:4-9](#); [2 Kings 18:1-4](#); [John 3:14-15](#); [6:32-40](#); [8:28](#); [12:30-34](#)

The Central Sanctuary

God wanted people to worship where he had chosen to put his name. For Israel, this was first the tabernacle and later the temple in Jerusalem.

God is *transcendent* (above all things) and *omnipresent* (present everywhere). Yet he chose a specific place for Israel to worship him. King Solomon later asked how the God of heaven could live in a building made by humans ([1 Kings 8:27](#)). The answer is that God's name represents himself.

The tabernacle and later the temple belonged to him and his name marked them. So they were, in a way, his homes. In the ancient Near East, names were more than just labels. They showed the character and nature of the person (for example, Jacob, [Genesis 27:36](#); Jesus, [Matthew 1:21](#); Barnabas, [Acts 4:36](#); Peter, [Matthew 16:17-19](#)). Thus, Solomon could advise, "A good name is more desirable than great riches" ([Proverbs 22:1](#)).

God lived in a holy place that carried his name. His glorious presence appeared as fire and cloud during the time Israel lived in the wilderness. This acted as a constant reminder that he was with his people ([Exodus 40:34-35](#)). Similarly, when Solomon established the temple, God's presence was also evident ([1 Kings 8:10-11](#)).

God later lived among his people as Jesus Christ ([John 1:14](#)). This removed the need for a central holy place (see [John 4:19-24](#)). Now, because the Holy Spirit lives within them, all Christians can "house" God's presence ([1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [6:19-20](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 2:21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:8-9](#), [22](#), [40](#); [26:30](#); [33:7-11](#); [40:34-35](#); [Numbers 7:1](#); [11:16](#); [Deuteronomy 12:4-7](#); [31:14-15](#); [1 Kings 8:10-11](#), [27](#); [John 1:14](#); [2:19-21](#); [Acts 7:44](#); [1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [6:19-20](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 2:21](#); [Hebrews 8:2](#), [5](#); [Revelation 21:22](#)

The Choice of Life or Death

Moses instructed the Israelites as they were about to enter the promised land. They had a choice. They could obey the covenant, which is life as God designed it, and live. Or they could refuse to obey the creator's design and die ([Deuteronomy 30:19](#)). This choice and its consequences continued throughout the time of God's covenant with Israel.

The specific language of Deuteronomy 30 appears again in the prophecy of Jeremiah during the Babylonian invasion. God said, "Behold, I set before you the way of life and the way of death" ([Jeremiah 21:8](#)). The prophet warned King Zedekiah and his people to obey the Lord's instruction. If they obeyed, they would live, if not, they would die.

Earlier in Jeremiah's prophetic ministry, the Lord gave the people of Judah a chance to repent ([Jeremiah 3:12-4:4](#)). They must stop idol worship, admit their guilt, and confess their rebellion. Then God would cleanse their minds and hearts. He would allow them to live peacefully in the land. Yet, the people continued to reject this offer ([Jeremiah 7:5-7](#); [18:8-11](#); [23:22](#); [26:13](#); [27:12-13](#); [29:32](#); [35:15](#); [36:3-7](#); [44:5](#)). So the Lord continued to warn them that rejecting the path of life would lead to judgment.

In Jeremiah's time, only a few chose life. Most rebelled and died. Ultimately, the people led by King Zedekiah ignored the Lord. They rebelled against the Babylonian army, and suffered judgment. They deliberately rejected the gift of life.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 11:26-29](#); [30:15-20](#); [Proverbs 9:1-18](#); [11:19](#); [18:21](#); [Isaiah 1:19-20](#); [Jeremiah 3:12-15](#); [4:3-4](#); [7:5-7](#); [18:7-11](#); [21:8-9](#); [23:22](#); [26:13](#); [27:12-18](#); [35:15](#); [36:3-7](#); [44:5](#); [Ezekiel 18:23-24](#); [Romans 6:23](#); [8:6](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)

The Christ Hymn: Christ's Divine Nature

The passage in [Philippians 2:6-11](#) is often called the Christ Hymn. This section reveals what early Christians believed about Jesus Christ. The hymn shows that early Christians believed Jesus existed before his birth on earth and that he has a divine nature (see also [Colossians 1:15-20](#); [2:9](#); compare [John 1:1-2](#); [Hebrews 1:1-3](#)).

The hymn teaches that Christ is not just another human prophet. He was with God the Father from the beginning. He is the one through whom God created the universe. As the Son of God, Jesus shares God's own nature.

This claim about Jesus being divine caused major disagreements between Jesus and the religious leaders of his time. They accused Jesus of blasphemy (speaking in a way that dishonors God) when he claimed to be equal with God ([John 5:16–18](#); [8:54–59](#); [10:30–39](#)).

The hymn also teaches that Jesus Christ came to earth in an act of great humility. The infinite God (who is eternal and not bound by time) took on human nature in the person of Jesus Christ and entered human history ([Philippians 2:7](#); see [Colossians 1:15](#); [John 1:10–14](#); [Hebrews 2:14, 17](#)). Jesus Christ, the glorious Creator of the universe, died as a sacrifice for the sins of human beings. This was to secure forgiveness and reconcile humanity with God ([Philippians 2:8](#); see [John 3:14–17](#); [Romans 5:9–10](#); [Colossians 1:20, 22](#); [2:13–14](#); [Hebrews 1:3](#); [10:9–14](#)). The Scriptures had prophesied this very thing (see [Isaiah 53:3–12](#)).

This hymn states that God raised Jesus from the dead and gave him the highest honor in heaven ([Philippians 2:9](#)). God also gave him the title "Lord" ([Philippians 2:11](#); compare [Colossians 1:18](#)). One day, all created beings will bow before him and acknowledge him as Lord of the universe ([Philippians 2:9–11](#)). He deserves the worship that only God is worthy to receive (see [Revelation 5:8–14](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 53:3–12](#); [John 1:1–2, 10–14](#); [3:14–17](#); [Romans 5:9–10](#); [Philippians 2:6–11](#); [Colossians 1:15–22](#); [2:9, 13–14](#); [Hebrews 1:1–3](#); [2:14, 17](#); [10:9–14](#); [Revelation 5:8–14](#)

The Church

The church is the community of people who acknowledge Christ as Lord and obey him ([Ephesians 5:21–24](#)). The New Testament word for "church" comes from the Greek word *ekklēsia* (meaning "a group of people who gather together"). In the Greek-speaking world, this word was used for different types of meetings. It could mean a formal political meeting or just an informal gathering of people (for example, [Acts 19:32, 39, 41](#)). In the Septuagint (the Greek translation of the

Old Testament), the term refers to when the community of Israel met (for example, [Deuteronomy 31:30](#)).

In the New Testament, *ekklēsia* refers to:

96. The entire body of Christ worldwide (for example, [Matthew 16:18](#); [Ephesians 1:22](#))
97. All Christians in a specific area (for example, [Acts 9:31](#); [1 Corinthians 1:2](#))
98. A local community that meets regularly for worship, teaching, fellowship, and prayer (for example, [Romans 16:5](#); see [Acts 2:42](#))

The New Testament uses several concepts to describe the church:

99. *The Israel of God* ([Galatians 6:16](#)): Those who are "God's own possession" ([1 Peter 2:9–10](#)). They serve as "a holy priesthood, offering spiritual sacrifices acceptable to God" ([1 Peter 2:5, 9](#)).
100. *God's family* ([Ephesians 2:19](#); [1 Timothy 3:15](#)): This consists of those adopted as God's spiritual children and named as his heirs.
101. *A holy temple*: The place God lives by his Spirit ([Ephesians 2:21–22](#); [4:6](#); [1 Corinthians 3:16–17](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Colossians 1:27](#)).
102. *Body of Christ*: They represent Christ fully in the world, with Christ as the leader ([Ephesians 1:23](#); [4:15](#); [5:23–24](#); [1 Corinthians 12:12–27](#); [Colossians 1:18, 24](#)).
103. *Christ's pure bride*: The one he died for, cares for, and cherishes. She will live with him forever in unity. ([Ephesians 5:25–29](#)).

The church is part of God's plan to unite everything in heaven and on earth under Christ's authority ([Ephesians 1:9–10](#)). Through Jesus Christ, God has called people from both Judaism and the non-Jewish world (gentile) to become one new people of God ([Galatians 6:16](#)). They are empowered by his Spirit to be present in the world, worship him,

and share the good news (gospel) of his unconditional love ([Ephesians 2:11-22](#)).

The spiritual roots of the church are in Judaism. The church fulfills God's intention for Israel to be "a light for the nations" and to "bring My salvation to the ends of the earth" ([Isaiah 49:6](#); see also [Romans 11:1-5](#)). In this new community of Jewish and non-Jewish believers, Jesus breaks down all the old divisions between people. No one is considered better or worse than others because of their ethnic background, social position, or whether they are male or female ([Galatians 3:28](#)).

Those united with Christ are members of his body. Paul describes the close connection between Christ and his people as similar to the unity of a physical body ([Romans 12:4-8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:12-27](#)). Being "in Christ" means "baptized into one body" ([1 Corinthians 12:12-13](#)). As a result, "you are the body of Christ, and each of you is a member of it" ([1 Corinthians 12:27](#)).

Christians connect with God as part of a new family. Being "in Christ" means being part of the church. Being a Christian means joining a community committed to express Christ's reality in its shared life.

Since the church is one body, unity is necessary. Paul often encouraged Christians to stay united and not let differences separate them.

The church includes people from different ethnic groups, so it should be a community of harmony and peace. Christians should live together in love, united by their shared experience of the Holy Spirit ([Ephesians 4:2-6](#)). God's goal for the church is to reach complete unity, faith, spiritual understanding, and Christian maturity. He intends for the full perfection of Christ ([4:13, 15](#); compare [Romans 8:29](#)). The church must reflect God's likeness ([Ephesians 4:24, 32](#); [5:1](#)).

Just like each part of the human body has a role, each church member has a function. God has given people in the church various gifts to strengthen the community and help it reach its full potential ([Ephesians 4:11-16](#); [Romans 12:6-8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:7-11, 28](#)).

God intends for the church to display his forgiving grace ([Ephesians 2:7](#); [3:10](#)). It should be a community where people can see God's glory, committed to praising that glory ([3:21](#); [5:18-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 8:29](#); [12:6-8](#); [1 Corinthians 3:16-17](#); [6:16](#); [12:7-28](#); [Galatians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 1:9-10](#), [23](#); [2:7](#); [2:14-3:13](#); [4:2-6](#), [11-16](#); [5:18-20](#), [23-29](#); [Colossians 1:18](#), [24](#), [27](#); [1 Timothy 3:15](#); [1 Peter 2:5](#), [9-10](#)

The Church as a Living, Active Body

The apostle Paul considered the church as the living body of Jesus Christ made up of believers. Paul did not make any formal difference between professional church leaders and ordinary members, where only the leaders did the ministry work. The community had leaders (see, for example, [1 Timothy 3:1-13](#)). But every Christian could contribute to building up the body ([1 Corinthians 12:12-31](#)). The early Christians usually gathered together in someone's home, and everyone could share a gift from God with others ([14:26-33](#)).

Paul understood that God's Spirit gives people special gifts for their specific ministries ([1 Corinthians 2:7-11, 28](#); [Romans 12:6-8](#); [Ephesians 4:11](#)). The Holy Spirit leads them when they come together for worship. Guided by the Spirit, every believer should use their spiritual gifts to help the church. Paul wanted believers to be aware of the Spirit's power in everything they did ([1 Corinthians 14:26-33](#)).

When Christians gather, every person is important and has an active role to play. Christians must listen for God speaking his word and be ready to speak it in all their relationships. Paul also calls for others to "weigh carefully" (or evaluate) what is said ([1 Corinthians 14:26, 29](#)). Every Christian is a necessary part of the group. Each person is called to actively help it grow.

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 12:4-8](#); [1 Corinthians 12:7-31](#); [14:26-33](#); [Ephesians 1:23](#); [4:11-13](#); [Colossians 1:24](#); [2:18-19](#); [1 Timothy 3:1-16](#)

The Church as God's Temple

The idea of the church as God's temple comes from the Old Testament. The kings David and Solomon received a promise that the temple in Jerusalem would be where God lived among his people (see [2 Samuel 7:12-16](#); [1 Kings 9:1-9](#)). Solomon finished the temple in 960 BC. The Babylonians destroyed it

in 586 BC. But the prophets of Israel anticipated a new temple. They shared a hopeful message that God would live among his people again (see, for example, [Isaiah 56:7](#); [Ezekiel 40–43](#)).

The Israelites rebuilt the temple in Jerusalem after the exile when they returned from Babylon. It reached its peak during Herod the Great's additions. But the arrival of Jesus Christ truly fulfilled the hopes of God's people (see [John 1:14](#); [2:19–22](#); [4:21–24](#)). Jesus is God's temple, where God's holiness lives. God invites his people to join him. Therefore, God's people should be a holy temple, a home for the Holy Spirit (see [1 Corinthians 3:16–17](#); [6:19](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16](#); [Ephesians 2:21](#); [1 Peter 2:5](#); [Revelation 3:12](#)).

The apostle Paul urged Christians to understand their identity as God's holy people (called "saints" in [2 Corinthians 1:1](#)). They should avoid moral evil and commit themselves to holy living and service to God. Paul encourages Christians to "cleanse ourselves from everything that defiles body and spirit, perfecting holiness in the fear of God" ([7:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 7:12–16](#); [1 Kings 8:12–53](#); [2 Chronicles 6:20](#); [Psalms 11:4](#); [27:4–6](#); [Zechariah 6:12–15](#); [Matthew 18:20](#); [John 2:18–22](#); [14:20](#); [17:23](#); [Romans 8:10](#); [1 Corinthians 3:10–17](#); [6:18–20](#); [9:11–14](#); [2 Corinthians 6:14–7:1](#); [Galatians 2:20](#); [Ephesians 2:20–22](#); [3:17–19](#); [Colossians 1:27](#); [Hebrews 3:6](#); [12:18–24](#); [1 Peter 2:4–9](#); [Revelation 1:12–16](#); [3:12](#), [20](#); [21:22](#)

The Cities of Refuge

The Israelites built the cities of refuge to protect innocent people from blood revenge. An avenger had the legal right to kill a murderer ([Numbers 35:19](#); see [Genesis 9:6](#)). If someone accidentally caused a death, the person fled to a city of refuge for temporary safety while awaiting trial ([Numbers 35:22–28](#)). The six cities of refuge spread across Hebrew territory so any Israelite could seek refuge.

After the trial, if the elders of the city found the person guilty of murder (instead of accidental killing), they handed him over to the avenger for punishment ([Deuteronomy 19:12](#)). If they found the person innocent, the killer stayed in the city of refuge for safety. When the high priest died, the killer could return home without fear of blood revenge. This compassionate law prevented the

land from pollution by innocent blood (see [Numbers 35:33](#)).

Paying a fine to repay the death of a person was not acceptable, even if the death was accidental ([Numbers 35:31–33](#)). Human life was too valuable for money to purchase it. When someone killed another person, whether on purpose or by accident, it led to alienation or exile.

Atonement is not easy, whether in ancient Israelite times or today. Everyone needs atonement to restore their relationship with God (see [Romans 3:23–26](#)). Jesus, the Son of God, offers this reconciliation. He acts as the great high priest and died as the ultimate sacrifice (see [Hebrews 4:14–10:18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 35:6–34](#); [Deuteronomy 19:1–13](#); [Joshua 20:1–9](#); [21:13](#), [21](#), [27](#), [32](#), [38](#); [1 Kings 1:50–53](#); [2:28–34](#)

The Climax of Scripture

The gospel story of the two disciples on the road to Emmaus is important. It shows Jesus' victory over death and reveals his role as the Messiah (God's chosen one). It also connects to Old Testament prophecies about him.

The two disciples told their unknown traveling companion that Jesus was a great prophet because of his teachings and miracles. They had hoped he was the Messiah. When the Jewish leaders arrested and crucified him, these two disciples became desperate and discouraged.

Jesus scolded them for not reading the Scriptures carefully. The Scriptures had always prophesied the Messiah's suffering. The apostle Luke then describes how Jesus guided the two disciples through the Scriptures, explaining "explained to them what was written in all the Scriptures about Himself" ([Luke 24:27](#)).

Jesus does not indicate which Old Testament passages talk about the suffering Christ. But other passages from Luke's writings refer to various texts:

- Jesus is "the stone the builders rejected" that "has become the cornerstone," for a new temple of God ([Psalm 118:22](#), cited in [Luke 20:17](#)).
- He is the suffering servant of the Lord, treated like a common criminal ([Isaiah 53:12](#), cited in [Luke 22:37](#)).
- His opponents mock, insult, and spit upon him ([Isaiah 50:6](#), suggested in [Luke 18:32](#)).
- He is the anointed king rejected by the leaders and the people of Israel, but declared innocent by God ([Psalm 2:1-2](#), cited in [Acts 4:25-28](#)).
- He is the descendant of King David who God will not abandon to the grave ([Psalm 16:8-11](#), cited in [Acts 2:25-28](#)).

According to [Luke 24:27](#), Jesus reviewed Israel's history and showed how it anticipates and achieves its purpose (climax) with Jesus the Messiah, God's agent of salvation. This is similar to how the apostle Paul describes Christ as "the end of the law" ([Romans 10:4](#)). All the Old Testament Scriptures, including the law of Moses, the prophets, and the Psalms, show God's story of salvation ([Luke 24:44](#)). This story achieves its purpose in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus.

Passages for Further Study

[Luke 24:13-49](#); [Romans 10:4](#)

The Cloud and Fire

When Israel was in the wilderness, God guided them with a pillar of cloud and fire. The pillar appeared to the Israelites immediately after the first Passover, when they left Egypt ([Exodus 13:20-22](#)).

The pillar had many roles:

- 104.** When the Egyptians chased the Israelites as they left Egypt, the pillar moved behind the Israelites and stopped the Egyptians ([Exodus 14:19-20](#)).

- 105.** During Israel's travels, the pillar showed that "the Lord went before them" ([Exodus 13:21](#)).
- 106.** When the pillar settled over the tabernacle and Israel's camp, it represented the Lord's presence and protection.
- 107.** The cloud and fire also guided the Israelites when traveling ([Exodus 40:36-38](#); [Numbers 9:17-23](#)). When the pillar stayed still, Israel remained in place. When it lifted and moved, the Israelites followed. They camped in different places for various lengths of time, sometimes brief and sometimes long. Thus, Israel "camped at the LORD's command, and they set out at the LORD's command" ([Numbers 9:23](#)).
- 108.** The pillar of cloud and fire was like a divine flag over the tribes as they marched (compare [Numbers 10:14, 18, 22, 25](#)).

The pillar appeared as a cloud during the day and as a pillar of fire at night ([Numbers 9:15-16](#); [Exodus 13:21](#)). In the Bible, fire and clouds often show God's presence and glory (for example, [Exodus 19:16-18](#); [24:15-18](#); [Matthew 17:5](#); [24:30](#); [Acts 1:9](#); compare [Psalm 18:8-13](#)). The cloud and fire showed that God's presence and glory traveled with Israel through the wilderness. This special appearance of God (a *theophany*) stayed with them during all their travels in the wilderness ([Exodus 40:38](#); see also [Exodus 13:22](#)).

Sometimes, the cloud covered the tabernacle, and the glory of the Lord filled it, so Moses could not enter ([Exodus 40:34-35](#)). Other times, the cloud came down and stayed near the entrance of the Tent of Meeting, showing that the Lord was speaking directly with Moses ([Exodus 33:7-11](#); compare [Numbers 11:25](#); [12:5](#); [Deuteronomy 31:15](#)). The pillar of cloud and fire was a constant reminder of the Lord's presence.

We do not have a detailed description of the fire and cloud, except that it had the shape of a pillar. Yet, it was a powerful symbol of God's special care for Israel (see [Nehemiah 9:19-21](#); compare [Psalms 46:1](#); [139](#); [John 1:14](#); [Romans 8:31-39](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 13:20-22; 14:19-24; 16:10; 19:16-18; 24:15-18; 33:7-11; 40:34-38; Leviticus 16:2; Numbers 9:15-23; 10:11-12, 34; 11:25; 12:5, 10; 14:14; 16:42; Deuteronomy 31:15; 1 Kings 8:11; 2 Chronicles 5:14; Nehemiah 9:19-21; Psalms 78:14; 99:7; 104:3; Ezekiel 1:4-5; 10:3; Matthew 17:5; 24:30; 26:64; Luke 9:34-35; Acts 1:9; 1 Corinthians 10:2; 1 Thessalonians 4:17; Revelation 1:7; 14:14-16](#)

The Collapse of Culture

Impressive cultures with creative and skilled people sometimes come to an end suddenly and completely. When digging, archaeologists often find a layer of ash between layers of impressive artifacts. The ash shows the culture's destruction. This is one of the most troubling parts of human history.

Israel's history includes cycles of bravery and success, followed by disaster. Leaders like Joshua, Samuel, David, and Solomon brought Israel to power. Yet, the nation often worshiped other gods instead of the one true God. As a result, God's people experienced judgment, and their culture failed.

They lost political independence and became slaves treated badly. The northern kingdom of Israel was particularly attracted to worshiping idols like Baal and Asherah. Thus, God allowed the Assyrians to conquer the northern kingdom, destroying it in 722 BC.

During the prophet Jeremiah's time, the spiritual and political culture in Judah was collapsing. Some kings, like Josiah, followed the covenant ban against idol worship and brought the people back to God. Yet, many rulers, including King Josiah's sons, did not continue these changes.

For instance, King Jehoiakim ignored his father's renewed commitment to God. He considered it as a threat to his political power. He became so opposed to the Lord that he tried to kill Jeremiah, the Lord's messenger. King Zedekiah was more fearful than opposed to change, but he also refused to obey the Lord.

God's messages through Jeremiah strongly criticize Judah's worship of Baal ([Jeremiah 2:8; 7:9; 11:13, 17; 12:16; 19:5; 23:13, 27; 32:29, 35](#)). He also criticized the immorality linked to this idol worship. Judah's moral decay and spiritual corruption, shown by its greed, hate, and violence,

were obvious to everyone. The people stubbornly refused to abandon idol worship and return to the worship of the one true God. Yet, the people of Judah hoped God would perform a miracle by defeating the Babylonian army and sending it away.

They believed the temple would magically protect them. They did not realize that God hated their actions there. This quickened their destruction instead of protecting them ([Jeremiah 7:4-15](#)). They were completely unprepared for the horror of defeat in war and the destruction of their nation, capital, and temple. They did not understand that their spiritual and moral failure had already made their destruction certain.

Passages for Further Study

[Joshua 1:1-9; 11:16-23; 1 Samuel 4:1-22; 2 Kings 17:6-18; 23:1-25:30; Jeremiah 7:4-15; 19:1-7; 24:1-10; 28:10-17; Daniel 7:1-8:27](#)

The Coming of God's Kingdom

A key part of Jesus' message was that God's kingdom had come. The people of Israel eagerly awaited this reality. It would fulfill God's many promises that had not yet become a reality:

- The Holy Spirit would return, as the Spirit had in the past. And God would "pour out" his Spirit on each Christian, fulfilling [Joel 2:28-32](#) (see [Acts 2:16-21](#)). This means that the Holy Spirit would be given to all believers, not just to special leaders as in Old Testament times.
- Jesus would defeat Satan ([Mark 3:27](#); [Luke 10:17-18](#)). This was already being shown when Jesus cast out demons ([Mark 1:21-28](#); [5:1-20](#); [Luke 11:20](#)). Jesus' power over demons was a sign that he was beginning to overcome Satan's influence in the world.
- The new covenant promised in [Jeremiah 31:31-34](#) would begin ([Mark 14:24](#)). This new agreement between God and his people would replace the old covenant made at Mount Sinai.
- The resurrection from the dead would produce its "firstfruits" ([Mark 8:31](#); [9:9, 31](#); [10:33-34](#); [16:6](#); [1 Corinthians 15:20, 23](#)). This means that Jesus would be the first to rise from the dead with a glorified body, beginning the process that will eventually include all believers.
- God's Anointed, the promised Son of David would come ([Matthew 2:1-12](#); [Luke 2:25-38](#)). This refers to the Messiah (or Christ), the special leader God promised to send who would be a descendant of King David.

Jesus's birth, ministry, death, resurrection, and ascension fulfilled these aspects of God's kingdom. People must repent and trust in the gospel (good news) because God's kingdom has come in Jesus ([Matthew 4:23](#); [6:10](#); [Mark 1:14-15](#); [4:26-32](#); [Luke 4:42-43](#)).

When Jesus began the kingdom, everything changed in Israel. The Holy Spirit was active again, working through John the Baptist and Jesus. For those who understood, the promised Christ, or Messiah, had arrived. Because God's kingdom was present in Jesus, the disciples did not fast like the Pharisees and John's disciples ([Mark 2:18-20](#)).

Fasting was not suitable because Old Testament promises were becoming fulfilled.

It was a time for celebration and feasting ([Mark 2:19-20](#)). This was because God's rule had started. People were already entering the kingdom and experiencing its signs ([10:23-31](#); [9:1](#)).

A future aspect of God's kingdom will happen when Jesus returns ([Mark 14:25](#)). At that time, God will judge evil and fully establish justice. Disease, poverty, and death will end. Jesus, the Son of Man, will return in glory and gather his chosen ones ([Mark 13:24-27](#); [Titus 2:11-14](#)).

He will judge the world ([Mark 8:38](#); [14:62](#); [Matthew 25:31-46](#); [2 Timothy 4:1](#); [Revelation 14:14-20](#)). He will resurrect the dead ([1 Corinthians 15:12-57](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11](#)). No one knows when Jesus will return ([Mark 13:32](#)). His followers should stay spiritually alert and watch for his coming as they await "the blessed hope" ([13:33-37](#); [Titus 2:13](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Jeremiah 31:31-34](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Matthew 4:23](#); [5:3](#); [6:10](#); [25:31-46](#); [Mark 1:14-15](#); [4:11](#), [26-32](#); [8:31-38](#); [9:1](#), [47](#); [10:23-25](#), [29-31](#); [13:24-27](#), [32-37](#); [14:25](#), [62](#); [Luke 2:25-38](#); [4:18-19](#), [42-43](#); [6:20](#); [10:18-20](#); [11:20](#); [Acts 1:6-8](#); [2:16-21](#); [1 Corinthians 15:22-28](#); [Titus 2:11-14](#)

The Coming of the Lord as Judge

The Bible tells us there will be a day of judgment. The book of James provides followers of Jesus with a warning and a promise about that day. James announces the Lord's future coming as Judge ([5:7-9](#); see also [Isaiah 26:21](#); [Micah 1:3](#)). God, who gave the law, is the "Judge, the One who is able to save and destroy" ([James 4:12](#)). Those who oppose Jesus Christ and oppress his followers will experience severe consequences (see [James 2:6-7](#); [5:5-6](#)).

God will judge followers of Jesus if they do these wrong things:

- if they fail to show mercy ([2:13](#));
- if they become friends with the world and its values ([4:4](#));
- if they sin with their words ([4:11](#); [5:9](#)); or
- if they live to satisfy evil desires ([4:1](#), [16](#)).

God will judge them according to the law that was meant to set them free ([2:12](#)).

The Lord's future coming affects our lives now. God already honors the faithful poor and humbles the rich who treat them badly ([James 1:9-10](#); [5:2-3](#)). Followers of Jesus are already God's special people as God is restoring all things ([1:18](#)). James says we should obey "the royal law" of the kingdom of Jesus the Messiah ([2:8](#)). Followers of Jesus will one day inherit this kingdom ([2:5](#)).

The return of Jesus might not happen soon. So James encourages Christians to endure and wait patiently for Jesus' return ([James 1:3-4](#); [5:7-8](#)). They will "receive the crown of life" ([1:12](#)). And they will gather the rewards of righteousness, which come from a life that is faithful to God ([3:18](#)).

Since judgment is coming, James commands followers of Jesus to "resist the devil" and "submit" themselves to God ([James 4:7](#)). We should "mourn" our sin and live with pure intentions and actions ([4:8-9](#)). We must help any Christian brother or sister who is moving away "from the truth" toward eternal death ([5:19-20](#)). Like the prophet Elijah, we must have faith, and practice prayer and confession ([5:13-18](#)). Like Job, we must endure suffering. Eventually, we will understand the extent of God's kindness and mercy ([4:10](#); [5:11](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 2:10](#); [Psalms 2:7-12](#); [96:11-13](#); [Isaiah 26:21](#); [Micah 1:3](#); [Matthew 16:27](#); [Luke 12:35-48](#); [18:8](#); [John 5:22-30](#); [Acts 10:42](#); [1 Corinthians 4:5](#); [James 5:7-9](#); [1 John 2:28](#)

The Coming of the Spirit of God

In the Old Testament, the Spirit of God sometimes "came upon" people to give them power for God's work and to prophesy ([Numbers 24:2](#); [Judges 3:10](#); [1 Samuel 10:10](#); [16:13](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#)). During Jesus' time, many people believed that the Spirit of prophecy had left Israel after the last Old

Testament prophets. Yet, the prophets predicted that when God's salvation came, he would "pour out" his Spirit on everyone ([Isaiah 32:15](#); [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#)).

This prophecy first comes true in the birth story of Jesus in Luke's Gospel. The Holy Spirit inspired prophets to witness and guided the events of Jesus' birth.

The Spirit filled John the Baptist even before birth ([Luke 1:15](#), [41](#)). His father Zechariah sang a Spirit-filled hymn of praise to God ([1:67](#)). Mary, the mother of Jesus, became pregnant with Jesus and prophesied through the Spirit's power ([1:35](#); [1:46-55](#)). The Spirit led the elderly Simeon to the temple to see the Christ ([2:25-27](#)). Later, the Spirit anointed Jesus at his baptism and empowered him to fulfill his role as the Christ ([3:21-22](#); [4:1](#), [18](#)).

After Jesus ascended to heaven, he fulfilled Old Testament prophecies by sending his Spirit to his disciples on the day of Pentecost. This empowered them to spread the good news (gospel) of salvation worldwide ([Luke 24:49](#); [Acts 1:8](#); [2:4](#), [17-18](#)). In the book of Acts, the church completed its mission with the Holy Spirit's guidance, power, and direction. The Spirit's arrival marks the start of a new era of God's salvation. God's presence and power are now within and among his people through the Holy Spirit.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 24:2](#); [Judges 3:10](#); [1 Samuel 10:10](#); [16:13](#); [Isaiah 32:15](#); [Ezekiel 11:5](#); [36:26-27](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Luke 1:15](#), [35](#), [41](#), [67](#); [2:24-27](#); [3:22](#); [4:1](#), [18](#); [24:49](#); [Acts 2:4](#), [17-18](#)

The Creation

The story of the creation of the universe is key to the Bible's message. Understanding the first chapters of the book of Genesis is important for developing a biblical perspective of the world (worldview).

The opening chapters of the Bible address key questions: Who created the world, and why? Why is the world as it is now? Genesis answers these questions. It counters the idol worship that Israel learned from their pagan rulers in Egypt.

In the promised land, the Israelites would again be close to people who trusted in false gods and worshiped created things instead of the creator. Genesis taught Israel that the one true God created

everything and has complete authority over all things. He alone deserves worship.

God changed chaos and made it the orderly universe we see today. In the first three days, he shaped the formless void into the structured universe. He created the heavens, water and sky, and the earth. In the next three days, he filled each area with life. On the seventh day, God's day of rest, he set a weekly pattern for human activity. This rest also points to the future spiritual rest God promised to those who trust in him (see [Hebrews 3:7-4:11](#)).

The creation story teaches that when God finished the creation, it was "very good" ([Genesis 1:31](#)). In this setting, humans had a perfect relationship with their creator until they sinned and violated that bond. This rebellion against God introduced evil into human souls (see chapters [3-6](#)). The world's evil does not result from a flaw in creation. Instead, it comes from rebelling against God's design and purposes.

Since the first rebellion, humans have separated themselves from the creator. They often do not acknowledge his presence and authority.

[Genesis 3:7-19](#) shows what this separation causes:

- shame,
- failed relationships with God and others,
- disconnection from the rest of creation, and
- death.

Since then, God has actively worked in history to restore humans to a relationship with him through Jesus Christ. Restored humans become a new creation (see [Galatians 6:15](#)). Through Jesus, eternal life is available to everyone. God will renew everything one day (see [Isaiah 65:17-25](#); [Romans 8:19-22](#)). The entire universe will be made new ([Revelation 21:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:1-2:3](#); [Psalm 33:6-9](#); [Proverbs 3:19](#); [8:22-31](#); [Isaiah 40:26-28](#); [45:11-12](#), [18-19](#); [Jeremiah 10:11-16](#); [John 1:1-4](#); [Romans 8:18-25](#); [2 Corinthians 5:17](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#); [Revelation 4:11](#); [21:1-5](#)

The Creator-King

God created and established the world. All of creation is his work ([Genesis 1-2](#); [Psalm 24:1-2](#); [95:4-5](#)). He also rules over his creation, managing and caring for everything he has made ([95:6-7](#); [96:10](#)).

Several psalms celebrate God's glory in creation ([Psalms 8](#); [19](#); [28](#); [33](#); [89](#); and [104](#)):

- 109.** [Psalm 8](#) emphasizes how God gives humans splendor and makes them rulers of creation.
- 110.** [Psalm 19](#) encourages us to think deeply about creation to gain wisdom.
- 111.** [Psalm 29](#) shows God's power and the stability of his creation.
- 112.** [Psalm 33](#) praises God's rule, order, and wisdom in creation, emphasizing the importance of respecting the Lord.
- 113.** In [Psalm 89](#), God's bases his promise to David on his commitment to creation ([89:9-18](#)).
- 114.** [Psalms 93-100](#) reflect on God's rule over the world. The earth belongs to him, and he has shown his power throughout history.
- 115.** [Psalm 104](#) is a hymn about creation. It turns the six days of creation into a beautiful song praising God's wisdom.

Scripture commands all nations to acknowledge and praise God, accepting his supreme authority (see [Psalm 9:11](#); [47:1-2](#), [7-9](#); [66:8](#); [117:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:1-2:4](#); [Psalms 8](#); [19](#); [28](#); [29](#); [33](#); [89](#); [93-100](#); [104](#); [Ecclesiastes 12:1-7](#), [13-14](#); [Isaiah 40:25-28](#); [43:15](#); [44:24](#); [51:13](#); [Jeremiah 10:16](#); [Acts 4:23-31](#); [Colossians 3:10](#)

The Cross and Passover

At the start of John's Gospel, John the Baptist introduced Jesus as "the Lamb of God" ([John 1:29, 36](#)). This phrase might refer to the sacrificial lamb killed daily in the temple ([Exodus 29:38-46](#)). Or it might refer to the sacrificial lamb mentioned in [Isaiah 53:7](#) (see [Acts 8:32-35](#); [Revelation 5:5-14](#)).

Both sacrifices represent rescue and forgiveness from sin.

Yet, this was not all that the apostle John intended. John presented Jesus as the Passover lamb. This lamb's death is the central event of the Passover season (see [Exodus 12:43-47](#); [Luke 22:7](#); [1 Corinthians 5:7](#)).

In the first century, Jews traveled to Jerusalem each spring to celebrate Passover and once again read the story of the exodus from Egypt (see [Exodus 12-15](#)). When God rescued Israel from Egypt, the Israelites sprinkled lamb's blood on their doorposts. This act saved those inside each home from death ([Exodus 12](#)). Jews who came to Jerusalem for Passover needed to provide a perfect young lamb for sacrifice. The lamb could have no disease or broken bones.

Jesus used his last Passover meal to show that his sacrificial death would give new meaning to the feast ([Mark 14:17-25](#)). At his crucifixion, they did not break Jesus' legs, which was often done to fulfill a Passover rule ([John 19:31-33](#); see [Exodus 12:46](#)). Blood flowed freely from his wound ([John 19:34](#)). This showed that he was giving his life for others. A lamb died to save Jewish families during Passover in Egypt. Similarly, the death of the Son of God on the cross brings salvation to the world.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 12:1-13:16](#); [29:38-46](#); [Numbers 9:1-14](#); [Deuteronomy 16:1-8](#); [2 Kings 23:21-23](#); [2 Chronicles 30:1-27](#); [Ezra 6:19-21](#); [Isaiah 53:7](#); [Ezekiel 45:21-22](#); [Matthew 26:2, 17-19](#); [Mark 14:17-31](#); [Luke 22:14-30](#); [John 1:29, 36](#); [John 19:17-36](#); [Acts 8:32-35](#); [12:3-4](#); [1 Corinthians 5:7-8](#); [Hebrews 11:28](#); [Revelation 5:5-14](#)

The Dangers of Sin

Choosing sin instead of remaining faithful to the one true God leads to disaster. This has been true since the beginning, when Adam and Eve's disobedience brought curses and separation from their first home ([Genesis 3](#)). It was also true throughout Israel's history (see, for example, [Numbers 16](#); [Joshua 7](#); [2 Samuel 11:1-12:19](#)). The New Testament gives many warnings about the eternal consequences of not repenting for sinful behavior ([1 Corinthians 6:9-10](#); [Galatians 5:19-21](#); [Revelation 22:15](#)).

During the late period of the Israelite kingdom, God's people often committed sinful acts. Words like *sin* and *evil* frequently describe the kings of Israel ([2 Kings 3:2](#); [13:2, 11](#); [14:24](#); [15:9, 18, 24, 28](#); [17:2](#)). This was true about the kings of Judah as well. They "did evil in the sight of the LORD" ([8:18, 27](#); [21:2, 16, 20](#); [23:32, 37](#); [24:9, 19](#)).

The northern kingdom of Israel was especially guilty. The Scriptures consistently criticize the kings and people for their lack of faith ([2 Kings 17:16-17, 22](#)). The main sin of false worship, started by Jeroboam I, continued in Israel until the end ([10:29](#); [17:21-23](#); [23:15](#)). God gave repeated warnings to the people through his prophets ([17:13](#)). He allowed foreign invaders to punish them ([13:3, 7](#)).

The Israelites did not change their behavior ([13:6](#); [17:14-17](#)). Eventually, God let foreign invaders defeat them and capture their land. The Assyrians took many people away into exile ([17:18, 20-23](#)).

The people of Judah were not innocent either. Many of their kings were guilty of serious evil. Judean society became more rebellious, and "lived according to the customs Israel had introduced" ([2 Kings 17:19](#)). But God showed repeated kindness (for example, [19:32-36](#)). His prophets warned the people ([21:8-15](#)). Yet, the people continued to sin, and God judged them again ([21:10-15](#); [23:26-27](#); [24:1-4](#); [25:1-21](#)).

When people truly repent, God will graciously forgive them and remove sin's penalty. Yet, it is better to remain faithful to God's commands ([2 Kings 18:5-6](#); [23:25](#); [Psalm 119:9-11, 33-37](#); [2 Timothy 4:7](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)). Then God's blessings can lead to success ([Psalm 112:1](#); [119:1-2](#); [144:15](#); [2 Kings 18:7](#); see also [2 Chronicles 26:4-5](#); [Proverbs 3:1-10](#); [2 Corinthians 3:5](#)). God's people should give God priority in their lives ([1 Kings 18:21, 36-39](#); see [Deuteronomy 6:13](#); [10:12-13](#); [Micah 6:8](#); [Matthew 6:33](#)). They should pray for God's enduring grace ([Psalm 19:13](#)). They should let the word of God guide them ([Psalm 119:9](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Timothy 3:16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 18:20-21](#); [Exodus 34:7](#); [Leviticus 26:14-46](#); [Numbers 15:30-31](#); [Deuteronomy 31:16-18](#); [1 Kings 8:46-51](#); [2 Kings 8:18, 27](#); [2 Kings 13:1-7](#); [14:23-24](#); [17:13-23](#); [18:9-12](#); [21:8-16](#); [23:25-27](#); [24:1-3](#); [19-25:21](#); [2 Chronicles 7:14](#); [33:12-13](#); [Psalm 119:9-11, 33-37](#); [Jeremiah 44:2-6](#); [Micah 6:8](#); [Matthew 6:33](#); [Colossians 3:16](#); [2 Timothy 3:16](#); [4:7](#); [Revelation 2:10](#)

The Day Is Coming

Jesus prophesied three future events in the Synoptic Gospels:

116. One event was his own death and resurrection ([Mark 8:31](#); [9:31](#); [10:33-34](#)). This had already happened before the Gospels were written.
117. The second event Jesus prophesied was the destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 ([Matthew 24:1-28](#); [13:1-23](#); [Luke 19:41-44](#); [21:5-24](#)). This event was probably about to happen when Mark wrote his Gospel (see Mark Book Introduction, "Date"). Yet, this event would not mark the absolute end. So the Christian community must continue to live faithfully and be spiritually watching for the return of the Son of God in glory, which could be soon ([Mark 13:34-37](#)).
118. The third event Jesus prophesied was his own future return ([Matthew 23:39](#); [24:3](#), [29-31](#), [24:36-25:46](#); [Mark 8:38](#); [13:24-27](#), [32-37](#); [Luke 21:25-36](#); [John 14:1-3](#)). The New Testament frequently mentions Jesus' second coming (see, for example, [1 Corinthians 1:7-8](#); [3:13](#); [5:5](#); [2 Corinthians 1:14](#); [Philippians 1:6](#), [10](#); [2:16](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:1-11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2](#); [2 Timothy 1:12](#), [18](#); [4:1](#), [8](#)).

When Jesus returns, God's kingdom promises will come true. Jesus will judge and destroy Satan and his angels ([Romans 16:20](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:3-12](#)). Those who refuse to trust in Jesus will experience eternal judgment ([Matthew 13:40-42](#); [25:31-46](#); [Luke 6:24-26](#); [16:19-31](#); [Acts 10:42](#); [Ephesians 5:6](#); [Colossians 3:6](#); [Hebrews 10:25](#); [2 Peter 3:7](#); [Jude 1:6](#); [Revelation 1:7](#); [6:14](#), [17](#)). Meanwhile, the faithful will resurrect to enjoy eternal life ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#)). God will gather his chosen people for salvation ([Mark 13:27](#); [Hebrews 1:14](#); [9:27-28](#)), grace ([1 Peter 1:13](#)), and glory ([1 Thessalonians 2:12](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:14](#); [1 Peter 1:7](#); [5:1](#), [4](#)).

He will give his people an endless inheritance and new eternal bodies ([1 Peter 1:4](#); [1 Corinthians 15:35-57](#); [Philippians 3:21](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#)). God will free all of creation from its curse and transform it ([Genesis 3:17-18](#); [Romans 8:20-23](#); [2 Peter 3:12-13](#); [Revelation 21:1-22:5](#)). Sorrow, tears, mourning, and death will no longer exist ([Revelation 21:4](#)). Those who were faithful to Christ in this life "will see God" ([Matthew 5:8](#); [Revelation 22:3](#)).

Because of these promises, Christians must pray and wait for his return ([Matthew 6:10](#); [Revelation 22:20](#)). We must not try to guess the dates of his coming ([Mark 13:32](#); [Acts 1:7](#)). Instead, we must live honorably and stay prepared ([1 John 2:28](#); [Matthew 24:36-25:30](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:1-11](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 5:8](#); [6:10](#); [13:41-42](#); [23:39](#); [24:3-25:46](#); [Mark 8:38](#); [13:1-37](#); [14:25](#); [Luke 6:24-26](#); [16:19-31](#); [19:41-44](#); [21:5-36](#); [John 14:1-3](#); [Acts 1:6-7](#); [10:42](#); [Romans 8:20-23](#); [16:20](#); [1 Corinthians 1:7-8](#); [15:35-58](#); [2 Corinthians 1:14](#); [Philippians 1:6](#), [10](#); [2:16](#); [3:21](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2-14](#); [2 Timothy 4:1-8](#); [Titus 2:11-13](#); [Hebrews 9:28](#); [10:25](#), [37](#); [1 Peter 1:7](#), [13](#); [5:1-4](#); [2 Peter 3:7-13](#); [1 John 2:28](#); [Revelation 1:7](#); [6:15-17](#); [21:1-22:7](#); [22:12](#), [20](#)

The Day of the Lord

The phrase *Day of the Lord* describes a time when God judges his enemies with righteous punishment. The ungodly receive the punishment they deserve, while the righteous gain their complete salvation (see [Isaiah 3:16-4:6](#)). On this day, God shows his powerful control over creation. When God appears in glory, people feel fear ([2:10](#), [19](#), [21](#)). This is because he examines all human support systems. This includes religious, economic, military, and social structures.

This phrase first appears in the prophecy of Amos ([Amos 5:18](#)). But it did not start with him. Amos corrected a common misunderstanding among the Israelites. They thought the day of the Lord would be a joyful day of salvation. They believed God would judge Israel's enemies and restore Israelite rule over greater Canaan.

Yet, Amos warned that the day of the Lord would bring darkness, not light. This was because the people were rebelling against God (see [Amos 5:10-12](#), [21-27](#)). The Israelites were confident that God

was always on their side. But their sins made them God's enemies, deserving full punishment.

The prophets often used the phrase "that day" to describe an important event (see [Isaiah 2:11](#); [27:1](#); [Zephaniah 1:8](#)). Because of God's warnings and the people's sins, the prophets saw "that day" as near (see [Joel 1:15](#); [2:1](#)). They hoped their warnings would cause God's people to repent (see [Zephaniah 2:1-3](#)). Unfortunately, most people ignored these warnings.

The day of the Lord arrived for the northern kingdom when Assyria destroyed Samaria. It came for the southern kingdom when Babylon invaded and destroyed Jerusalem between 605 and 586 BC.

The day of the Lord is disastrous for ungodly people. The prophet Joel compares its destruction to a locust plague ([Joel 1:1-2:11](#)). Yet, this day guarantees God's people that he is sovereign and just. It is a day of salvation for those who obey the prophets and "everyone who calls on the name of the LORD" (see [Joel 2:31-32](#)).

The same God who brings destruction to his enemies will be a refuge and stronghold for his people ([Joel 3:16](#)). Nations used by God to judge Israel and Judah will later experience their own "day of the Lord" (see, for example, [Isaiah 13:4-22](#); [Ezekiel 30:1-5](#); [Obadiah 1:15-16](#)).

The Old Testament prophets mostly regarded judgment as happening during the exile of the Israelites to Babylon. New Testament writers use the phrase *Day of the Lord* to describe Jesus' return as the judge of the world. That day "will come like a thief" ([2 Peter 3:10](#); see also [1 Thessalonians 5:2-4](#)). Therefore, God's people must be ready, or they will experience an end similar to those who ignored the prophets' warnings.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 2:10-22](#); [4:1-6](#); [13:4-12](#); [Ezekiel 30:1-5](#); [Joel 1:13-15](#); [2:1-11](#), [28-32](#); [3:9-16](#); [Amos 5:18-24](#); [Obadiah 1:15-16](#); [Zephaniah 1:2-18](#); [Malachi 4:1-5](#); [1 Corinthians 1:8](#); [5:5](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:2](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2](#); [2 Timothy 1:18](#); [2 Peter 3:10](#); [Revelation 20:1-15](#)

The Exodus as History

Israel's view of reality was very different from other ancient cultures. Other major cultures around Israel, from Sumer in southern Mesopotamia in 2000 BC to Rome in AD 200,

developed their perspectives by observing creation. They believed in many gods and thought events happened in endless cycles. In contrast, ancient Israel believed in one God, separate from the world. He created the world with a purpose and guides events to fulfill that purpose.

How did the Israelites develop this unique view? Was it through encounters with the true God in historical events? The most reasonable explanation for Israel's distinct understanding is that, as the Bible describes, God revealed himself to them through events recorded as history.

Egyptian texts do not mention the events described in the Bible, which makes some people doubt. Yet, it was uncommon for a powerful nation to record their defeat by slaves. The Bible's historical accounts, including stories of Israel's own failures, are unique in the ancient Near East.

Archaeology cannot prove specific events happened. But it can show that conditions allowed them to occur. This is true for the book of Exodus and the Bible in general. Egyptian records and archaeology do not confirm or contradict the Bible's account. Yet, the text of Exodus shows a deep understanding of Egyptian thought and culture, similar to a historical record.

The Bible's writers believed they were describing real events. They expected readers to regard them that way. [Exodus 18:8-12](#) shows the first example of someone who trusted God because of a true story.

Faith in God and in the Bible has a strong historical foundation. God has acted in history to save humanity. His actions include Israel's escape from Egypt. These actions achieve their goal in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 14:15-15:21](#); [18:8-12](#); [Judges 11:12-27](#); [Acts 7:1-56](#)

The Family Redeemer

The idea of the family redeemer was established in the law of Moses. The story of Ruth shows us an example of this idea. In that book, this term has a specific legal meaning. In other places, the Hebrew term *go'el* translates as "next of kin" ([Numbers 27:11](#); [35:19, 24](#)).

According to the Moses' law, family redeemers had three main duties in Israel:

- 119.** [Leviticus 25:23-34](#) explains that if an Israelite became very poor and had to sell his land, a family member should pay off the debt to keep the land in the family. If no relative could buy the land and the seller could not buy it back, the land would still return to the seller or his heirs in the Jubilee year (fiftieth). Two examples of family redeemers buying land for their relatives are Boaz and Jeremiah ([Ruth 4:1-12](#); [Jeremiah 32:6-15](#)).
- 120.** Similarly, if an Israelite became very poor and had to sell himself into debt-slavery, a family redeemer had an obligation to release him from service to a non-relative ([Leviticus 25:35-55](#)). The poor Israelite would repay his debt by working for his relative. He would probably treat him better than a stranger would.
- 121.** The family redeemer was responsible for seeking justice if someone killed an Israelite, as described in [Numbers 35:9-34](#).

The idea of the family redeemer shows us that God owns everything. He tells us to love our neighbors as ourselves ([Leviticus 19:18](#); [Matthew 22:39-40](#)). The New Testament describes Jesus as the perfect family redeemer. He frees us from the slavery of sin and death, which we chose for ourselves ([Matthew 20:28](#); [Romans 3:24-25](#); [Ephesians 1:7](#); [Titus 2:14](#); [Revelation 5:9](#); compare [Exodus 6:6](#); [15:13](#); [Psalm 130:8](#); [Isaiah 44:22](#); [59:20](#); [63:9](#); [Jeremiah 31:11](#)).

Like the Old Testament family redeemer, such as Boaz, and following our great redeemer's example, we must show love and kindness to others ([Leviticus 19:11-18](#); [Matthew 5:43-48](#); [19:19](#); [22:37-40](#); [Romans 13:8-10](#); [Galatians 5:14](#); [James 2:8-9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 25:23-55](#); [Numbers 35:9-34](#); [Ruth 2:20](#); [3:9](#), [12](#); [4:1-10](#); [Isaiah 59:20](#); [Jeremiah 32:6-15](#); [Matthew 20:28](#); [Romans 3:24-25](#); [Ephesians 1:7](#); [Titus 2:14](#); [Revelation 5:9](#)

The Gift of Prophecy

As the apostle Peter stated on the day of Pentecost, prophecy was a result of God's Holy Spirit poured out ([Acts 2:17-21](#); see [Joel 2:28-32](#)). The book of Acts mentions a few Christian prophets ([Acts 11:27-28](#); [13:1](#); [15:32](#); [21:9-11](#); see also *The Martyrdom of Polycarp* 12:3; 16:2). One of these prophets was Agabus, who acted like an Old Testament prophet by performing symbolic acts ([Acts 21:10-11](#); see [1 Kings 11:29-32](#); [Isaiah 20:2-6](#); [Jeremiah 13:1-11](#); [Ezekiel 4:1-5:17](#)). He also prophesied future events ([Acts 11:28](#); [21:10-11](#)).

Philip the Evangelist had four daughters "who prophesied" ([Acts 21:9](#)). The apostle Paul also recognized that some Christian women had this prophetic gift ([1 Corinthians 11:5](#)). In the Old Testament, most prophets were men, but some women were also prophets, like Miriam, Deborah, and Huldah ([Exodus 15:20](#); [Judges 4:4](#); [2 Kings 22:14-20](#); [2 Chronicles 34:22-28](#)). In the New Testament, both men and women, young and old, receive the gift of prophecy, as Peter mentioned in his sermon on the day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:17-18](#)).

Prophecy sometimes involves predicting the future ([Acts 20:22-23](#); [21:10-11](#); see [Romans 9:24-33](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-17](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:3-4](#)). At its core, prophecy is about sharing God's message by preaching, urging, and explaining God's will ([Acts 15:32](#); [19:6](#); [Romans 12:6](#); [1 Corinthians 14:3-4](#), [29-33](#); [Revelation 19:10](#)). The gift of prophecy is plainly mentioned in the letters of 1 Corinthians and Ephesians as one of the gifts of the Holy Spirit and Jesus to his church ([1 Corinthians 12:4-11](#); [Ephesians 4:11-13](#)). It is intended to benefit Christians ([1 Corinthians 14:22](#)).

Prophecy needs testing ([1 Thessalonians 5:19-21](#)). The church receives strong warnings about false prophets ([1 John 4:1](#); see also [Revelation 2:20-23](#)). Christians must use this gift faithfully and as the Scriptures and God's Spirit instruct. Boldly sharing God's truth helps the church understand God's will and motivates people to obey it.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 15:20](#); [Deuteronomy 13:1-5](#); [Judges 4:4](#); [1 Kings 11:29-32](#); [2 Kings 22:14-20](#); [Isaiah 20:2-6](#); [44:25](#); [Jeremiah 13:1-11](#); [23:25-32](#); [Ezekiel 4:1-17](#); [13:2-9](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Matthew 7:15](#); [24:24](#); [Acts 2:17-21](#); [11:27-28](#); [13:1](#); [15:32](#); [19:6](#); [20:23](#); [Acts 21:9-11](#); [Romans 12:6](#); [1 Corinthians 11:5](#); [12:4-11](#); [14:1-40](#); [Ephesians 4:11-13](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:19-21](#); [2 Peter 2:1](#); [1 John 4:1-3](#); [Revelation 2:20-23](#); [19:10](#)

The Glory of God

Glory in the Old Testament means something different than in English. In English, it often describes something temporary, like a sunset or last year's winning team.

The Hebrew word for *glory* means what is "heavy" or "solid." It implies "importance" or "worth." This is the opposite of "temporary" or "empty." When God's glory appears, it is not just a bright light or a shining cloud. It is a visible sign of his absolute reality.

God's glory shows his presence, power, and majesty (see [Ezekiel 1:28; 10:4](#)). God's glory may appear in nature, like during a thunderstorm or in the plagues on the Egyptians ([Job 37:2-5; Psalm 29:3, 7; Numbers 14:21-22](#)). God's glory can also be a special event, like the revelation on Mount Sinai ([Deuteronomy 5:24](#)). When God established the tabernacle and King Solomon's temple, God's glory filled them ([Exodus 40:34-35; 1 Kings 8:10-11](#)). This showed his approval and presence there. Similarly, the glory of the Lord sent the fire that started the first sacrifices in the holy place ([Leviticus 9:22-24](#)).

When God shows his glory to his creation, it is often called a *theophany* (see, for example, [Exodus 24:16-18](#)). God provides limited views of his glory because he says, "no one can see Me and live" ([Exodus 33:18-23](#); see also [Isaiah 6:5](#)). To "give glory" to God means to speak or act in a way that acknowledges who God is ([Joshua 7:19; Isaiah 24:15; Jeremiah 13:16](#)).

Jesus Christ reflects God's glory and image ([2 Corinthians 4:4](#)). Through his death and resurrection, God glorified him ([John 17:1-5](#)). When Jesus returns, he will show God's glory in his restored kingdom ([Revelation 21:11, 23](#)). The apostle Paul says that Christ's presence in Christians' lives guarantees us that we will share in that glory ([Romans 5:2; Colossians 1:27](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 14:17-18; 16:6-12; 33:17-23; 40:34-38; Leviticus 9:23-24; 10:1-3; Numbers 14:21-22; Deuteronomy 5:24; Joshua 7:19; 1 Kings 8:11; 2 Chronicles 7:1-3; Job 37:2-5; Psalms 3:3; 8:4-6; 19:1; 29:3, 7-9; 48:8; Isaiah 6:3-5; 42:8; 43:7; 66:18-19; Jeremiah 13:16; Ezekiel 1:28; 10:4; Hosea 4:7; John 17:1-5; Romans 5:2; 2 Corinthians 4:4; Colossians 1:27; Revelation 21:10-11, 23-25](#)

The Good News Message

The apostles shared the good news about Jesus (or "gospel") in a specific order, with these parts:

- 122.** The Old Testament promises came true through Jesus Christ's life, death, and resurrection.
- 123.** God has lifted up Jesus by raising him from the dead to be the leader of the new people of God as the Messiah chosen by God.
- 124.** The apostles witnessed God's work in Jesus Christ. They saw his public ministry and resurrection ([Acts 2:32; 3:15; 4:33; 5:30-32; 13:30-31](#)). They served as his chosen messengers ([10:39-43](#)).
- 125.** The right response to this good news is to repent (turn away from sin) and trust in Jesus ([Acts 2:38; 3:19; 13:39, 48; 17:30; 20:21; 26:20](#)).
- 126.** God promises to give the Holy Spirit to those who accept God's forgiveness and salvation from sin through Jesus Christ.

The apostles often shared this basic message with both Jews and non-Jews (called gentiles) across the Mediterranean region (see [Acts 1:8; 9:15](#)). You can find it in the speeches of Peter and Philip in [2:14-41; 3:12-26; 4:8-12; 5:29-32; 8:4-13, 26-40](#); and [10:34-43](#). Paul's preaching also includes these themes (for example, [Acts 13:16-49; 1 Corinthians 15:1-11](#)).

This powerful message of God's saving grace changes people's wills and minds to obey him. Receiving this message is the first step towards salvation. God calls everyone to repent from sin and trust in the saving power of Jesus ([Acts 4:12; 13:38; 16:30-31](#)). Through Jesus, God continues to make everyone right with him who continues to trust in him ([13:39](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 4:23-24; 24:14; Mark 1:1, 14-15; Luke 4:18-21; Acts 2:14-40; 3:12-26; 8:25-40; Acts 10:34-43; 13:16-41; 16:31; 17:16-31; 20:21; Romans 1:1-5, 15-17; 10:15-17; 16:25-27; 1 Corinthians 1:18; 15:3-8; 2 Corinthians 4:3-7;](#)

[Ephesians 1:13; 2:4-18; 2 Thessalonians 2:13-14; 2 Timothy 1:9-10; 2:8-13; Hebrews 4:1-16; 1 Peter 1:3-12; Revelation 14:6-7](#)

The Grace of God

Grace is an important word in the Bible. It shows God's kindness and favor. It is often related to how he saves those who do not deserve it. The New Testament emphasizes that grace came through Jesus Christ ([John 1:14-17](#)). This does not mean God's grace was absent in the Old Testament. Instead, God's grace toward humanity achieved its goal through his Son.

According to the book of Acts, the Jewish community was the first to experience God's great favor (see [Acts 11:19-21; 13:43-49](#)). Later, it became obvious that God's grace through Jesus Christ also extends to non-Jewish people (gentiles) ([Acts 15:8-9; Ephesians 2:11-18; Titus 2:11](#)). Miraculous signs and wonders confirmed God's grace at work among the gentiles ([Acts 14:3](#)).

The apostle Paul shared the good news (the gospel) about God's wonderful grace ([Acts 20:24](#)). He did not try to prove God's grace. He assumed it as true when sharing the good news (see, for example, [Romans 3:24; 5:15-21](#)). Paul made it plain that we do not earn our salvation.

God acts only through his grace ([Romans 4:4-5; Ephesians 2:4-9](#)). People cannot do good works to earn us favor with God. If they did, God would have to reward them like a worker earns a wage (see [Romans 11:5-6](#)).

God's grace affects Christians throughout their lives, not just at conversion. The letter of 2 Peter ends with a command for Christians to "grow in the grace" of "Jesus Christ" ([2 Peter 3:18](#)). Paul "urged them to continue in the grace of God" as they remained faithful to their Lord ([Acts 13:43](#)).

When Paul left the leaders of the church at Ephesus, he entrusted them "to God and to the word of His grace." This was a divine message that could strengthen and support them ([Acts 20:32](#); see [15:40](#)). God's grace is central to the Christian message and experience, from start to finish. It is no surprise that grace is a common theme in the writings of Jesus' early followers.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 34:5-7; Numbers 6:22-27; Ezra 9:8; Psalms 30:5; 31:16; Psalm 84:11; Isaiah 60:10;](#)

[61:1-3; Hosea 14:1-9; Luke 4:18-19; Acts 15:11; 20:24; Romans 5:15-17, 20-21; 12:6; 2 Corinthians 6:1; 8:9; 12:9; Galatians 2:21; 4:10; 5:3-6; Ephesians 1:3-8; 2:4-10; 2 Timothy 1:9; 2:1; Titus 2:11; 3:7; Hebrews 2:9; 4:16; 13:9; James 4:6; 1 Peter 5:5-6, 12; 2 Peter 3:17-18](#)

The Growth of the Church

The book of Acts describes the church's growth after the day of Pentecost. Initially, the church increased in numbers. After Jesus' ascension to heaven, only 120 Christians attended the first prayer meeting to seek divine guidance ([Acts 1:12-15](#)). After the Holy Spirit's powerful arrival on Pentecost, the number of Christians increased to about 3,000 ([2:41](#)). Many more accepted Peter and John's preaching of the good news about Jesus (the gospel), increasing the number to about 5,000 ([4:4](#)). The church continued to increase ([5:14; 6:1; 9:31; 21:20](#)).

There is also plain evidence of geographical spread (see [Acts 1:8; 9:15](#)). The church was not only in Jerusalem. The gospel message spread to Lydda, Sharon, and Joppa on the Mediterranean coast ([9:32-43](#)). The message of salvation in Christ also expanded from its Jewish base into Samaria ([8:4-12](#)).

Then it spread into Phoenicia, Cyprus, and Antioch ([11:19-26](#)). As Peter declared to the household of the Roman centurion Cornelius, "God does not show favoritism" ([10:34](#)). The message of "the gospel of peace through Jesus Christ" is for everyone ([10:36](#)).

As the Christian faith increased in numbers and spread geographically, Christian communities also experienced deeper spiritual growth. [Acts 2:42-47](#) shows this development in the church's inner life. It emphasizes united prayer during crises, generous sharing, courage in persecution, and bold witnessing ([4:23-31, 32-37; 5:27-33, 40-42; 16:19-25](#)). The preaching of the deacon and evangelist Philip, the deacon Stephen's manner of dying, and the behavior of the apostles Paul and Silas in prison showed great spiritual maturity ([7:59-60; 8:4-40; 16:19-25](#)).

Church leaders encouraged Christians, strengthened their faith, and helped them endure persecution ([14:22; 15:32, 41; 18:23](#); see [2 Timothy 1:8; 2:1-9; 3:12](#)). They lived by the standards they set for others ([1 Corinthians 4:16,](#)

[20](#); [Philippians 4:9](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:5-8](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:9](#)). The church's careful inclusion of non-Jewish people (gentiles) caused important spiritual and numerical growth. "So the churches were strengthened in the faith and grew daily in numbers" ([Acts 16:5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 1:8](#), [13-15](#); [2:41-47](#); [4:4](#), [23-37](#); [5:14](#), [27-33](#), [40-42](#); [6:1](#); [7:59](#); [8:4-40](#); [9:15](#), [31](#), [35](#), [42](#); [10:34](#), [36](#); [11:19-26](#); [14:22](#); [15:32](#), [41](#); [16:5](#), [19-25](#); [18:23](#); [21:20](#); [1 Corinthians 4:16](#), [20](#); [Philippians 4:9](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:5-8](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:9](#); [2 Timothy 1:8](#); [2:1-9](#); [3:12](#)

The Heart in the Psalms

The Hebrew words *leb* and *lebab* both mean "heart." But these words are difficult to translate. They rarely refer to the physical human heart. Instead, these terms usually refer to the center of a person's being. They represent a person's thoughts, reflections, will, and motives. The story of someone's heart shows their commitment and the direction of their life.

The psalms speak a lot about the heart. The hearts of evil people are clever and full of schemes ([Psalm 58:2](#); [64:6](#); [140:2](#)). They are deceptive, hypocritical, greedy, jealous, and lack honesty ([10:3](#); [28:3](#); [41:6](#); [55:21](#); [62:4](#); [141:4](#)). Over time, they become more arrogant, careless, and stubborn ([14:1](#); [17:10](#); [73:7](#); [78:8](#); [81:12](#); [95:8](#), [10](#); [101:5](#); [119:70](#)). Evil people are only loyal to themselves ([78:37](#)). Their harmful way of life leads to their own destruction ([5:9](#)).

Meanwhile, the writers of the psalms openly express their sorrow, trouble, suffering, and desperation ([13:2](#); [22:14](#); [25:17](#); [38:8](#), [10](#); [40:12](#); [55:4](#); [61:2](#); [69:20](#); [73:21](#), [26](#); [109:22](#); [143:4](#); [147:3](#)). Through their pain, their hearts grow. Their character becomes stronger, and their relationship with God deepens because of these painful experiences. They pray intensely ([62:8](#); [119:145](#)). They desire God ([84:2](#)). They trust in him ([28:7](#)). They invite God to examine their hearts or motives ([7:9](#); [17:3](#); [26:2](#); [139:1-6](#), [23](#)). Their commitment remains steady, and they have "a pure heart" ([24:4](#); [51:10](#); [73:1](#), [13](#)). They are content, even when humbled ([131:1](#)).

As God heals their broken hearts (their deep emotional pain, sorrow, or distress), they become strong and confident ([34:17-18](#); [51:17](#); [27:3](#), [14](#); [31:24](#); [57:7](#); [108:1](#); [112:7-8](#); [138:3](#)). They are full

of life ([22:26](#); [69:32](#)). In the end, God satisfies them and fulfills what their hearts desire ([20:4](#); [21:2](#); [37:4](#)). This brings joy and praise to godly people ([4:7](#); [9:1](#); [13:5](#); [16:7](#), [9](#); [19:8](#); [30:11-12](#); [33:21](#); [86:12](#); [89:50](#); [102:4](#); [105:3](#); [111:1](#); [119:7](#), [111](#); [138:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 7:9](#); [9:1](#); [13:2](#); [14:1](#); [16:7-9](#); [17:3](#); [19:8](#); [20:4](#); [21:2](#); [22:14](#), [26](#); [24:4](#); [26:2](#); [27:3](#), [14](#); [28:3](#), [7](#); [33:21](#); [34:17-18](#); [37:4](#); [38:8](#), [10](#); [51:10](#), [17](#); [55:4](#), [21](#); [57:7](#); [58:2](#); [61:2](#); [62:4](#), [8-10](#); [64:6](#); [69:20](#); [73:1](#), [7](#), [13](#), [21](#), [26](#); [78:8](#), [37](#); [81:12](#); [84:2](#); [86:12](#); [89:50](#); [95:8](#), [10](#); [102:4](#); [108:1](#); [109:22](#); [111:1](#); [119:70](#), [111](#), [145](#); [131:1](#); [138:1](#); [139:1-24](#); [140:2](#); [147:3](#)

The Holiness of God's People

God called the people of Israel "to be holy" because he freed them from slavery in Egypt (see [Leviticus 11:45](#)). He also freed humanity through Jesus Christ, who paid the price to release us from slavery to sin and death ([1 Peter 1:18](#)). God paid the ultimate price to set humanity free, redeeming us "with the precious blood of Christ, a lamb without blemish or spot" ([1:19](#)). Through this sacrifice, God has purchased our freedom from the empty way of life that people experience before coming to Christ.

Holiness was at the center of the lifestyle that God required from his people under the old covenant (the agreement God made with Israel through Moses at Mount Sinai). God commanded them to "Be holy because I, the LORD your God, am holy" (see [Leviticus 19:2](#)). God had rescued his people from the control of a cruel, foreign nation that worshiped other gods. Now they were to live as God's people in the new land where he was bringing them.

The apostle Peter applies this same requirement to God's people of the new covenant (the agreement God made through Jesus Christ). This includes all who have come to God through faith in Jesus Christ. Peter writes, "just as He who called you is holy, so be holy in all you do," ([1 Peter 1:15](#)). This holiness has both a negative and a positive side.

Negatively, to be holy means to separate *from* this world. This means avoiding the ways of thinking and acting that are common among people who do not know God. We turn away from our old sinful lifestyle that we lived before becoming Christians. Because of their new identity in Christ, believers

live as foreigners in this world ([1 Peter 1:17](#)). Their values are shaped by God's kingdom rather than earthly culture.

Positively, to be holy also means to be separate *for* God. This means we try to be like our Father in heaven and live according to the values of our new homeland, the kingdom of God.

Believers in Christ have been set free from the old, meaningless life and its values. We are to live as obedient children of our heavenly Father ([1 Peter 1:14](#)). Our Father has not only saved us because he loves us, but he also disciplines his children, just like a human father would. He will judge "each one's work impartially" ([1:17](#)).

Therefore, we must live before God "in reverent fear" ([1:17](#)). We must acknowledge his holiness and majesty and strive by faith to reflect his holy character in our lives. Holiness is an essential part of the Christian life. While we are justified by faith, true faith naturally expresses itself in a life that reflects God's holiness (see [James 2:14-26](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Leviticus 10:3](#); [11:44-45](#); [19:2](#); [Isaiah 29:17-24](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-20](#); [Hebrews 12:1-13](#); [1 Peter 1:15-18](#); [Revelation 21:5-8](#); [22:14-15](#)

The Holy One of Israel

The phrase *The Holy One of Israel* appears in the prophecy of Isaiah about 24 times. The Holy One is "the King" ([Isaiah 6:5](#)). The righteous and just one is the God without equal ([26:7](#); [40:25](#)). He is the redeemer of his people ([41:14](#)).

Anyone approaching the Holy One must worship him with reverence and awe. The Holy One associates himself with Mount Zion. It is holy because it is his symbolic home (see [18:7](#); [24:23](#); [27:13](#); [56:7](#); [60:1-22](#)).

The Holy One of Israel is different from all creation because he is morally perfect creator. Sinful people cannot live with him (see [Isaiah 1:4](#)). God's holiness requires ceremonial purity and moral perfection. God is like a consuming fire that removes anything not connected to his holy will (see [33:14](#)).

Yet the Holy One of Israel reserves a small group of people for himself ([Isaiah 4:2-3](#); [6:13](#)). He spiritually cleanses them and promises to be with his own redeemed people ([12:6](#); [35:8-9](#); [62:12](#); see also [49:7](#)). He shows his holy power by helping

sinful and weak humans. He saves them from the exile caused by their sin, and opening the new creation for them.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 71:22-23](#); [78:41](#); [Proverbs 9:10](#); [Isaiah 6:1-5](#); [10:17](#); [20](#); [17:7](#); [29:17-24](#); [30:15](#); [41:14](#); [17-20](#); [43:1-4](#); [10-21](#); [48:17-18](#); [54:4-5](#); [55:5](#); [57:15](#); [Jeremiah 50:29](#); [51:5](#); [Ezekiel 39:7-8](#); [Hosea 11:8-9](#); [Habakkuk 3:3-6](#); [John 6:66-69](#); [Acts 2:27](#); [13:35](#); [Revelation 16:5-7](#)

The Holy Spirit's Presence

The book of Acts emphasizes the presence and power of the Holy Spirit. Before the Spirit came, Jesus spoke about the Spirit's influence on his followers ([1:8](#); see [John 14:15-17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7-15](#)). The Spirit clearly guided the early church in selecting Spirit-filled leaders to care for the needs of the Hellenistic widows ([Acts 6:1-7](#)). These were Greek-speaking Jewish widows who needed help in the daily distribution of food. The Holy Spirit chose the apostles Barnabas and Saul for missionary work ([13:1-5](#)). When the first church council met to discuss the membership of non-Jewish people (gentiles), they followed the Spirit's direction ([15:28](#)).

The Holy Spirit filled Christian workers Stephen and Philip to preach with the Spirit's power ([Acts 6:1-8:40](#)). The Spirit energized the apostle Paul's ministry from the start ([9:17](#)). In the book of Acts, the church increased and expanded under the Holy Spirit's guidance and power (for example, [2:4](#), [41-47](#); [4:31](#); [5:32](#); [8:15](#), [17](#), [29](#); [9:31](#)). Because of the Spirit's important role in Acts, people often call it "the Acts of the Holy Spirit."

The Holy Spirit acts in many ways:

- The Holy Spirit gives and restores life ([Genesis 2:7](#); [Psalm 104:24-30](#); [Ezekiel 37:1-14](#); [Joel 2:28-32](#); [Romans 8:9-11](#)).
- The Holy Spirit calls and chooses workers for Christ's service ([Acts 13:2](#); [20:28](#)).
- The Holy Spirit directs God's servants where and when he wants them to act ([Acts 8:29](#); [9:15](#); [10:19-20](#); [11:12](#); [16:6](#); [1 Corinthians 2:13](#); [1 Peter 1:12](#)).
- The Holy Spirit inspired the writing of Scripture ([2 Timothy 3:16-17](#); [2 Peter 1:20-21](#)).
- The Holy Spirit teaches the church Christ's message ([John 14:26](#); [1 Corinthians 12:3](#)).
- The Holy Spirit shows the power of the good news about Jesus (the gospel) through miraculous signs and wonders ([Acts 14:3](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#)).
- The Holy Spirit teaches God's people the truths of Scripture ([Acts 1:16](#); [Hebrews 9:8](#); [10:15-17](#); [1 Peter 1:11-12](#)).
- The Holy Spirit testifies about Jesus and brings him glory ([John 15:26](#); [16:13-14](#)).
- The Holy Spirit makes people aware of their sins and their need for the good news ([John 16:8](#)).
- The Holy Spirit warns them against becoming stubborn ([Hebrews 3:7-11](#), [15](#)).
- The Holy Spirit gives gifts to God's people ([1 Corinthians 12:4-11](#)).
- The Holy Spirit empowers them to share the good news, serve the Lord, and work for God's kingdom.

Passages for Further Study

[John 14:15-17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:7-15](#); [Acts 1:8](#), [16](#); [2:4](#), [41-47](#); [4:31](#); [5:32](#); [6:1-7](#); [8:15](#), [17](#), [29](#); [9:15](#), [17](#), [31](#); [10:19-20](#); [11:12](#); [13:1-5](#); [14:3](#); [15:28](#); [16:6](#); [20:28](#); [1 Corinthians 2:13](#); [12:1-11](#); [Ephesians](#)

[1:13-14](#); [2 Timothy 3:16-17](#); [Hebrews 2:4](#); [3:7-11](#), [15](#); [9:8](#); [10:15-17](#); [1 Peter 1:11-12](#); [2 Peter 1:20-21](#)

The Holy Spirit's Work

Different New Testament writers emphasized various aspects of the Holy Spirit's work. The apostle John, for example, emphasized the Spirit's role as a teacher and revealer of God's thoughts and ways ([John 14:17](#), [26](#); [15:26](#); [16:13-15](#); [1 John 2:20](#), [27](#)). The apostle Luke focused on the Spirit's guidance and power for spreading the Christian message ([Acts 1:8](#); [4:8-12](#), [31](#); [8:29-40](#); [13:9-12](#)). Meanwhile, the apostle Paul provided a broad perspective of the Spirit's work.

Paul teaches that God gives the Holy Spirit to everyone enters a saving relationship with Jesus Christ ([1 Corinthians 6:19](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#)). The Spirit brings new life in Christ and confirms the salvation of Christians and their identity as God's children ([1 Corinthians 6:11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:13](#); [Romans 8:9](#), [14-17](#)).

The Holy Spirit gives Christians:

- power over sin ([Romans 8:1-4](#));
- power to live the Christian virtues ([Galatians 5:22-23](#)); and
- power to serve in Christian ministry ([1 Corinthians 12:1-31](#)).

Christians must "be filled with the Holy Spirit" ([Ephesians 5:18](#)). They may encounter a struggle between their human desires and the Spirit. But, they can please God by obeying the Spirit's guidance and strength ([Galatians 5:16-18](#)).

The Holy Spirit helps Christians understand God's thoughts and ways ([1 Corinthians 2:9-16](#)). He provides spiritual gifts to Christians to support the church's overall health ([12:1-31](#)). The Spirit guides and strengthens worship as Christians use the gifts given by him ([14:26-33](#), [39-40](#)).

The Holy Spirit guarantees that Christians will receive all the blessings God has promised ([2 Corinthians 1:21-22](#); [5:1-5](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#)). The Spirit supports Christians and prays for them when they are weak ([Romans 8:26-27](#)). The Spirit's goal is to make Christians "conformed to the image of" God's Son ([Romans 8:28-29](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[John 14:15-17, 26; 15:26; 16:7-15; Acts 1:8; 2:4; 5:32; 6:1-7; 8:29, 39; 9:31; 13:1-5; 14:3; 15:28; 16:6; 20:28; Romans 8:1-4, 9, 14-17, 26-29; 1 Corinthians 2:9-16; 6:11, 19; 12:1-31; 14:1-33, 39-40; 2 Corinthians 1:22; 5:5; Galatians 3:5; 5:16-18, 22-23; Ephesians 1:13-14; 5:18; 2 Thessalonians 2:13; 2 Timothy 3:16-17; Hebrews 2:4; 3:7-11, 15; 9:8; 10:15-17; 1 Peter 1:11-12; 2 Peter 1:20-21; 1 John 2:20, 27](#)

The Household

The household was the basic family unit of Greco-Roman society. People believed that if households were stable, the state would also be stable. In these households, everyone had clear roles and responsibilities that were deeply embedded in their culture. The main goal was to keep the "natural" order of authority and obedience. Breaking this order would lead to dishonor and corruption.

In this system, the husband-father-master was in charge of everyone. Men controlled public spaces and government, while women managed the home. Greco-Roman speakers often accused new foreign religions, like Christianity, of corrupting society by threatening the household structure.

The New Testament household codes were not new ideas (see [Ephesians 5:21-6:9; Colossians 3:18-4:1; 1 Timothy 2:8-15; 5:1-2; 6:1-2; Titus 2:1-3:8; 1 Peter 2:18-3:7](#)). The apostles adapted them to fit the Christian faith and address specific needs. The Christian faith often made major changes to the normal practices of culture. Yet, wisdom and carefulness were necessary. Ignoring the normal practices of culture could cause severe problems. This could bring dishonor, disgrace, and shame on the entire household—including Jesus, the head of the Christian household.

This was the effect of some false teachers in Ephesus, as discussed in the first letter to Timothy in the New Testament. In this context, the New Testament household codes helped Christian communities live in a way that:

- 127.** stopped accusations that Christianity threatened the state; and
- 128.** served as a strong, attractive witness to the truth.

Passages for Further Study

[Ephesians 5:21-6:9; Colossians 3:18-4:1; 1 Timothy 2:8-15; 3:5, 12, 15; 5:1-2, 8; 6:1-2; Titus 2:1-3:8; 1 Peter 2:13-3:7; 4:17; 5:1-5](#)

The Land

The land was very important to ancient Israel because agriculture was the main way people made a living. Most Israelites were farmers or herders, and their survival depended on the land's ability to produce crops and support livestock.

God gave the Israelites the privilege and responsibility of living in Canaan. This was part of God's covenant with Israel ([1 Kings 8:33-40](#); see also [Deuteronomy 28](#)). The land was central to Israel's relationship with God, who promised it to Abraham and his descendants ([Genesis 12:1-3; 13:14-17](#)). The nation of Israel lived as those who tended and owned the land. The land was Israel's "inheritance" ([Deuteronomy 4:21](#)). God gave it to them and required their loyalty ([Deuteronomy 4:40](#)). God expected the people to manage the land well and serve him faithfully.

Sadly, God's people chose their own way to live. They worshiped pagan gods and themselves ([2 Kings 17:7-17](#)). So, God allowed foreign nations to gradually take Israel's land (for example, [2 Kings 8:20-22; 13:1-3; 17:3](#)). Eventually, Assyria invaded the northern kingdom, sending the Israelites into exile ([17:5-6, 22-23](#)).

Through these events, God warned Judah, the southern kingdom, that they would lose their land if they did not change ([2 Kings 21:8](#)). Unfortunately, they did not listen ([21:9](#)). Their unfaithfulness led to them being forced out of the land by the Babylonians ([25:1-21](#)).

Israel's rebellion and failure to manage the land God gave them is a warning to us. God has redeemed us through Christ Jesus so we can live faithful and productive lives ([John 15:16; Ephesians 2:4-10](#)). If we are unfaithful and unproductive, we might lose our role in serving Christ ([John 15:1-2, 6](#)). By remaining connected to him, we "bear much fruit" and grow in our faith ([John 15:5](#)).

God's people always have a tendency to sin (see [Romans 3:23; 1 John 1:8, 10](#)). But God is always ready to forgive and restore those who repent and to renew the blessings of his covenant (see [1 John 1:9](#)). Jesus, who mediates the new covenant between God and his people, is also their advocate

in heaven ([Matthew 26:27-28](#); [1 John 2:1](#)). In the end, those who remain faithful to God will receive the blessings of the new heaven and the new earth ([1 Peter 1:3-5](#); [Revelation 21:1-7](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:1-3](#); [13:14-17](#); [Leviticus 26:1-46](#); [Deuteronomy 28:1-68](#); [1 Kings 8:29-51](#); [9:3-9](#); [2 Kings 17:18-23](#); [Psalms 24:1](#); [89:11](#); [1 Peter 1:4](#); [Revelation 21:1-7](#)

The Last Things and the Thessalonians

The Christians in Thessalonica eagerly accepted the apostle Paul's teachings about the day of the Lord and Jesus' second coming. Yet, this led to questions and guesses about the end of time.

They wondered what would happen to Christians who died before Jesus returned ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#)). They also asked when "the Day of the Lord" would come ([5:1-11](#)). They wondered if Christians would experience God's wrath ([1:10](#); [5:9](#)). Paul reassures the church by explaining these topics and reminding them of the teachings they had already received ([4:13-5:11](#)).

Paul probably expected Jesus to return during his lifetime ([4:15](#)). Yet, he also knew the final event would occur unexpectedly, "like a thief in the night" ([5:2](#)). The way to be ready for the end is not by knowing the date but by living with Christian alertness. This means keeping a constant spiritual watchfulness and being ready to meet Jesus.

The Thessalonians needed to understand the deaths of fellow Christians. Paul does not discuss the state of Christians between their death and Jesus' return. Instead, he focuses on the resurrection. Just as God raised Jesus from the dead, Christians who die will also be raised when he returns. They will rise from the dead first, then join the living Christians to meet Jesus at his royal coming.

Paul tried to explain the Christian hope. But the Thessalonian Christians became confused by false teachings that said, "the Day of the Lord has already come" (see [2 Thessalonians 2:2](#)). To correct this misunderstanding, Paul discussed this topic further in his second letter to the young church (see [2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Mark 13:1-37](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-5:11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:1-12](#)

The Law and the Spirit

A common question many Christians ask is whether Christians need to follow Old Testament laws to spiritually grow in their faith. Does obeying God's law help Christians become more holy?

When the Christians in Galatia heard and accepted the good news about salvation through faith in Christ, they also received the Holy Spirit. This Holy Spirit served as proof that they were true believers. God not only gave his Spirit to them but also performed miracles among them ([Galatians 3:5](#)). The Christians in Galatia knew from their own experience that the Holy Spirit has the power to transform them into new people. The apostle Paul had taught them to depend on the Spirit for guidance in their lives.

After Paul left Galatia, Jewish-Christian teachers came to the area. These teachers taught something different. They said people needed to follow God's law both to be accepted by God and to become holy and mature. These teachers claimed that Paul's teaching about becoming more holy by the Holy Spirit (instead of carefully obeying God's law) would lead people to break God's laws and commit sins.

Paul answered these teachers by saying God does two important things through faith:

129. God *counts* or *considers* us righteous because of our faith.

130. God actually makes us righteous through faith by the work of the Holy Spirit ([Galatians 5:16-26](#)). Paul explained that people who depend on the Spirit and follow the Spirit's guidance will not sin. This is because God's Spirit will never lead people to do wrong things.

The real problem is not that people do not understand what is right and wrong. Our conscience, which God gave us, tells us when we are doing something wrong. God's law makes his standards for right living even clearer ([Romans 7:7-12](#)). The real problem is that our hearts are often stubborn and sinful. We also lack the wisdom to know the right thing to do in different situations. Because of sin's effects on human nature, we

struggle to apply God's word in a way that matches what God truly wants.

The law cannot improve our condition. But when the Holy Spirit guides and controls us, he transforms our desires so that we do things that please God ([Galatians 5:22-23](#); [Romans 8:5-14](#)). God's Spirit helps his people fulfill the true meaning and purpose of his law. But following the law should not be our main goal or focus. The law is just our "guardian" ([Galatians 3:24-25](#)). Instead, we should focus on trusting God, relying on the Spirit, and loving others. God's Spirit gives us the desire and strength to do these things in a way that pleases God.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 11:16-17, 24-30](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Ezekiel 36:26-27](#); [Luke 24:49](#); [Acts 5:32](#); [Romans 7:1-8:17](#); [12:2](#); [2 Corinthians 3:7-18](#); [Galatians 3:2-5](#); [5:5](#), [16-26](#); [Hebrews 12:14-29](#)

The Limitations of Law

The law was central to God's special agreement (the covenant) with the people of Israel. Many Jews in the apostle Paul's time, including Jewish Christians, still considered it as essential for living. Therefore, Paul often addresses questions about the law, especially in his letters to the Romans and the Galatians. He explores this deeply in [Romans 7](#). There he argues that the law of Moses, instead of improving people's lives, caused sin and brought death (see [7:5](#)).

Paul wants his readers to understand that the law is not to blame. God's law is good and holy ([Romans 7:12](#)). But it cannot change the human heart or will. Whether Paul describes a non Christian, a mature Christian, or an immature Christian, the message is the same. The law cannot defeat human sin (see [Romans 7:14-25](#)).

God gives the law to people who, because of their link to Adam's curse, are already easily controlled by sin's power. We may want to obey God's commands, but we find it impossible. Only a new and powerful experience of God's power and grace in Jesus Christ can rescue us ([Romans 7:25](#)). Through God's Spirit, Jesus set us free "from the law of sin and death" ([Romans 8:2](#)).

If God's good and holy law cannot save us, human laws are even less helpful for spiritual health. Whether these laws come from a religious leader, a

tradition, or a church, they cannot change the human soul. They can instruct us, but they cannot give us the strength to follow them. God's law offers a guide for the new life given by grace. But it cannot replace the power of God's grace, which comes through Christ's work.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 5:1-33](#); [6:17-25](#); [Joshua 24:19-27](#); [Ezra 7:25-26](#); [Psalms 1:1-3](#); [19:7-14](#); [78:56-59](#); [119:144](#); [Isaiah 24:5](#); [26:4-8](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Hosea 4:6](#); [8:12](#); [Habakkuk 1:4](#); [Matthew 5:17-20](#); [7:12](#); [Mark 7:8-9](#); [Luke 16:16-17](#); [John 1:16-17](#); [7:19](#); [Acts 13:38-39](#); [Romans 2:13-29](#); [3:19-21](#); [27-28](#); [4:13-16](#); [7:1-25](#); [8:3-4](#), [7](#); [9:4](#), [31-32](#); [10:3-5](#); [Galatians 2:16-21](#); [3:2](#), [10-13](#), [17-25](#); [5:1-4](#); [1 Timothy 1:5-11](#); [Hebrews 8:7-13](#); [10:1-18](#); [1 John 3:4-6](#)

The Little Horn

In the vision of the prophet Daniel, the little horn represents a king. It has human-like features, such as eyes and a mouth. This imagery is typical of apocalyptic literature.

"Apocalyptic" is from a Greek word meaning "reveal." So, this kind of message or writing reveals the hidden plans of God. Apocalyptic writings often using mysterious language and images. The little horn draws Daniel's attention because of its boastful speech and violent actions against other kings, God's people, and the Most High God.

What or who is the little horn? The little horn in [Daniel 7:8](#) links to evil figures in [9:27](#) and [11:40-45](#). Antiochus IV Epiphanes shares qualities with the little horn in [7:8](#), but they are not the same ([8:9-14](#), [23-25](#); [11:21-39](#)).

Both ancient and modern interpreters believe the little horn represents the future antichrist (a powerful leader who will strongly oppose God and God's people). Some think certain historical figures from the Greek and Roman empires, like Antiochus IV Epiphanes, Nero, Caligula, and Domitian, have partially fulfilled this vision. According to this perspective, this future person will be a man, not a demon or Satan.

Some see the little horn as a symbol of evil opposing God and his people. Some interpreters think no single person will fulfill this vision. Instead, they believe it represents evil forces in the world. Others believe the antichrist has already

appeared. The New Testament suggests the idea of the antichrist will have a final fulfillment (see [2 Thessalonians 2:3-12](#); [1 John 2:18](#); [4:3](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:1](#), [5](#); [16:13-14](#); [17:11](#); [19:20-21](#); [20:10](#)).

This little horn reminds God's people that evil strongly opposes God and his people. The king mentioned here takes over the world's kingdoms ([Daniel 7:8](#)). But his evil system will not win because God will destroy evil. God's people can find comfort in knowing this time of evil will not last long ([Revelation 12:12](#)). God will destroy the works of this evil kingdom ([Daniel 7:11-12](#)).

God's chosen ruler, who appears "like a son of man" (looking like a human being), is given authority by God (called "the Ancient of Days" in this vision; [Daniel 7:13-14](#)). He will rule with God's approval and power, and his rule will last in a kingdom that cannot be destroyed. God encourages his people to endure and remain faithful. They live in hope of a righteous kingdom where God will live among them (see [Revelation 21:3](#)). "The zeal of the LORD of Hosts will accomplish this" ([Isaiah 9:7](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 7:8](#), [11](#), [20-21](#), [24-26](#); [8:9-12](#); [9:26-27](#); [Mark 13:14](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:5-12](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:1-10](#); [20:10](#)

The Lord of Nations

Both the Old Testament and the New Testament state that the Lord is the one true God. God is supreme over all nations and peoples at all times. Even if rulers do not believe in or acknowledge him, God remains in control. Kings and emperors might think they control everything in their lands, but they are mistaken. The Lord God is ultimately in charge.

The Old Testament prophets said that the Lord God of Israel chose the kings or emperors of each nation. God held rulers accountable for the morality of their policies and how they practiced them. This idea is clear in [Jeremiah 18](#), [25](#), and [46-51](#).

Nations that did not acknowledge the one true God would encounter severe judgment. For some nations, God promised that a small group (called a remnant) would survive (see [Jeremiah 46-51](#)).

The Lord wants people from every nation to turn to him and follow him with sincere hearts and

complete dedication. He has always wanted all people to live righteous lives and experience the joy of truly worshiping him. The book of Revelation describes people from every nation, tribe, and language worshiping God in the future ([Revelation 7:9-10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 8:20-22](#); [9:29](#); [2 Kings 19:22-37](#); [Jeremiah 18:5-11](#); [25:15-29](#); [46:1-51:64](#); [Daniel 2:19-21](#); [4:34-37](#); [Haggai 2:7](#); [Matthew 28:18-20](#); [Acts 12:21-23](#); [Romans 13:1-7](#)

The Message of Reconciliation

Reconciliation is a term found throughout the New Testament. It means making peace and repairing broken relationships. When two people reconcile, they stop being enemies and become friends again. In the same way, through Jesus, people can have their relationship with God restored.

In [Romans 5:1-11](#), the apostle Paul focuses on the cost of God's reconciling work through the death of his son.

[Colossians 1:15-20](#) is a hymn that praises Jesus Christ. It tells how he brings all of creation (everything in heaven and on earth) back into a right relationship with God. The passage shows that Jesus is Lord over all things that exist.

In [Ephesians 2:11-22](#), the focus is on reconciliation that includes both Jews and non-Jews (gentiles). They form a united church with all opposition removed.

Paul explains reconciliation in detail when discussing the meaning of Jesus' death in [2 Corinthians 5:18-21](#). Earlier, Paul reminded the Corinthians about the importance of the cross ([1 Corinthians 15:3-5](#)). But he did not explain much about its meaning then. Now, he clarifies that Christ's death on the cross means Christ "became" sin so sinners could reconnect with God.

This reconciliation changes enemies into friends. The cost of this exchange is that "God made Him who knew no sin to be sin on our behalf, so that in Him we might become the righteousness of God" ([2 Corinthians 5:21](#)).

With Jesus' resurrection and his victory over death, a new world begins. In this new era, God's people have the promise of eternal union with him (see [2 Corinthians 4:14-5:10](#)). Those who trust in Jesus

for salvation receive the Holy Spirit, which guarantees future salvation (5:5). They know that God accepts them and will welcome them forever.

Those who have made peace with God should help others find their way back to him (2 Corinthians 5:18-21). Since Christians have experienced this peace, they should also try to restore their personal relationships (see Matthew 5:24; 18:15; Romans 12:18).

Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 45:15](#); [Daniel 9:24](#); [Matthew 5:24](#); [18:15](#); [Acts 10:36](#); [Romans 5:1-2](#); [8:6-9](#), [15-16](#); [12:18](#); [15:13](#); [2 Corinthians 5:18-21](#); [13:11](#); [Ephesians 2:11-18](#); [Colossians 1:19-22](#); [Hebrews 2:17](#)

The Messiah

The Greek word *christos* has the same meaning as the Hebrew word *mashiakh*. It means "anointed one" (or "chosen one"). Both words translate as "Messiah" or "Christ." In the Bible, the Messiah is someone chosen by God for a special purpose. In ancient times, people poured oil on a person's head to show that God had chosen them for an important task. This act was called anointing.

In Judaism, the term *messiah* had different meanings. The Old Testament refers to different people who received special anointing from God. God chose these people for different tasks and reasons. Not all of these people did good things, but God still selected them for his purposes ([Exodus 28:41](#); [1 Samuel 9:16](#); [1 Kings 19:16](#); [Isaiah 45:1](#)).

The prophets expected a future Messiah who would begin God's kingdom ([Daniel 9:25-26](#); [Zechariah 9:9-10](#)). During Jesus' time, many Jews expected the Messiah to be a political warrior. He would lead Israel to victory over its oppressors and restore Israel as an independent kingdom (see *Psalms of Solomon* 17-18).

Some Jews viewed the Messiah as a person who would come before the kingdom of God. The community at Qumran, where they found the Dead Sea Scrolls, expected a Messiah who would serve as both a priest and a political warrior.

Because of this confusion, it is not surprising that Jesus avoided the title. He taught his followers that he would suffer as Isaiah prophesied ([Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#)). The Jews interpreted this passage to refer to Israel. Jesus emphasized suffering and

service as the path to victory ([Matthew 16:21-28](#); [20:25-28](#)). This was opposite of the popular Jewish view of the Messiah as a royal conqueror. Yet, this was God's way of establishing his kingdom (see [Luke 2:25-32](#); [John 12:37-50](#); [Acts 2:29-36](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 17:6](#); [Exodus 28:41](#); [1 Samuel 9:16](#); [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#); [Daniel 9:25-26](#); [Zechariah 9:9-10](#); [Matthew 2:4-6](#); [11:2-6](#); [16:13-20](#); [17:10-12](#); [22:41-46](#); [24:23-27](#); [26:62-65](#); [Luke 2:8-11](#), [25-35](#); [3:15-18](#); [23:35-43](#); [24:26-27](#), [46-47](#); [John 4:21-29](#); [7:25-27](#), [31](#), [40-43](#); [12:34-50](#); [20:30-31](#); [Acts 2:22-36](#); [3:17-26](#); [4:25-28](#); [9:22](#); [13:23-25](#); [17:3](#); [26:22-23](#); [28:17-24](#)

The Messianic Banquet

Through his teaching and miracles, Jesus showed that the messianic banquet was ready. The messianic banquet is a special feast that God promised to prepare when the Messiah came. He invited all people to come and receive God's salvation and become part of God's kingdom.

Jesus compared his ministry to a wedding feast, with himself as the groom ([Luke 5:33-35](#)). The kingdom of God was like a grand banquet. God invited everyone, but some chose not to attend ([Luke 14:15-24](#); see also [Matthew 8:11-12](#)). Jesus often shared meals with a variety of people. This included disliked tax collectors and committed Pharisees ([5:29-32](#); [7:36-50](#); [11:37-41](#); [14:1-6](#)).

He also used the imagery of feasting and banquets in his teachings and parables ([Luke 5:33-35](#); [12:35-38](#); [14:7-14](#), [15-24](#); [17:7-10](#); [22:28-30](#)). Additionally, he fed large crowds with just a few loaves and fishes ([9:10-17](#)).

The Old Testament background for this feast imagery is [Isaiah 25:6](#). It describes God's final salvation as a great feast for everyone: "the LORD of Hosts will prepare a lavish banquet for all the peoples, a feast of aged wine, of choice meat, of finely aged wine" (see also [Isaiah 65:13-14](#)).

Jesus' public ministry began the invitation to the banquet and its beginning. Through his death and resurrection, he brought salvation. Now, everyone can come to God's banquet table and receive the kingdom's spiritual blessings. Yet, this banquet will fully happen in the future kingdom. Then, Jesus' disciples will "eat and drink at My table in My kingdom" and "sit on thrones, judging the twelve

tribes of Israel" ([Luke 22:30](#); see also [Revelation 19:7-9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 25:6](#); [65:13-14](#); [Luke 5:29-35](#); [6:21](#); [7:36-50](#); [9:10-17](#); [11:37-41](#); [12:35-40](#); [13:24-30](#); [14:1-24](#); [17:8](#); [22:30](#)

The Mystery of the Good News

In his letters, the apostle Paul often uses the word *mystery* to describe the good news about Jesus (some translations use the word *secret*). Sometimes, Paul uses *mystery* as a way of referring to the good news itself ([Colossians 2:2](#); [4:3](#); [1 Corinthians 2:1](#); [Ephesians 1:9](#); [6:19](#)). Often, as in [Colossians 1:26](#), Paul says, it is "the mystery that was hidden for ages and generations but is now revealed" (see also [Romans 16:25](#); [1 Corinthians 2:7](#); [Ephesians 3:9](#)). Paul does not mean the good news is a mystery that has to be investigated. He also does not mean the good news is a Gnostic idea that only a few people can understand. (Gnostics emphasized special secret knowledge as the key to salvation.)

Instead, Paul adapts the term from Jewish apocalyptic teaching. The term *apocalyptic* comes from a Greek word meaning "uncovering" or "revelation." This is the same word that gives the book of Revelation its name. In the apocalyptic view, God has already created a plan for all of history. This plan exists in God's mind but remains hidden from humans until God chooses to reveal it. For Paul, this secret plan has now been shown to everyone through Christ. It is now being shared throughout the world by his apostles.

In the Old Testament, prophets shared parts of the good news, but God kept some details hidden until the New Testament. These include:

- the full participation of gentiles (non-Jewish people) as fellow heirs with Jews ([Colossians 1:27](#); [Ephesians 3:1-9](#));
- the indwelling of Jesus Christ in believers ([Colossians 1:27](#); [2:2](#)); and
- the union of Christ and his church (this union is shown or illustrated by the union of husband and wife ([Ephesians 5:32](#))).

Some parts of God's plan remain hidden and will be revealed in the future, such as:

- the salvation of all Israel ([Romans 11:25-27](#)); and
- Christians will be transformed when Jesus returns ([1 Corinthians 15:51-53](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 11:25](#); [16:25](#); [1 Corinthians 2:1](#), [7](#); [15:51](#); [Ephesians 1:9](#); [3:1-9](#); [5:32](#); [6:19](#); [Colossians 1:26-27](#); [2:2](#); [4:3](#)

The New Community

The New Testament emphasizes the importance of the Christian community. Cultures that focus on individuals can miss this emphasis. Although God converts and spiritually rebirths Christians as individuals, he does not want them to remain isolated ([John 3:3](#); [1 Peter 1:23](#)). God intends to unite us as "living stones" in his "spiritual house" ([1 Peter 2:5](#)). God no longer lives in a building on Mount Zion in Jerusalem. He now lives in and among his people through the Holy Spirit.

God promised to rebuild his temple (see [Ezekiel 40-48](#)). He fulfills this promise as he lives among his people (see [John 1:14](#)). Under the new covenant, the people themselves are the "temple." We must unite in worship, praise, and service to fulfill God's purpose. Christians share the blessing of being chosen by God to carry out his mission to the world.

[1 Peter 2:9](#) teaches that the church now has the same special role that God once gave to Israel. The church is a "chosen people" (see [Deuteronomy 7:6](#)). It is "a royal priesthood," "a holy nation" (see

[Exodus 19:6](#)). It is "God's own possession" (see [Exodus 19:5](#)).

With this special status comes the duty to share the truth about God with the nations. By worshiping together and serving in different ministries, we "proclaim the virtues of Him" ([1 Peter 2:9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:3](#); [Exodus 19:4-6](#); [Deuteronomy 7:6](#); [2 Chronicles 5:13-14](#); [Isaiah 11:1-16](#); [John 1:14](#); [1 Corinthians 3:9-17](#); [6:19](#); [2 Corinthians 6:16-18](#); [Ephesians 2:19-22](#); [1 Peter 2:4-10](#); [Revelation 3:12](#); [21:1-3](#), [22](#)

The New Covenant

A covenant is a formal agreement or promise made between two parties. In the Bible, covenants are special agreements between God and people.

The old covenant refers to the agreement God made with the people of Israel at Mount Sinai after he rescued them from slavery in Egypt. The main promise of the covenant of Mount Sinai was, "I will take you as My own people, and I will be your God" ([Exodus 6:7](#); see [Jeremiah 31:33](#)). The relationship between God and his people in the Sinai covenant included laws carved in stone and a priestly class who managed all religious institutions and activities.

The new covenant is the agreement God made with people through Jesus Christ. The new covenant would differ from the old in a key way. The new covenant would no longer be external to the worshipers but would be written on their hearts ([Jeremiah 31:33](#)). The old covenant's major weakness was its lack of power to help people obey its commands ([Romans 8:3](#)). The new covenant would be placed inside people's hearts and minds through the power of the Holy Spirit ([Ezekiel 36:24-27](#)).

Because of this, it would become possible for people everywhere (not just a few chosen ones) to fulfill God's covenant plan for life. This plan is summarized in the two "Great Commandments" ([Matthew 22:35-40](#)):

131. "You shall love the LORD your God" ([Deuteronomy 6:5](#)).

132. "Love your neighbor as yourself" ([Leviticus 19:18](#)).

The new covenant would achieve what the old one intended but could not achieve. It would create new individuals and a new community. The goal is a deep transformation of sinners, starting with forgiveness of sins and leading to holiness shown by good works ([Ephesians 1:4](#); [2:8-10](#)).

[Jeremiah 30-33](#) emphasizes a hopeful future for Israel. The key moment is when the Lord God promises a new covenant with his people ([31:31-34](#)). This passage points to Jesus of Nazareth, whose death would confirm this new covenant. Jesus connected the new covenant to himself during the communion ceremony ([Matthew 26:28](#); [Mark 14:24](#); [Luke 22:20](#); see also [1 Corinthians 11:25](#); [2 Corinthians 3:6](#)).

Jesus' death made him the mediator of the covenant for all who trust in him ([Hebrews 8:8-12](#); chapter [9](#)). Christians remember this truth each time they take Communion (also called the Lord's Supper or the Eucharist). According to the New Testament, all Christians will know God directly through the Holy Spirit, made possible by Christ's sacrifice. They will know him personally and experience him powerfully, unlike most people in Old Testament times.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 11:1-9](#); [54:13-15](#); [Jeremiah 31:31-34](#); [Ezekiel 37:24-28](#); [Matthew 26:27-28](#); [Luke 22:20](#); [Romans 11:25-36](#); [1 Corinthians 11:23-26](#); [2 Corinthians 3:6-18](#); [Hebrews 8:8-9:28](#)

The New Order

Isaiah describes two different ways the world can be. The first way (the *old order*) is how things are now, where people struggle with power and difficulties. The second way (the *new order*) is God's new creation that will come in the future, where everything will be fair and people will live together in peace.

When Isaiah thinks about the old way of life, he remembers:

- sadness ([Isaiah 65:19](#)).
- death ([65:20](#))
- injustice and violence ([65:21-22](#))
- the absence of God ([65:24](#))

In this old way of life, people trust in their own strength and are proud.

Isaiah's vision of the new order focuses on the Lord as the great king in holiness and glory (see [6:1-5](#)).

God's people experience aspects of this new order now, such as:

- God's comfort ([40:1](#))
- salvation ([45:22](#))
- joy ([24:14-15](#))
- righteousness ([24:16](#))
- peace ([26:3](#))
- divine blessing and protection

There are other aspects that we cannot experience yet, such as:

- the end of death ([25:7-8](#))
- resurrection ([26:19](#))
- the end of fighting, wrongdoing, and evil ([60:18](#); [65:25](#))
- full enjoyment of God's presence ([60:19](#)).
- God ruling in his eternal kingdom without opposition (see [Revelation 21-22](#))

Those who trust in God anticipate these things in the future.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 11:1](#); [24:14-16](#); [25:7-8](#); [26:19](#); [30:26](#); [43:18-19](#); [60:18-19](#); [62:2](#); [65:17-25](#); [Jeremiah 23:7-8](#); [31:10-14](#); [2 Corinthians 3:6-11](#); [5:17](#); [Hebrews 12:18-24](#); [Revelation 21:1-22:21](#)

The Old Life and the New Life

When people become Christians, they unite with Jesus and share in his death and resurrection. Their old life, marked by sin, ends with Jesus. They start a new life through his power within them (see [Romans 6:3-14](#)).

God transforms them by his Spirit. Their minds are renewed (see [Romans 12:2](#)). Their desires and actions change, and their lives begin to show his Spirit ([Galatians 5:22-23](#)). They begin to spiritually grow and become more like Jesus.

Christians have a duty to be "conformed" to Jesus' death and resurrection (see [Philippians 3:10-14](#)). They must turn away from darkness and commit to a life full of light ([Ephesians 4:17-5:20](#)). This means they are to stop living in evil ways and start living in God's good ways. The apostle Paul describes this change using the image of clothing. God calls Christians to remove the old, sinful life influenced by the devil and put on a new, pure life guided by the Holy Spirit ([Ephesians 4:21-24](#); [Colossians 3:1-15](#); see also [Galatians 3:27](#)). In doing so, they acknowledge their dependence on God's grace and power.

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 6:3-14](#); [12:1-2](#); [Galatians 5:19-23](#); [Ephesians 4:17-5:20](#); [Philippians 3:12-14](#)

The Old Realm and the New

The Jewish people in Paul's time saw a clear difference between the "present evil age" and a "glorious age to come." Throughout [Romans 5-8](#), Paul uses these contrasting "realms" or "kingdoms" to explain our experience of salvation.

The rulers of the old realm are:

- death ([Romans 5:12-21](#));
- sin (chapter [6](#));
- the law (chapter [7](#)); and
- sinful nature ("the flesh" in [8:1-11](#)).

The new realm is characterized by:

- life ([Romans 5](#));
- righteous living (chapter [6](#));
- grace (chapter [6](#)); and
- the Holy Spirit (chapter [8](#)).

A person's future depends directly on which of these two realms they belong to.

Each realm has a leader representing its people. Adam, the first man, leads the old realm of sin and death. Christ leads the new realm of forgiveness and life. By nature, all humans belong to the old realm of sin and death, represented by Adam. His sin and death affect everyone's future ([Romans 5:12, 18-19](#)).

Those who have faith in God through Jesus move into the new realm of life. God appointed Jesus Christ as a "second Adam" (see [5:14](#)). By obeying God and fulfilling his will, Jesus achieved a major victory over the realm of sin that Adam started ([5:18-19](#)). By accepting God's gift of grace, people choose Jesus as their leader and hope for eternal life ([5:17](#)).

People in the new realm unite with Christ and enjoy the benefits of this union. They have "died with Christ," been "buried with Christ," and their current new life with Christ is an introduction to the day they will "live with Him" forever ([Romans 6:3-11](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 2:1-10](#); [110:2](#); [145:13](#); [Daniel 2:31-45](#); [7:1-28](#); [Matthew 3:2](#); [6:10](#); [7:13](#); [8:11-12](#); [12:25-28](#); [13:44-52](#); [20:25-28](#); [John 18:36](#); [Romans 5:12-8:39](#); [14:17](#); [1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#); [15:20-28](#); [Galatians 5:16-26](#); [Ephesians 1:3](#), [20](#); [2:6](#); [5:1-20](#); [Colossians 1:13-14](#); [Hebrews 6:4-5](#); [12:18-29](#); [Revelation 11:15](#); [12:10](#)

The Passover

The feast of Passover became a central part of Israelite religious practice. This festival celebrated God's rescue of the Hebrews from Egypt and his protection from the final deadly plague. God wanted it observed every year, following the instructions in the book of Exodus ([Exodus 12:1-27](#)). Passover was a reminder for future generations of God's saving actions. All the people participated in the feast. They ate only unleavened bread, just as they did when they quickly left Egypt.

During the first Passover, they sacrificed a lamb to save the firstborn son of each Israelite family ([Exodus 12:12-13](#), [23](#)). Passover represents that we can escape death only through a sacrifice that substitutes for us. Passover was an important event in Israelite history. But the exodus from Egypt did not solve the universal problem of death, which comes from sin ([1 Corinthians 15:56](#)).

Many years later, during the Passover feast, Jesus Christ gave his "life as a ransom for many" ([Matthew 20:28](#); [Mark 10:45](#)). He became "the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world!" ([John 1:29](#)). While sharing a final Passover meal with his disciples, Jesus explained the symbolic meaning of the wine they shared: "This is My blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many for

the forgiveness of sins" ([Matthew 26:28](#)). He represents and begins a new Passover. Jesus completely and finally defeated sin and death through his sacrifice (see also [Isaiah 25:7-8](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 12:1-51](#); [Leviticus 23:4-8](#); [Numbers 9:1-14](#); [Numbers 28:16-25](#); [Deuteronomy 16:1-7](#); [Matthew 26:17-30](#); [Luke 22:15-20](#); [1 Corinthians 5:6-8](#)

The Plagues

The main purpose of the plagues in Egypt was not to rescue the Hebrew people from Egyptian oppression. If rescue was the goal, one big miracle would have been enough. The plagues intended to show who God is to Israel, Egypt, and nearby nations.

The Israelites likely forgot who God was. They lived for hundreds of years in Egypt, a culture that worshiped many false gods. Whatever they believed about God when they arrived, the Israelites became influenced by pagan views during their time there (see [Exodus 32](#)).

The plagues in the book of Exodus showed the Lord's complete power over all creation. These disasters targeted elements that the Egyptians respected and worshiped:

133. *The Nile Turned to Blood* ([7:14-25](#)):

The Nile River, seen as a god that provided life and fertility to Egypt, turned into a symbol of death.

134. *Frogs* ([8:1-15](#)):

The Egyptians respected frogs, represented by *Heqet*, the frog-headed goddess of fertility. They thought she had the secret to life after death. Now, frogs covered the land, bringing the smell of death.

135. *Gnats* ([8:16-19](#)):

"The finger of God" brought a plague of biting insects from the ground. This showed God's power over *Geb*, the Egyptian god of the earth.

- 136. *Flies* (8:20-32):** The Lord made a clear difference between Israel and Egypt. Swarms of biting flies filled the land and tormented the Egyptians, including Pharaoh. They revered flies as symbols of life from death.
- 137. *Death of Livestock* (9:1-7):** The Egyptians saw cattle as holy, believing they controlled life and fertility. They depicted *Amon-Re*, Egypt's chief god, as a bull. "The hand of the Lord" struck the cattle, showing his supreme power.
- 138. *Festering Boils* (9:8-12):** God gave the Egyptians painful sores. The Egyptian goddess of healing, *Sekhmet*, could not help them.
- 139. *Hail* (9:13-35):** The Egyptian god *Osiris*, who represented plants, could not stop the Lord from destroying them, because "the earth is the LORD's."
- 140. *Locusts* (10:1-20):** The Lord sent wind to bring locusts, which destroyed the remaining plants. This ended any hope that *Osiris* could restore Egypt's crops.
- 141. *Darkness* (10:21-29):** The Lord showed total control over *Re*, the sun god and leader of the Egyptian gods, who was seen as the father of mankind. No power in Egypt could oppose the Lord and his plans.
- 142. *Death of the Firstborn* (11:1-12:30):** The Lord took the life of each Egyptian family's male heir, which they valued most. Meanwhile, the Lord saved Israel through the Passover blood sacrifice.

Yahweh showed both the Egyptians and the Israelites that he is the only God.

The plagues are often known as "signs," similar to Jesus' miracles (for example, [Exodus 7:3](#); [10:1-2](#); [John 2:23](#); [4:48](#); [12:37](#)). The plagues demonstrate that worshipping created things leads to God's judgment. In contrast, Jesus' miracles show that God can conquer all deadly aspects of creation. This

includes illness, evil forces, unpredictable nature, and even death, through the gift of life.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:15-20](#); [20:1-18](#); [Exodus 7:3-5](#); [7:14-11:10](#); [12:28-33](#); [32:35](#); [Numbers 11:33](#); [12:1-15](#); [16:43-50](#); [1 Kings 13:4](#); [2 Kings 2:24](#); [2 Chronicles 26:16-21](#); [Acts 5:1-11](#)

The Poor and Needy in the Psalms

Throughout the Bible, God supports those who are poor and needy. These people are often oppressed and treated badly by society or greedy people. The book of Psalms frequently mentions the struggles of the oppressed and God's concern for them. In their distress, the poor and needy can find refuge in the Lord (see [Psalms 76:9](#); [107:4-9](#)). They can call out to him, as he has promised to care for them (see [25:16-18](#); [70:1-5](#); [74:19](#)). They can trust him and wait with hope for him to bring justice ([18:1-50](#); [70:5](#)).

Many people may experience life with sorrow ([Psalms 88:13-15](#); [90:15](#); see [102:1-28](#)). Distress can be a form of discipline that teaches righteousness ([119:71](#), [75](#)). No matter how long, severe, or what causes it, the Lord hears the cries of the poor, as many psalms show ([10:17-18](#); [12:5](#); [22:24](#); [35:10](#); [109:31](#); [113:5-7](#); [140:12](#)). In the end, God will satisfy the poor and the godly will rejoice (see [22:26](#); [132:15](#); [34:1-2](#); [69:32](#)).

God chose the kings from David's family line to bring justice to God's suffering people ([Psalm 72:2, 4, 12](#)). But they did not succeed. Jesus, the Christ king, understands our human struggles ([Isaiah 53:4, 7](#)). He has come to help the poor and oppressed ([Luke 4:17-21](#); see [Isaiah 61:1-3](#)). He is the hope for those who know they need him and who desire righteousness ([Matthew 5:3-12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 9:18](#); [10:1-18](#); [12:5](#); [22:1-31](#); [34:1-22](#); [35:10](#); [37:14](#); [40:17](#); [41:1](#); [49:2](#); [68:10](#); [69:33](#); [70:5](#); [72:2-4](#); [12-13](#); [74:21](#); [82:3-4](#); [107:41](#); [109:16, 22, 31](#); [132:15](#); [140:12](#)

The Priestly Blessing

The priestly blessing is a well-known and beloved passage in the Hebrew Bible ([Numbers 6:22-27](#)). For centuries, worshipers have found comfort in its

short yet meaningful lines. This famous text is simple and distinguished.

The priestly blessing calls for the Lord's favor by repeating his name in each request ("the Lord" means *Yahweh*; see study note on Exodus 3:15). Repeating God's name reminds his people of his care and role in their lives. This blessing emphasizes the bond between God and his people and helps them remember from where their blessings come.

Many Old Testament passages talk about blessings from God and people (for example, [Genesis 12:1-3; 27:1-40](#); [Deuteronomy 7:12-15](#); [28:1-14](#)). The Israelites needed God's blessings, his help and favor, as they prepared to leave Sinai. Modern readers often think of blessings in general terms. But, the Israelites in the wilderness understood them as food, water, health, children, protection from enemies, and settling in the promised land. Throughout the book of Numbers, God provided Israel's practical needs.

The Lord blessed Israel through the words of Aaron and his sons, the priests ([Numbers 6:22-23](#)). Besides their work in the tabernacle (and later the temple), the priests played a key role in Israelite life. For example, the priests helped guarantee justice in the land ([Deuteronomy 17:8-12](#)). They supported the king in his duties, following a principle in [Deuteronomy 17:18-20](#). Eli the priest comforted Hannah and guided young Samuel's spiritual growth ([1 Samuel 1:1-3:21](#)). The priests and Levites were active in teaching Israel's spiritual lessons (see, for example, [Deuteronomy 33:9-10](#); [Nehemiah 8:9-12](#); [Malachi 2:5-9](#)).

An important archaeological discovery emphasizes the importance of this ancient priestly blessing. In 1980, excavators found two small silver scrolls in a rock-cut tomb at *Ketef Hinnom*, southwest of Jerusalem's Old City. Scholars date these objects (amulets) to the late 600s or early 500s BC. After a long and careful process, they unrolled the delicate scrolls and found the blessing from [Numbers 6:24-26](#), closely matching the Hebrew Bible text.

In ancient times, people sometimes wore such scrolls as symbolic objects (charms), similar to *tefillin* or "phylacteries" or "prayer boxes" (see [Deuteronomy 6:8](#); [Matthew 23:5](#)). These small scrolls are the earliest biblical manuscripts and contain the earliest reference to *Yahweh*, the Old Testament name of God, found in Jerusalem. These archaeological finds show the lasting appeal of this brief biblical text.

Many New Testament letters conclude with a blessing for the readers. This blessing is similar to the priestly blessing in Numbers (for example, [2 Corinthians 13:14](#); [Hebrews 13:20-21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:28; 9:1, 26-27; 12:1-3; 14:19-20; 28:1-4; 48:15-20; 49:25-26](#); [Leviticus 9:22](#); [Numbers 6:22-27; 24:1-9](#); [Deuteronomy 10:8; 33:11-29](#); [1 Samuel 2:20](#); [1 Kings 8:55-65](#); [2 Chronicles 30:27](#); [Psalms 115:12-15; 128:1-6](#); [Matthew 5:3-11](#); [Luke 11:27-28](#); [2 Corinthians 13:14](#); [Ephesians 6:23](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:23-24](#)

The Promise of a Second Exodus

God brought the people of Israel back to their homeland from Babylon, just as he had brought them out of Egypt many years before ([Isaiah 48:20-21](#)). (This first rescue from Egypt is called the exodus.) This time, when leaving Babylon, the people needed to be pure and take their time, not rushing to leave ([52:11,12](#)).

The experience in exile and the journey compare to a desert from which the Lord rescues (see [Isaiah 35:1](#)):

- He creates a road through the desert and turns it into a place with water, plants, and animals ([Isaiah 43:19-20](#)).
- He removes obstacles ([42:16](#); [49:11](#)).
- He guides his people ([42:16](#); [58:11](#); [63:13](#)).
- He feeds them ([49:10](#)).
- He protects them from the heat ([49:10](#)).
- He gives them strength ([58:11](#)).
- He changes their sorrow into great joy ([51:3](#)).
- He pours out his Spirit on them ([44:3-4](#)).

Christians also experience an "exodus." They leave behind sin and death through Jesus' death and resurrection. The Holy Spirit helps Christians have a new life. They serve God joyfully while waiting for his kingdom to fully arrive.

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 35:8-10](#); [42:14-16](#); [43:18-21](#); [44:3-4](#); [48:20-21](#); [49:9-12](#); [52:11-12](#); [58:8-12](#); [Jeremiah 31:2-17](#); [Joel 3:17-21](#); [Luke 1:78-79](#); [John 7:38](#); [15:19](#); [2 Corinthians 5:17](#); [6:17-18](#); [Ephesians 5:8](#); [Colossians 1:13](#); [Hebrews 13:12-14](#); [Revelation 7:16](#)

The Promise of Dynasty

God promised King David that his family line would last forever ([2 Samuel 7:11-16](#) and parallel passage in [1 Chronicles 17:9-14](#)). Yet, the writer of Chronicles (called the Chronicler) lived when David's family line seemed to have ended. Although David's descendants continued, no descendant had been king since Judah's exile to Babylon over 150 years earlier (see [1 Chronicles 3:1-24](#)). This situation raised doubts about Israel's future hope.

The Chronicler intended to show that God's promise to David was unconditional and that his throne was indeed "secure forever." Even the possibility of exile does not remove the hope of God's promise of a royal family line. The promise would continue for a future time because a future descendant of David would inherit the throne ([1 Chronicles 17:11](#)).

The Chronicler did not directly write about the Messiah in the strict meaning of the term. He was not mainly focused on the coming of a deliverer chosen by God. Instead, he hoped that kings from David's line would lead the covenant community again (the people of Israel who had a special agreement with God). The Chronicler encouraged the community to anticipate a new king who would improve Israel's condition.

The birth of Jesus, the Son of David, fulfilled the Chronicler's hope for Israel. Jesus met the Chronicler's expectation of a new king (see [Matthew 1:1-17](#)). His kingdom includes all nations ([Isaiah 49:6](#)). It extends "from sea to sea, and from the Euphrates to the ends of the earth" ([Zechariah 9:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 49:8-12](#); [1 Chronicles 5:1-2](#); [17:1-15](#); [22:6-13](#); [28:4-7](#); [Psalms 78:67-72](#); [132:11-12](#); [Amos 9:11-12](#); [Matthew 1:1-17](#); [22:41-46](#)

The Promise of New Life

The resurrection is a key belief in Christianity. Without it, the Christian faith has no value ([1 Corinthians 15:14](#)). God promises that his people will share in this resurrection with Christ ([Colossians 3:1](#)). It is important to plainly understand the new life God promises us.

[Ezekiel 37](#) might seem to suggest that everyone will resurrect with new bodies after death. Yet, the prophet Ezekiel is not asking, "Can human bones come back to life?" Ezekiel and his audience already knew about the possibility of resurrection from the miracles of Elijah and Elisha ([1 Kings 17:17-24](#); [2 Kings 4:31-37](#); [13:20-21](#)). Instead, Ezekiel is asking, "Can *these* bones live?" He is questioning if God can restore the nation of Judah since they are a stripped, broken apart, and dried-up nation.

At that time, the Babylonians had devastated Judah, destroyed the temple, and exiled many people to Babylon. The nation had lost its power, been broken politically, and was spiritually exhausted. Those still in Judah were a small group, only the poorest of the poor (see [2 Kings 25:8-12](#)). Many believed there was no future for God's people. They said, "Our bones are dried up, and our hope has perished; we are cut off" ([Ezekiel 37:11](#)). The question was not whether God *could* revive them, but whether he *would* perform such a miracle for the dry bones representing Israel.

The prophet answered this question with a strong *Yes!* God would bring his people back to life by pouring out his Spirit, responding to the prophet's word. Their death because of their sins was real. But God would not leave them in the grave (see [Psalm 16:10](#)). Instead, he promised that in the future he would give his people life through his Spirit. He would transform them into a new creation, a new Spirit-filled Israel. This new people of God would stand as a mighty army to serve the Lord.

God can bring back to life those who are physically or spiritually dead. He chooses to give new life to sinners who do not deserve it (see [John 3:5-7](#); [Ephesians 2:1-7](#)). Those who suffer from sin also receive the new life God offers through his Spirit, both now and forever (see [Romans 8:5-13](#); [Colossians 3:1-11](#)). He makes people, whom the world sees as beyond saving, acceptable to him through Christ ([1 Corinthians 6:9-11](#)). He also prepares them for meaningful work in his service ([Ephesians 4:12-13](#); [6:11-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 17:17-24](#); [2 Kings 4:31-37](#); [13:20-21](#); [Psalm 16:10](#); [Ezekiel 18:31](#); [37:1-28](#); [39:29](#); [Matthew 22:31-32](#); [Romans 8:11](#); [2 Corinthians 5:17](#)

The Purpose of the Judgments

What is the purpose of God's judgments? Are they meant to bring redemption, or are they just meant to destroy? The judgments in the book of Revelation provide some clues.

At the end of the sixth trumpet, despite all the plagues, people "still did not repent of the works of their hands" ([Revelation 9:20-21](#)). Some people will not change, no matter what happens to them, even under pressure.

The tormented people of the fifth trumpet wanted to die instead of turning to God in repentance ([9:6](#)). Many choose death over admitting their sins.

In the sixth seal, the people asked the rocks to fall on them to hide them from "the wrath of the Lamb" ([6:12-17](#)). Their desire to escape judgment shows fear instead of trust in God.

Revelation emphasizes God's final justice and the idea of retribution or pay back ([16:5-7](#)). Both Christians and non-Christians will get what they deserve (see [2:23](#); [11:18](#); [14:13](#); [18:6](#); [20:12-13](#); [22:12](#)).

The judgments are God's partial response to the prayers of the saints for justice. Judgment happens in God's time, not ours ([6:9-11](#); [8:2-5](#)).

The judgments, similar to the plagues on Egypt, show that earthly gods and God's enemies lack power ([Exodus 7:8-12](#); [12:12](#); compare [Revelation 13:4-17](#); [19:20-21](#); [20:9-10](#)).

The judgments are part of God's mission and provide a final opportunity to repent ([Revelation 14:6-7](#); see [9:20-21](#); [16:9](#), [11](#), [21](#)).

God has made it clear that sin is wrong and judgment is coming ([Romans 2:5-11](#)). Yet, many people still refuse to repent and accept God's grace ([Romans 1:32](#)). Even in the final days, when God sends his witnesses to warn about the coming destruction, many will choose to support evil forces. They will celebrate the downfall of God's prophets ([Revelation 11:3-10](#)). Those who oppose God and turn away from him he will eventually remove from his presence.

Judgment for disobedience and evil actions is certain (see [Romans 1:18-2:11](#)). Yet God patiently waits for people to repent and offers his grace (see [Romans 2:4](#); [2 Peter 3:8-10](#)). Therefore, these warnings about judgment can be a chance for change.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 6:6](#); [12:12](#); [Leviticus 26:25](#); [2 Kings 17:7-23](#); [Psalm 103:6](#); [Proverbs 16:11](#); [Isaiah 13:11](#); [26:21](#); [59:18](#); [Jeremiah 5:1-9](#); [Ezekiel 11:21](#); [39:21-24](#); [Zephaniah 1:12](#); [Malachi 3:5](#); [Luke 12:47](#); [John 5:30](#); [Romans 2:2-11](#); [Hebrews 2:1-4](#); [10:29](#); [Revelation 9:20-21](#)

The Purpose of the Sinai Covenant

Almost everything the Israelites learned about ultimate reality from the Egyptians was incorrect. There are not many gods. There is only one God. The Creator is completely good, and evil comes from rebelling against him. You cannot gain God's blessings through magic or trying to influence God. God's blessings are free to those who lovingly submit to him.

When the Israelites left Egypt, they did not fully understand God as he intended. Through the plagues and crossing the Red Sea, they learned about God's unique power. In the wilderness, they discovered God's caring provision. Yet, they still did not know God's character. The covenant at Sinai was a special agreement between God and the Israelites. The covenant was designed to teach the Israelites about God's nature and character as they followed his Torah, his instructions.

The covenant used a well-known political form, the *suzerain-vassal treaty*. In this type of treaty, a powerful king (the *suzerain*) made a treaty with a nation he had conquered (the *vassal* people). The conquered people promised complete loyalty to the king and agreed to follow his rules. In return, the king promised to care for them and protect them from enemies. In the covenant at Mount Sinai, God asked the people for complete loyalty to him as their only God. He wanted them to live in a way that showed his will and nature as their Creator and King.

God wanted the Israelites to simply obey him. Yet, since the first human sin, there has been a fundamental problem with the human spirit ([Genesis 3](#)). Simple obedience was impossible for the Israelites because their wills were not obedient.

The covenant was good, but it could not enable the Israelites to follow it ([Romans 7:12](#); [8:3](#)). Without God's Spirit, we cannot do what we must or share the creator's character. But now, Jesus has died as a sacrifice on the cross to remove our sins. So, God empowers by the Spirit those who trust in Christ to fulfill his covenant purpose and share his holy character.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 9:1](#); [19:3-6](#); [Leviticus 11:44-45](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [32:40](#); [John 16:5-11](#); [Romans 8:5-14](#); [10:8-17](#); [Galatians 5](#)

The Remnant

The remnant is a small group of people who remain faithful to God. When foreign armies threatened to invade, and people feared being taken away from their homeland, the idea of the remnant was a source of hope for God's people (see [Micah 2:12-13](#); [4:6-8](#)). The exile of the Israelites to Babylon was God's judgment on his people. But God showed he would not destroy them completely (see [Hosea 11:8-11](#)). Preserving a remnant showed God's mercy and faithfulness.

The idea of a remnant was central to the prophet Isaiah's message. One of his sons was named Shear-jashub, which means "a remnant will return" ([Isaiah 7:3](#); see [10:21](#)). Isaiah prophesied that when God judged his people with destruction, he would save the remnant to be the starting point of a new beginning. This destruction happened when the Babylonians attacked from 605 to 586 BC.

Because the population of Judah would be greatly reduced (as the northern kingdom of Israel had been already), this remnant would be a very small beginning. Isaiah describes the remnant as:

- a "Branch" ([4:2](#)),
- a "stump" ([6:13](#)),
- a community of the "poor" and "needy" ([25:4](#)), and
- grain that "will be gathered one by one" ([27:12-13](#)).

This remnant was to trust in God while waiting for him to establish his rule and reward them (see [3:10](#); [40:10](#)). God promised that this small group would grow into a large crowd from both Israel and other nations ([27:6](#); [60:3](#)).

In fulfillment of prophecy, a remnant of God's people were allowed to return to Jerusalem and rebuild the temple during King Cyrus of Persia's rule ([Ezra 1:2-4](#)). Ezra the priest saw this preservation of a remnant as an act of God's grace. He also knew this grace could be put at risk if the people followed their ancestors in disobedience ([Ezra 9:5-15](#)).

The idea of the remnant encourages people to remain faithful to God, even when others are not. For Israel and Judah, this faithfulness would restore their land and bring the blessings God promised his people.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 19:31](#); [2 Chronicles 36:20](#); [Ezra 9:14](#); [Isaiah 1:8-9](#); [4:1-3](#); [6:13](#); [10:19-22](#); [11:10-16](#); [27:12-13](#); [28:5](#); [37:31-32](#); [46:3-4](#); [Jeremiah 6:9](#); [23:3-4](#); [31:7-8](#); [Amos 5:15](#); [Micah 2:12](#); [4:6-7](#); [5:7-8](#); [7:18](#); [Zephaniah 3:11-13](#)

The Resurrection of Jesus

The Bible clearly describes how Jesus physically rose from the dead through God's power. However, many other explanations have been suggested:

- 143.** Jesus did not actually die. He fainted and later woke up in a cold tomb. Some call this the "the swoon theory."
- 144.** Jesus' disciples stole his body and lied about the resurrection (see [Matthew 28:12-15](#)).
- 145.** The disciples saw things that were not there (called hallucinations) and had dreams, causing them to confuse these experiences with a physical resurrection.
- 146.** The resurrection is a personal faith experience, not a historical event.

These ideas often come from doubt about supernatural or miraculous events. They overlook that for New Testament writers and their audiences, the term *resurrection* meant an actual dead body coming back to life (see [1 Corinthians 15](#)).

There is historical evidence for Jesus' resurrection. The biblical accounts are reliable as well. These proofs include:

- 147. The empty tomb.
- 148. Women as witnesses, which was unusual at that time. This is because people then considered women's testimony less reliable than men's.
- 149. The consistent accounts of Jesus' appearances after his resurrection.
- 150. How the disciples transformed from fearful to fearless followers.
- 151. The disciples' ability to accept the shame of following the religion of a crucified man. According to [Deuteronomy 21:23](#), such a death meant being under God's curse.

Judaism had no concept of a Messiah (God's chosen one) who would die and then rise again that could easily be applied to Jesus. Creating a story that no one would find believable would not have made sense. The most reasonable conclusion is exactly what the New Testament declares: Jesus did rise from the dead.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 16:21](#); [17:9](#), [23](#); [20:19](#); [26:32](#); [28:1-10](#); [Mark 14:28](#); [Luke 9:22](#); [14:14](#); [John 2:19-22](#); [5:21](#); [6:39-40](#); [11:1-44](#); [14:20](#); [21:14](#); [Acts 1:21-22](#); [2:22-36](#); [3:15](#), [26](#); [4:2](#), [10](#), [33](#); [5:30](#); [10:39-40](#); [13:29-31](#); [17:18](#), [32](#); [23:6-10](#); [Romans 1:4](#); [4:24-25](#); [6:4-5](#), [9](#); [7:4](#); [8:11](#), [34](#); [10:9](#); [1 Corinthians 6:14](#); [15:4](#), [12-23](#), [35](#), [42-44](#), [52](#); [2 Corinthians 1:9](#); [4:14](#); [5:15](#); [Galatians 1:1](#); [Ephesians 1:19-20](#); [2:5-6](#); [Philippians 3:10-11](#); [Colossians 2:12](#); [3:1](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:10](#); [4:14](#); [2 Timothy 2:8](#), [18](#); [Hebrews 6:2](#); [11:35](#); [1 Peter 1:21](#); [3:18](#), [21](#); [Revelation 20:4-8](#), [11-15](#)

The Resurrection of the Dead

Jesus spoke about a future resurrection for everyone. God will raise up all people to eternal life or to judgment ([Mark 12:26-27](#); [John 5:28-29](#); [6:39-40](#), [44](#), [54](#); [11:25-26](#); see also [Luke 20:34-36](#)). When Jesus returns, all his followers will resurrect to be with him forever ([1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#); see also [2 Corinthians 5:1-10](#)).

This strong hope defined the perspective of early Christians. They endured suffering by focusing on the life to come ([2 Corinthians 4:16-18](#); compare [Hebrews 12:2](#)). They expected Jesus to return,

resurrect their bodies, and anticipated living with him forever ([1 Peter 1:3-6](#), [23](#)). They based their faith on the foundation of Jesus' own bodily resurrection ([1 Corinthians 15:12-20](#); [Acts 4:33](#); see also [2 Corinthians 4:14](#)).

Resurrection bodies will be very different from the bodies we have now, which have limits and weaknesses. These new bodies will be like Christ's own resurrection body: glorious, strong, never dying, and spiritual ([1 Corinthians 15:35-58](#)).

Christians are already united to Christ, so they begin experiencing resurrection life now. They "were raised" with Christ and are "alive to God in Christ Jesus" ([Romans 6:4-11](#); [8:10-11](#); [Colossians 2:12](#)). Their lives now focus on spiritual realities of heaven, not worldly things ([Colossians 3:1-4](#)). Christians can experience the transforming power of this new life, which frees them from sin and death ([Romans 8:1-4](#)). In all challenges, they trust in God's resurrection power, not themselves ([2 Corinthians 1:9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Job 19:25-27](#); [Psalms 16:10](#); [49:15](#); [Daniel 12:2-3](#); [Matthew 16:21](#); [28:1-10](#); [Mark 12:18-27](#); [John 3:13-16](#); [5:25-30](#); [6:39-40](#); [11:21-27](#); [Acts 2:23-24](#); [3:14-15](#); [4:33](#); [10:39-41](#); [17:2-3](#); [24:15](#); [26:22-23](#); [Romans 1:4](#); [4:25](#); [6:4-11](#); [8:10-11](#); [1 Corinthians 15:12-58](#); [2 Corinthians 1:8-9](#); [4:13-18](#); [5:1-10](#); [Ephesians 1:19-20](#); [Colossians 2:12](#); [3:1-4](#); [1 Thessalonians 4:13-18](#); [1 Peter 1:3-6](#), [23](#); [Revelation 20:11-15](#); [21:1-7](#); [22:1-6](#)

The Return of God's Presence with His People

The descriptions of the Israelite exile include the terrible reality that, as part of his judgment, God removed his presence from his people and from the holy city of Jerusalem. This idea is most obviously present in a vision by the prophet Ezekiel. He saw God's glorious presence leaving the temple ([Ezekiel 10:1-22](#); [11:22-23](#)). The prophets talked about the future return of God's people to the land. They often mentioned the return of God's presence (see, for example, [Isaiah 52:7-8](#); [Ezekiel 43:1-9](#)).

The prophet Zechariah focused on the Lord returning to his people. He believed God would live among them again, and the Lord's glory would be in Jerusalem ([Zechariah 1:16](#); [2:5](#), [10-11](#); [8:3](#), [23](#)). God's presence would return when they rebuilt the temple. This would bring spiritual rebirth or

newness and plenty of crops ([1:17](#); [4:8-9](#); [6:15](#); see also [Haggai 2:19](#)).

In the future, God's presence would save Jerusalem and Israel from enemies. The Lord would be king over the earth. Everyone would worship the one true God ([Zechariah 9:16](#); [10:6](#); [12:9](#); [14:9](#)). Both now and in the future, the Lord's return to Jerusalem linked to the work of God's Spirit ([4:6](#); [12:10](#); see also [Haggai 2:5](#)).

Zechariah's promise of the Lord's presence in Jerusalem prophesied the arrival of Jesus the Messiah (God's chosen one). It emphasized the amazing mystery of God's Word becoming man and living among humanity ([John 1:14](#)).

Sections for Additional Review

[Genesis 26:3](#); [31:3](#); [Exodus 3:12](#); [Deuteronomy 31:23](#); [Joshua 1:5](#); [Judges 6:16](#); [Isaiah 7:14](#); [43:2](#); [52:8](#); [Ezekiel 37:27](#); [Joel 3:21](#); [Haggai 2:5](#); [Zechariah 1:16-17](#); [2:5](#), [10-11](#); [4:6](#); [8:3](#), [23](#); [14:9](#); [John 1:14](#)

The Righteous Suffer

The book of Job invites readers to examine why we have faith in God. Job lost his possessions, family, and friends. This deeply tested his faith. Yet, he kept trusting God and proved that when Satan accused him, Satan was wrong.

Sin causes suffering, but the book of Job shows that suffering is not always because of a person's sin. Human suffering is more complex than just behavior and consequence. Some people today wrongly believe that being godly leads to material wealth, like Job's friends did. This view has problems, as history shows. There are many examples of righteous people who suffer, including Jesus Christ.

Scripture tells us that Christians must also share in Christ's suffering. It says "our present sufferings are not comparable to the glory that will be revealed in us" ([Romans 8:17-18](#)). Being a disciple of Christ means being willing to follow him into suffering (see [Luke 9:23-25](#); [Philippians 3:10-11](#)).

Even in his complaints, Job recognized that only God could provide the answers he needed. When Job wished for death, he sought relief until God could deal him under better conditions ([Job 14:13](#)). When Job wanted "a mediator," it was to help him find favor with God ([9:33-35](#)). When Job complained that God did not listen, it was because

he knew his answers had to come from God (see [19:25-27](#)). This is essential to faith.

We cannot know or understand everything (see [Genesis 2:16-17](#); [Deuteronomy 29:29](#); [Acts 1:7](#); [1 Thessalonians 5:1-2](#)). Some things are for God alone to understand and guide according to his will. We should live by faith. Even when we suffer, we can trust God (see [Romans 8:26-39](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 4:4-8](#); [26:17-33](#); [31:38-42](#); [37:2-36](#); [39:1-20](#); [Exodus 1:8-11](#); [1 Samuel 18:10-11](#), [28-29](#); [19:10](#); [22:1-19](#); [1 Kings 21:1-15](#); [2 Chronicles 24:20-22](#); [Job 9:33-35](#); [14:13](#); [19:25-27](#); [Isaiah 54:17](#); [Jeremiah 11:18-21](#); [26:1-23](#); [38:1-13](#); [Matthew 23:29-37](#); [John 5:24](#); [15:20](#); [Acts 6:8-7:60](#); [Romans 8:17-18](#), [26-39](#); [Hebrews 12:1-13](#); [1 Peter 4:12-16](#)

The Secret of the Messiah

In the Gospel of Mark, Jesus often tells people not to reveal his true identity as the Messiah (God's chosen one). This includes:

- those Jesus healed or raised from the dead,
- the disciples who knew Jesus was the Christ (the Greek word for Messiah), and
- the demons who understood Jesus' true identity (see [Mark 1:34](#), [44](#); [3:11-12](#); [5:43](#); [7:36](#); [8:29-30](#); [9:9](#)).

This theme (often called the "Messianic Secret") appears less often in the Gospels of Matthew and Luke (see [Matthew 8:4](#); [16:20](#); [Luke 9:21](#)). Why did Jesus command those he healed and those who knew his true identity to keep both his healing miracles and his identity a secret?

One possibility relates to how the Roman authorities would have reacted. During his earthly ministry, Jesus was a very popular preacher who announced the arrival of God's kingdom. He miraculously healed people and allowed his followers to call him Israel's long-awaited Messiah and King.

Roman authorities would not allow this. They would quickly try to stop such a movement. In the Roman Empire, there was no room for another kingdom or messianic rescuer within Roman rule.

Therefore, even though Jesus told his disciples he was the Christ, he did not plan to lead a political revolution against Rome ([Mark 8:27-30](#)).

Another reason Jesus might have wanted to keep his true identity secret might be the widely misunderstood identity of Jesus in the Gospel of Mark. There was a misunderstanding even among his closest followers. Jesus makes it clear that his role as Messiah, the Son of God, is directly related to his suffering and death. This reality did not match Jewish expectations of the Messiah.

Right after the apostle Peter declares Jesus as the Christ (the Messiah), Jesus announces he will suffer and die ([Mark 8:27-31](#)). Peter's response shows he does not understand ([8:32-33](#)). Jesus' miracles and deep teaching were important, but his death as a sacrifice was the most important part of his role as the Messiah.

For these reasons, Jesus found it wise to teach about God's kingdom using parables. Parables are stories that have symbolic meanings (see [Mark 4:1-34](#), especially [4:10-12](#)). This approach helped reduce the excitement caused by his miracles ([1:44](#); [5:43](#); [7:36](#); [8:26](#)). It also allowed him to hide his presence at times from the people ([7:24](#); [9:30-31](#)). He kept his teachings hidden from outsiders ([4:10-12](#), [33-34](#); [7:17](#)). He instructed those who knew his true identity not to reveal it ([Mark 1:23-26](#), [34](#); [3:11-12](#); [8:29-30](#); [9:9](#)). Jesus came "to give his life as a ransom for many" ([10:45](#)). He did not come to lead the nation of Israel in a rebellion against Rome.

But Jesus Christ, the Son of God, could not be hidden ([Mark 1:1](#)). The secret was impossible to keep because Jesus is too important ([7:36](#)). Those who experienced his healing and saw him heal others could not stop sharing what he did. Jesus's identity became clear, and people realized he is truly the Messiah, the Son of God, the one with power over nature, sickness, and death. For readers and hearers of the Gospel of Mark who learn of his identity in the first verse, Jesus proved to be the Messiah because of (not in spite of) his suffering, death, and resurrection.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 8:4](#); [16:20](#); [Mark 1:34](#), [44](#); [3:11-12](#); [5:43](#); [7:36](#); [8:29-30](#); [9:9](#), [30-31](#); [Luke 9:21](#)

The Servant-Leader

A servant-leader is a person who has a strong desire to achieve a goal by helping and serving others. This type of leader desires to take on the role of a servant rather than focusing on their own authority or status.

The Old Testament describes Moses as the Lord's servant ([Exodus 14:31](#); [Numbers 12:7-8](#)). Moses did not seek power, fame, or material gain. He hesitated to assume his leadership role. He used his prophetic authority with humility ([Numbers 12:3](#)). He knew he was under God's authority (see [Deuteronomy 34:10-12](#); [Hosea 12:13](#)).

From the time God called him, every event in Moses' story shows that he regarded his leadership as service to God. He submitted to God, did not care for himself, and was faithful. The way he acted toward the Israelites showed concern, a desire to persuade, and vision. Moses took a leadership role at a critical moment in Israelite history and often prayed or interceded for the people. He humbly submitted to God, which was the foundation of his great leadership.

Jesus of Nazareth is the perfect servant-leader. The gospels show Jesus as the Lord's "suffering servant" (see [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#)). This was especially shown through his sacrificial death, the ultimate act of service ([Mark 10:45](#)). Jesus spoke with great authority but with humility. He knew his role was like a shepherd who "lays down His life for the sheep" ([John 10:11](#)).

He spent time with children and used them as examples for those who want to fully follow God ([Matthew 18:4](#)). When James and John asked for important positions in his kingdom, Jesus criticized their worldly ambition ([Mark 10:35-45](#)). He corrected them by teaching them to follow his example as a servant ([Matthew 20:24-28](#); [23:11-12](#); [Mark 10:43-45](#)). As a model for all who want to lead others through a life of service, Jesus knew his purpose was to bring glory to God's name ([John 12:27-28](#)).

The apostles Paul and Peter followed Christ's example and lived according to his ideal of servant leadership. Paul's life of service showed humility and self-sacrifice for others (see [2 Corinthians 11:23-28](#)). He taught Christians to do the same ([Romans 8:17](#); [Galatians 5:13](#); [2 Timothy 1:8](#); [2:3](#)). He praised those who did (for example, [Philippians 2:25-30](#); [Colossians 4:7](#)).

Peter also showed self-sacrificial service for Christ (for example, [Acts 3:1-11](#); [4:13-22](#); [5:12-16](#); [9:32-42](#)). His instructions plainly define the character of a servant-leader ([1 Peter 4:10-11](#); [5:1-5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 13:8-12](#); [14:11-24](#); [30:31-32](#); [Exodus 14:31](#); [Numbers 12:3, 7-8](#); [Deuteronomy 34:10-12](#); [1 Kings 12:1-7](#); [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#); [Matthew 18:4](#); [20:24-28](#); [23:11-12](#); [Mark 10:35-45](#); [John 10:11](#); [12:27-28](#); [Acts 3:1-11](#); [4:13-22](#); [5:12-16](#); [9:32-42](#); [Romans 8:17](#); [2 Corinthians 11:23-27](#); [Galatians 5:13](#); [Philippians 2:25-30](#); [Colossians 4:7](#); [2 Timothy 1:8](#); [2:3](#); [1 Peter 4:10-11](#); [5:1-5](#)

The Seventy Sets of Seven

The "seventy weeks" (or sevens) in [Daniel 9:24-27](#) have always been difficult to understand. Although it is difficult to connect them to a specific historical period, these "seventy sets of seven" are important. They show God's control over history and emphasize his power to fulfill his plans for his people. The number seventy is seven times ten. This symbolizes completeness. For instance, the seventy years of exile for God's people were enough time to discipline them ([9:2](#)).

Here are the two main ways people understand the seventy sets of seven:

152. THE RULE OF ANTIOCHUS IV (175-163 BC). According to this view, the seventy sets of seven is a time period that begins with Cyrus II of Persia and ends with Antiochus IV. Cyrus II (also known as Cyrus the Great) was the king of Persia who ruled from 559 to around 530 BC. In 539 BC, Cyrus allowed the Jewish people to return to their homeland (see [9:25](#); [Ezra 1:2-4](#)). Antiochus IV was a Greek king who ruled over Syria and the surrounding areas from 175 to 163 BC (see [Daniel 8:23-25](#); [11:21-39](#)).

In this understanding of the seventy sets of seven, "the Messiah" (or chosen one) was the high priest Onias III, and the "prince" was Antiochus IV ([9:26-27](#)). Antiochus made a treaty with the people of Judea in 174 BC, allowing them to practice their faith peacefully. But in 170 BC, Antiochus attacked Jerusalem, killed many, and stole from the temple.

Then, in 167 BC, Antiochus ended the sacrifices and offerings. He forced the Jews to abandon their faith under threat of death. He made the temple ceremonially unclean with "the abomination of desolation" (something that showed disrespect for God and his holy temple). Antiochus placed a statue of the Greek god Zeus on the altar of burnt offering. He also sacrificed pigs on the altar and other ceremonially unclean animals (compare [11:21-35](#)).

God punished Antiochus with a painful disease, and Antiochus died in 163 BC. "The decreed destruction" was "poured out on him" ([9:27](#); see also [8:25](#); 1 Maccabees 1:10-24; 6:7-16; 2 Maccabees 9:1-29).

According to this view, when Jesus spoke of the "the abomination of desolation," he referred to the Jews' experience during Antiochus's time as a model for future events (see [Matthew 24:15](#); compare [Luke 21:20](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:3-4](#)).

153. THE DEATH OF JESUS CHRIST (AD 30 or 33). According to this view, the seventy weeks are a prophecy about Jesus Christ, the Messiah (God's chosen one). People who support this view think the seventy sets of seven began with Cyrus's decree in 539 BC ([Ezra 1:1-4](#)). Or, it may have begun with one of the decrees given to Nehemiah in either 458 or 445 BC ([Ezra 7:8-26](#); [Nehemiah 2:1-10](#)). Jesus may have died at the end of sixty-nine sets of seven (seven plus sixty-two, [Daniel 9:25-26](#)). Or, it may have been halfway through the seventieth year ([9:27](#)).

These two options affect how the seventy sets of seven conclude. In the first option, the seventieth set of seven is a future event not yet fulfilled. In the second option, the seventieth set of seven finished when the Romans destroyed Jerusalem and the temple in AD 70. If Cyrus's decree is the starting point, the 490 years are symbolic. Yet, if the decree given to Nehemiah in 445 BC to rebuild the city is the starting point, then nearly 483 years (69 times 7 years) passed between that date and Jesus' death in AD 30 or 33 (see [Nehemiah 2:1](#); [Daniel 9:25](#)).

Scholars have two different ways of explaining what happened to the seventieth set of seven years:

154. *The Seventieth Set of Seven is Yet to Occur.* Many interpreters believe that Jesus' death happened at the end of the sixty-ninth set of seven. They think the seventieth set of sevens has not yet happened. This means there is a long gap between the sixty-ninth and seventieth sets. The seventieth set is still in the future and links to the antichrist's rule during the final troubles (the tribulation) at the end of history (see [2 Thessalonians 2:3-12](#); [1 John 2:18-22](#); [4:3](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:1](#), [5](#); [16:13-14](#); [17:11](#); [19:20-21](#); [20:10](#)).

155. *The Seventieth Set of Seven Completed When Rome Destroyed Jerusalem and the Temple.* Some interpreters believe the seventy weeks ended with the coming of Jesus, his death and resurrection, and the destruction of Jerusalem and the temple in AD 70.

In this view, Jesus started his ministry at the end of the sixty-ninth set of seven, around AD 28. He ministered for about three and a half years and died in the middle of the seventieth seven. The remaining half-seven concluded when the "prince" (one or more Roman leaders) destroyed Jerusalem and its temple in AD 70. The conflict and suffering between God's people and the world's kingdom continue until the end. This is when Jesus will return, judge the wicked, and establish his kingdom.

Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 7:8](#), [11](#), [20-21](#), [24-27](#); [8:9-14](#); [9:24-27](#); [11:29-31](#), [40-45](#); [12:7](#), [11](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:3-12](#); [1 John 2:18-22](#); [4:3](#); [2 John 1:7](#); [Revelation 13:1](#), [5](#); [16:13-14](#); [17:11](#); [19:20-21](#); [20:10](#)

The Shepherd

In ancient Jewish society, shepherds who cared for sheep or goats were important. Shepherding was essential in the ancient Near East. Each morning, the shepherd led the flock out ([John 10:2-4](#)). He found grass and water and protected them from wild animals ([Amos 3:12](#)). He searched for and returned any of the flock that wandered off ([Ezekiel 34:8](#); [Matthew 18:12](#)). He returned the flock to the pen every evening.

The word *shepherd* became a common term for a ruler. People often referred to the kings of Assyria, Babylon, and Egypt as shepherds because they protected their people. This metaphor is also common in the Old Testament ([Numbers 27:17](#); [1 Kings 22:17](#); [Jeremiah 10:21](#); [23:1-2](#); [Ezekiel 34:1-10](#)).

The Old Testament regards God as the "Shepherd of Israel," caring for every part of his people's well-being ([Genesis 49:24](#); [Psalms 23:1](#); [80:1](#); [Isaiah 40:11](#)). God himself would take care of his flock ([Jeremiah 23:3](#); [31:10](#); [Ezekiel 34:11-22](#)). He

promised to provide faithful leaders who cared for his people ([Jeremiah 3:15](#); [23:4](#)).

When Israel's early leaders were unfaithful, God took action and chose his servant David as a faithful leader. He later promised to establish David's descendants as leaders over Israel (see [Ezekiel 34:23-24](#)). By the time of the prophet Jeremiah, *shepherd* began to refer to the coming Messiah (God's chosen one).

In the New Testament, Jesus called himself "the Shepherd" ([Matthew 25:31-33](#); [Mark 14:27](#); [John 10:1-30](#)). He is the "Good Shepherd" who sacrifices his life for the sheep ([John 10:11-18](#); see also [Hebrews 13:20](#)).

The church leaders are also known as shepherds ([Ephesians 4:11](#), translated as "pastors"). God gives them to the church to care for his people like a shepherd cares for sheep, guiding and teaching them in God's ways. They must remain faithful shepherds until Jesus Christ, "the Chief Shepherd," comes to lead his people directly ([1 Peter 5:1-4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 29:1-10](#); [Numbers 27:16-18](#); [2 Samuel 7:7](#); [1 Kings 22:17](#); [1 Chronicles 11:2](#); [Psalms 23:1-6](#); [77:20](#); [80:1](#); [Isaiah 40:11](#); [44:28](#); [56:10-11](#); [Jeremiah 10:21](#); [25:34-36](#); [Ezekiel 34:1-31](#); [Micah 7:14](#); [Zechariah 10:2b-3](#); [11:4-17](#); [13:7](#); [Matthew 2:6](#); [18:12-14](#); [26:31](#); [John 10:1-16](#); [1 Peter 2:25](#); [5:1-4](#); [Jude 1:12](#); [Revelation 7:17](#)

The Son of God

Jesus' healings, exorcisms (casting out demons), raising the dead, and teachings resulted in wonder, awe, amazement, and fear (for example, [Mark 1:22](#); [27](#); [4:41](#); [5:15](#); [20](#); [33](#); [7:37](#); [9:15](#); [10:24](#); [26](#); [32](#); [12:17](#); [15:5](#)). This amazement emphasizes the miraculous nature of Jesus' ministry. The Gospel writers wanted readers to ask, "What kind of man is this? Even the winds and the sea obey Him!" ([Matthew 8:27](#); [Mark 4:41](#); [Luke 8:25](#)). Mark answers this at the start of his Gospel: Jesus is the "Christ, the Son of God" ([Mark 1:1](#)).

In the Old Testament, the title "Son of God" refers to the people of Israel ([Exodus 4:22](#); [Deuteronomy 32:5-6](#), [18-19](#); [Psalm 82:6](#); [Jeremiah 3:19](#); [31:9](#); [20](#); [Hosea 11:1](#); [Malachi 2:10](#)). It can refer to angels ([Genesis 6:2](#); [Job 1:6](#); [2:1](#); [38:7](#); [Psalm 29:1](#)). It also has a special meaning for Israel's king, as they regarded the anointed king as God's "son" ([2](#)

[Samuel 7:14](#); [1 Chronicles 22:10](#); [28:6](#); [Psalms 2:7](#); [89:26-27](#)).

The title also appears in Jewish writings between the Old and New Testaments (including the Apocrypha and the Dead Sea Scrolls). It possibly refers to the coming Messiah (God's chosen one). Jews in the first century likely considered the coming Messiah as a "Son of God."

God confirmed Jesus as "the Son of God" at his baptism ([Mark 1:11](#); [Matt 3:17](#); [Luke 3:22](#)). Demons also recognized him during his ministry ([Matthew 8:29](#); [Mark 1:24](#); [1:34](#); [3:11](#); [5:7](#); [Luke 4:34](#); [8:28](#)). Later, the disciples acknowledged Jesus as the Christ ([Matthew 16:16](#); [Mark 8:29](#); [Luke 9:20](#)). Jesus then began teaching them about his coming death ([Matthew 16:21](#); [Mark 8:31](#); [Luke 9:22](#)).

At the transfiguration, Jesus' appearance changed to reveal his glory as God's Son, and God confirmed what the disciples had said about Jesus ([Matthew 17:5](#); [Mark 9:7](#); [Luke 9:35](#)). As Jesus neared his death, he affirmed his identity as God's Son through his teachings and during his trial ([Mark 12:1-12](#); [13:32](#); [Mark 14:61-62](#)).

At Jesus' death on the cross, something powerful happened. A Roman soldier (called a centurion) who watched Jesus die was the first person in the story to acknowledge Jesus as "the Son of God" ([Mark 15:39](#)). Earlier in the Gospels, people had seen Jesus was God's Son when he drove out evil spirits, and God himself had announced Jesus as his Son. But it was Jesus' willing death on the cross, and the way he died, that showed most clearly that he was truly God's Son ([Mark 15:33-39](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 4:22](#); [Deuteronomy 32:5-6](#); [2 Samuel 7:14](#); [1 Chronicles 22:10](#); [28:6](#); [Psalms 2:7](#); [89:26-27](#); [Jeremiah 3:19](#); [31:9](#); [20](#); [Matthew 26:63-68](#); [Mark 1:1](#), [11](#), [24](#); [4:35-41](#); [8:31](#); [9:7](#); [12:1-12](#); [14:61-62](#); [15:32-39](#); [Luke 1:32-35](#); [4:41](#); [John 1:18](#); [3:16-17](#); [35-36](#); [5:19-26](#); [17:5](#), [24](#); [20:31](#); [Acts 13:33](#); [Romans 1:4](#); [5:10](#); [8:3](#), [32](#); [2 Corinthians 1:19](#); [Galatians 2:20](#); [4:4-5](#); [Ephesians 4:13](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:10](#); [Hebrews 1:2-14](#); [3:6](#); [5:5](#); [1 John 1:3](#); [2:22](#); [3:23](#); [4:9-10](#), [14](#); [5:20](#); [2 John 1:3](#), [9](#); [Revelation 2:18](#)

The Son of Man

"Son of Man" was Jesus' favorite way to refer to himself. The phrase is unusual in both Greek and English. It translates the Hebrew phrase *ben 'adam*, which means "human being" or "person" (see, for example, [Ezekiel 2:1-8](#)). Jesus liked this name because it did not cause debates like the titles "Christ" or "Messiah."

The Gospels use the expression in three ways:

156. The background to Jesus' use of the title comes from [Daniel 7:13-14](#). In this passage, a messianic figure "like a son of man" (meaning "like a human") arrives with the clouds of heaven and receives great glory and power. Jesus saw himself as the one who would return to earth in the clouds of heaven (see [Mark 8:38](#); [13:26](#); [14:62](#)). Sometimes, Jesus used "Son of Man" to describe his role as judge, deliverer, savior, and the one who rights wrongs ([Matthew 10:23](#); [13:41](#); [16:27](#); [19:28](#); [24:27](#), [30](#), [37](#), [44](#); [25:31](#); [26:64](#)).
157. Jesus often called himself the "Son of Man" to show he was a suffering redeemer ([Matthew 12:40](#); [17:9](#), [12](#), [22](#); [20:18](#), [28](#); [26:2](#), [24](#), [45](#)). This idea comes from [Isaiah 52:13-53:12](#).
158. Sometimes, Jesus used "Son of Man" to describe himself as a representative of humans ([Matthew 8:20](#); [11:19](#); [12:8](#), [32](#); [13:37](#)). The book of Ezekiel uses "son of man" in a similar way (again see, [Ezekiel 2:1-8](#)).

Jesus did not use "Son of Man" to separate his humanity from his divinity as "Son of God" sometimes does. By using this title, Jesus defined himself as the Messiah or Christ (God's chosen one) on his own terms. He used "Son of Man" to describe his complete identity and implied that those who watched and listened should recognize who he is.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 2:1-8](#); [3:1](#), [4](#), [10](#), [17](#), [25](#); [4:1](#); [Daniel 7:13-14](#); [8:17](#); [Matthew 8:18-22](#); [9:6](#); [10:23](#); [11:19](#); [12:8](#), [32](#), [40](#); [13:37](#), [41](#); [16:13](#), [27-28](#); [17:9](#), [12](#), [22](#); [19:28](#); [20:18](#), [28](#); [24:27](#), [30](#), [37-39](#), [44](#); [25:31](#); [26:2](#), [24](#), [45](#), [64](#); [Mark 2:10](#); [John 1:51](#); [3:13-14](#); [5:27](#); [6:27](#), [53](#),

[62](#); [8:28](#); [9:35](#); [12:23](#), [34](#); [13:31](#); [Acts 7:56](#); [Hebrews 2:6](#); [Revelation 1:13](#); [14:14](#)

The Sovereignty of God

People often think they can control everything that happens in their lives through their own choices and actions. But the Bible teaches us something different. It shows us that God has the highest power and authority over all things (see, for example, [Deuteronomy 4:39](#); [Psalms 135:5-7](#); [Isaiah 46:8-11](#); [Jude 1:24-25](#)). While our choices and actions have real consequences, God's will (what God wants and plans) is much more important (see [James 4:13-16](#)).

God guides and controls everything that happens. We call this the sovereignty of God. God rules over the lives of all people ([Psalm 135:5-12](#)). God also controls the entire universe and everything that happens in the world's history ([Isaiah 40:15-17](#); [Acts 17:24](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#)). God directs everything to his planned outcomes ([Isaiah 46:10](#); [Daniel 7:27-28](#); [Matthew 24:14-31](#); [Revelation 1:7-8](#)).

In 2 Kings, God shows his power over nations. He chose and removed the kings of Israel and Judah based on His plans and their obedience. He allowed attacks on his people as punishment for their sins ([2 Kings 8:18-22](#)). God was in control when the Assyrians attacked Samaria and defeated the northern kingdom ([17:1-6](#), [18](#), [20](#)). King Hezekiah succeeded in Judah because of the Lord's blessings ([18:5-7](#)). God's influence is obvious in the complex international events during the rules of Judah's last kings, as he promised ([23:26-27](#)).

God shows his power by answering the prayers and requests of his people. When the Elisha prayed, God answered his faithful prophet. Through Elisha, God allowed the woman from Shunem to have a son and later brought that son back to life ([2 Kings 4:17](#), [32-35](#)). The Lord kindly answered King Jehoahaz's prayers and sent a rescuer for troubled Israel ([13:4-5](#)). He honored King Hezekiah's prayers for Jerusalem and for his own life ([19:1-7](#); [20:1-6](#)).

Paul shows that God decides the path of salvation. Paul often explains the surprising events in salvation history by referring to God's words and actions. Human choices alone cannot explain the situation. God has said, "I will have mercy on whom I have mercy" ([Romans 9:15](#)). Theologians will

keep debating God's role and human choice in salvation, but God's control is evident.

Because God is sovereign, his people should try to live in harmony with his will ([Romans 12:1-2](#)). They should use the strength he provides (see [1 Corinthians 1:8-9](#)). We can follow Christ's example in his prayer, "Yet not as I will, but as You will" ([Matthew 26:39](#)). Today, many people ignore God's influence in human affairs. Yet, God's decisions guide the world and the lives of those who trust him.

When we live for God's glory, everything that happens is ultimately for our good ([Isaiah 42:8](#); [Habakkuk 2:14](#); [Jude 1:24-25](#); [Psalm 84:11](#); [Ephesians 3:16-19](#); [Colossians 1:27](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:11-12](#)). We can confidently say that "God works all things together for the good of those who love Him, who are called according to His purpose" ([Romans 8:28](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 8:22](#); [9:29](#); [Deuteronomy 4:39](#); [32:8](#), [39](#); [Joshua 2:11](#); [1 Samuel 2:6-8](#); [2 Kings 13:4-5](#); [17:1-6](#), [18-20](#); [18:5-7](#); [19:5-7](#); [20:4-6](#); [Psalms 24:1-2](#); [84:11](#); [135:5-12](#); [Isaiah 40:15-17](#); [45:7](#); [46:10](#); [Jeremiah 27:5-7](#); [Daniel 7:27-28](#); [Habakkuk 2:14](#); [John 19:11](#); [Acts 17:24-26](#); [Romans 8:28](#); [9:5-24](#); [1 Corinthians 1:8-9](#); [Colossians 1:15-20](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:11-12](#); [Jude 1:24-25](#); [Revelation 1:7-8](#)

The Spirit of the Law

When King Hezekiah wanted to celebrate Passover, he had a problem. Passover is a feast marking Israel's freedom from slavery in Egypt and is the first feast of Israel's religious year ([Exodus 12:1-2](#)). Hezekiah intended to restore Israel's worship of the Lord. Yet, the time between starting his renewal efforts and the first month of the year was too short. The priests did not have enough time to prepare and gather the people ([2 Chronicles 30:2-3](#)). As a result, he could not celebrate Passover at the usual time.

Hezekiah held the Passover a month late ([2 Chronicles 30:15](#)). He believed celebrating was more important than the timing. By delaying, he gave people time to gather at the temple in Jerusalem. This brought harmony between Judah and the northern kingdom and unified the celebration.

Following precise regulations was less important than guaranteeing everyone could celebrate Passover. When the feast began, many people had not properly purified themselves. So they could not slaughter their own sacrifices as the law required.

Hezekiah decided participation in Passover was more important than strict obedience to regulations. He prayed for the pilgrims who could not prepare properly. Although they could not make sacrifices without being pure, they could still participate in Passover. Having the right attitude and seeking the Lord in prayer led to God's gracious acceptance ([2 Chronicles 30:18-20](#); see also [1 Corinthians 11:27-34](#)).

Religious leaders often criticized Jesus for not following all aspects of the law. They especially were concerned about the Sabbath and purity. Jesus taught that showing love to others was more important than following every detail of the law. He also criticized religious leaders for focusing too much on the details of the law instead of the principles behind them. While strict obedience to the law was key to Jewish identity, the spirit of the law allowed some flexibility in certain situations.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 12:1-30](#); [2 Kings 5:17-19](#); [2 Chronicles 30:1-27](#); [Matthew 15:21-28](#); [John 8:1-11](#); [Romans 3:23-28](#); [1 Corinthians 11:27-34](#); [Hebrews 9:13-15](#); [James 5:16](#)

The Spirit's Presence

In the Old Testament, the Spirit of the Lord came to people or groups when God gave them a task or chose them for a role. The Spirit empowered judges like Othniel, Gideon, and Jephthah for their duties ([Judges 3:10](#); [6:34](#); [11:29](#)). Saul and David received the Spirit of God when anointed as kings ([1 Samuel 10:1](#), [9-10](#); [16:13](#)).

The Spirit left when the task ended or the person lost their role. When Samuel anointed David as the next king, the Spirit left Saul ([16:13](#), [14](#)). This was because he was disobedient and God rejected him as king ([13:7-14](#); [15:10-29](#); compare [28:15](#); [Judges 16:20](#)). After David sinned with Bathsheba, he prayed to avoid the same judgment, "take not Your Holy Spirit from me" ([Psalm 51:11](#)).

In the New Testament, God's Holy Spirit is given to everyone who trusts in Jesus for salvation, not just to those in specific roles (see [Acts 2:14-21](#); [1](#)

[Corinthians 12:1-13](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#)). The Spirit helps God's servants do the work they are called to do (see [1 Corinthians 12:7-10](#)). The Old Testament story of the Spirit leaving Saul shows why the New Testament warns against sinning against the Spirit and causing him sorrow (see [Mark 3:28-29](#); [Ephesians 4:30](#); [Hebrews 6:1-8](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 41:37-40](#); [Exodus 31:1-6](#); [Judges 3:9-11](#); [Judges 6:34](#); [Judges 11:29](#); [Judges 14:5-6](#); [Judges 16:20-21](#); [1 Samuel 10:1-10](#); [1 Samuel 11:6-7](#); [1 Samuel 16:13-23](#); [1 Samuel 19:19-23](#); [2 Chronicles 20:13-19](#); [2 Chronicles 24:20-22](#); [Psalm 51:11-12](#); [Isaiah 11:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 31:33-34](#); [Joel 2:28-29](#); [Mark 3:28-29](#); [Acts 2:1-21](#); [Acts 4:31](#); [Ephesians 1:13-14](#); [Ephesians 4:30](#); [Hebrews 6:4-8](#)

The Stone the Builders Rejected

Jesus continually offended the Jewish leaders and their followers. Although he was from the family line of King David, they questioned his mother's reputation ([Matthew 1:18-25](#)). Jesus came from Nazareth ([Matthew 2:23](#)). This place did not have a good reputation either ([Matthew 13:53-58](#)). He mainly worked in Galilee, far from the center of Jewish authority ([Matthew 4:12-16](#)). His closest friend was John, who became known for baptizing people and boldly speaking against political leaders as a prophet ([Matthew 11:2-19](#); [14:3-12](#)).

Jesus often gave indirect answers ([Matthew 13:10-15](#); [17:24-27](#); [19:3-12](#); [21:23-27](#)). He refused to show miraculous signs to prove his claims ([12:38-42](#); [16:1-4](#)). He spent time with people whom society rejected ([9:9-13](#); [11:16-19](#)). He challenged Jewish customs ([5:17-20](#); [9:14-17](#); [12:1-14](#); [15:1-20](#); [21:12-13](#)). He avoided public recognition ([8:4](#); [12:15-21](#)).

He shared his insights with unexpected people ([Matthew 11:25-27](#); [13:16-17](#); [16:13-20](#)). He spoke about the humiliating death he would suffer ([16:21](#); [17:22-23](#); [20:18-19](#); [26:2](#)). Jesus did not seek attention or make his role obvious. Instead, he chose humility, privacy, and sharing revelations that people could only understand through faith.

In the end, Jesus was proven right. He won arguments ([Luke 20:20-40](#)). He removed demons who had control of people ([Matthew 8:28-34](#)). He healed people in amazing ways ([Matthew 9:1-8](#)). He resurrected people from the dead ([Matthew 9:18-26](#)). Finally, he rose from the dead ([Matthew](#)

[28:1-10](#)). His ministry caused division but was effective in beginning God's kingdom on earth ([Matthew 11:2-6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 3:8](#); [8:14-15](#); [28:12-13](#); [59:9-10](#); [Jeremiah 13:16](#); [20:11](#); [31:7-9](#); [50:31-32](#); [Hosea 4:4-6](#); [5:5](#); [14:9](#); [Malachi 2:7-9](#); [Matthew 11:5-6](#); [13:54-58](#); [17:27](#); [21:42-46](#); [Mark 6:3](#); [Luke 20:17-19](#); [John 6:60-69](#); [Romans 9:30-33](#); [11:7-12](#); [14:12-13](#); [20:21](#); [1 Corinthians 1:21-23](#); [8:9-13](#); [10:31-11:1](#); [2 Corinthians 6:3](#); [Galatians 5:11](#); [1 Peter 2:5-8](#); [1 John 2:10](#)

The Suffering Prophet

In the Gospels, Jesus has many titles, such as Messiah (or Christ), Son of David, Son of Man, Son of God, and Lord. In Luke, an important title is "Prophet." Jesus is the prophet Moses predicted in [Deuteronomy 18:15](#).

As a prophet, Jesus preached God's word and performed miracles like the great prophets of the Old Testament. When Jesus raised a widow's son, the people exclaimed, "A great prophet has appeared among us!" ([Luke 7:16](#)). The disciples told Jesus that people were calling him a prophet ([Matthew 16:13-14](#)). The disciples on the road to Emmaus described him as "a prophet, powerful in speech and action before God and all the people" ([Luke 24:19](#)).

Like other prophets, Jesus suffered for his message (see [1 Kings 19:1-18](#); [Jeremiah 11:18-19](#); [18:18](#); [20:1-2](#); [7-18](#); [26:7-11](#); [20-23](#); [38:1-6](#)). People connected Jesus' role as a prophet to his miracles and teaching. But Jesus linked it mainly to his suffering. In Nazareth, he stated that "no prophet is accepted in his hometown" ([Luke 4:24](#)). He later accused Israel's leaders of killing their prophets ([11:47-51](#)). As he traveled to Jerusalem, he said, "it is not admissible for a prophet to perish outside of Jerusalem" ([13:33](#)).

In the Old Testament, when Israel ignored God's prophets, divine judgment came. Similarly, God's people would encounter judgment if they did not listen to Jesus (see [Acts 3:22-23](#)).

The revelation that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen one) shows he is the savior for all people. His role as a prophet shows his message is from God. His words are truly God's words, which people must hear and follow.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 18:15](#); [Matthew 5:12](#); [23:34-37](#); [Luke 4:22-24](#); [6:23, 26](#); [7:16](#); [11:47-52](#); [13:33-34](#); [24:17-21](#); [Acts 3:22-23](#); [7:37, 52](#)

The Superiority of the Son

The book of Hebrews shows why Jesus, the Son of God, is greater than all others in who he is (his nature) and what he does (his ministry).

Superior in Nature

The Son's superior *nature* is mainly discussed in [Hebrews 1:1-3:6](#). In the book's introduction ([1:1-4](#)), the Son is shown as the creator, supporter, and heir of the universe ([1:2-3](#)). He is "the radiance of God's glory and the exact representation of His nature" ([1:3](#)). He is honored, having cleansed sins and has a status "far superior to the angels" ([1:3-4](#)).

Superior to Angels

In [Hebrews 1:5-14](#) and [2:5-18](#), the Son is shown to be greater than the angels. He has a special relationship with the Father ([1:5](#)). He is the ruler, creator, and he who changer of the created world ([1:8-12](#)). The angels have a lower status than him, and they worship him ([1:6-7](#)). God the Father raises him to the highest position of honor at his right hand ([1:13](#); [Psalm 110:1](#)). He has authority over everything ([Hebrews 2:5-8](#)).

Superior to Moses

In [Hebrews 3:1-6](#), the author uses the respect his audience has for Moses to argue for even greater respect for the Son. Like Moses, the Son was faithful in serving God's people. Yet, the Son deserves more glory and praise than Moses because he has the same nature as God the Father. The Son is the ultimate builder of God's house ([3:3-4](#)). The Son is ultimately in charge of God's people ([3:5-6](#)).

*Superior Ministry***Superior Priest**

The sections highlighting the Son's superior *ministry* are mainly in [Hebrews 7:1-10:18](#). Through his superior role as high priest, Jesus has introduced a "better hope" ([7:19](#)). "A better covenant" guarantees this hope ([7:22](#)). "Better promises" ground this hope ([8:6](#)). This allows him

to perform a ministry "more excellent" than that of the old covenant priests ([8:6](#)). The old covenant was the agreement God made with the Israelites through Moses.

Superior Sacrifice

Jesus' ministry under the new covenant is a better system because of his "better sacrifices" ([9:10, 23](#); see also [12:24](#)). The new covenant is the new agreement God made through Jesus. Jesus' ministry leads new-covenant believers in God to expect "a better and permanent possession" ([10:34](#)). It is a "better country, a heavenly one" ([11:16](#)). They will "gain a better resurrection" ([11:35](#)). For believers in Jesus under the new covenant, God has "planned something better" that old-covenant believers could only anticipate ([11:40](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 110:1](#); [Hebrews 1:1-14](#); [3:1-6](#); [7:1-10:18](#); [10:34](#); [11:16, 35, 40](#)

The Tabernacle

The tabernacle was a portable sanctuary where God lived among the Israelite people. From the beginning of creation, God's plan was to share his life with humans and allow people to have a close relationship with him. However, when sin entered the world, it created a serious problem ([Genesis 3](#)). If sinful people were to come into God's presence, God's holiness would destroy them.

The tabernacle provided a temporary solution to this problem. It was a special structure like a tent that allowed the Israelites to enjoy God's presence without being destroyed by it ([Exodus 25:8](#)). It served as a mobile place of worship where Israel offered sacrifices to God and worshiped him.

The tabernacle shows us what is necessary to enter God's presence:

- The altar shows that sin must be removed through a sacrificial death. This was a large bronze structure where animals were sacrificed to pay for people's sins.
- The washbasin shows that having a relationship with God requires removing uncleanness—anything that goes against God's perfect moral standards. This was a large bronze bowl filled with water where priests washed their hands and feet before serving in the tabernacle.
- In the Holy Place, the lampstand and the table show that we must walk in God's light and depend on him to provide what we need. The golden lampstand had seven branches and provided the only light in the Holy Place, while the table held twelve loaves of bread representing God's provision for the twelve tribes of Israel.
- The incense altar represents prayer. The constantly rising incense reminds those who are forgiven and clean, who follow God's guidance and depend on him, that they have complete access to him. This small golden altar stood just before the curtain to the Most Holy Place, and priests burned sweet-smelling incense on it daily.
- The curtain between the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place reminds us that the Almighty, the holy God who invites us into fellowship, must not be approached carelessly. This thick, colorful veil separated the two rooms and protected people from God's direct presence.

- Behind the curtain is the ark of the covenant, over which God's glory appeared. This symbolized God's rule as Israel's king. The central position of the ark reflects God's main purpose for his people—a covenant relationship with the living God. The ark was a gold-covered wooden chest containing the stone tablets of the Ten Commandments, Aaron's rod, and a jar of manna.

Our new covenant relationship with God is possible because of Jesus' perfect sacrifice for sin and his role as our high priest before God (see especially [Hebrews 9–10](#)). He has fulfilled the requirements shown by the ancient tabernacle. We can now approach God's throne with courage and confidence (see [Ephesians 3:12](#); [Hebrews 4:14–16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 25:1–9](#); [26:1–37](#); [35:4–36:38](#); [38:21–31](#); [39:32–40:35](#); [2 Chronicles 3:1–7:22](#); [Hebrews 9:1–28](#)

The Theater and Revelation

In the ancient world, theater was a form of storytelling through live performances with actors, scenes, and dramatic presentations. Understanding the way ancient performances worked can help us understand [Revelation 4–5](#). These chapters introduce a divine drama (like a play with scenes and actors) and show the importance of God's agent (the Messiah) in world history. This passage prepares the reader for the main message of the book, which is about the world, the reality of judgment, and the victory that comes through the Lamb (Jesus). In these chapters, a series of scenes (like in a play) is used to communicate the message.

[Revelation 4:1–3](#) begins by describing God on his heavenly throne. In ancient theater, a person representing a god sat in a central box or throne high above the stage. This actor explained each scene's importance to the audience with positive and negative comments. Or he resolved script problems too complex for the characters. Similarly, readers of Revelation should look for scenes where God or his messengers interpret or interrupt to explain the message.

The ancient drama developed on the stage beneath the divine figure. Between the stage and the audience, a group of speakers expressed the play's emotions. In Revelation, the four living creatures have a similar role ([Revelation 4:6–8](#)).

The twenty-four elders represent the old and new covenants ([4:4](#)). (The "old covenant" refers to the agreement God made with Israel through Moses, which included the Ten Commandments and other laws recorded in the first books of the Bible. The "new covenant" refers to the agreement God made through Jesus Christ, which the New Testament describes as fulfilling the old covenant and establishing a new way of relating to God based on faith in Jesus.) The twenty-four elders act as a chorus with alternating groups of speakers and provide the historical background for this great drama. They also give the historical context for this great drama. God provides the script, and only his special agent, "the Lamb," can open, read, and perform it ([5:1–5](#); [6:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Revelation 4:1–5:14](#)

The Thousand Years (The Millennium)

A millennium is 1,000 years. [Revelation 20](#) describes the 1,000-year rule of Jesus Christ on earth. Christian groups who highly respect Scripture as God's inspired and authoritative word have held three views on how this millennium relates to the second coming of Jesus:

- 159. Premillennialism:** The time between Jesus' first and second comings will end when he returns. He will rule on earth for 1,000 years with his holy people. After this, Jesus will bring final judgment and establish his eternal kingdom. This view places Jesus' return before (pre-) the millennium.

160. Amillennialism: This is not a literal 1,000-year period. The "1,000 years" is symbolic and represents the current time between Jesus' first and second comings. During this period, Jesus rules spiritually with his people. At the end of this time, Jesus will return, bring final judgment, and begin his eternal kingdom. This view sees no (a-) separate millennium apart from the current church age.

161. Postmillennialism: During the time between Jesus' first and second comings, he will extend his rule through the church. This will lead to a long period of peace on earth. This period is the "1,000 years." At the end of this time, Jesus will return, carry out the final judgment, and establish his eternal kingdom. This view places Jesus' return after (post-) the millennium.

These different ideas have caused conflict among Christians. Many have abandoned Christian relations with those who hold different opinions. But Christians should show humility and love, not letting these differences divide them. (see [1 Peter 3:8](#)).

The main message of Revelation is that Jesus Christ will physically return and rule a new heaven and earth. A real spiritual battle is happening. Hell, like heaven, is real, and God will judge everyone by his standards. The prophecies of Revelation give hope to God's people during pain, suffering, and confusion in the world.

Passages for Further Study

[Revelation 20:1-10](#)

The Unknown God

The apostle Paul spoke to the Areopagus, the high council of the city of Athens ([Acts 17:19](#)). He spoke to people who did not share his belief in the God of Abraham and Moses. This God had revealed himself, "On many past occasions and in many different ways... through the prophets" ([Hebrews 1:1](#)).

Paul's audience thought differently about religion than he did. They had many gods in their culture, and common people still believed in the ancient gods. Yet, many of the people who influenced the culture of Athens no longer believed the gods existed. Instead, they followed either *materialism* (the belief that only physical things exist) or *pantheism* (the belief that the divine is in everything).

They all lacked the belief in one true God who is Lord of all. Their myths described the actions of various gods, but they did not believe that the ultimate reality, God himself, could be known. Instead, they reasoned and discussed the latest ideas, hoping to better understand the nature of things.

When Paul visited Athens, many philosophical ideas were popular. Yet, Stoicism and Epicureanism were the two main schools of thought ([Acts 17:18](#)).

Stoicism was founded by Zeno of Citium, who lived from around 334 to 262 BC. Those who followed the teachings of Stoicism were called Stoics. The Stoics studied nature's laws and believed in the *Logos*, a force that organizes and sustains everything. This force gives life and reason to humans. A good life is one where reason leads, and peace of mind and harmony with nature exist. Many important ancient leaders were Stoics or influenced by Stoicism. This included Cicero, Seneca, and Marcus Aurelius. Some Christians found Stoic ideas appealing because of similarities between the Stoic *Logos* and the divine *Logos* and between natural law and God's law ([John 1:1-18](#)).

The Epicureans were people who followed the teachings of Epicurus, who lived from 341 to 270 BC. They were empiricists, which means they believed knowledge comes from what we can experience with our senses (like seeing, hearing, or touching) rather than from abstract reasoning. Epicureans focused on natural evidence and showed little interest in mathematics. Their main interest was ethics, the study of right behavior (morality). They judged actions or things by the pleasure or pain they caused. Epicurus viewed belief in gods as a threat to peace of mind. He and his followers believed that no one should fear either gods or death.

When Paul spoke, he used their poets to explain complex ideas. He said that the God who created everything is personal and able to be known. God showed himself clearly, in real history, and in a

complete way in Jesus Christ. After death, there is not an end or a journey of the soul, but only coming judgment. The resurrection of Jesus from the dead proves all these things.

Most Greeks in Athens thought it was foolish, but it is the ultimate truth. God can be known through Jesus Christ.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 50:7-15](#); [Isaiah 42:5-7](#); [Acts 17:16-32](#); [Romans 1:18-32](#); [Colossians 1:15-23](#); [Colossians 2:6-12](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:9-10](#); [Hebrews 1:1-4](#)

The Word

The apostle John begins his Gospel with an extraordinary description of Jesus Christ as "the Word" (Greek *logos*, [John 1:1](#)). In the first century, both Greek and Jewish listeners would understand the deep meaning of this title.

Greeks would think of the fundamental forces that sustain the universe. Jews would remember God creating the world by speaking ([Genesis 1:3-28](#); [Psalm 33:6, 9](#)). In Jesus' time, the "Word" of God had gained creative personal qualities. Jews saw God's "Word" as another way of speaking about God's "Wisdom." Through Wisdom, God entered the universe, to create the world ([Proverbs 8:22-31](#)).

John explains that Jesus shares the same essence or nature as God. The Son existed before time and created everything. John connects the truth that Jesus is God to the ancient Jewish idea of Wisdom. This divine Wisdom, present with God before time, God now reveals in Jesus Christ. In a powerful verse, John writes that this Logos, or Wisdom, became a human person and lived among us ([John 1:14](#)). What God is, the Logos is, and the Logos is Jesus Christ.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:3-28](#); [Psalm 33:6, 9](#); [Proverbs 8:22-31](#); [Isaiah 40:8](#); [John 1:1-18](#); [1 John 1:1](#); [Revelation 19:13](#)

The World

The book of John often uses the word "world" (Greek *kosmos*). In Greek-speaking Jewish thought, *kosmos* means the heavens and the earth created by God ([Genesis 1](#); see also [John 1:3, 10](#); [17:5, 24](#)). The

apostle John expands this idea to include humanity (for example, [1:10](#); [3:16](#)).

Although God created it as good, the human world now opposes God ([John 1:10-11](#); [3:19-20](#); [12:37-41](#)). People love the darkness and cannot understand the light, actively resisting it ([3:19](#)). The world is without life and needs life ([6:33, 51](#)). Yet, it hates the one who can save it ([7:7](#)). Satan is the "prince of this world" ([12:31](#)). But he will encounter judgment one day.

God loves humanity, even though people often oppose and rebel against him. Jesus died to remove the world's sin ([John 1:29](#); [3:16-17](#); [1 John 2:2](#)). Yet, God's love for his creation exists alongside his need to judge the sin in the world ([John 3:18-21, 36](#); [5:27-30](#); [12:47-48](#)). Followers of Jesus feel this same tension in their mission. God calls us to share his love with the world. But we will encounter conflict because the world may oppose our message (see [15:18-27](#); [17:13-26](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 6:11-12](#); [Psalms 2:1-6](#); [9:8](#); [Isaiah 61:11](#); [66:16](#); [Matthew 5:14](#); [13:38-40](#); [John 1:9-10](#); [3:16-19](#); [7:7](#); [8:12](#); [14:17-19](#); [15:18-19](#); [16:7-9, 33](#); [John 17:5-26](#); [Acts 17:31](#); [1 Corinthians 1:20-28](#); [3:3](#); [6:2](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19](#); [Ephesians 2:2](#); [Colossians 2:20](#); [James 4:4](#); [2 Peter 1:4](#); [2:20](#); [1 John 2:15-16](#); [4:3-5](#)

The Worship of Angels

Scripture often describes angels as beings that inspire awe or fear (for example, [Joshua 5:13-15](#); [Luke 2:8-10](#)). Yet, angels serve God and he does not allow people to worship them ([Hebrews 1:5-14](#); [Revelation 19:10](#)). Jewish tradition developed the idea of angels as mediators (those who connect others to God). In pre-Christian Judaism, people emphasized God's *transcendence* or "otherness" so much that they believed mediators were necessary to communicate with him. In this context, angels became more important.

For Christians, Jesus has a unique role as mediator between God and humans. Focusing on angels or deceased saints as ways to communicate with God can distract from honoring Jesus as the only necessary mediator ([1 Timothy 2:5-6](#); see also [2 Corinthians 5:19-21](#); [Hebrews 7:24-25](#)). God still uses angelic messengers, but they are creatures serving him, not divine beings to worship. Only God deserves our prayers and worship.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 27:23–24](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19–21](#); [1 Timothy 2:5–6](#); [Hebrews 1:5–14](#); [7:24–25](#); [Revelation 19:10](#)

The Written Word

During the prophet Jeremiah's crisis at his public trial on the temple grounds, friends saved his life ([Jeremiah 26](#)). Yet, King Jehoiakim killed the prophet Uriah and tried to arrest Jeremiah. Would this end Jeremiah's public ministry? Was public speaking the only way to communicate the Lord's messages to Judah's leaders and people?

Killing and silencing the messengers did not stop the Lord's messages. The Lord can also effectively share his message in writing. The Lord told Jeremiah to write down all the messages he had preached ([Jeremiah 36](#)). Jeremiah had a helper named Baruch, who was skilled in writing and making copies.

While hiding, Jeremiah and Baruch bought a scroll (a paper roll made of papyrus) and prepared it to write the messages. When they finished writing, they read the scroll in the temple courtyard and to King Jehoiakim. The king cut up the scroll and burned it. But Jeremiah wrote the messages on a new scroll, adding new material. For the rest of Jeremiah's ministry, he wrote his messages on papyrus. Then he sent them to leaders of various countries and to the Israelite exiles in Babylon (see [Jeremiah 29](#)).

The first instance of writing God's word of course appears in Exodus. God instructed Moses to write the words of the covenant ([Exodus 24:4](#); also see [Exodus 17:14](#)). It specifically states that Moses wrote the book of Deuteronomy ([Deuteronomy 31:9, 24](#)). The existence of the written law likely started a tradition of documenting God's revelations ([Joshua 24:26](#); [1 Samuel 10:25](#); [1 Chronicles 29:29](#); [2 Chronicles 9:29](#); [Isaiah 8:16–17](#); [30:8](#)). It seems that prophets recorded many of Israel's historical writings (see [2 Chronicles 12:15](#); [13:22](#)).

Communities preserved these documents for a long time, especially those written on leather scrolls. They made many copies from one document. These copies were so valuable that people carefully preserved them for centuries. They also translated the copies into many languages.

The book of Jeremiah and the writings of other prophets, wise men, and teachers have become preserved, collected, and handed down to us as the Old and New Testaments. These texts provide a written record of God's messages to his people (see [2 Timothy 3:16–17](#); [2 Peter 1:20–21](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 17:14](#); [31:18](#); [34:27–28](#); [Deuteronomy 31:9–13](#); [Isaiah 30:8](#); [Jeremiah 30:2–3](#); [Jeremiah 36:1–32](#); [45:1](#); [51:60–64](#); [Ezekiel 43:11](#); [Daniel 7:1](#); [Luke 1:1–4](#); [John 5:46–47](#); [20:30–31](#); [21:24–25](#); [Acts 1:1–2](#); [Romans 15:4](#); [1 Corinthians 10:11](#); [2 Timothy 3:16–17](#); [Philemon 1:21](#); [Hebrews 13:22](#); [1 Peter 5:12](#); [2 Peter 1:20–21](#); [1 John 1:4](#); [2:12–24](#); [5:13](#); [Revelation 1:11](#); [10:4](#); [21:5](#); [22:18–19](#)

Tolerance

The apostle Paul urges tolerance (patient understanding) between those weak in faith and those strong in faith. He teaches Christians to accept each other ([Romans 14:1](#); [15:7](#)). He instructs them to stop condemning one another and making each other feel unimportant. Instead, they should worship God with a united voice and spirit ([Romans 15:6](#)).

Paul is discussing whether Christians need to follow certain Old Testament laws and Jewish worship practices. Scholars use the Greek word *adiaphora*, meaning "non-essentials," to describe beliefs or practices that Scripture neither requires nor bans. On these issues, Christians should accept different opinions. Sometimes, Christians may feel free to do certain activities, but doing so might cause problems for others. In these cases, Paul advises Christians to consider others' needs before their own (see [1 Corinthians 8:1–13](#)).

Paul uses a different approach to tolerance when the good news (gospel) is at risk. In the letter to the Galatians, for example, Paul confronts false teachings about the good news by strongly criticizing the false teachers ([Galatians 1:6–9](#)). He warns readers that accepting false teachings will separate them from Christ ([Galatians 5:4](#)).

Today, we must be cautious about what we tolerate and what we oppose. Christians should carefully consider the issues they encounter with other Christians. If we stay true to the basic truth of the good news about Jesus, we should not argue or be divided over less important matters.

Yet, some issues affect the core message of the good news. In these cases, Christians should remain firm and faithful to the good news and to Jesus Christ. Sometimes, it is difficult to determine if an issue is central. It may be important for discussion but not essential for Christian unity. Paul's approach to various issues in his time can guide us in handling conflicts and arguments today.

Passages for Further Study

[Psalm 133:1-3](#); [Romans 12:9-21](#); [14:1-15:13](#); [1 Corinthians 1:10](#); [6:1-20](#); [8:1-13](#); [10:1-11:1](#); [12:12-27](#); [13:1-8](#); [2 Corinthians 6:14-7:1](#); [Colossians 3:12-15](#); [2 Timothy 2:23-26](#)

True Justice

The community of God's people in Old Testament Israel had to care for widows, orphans, and foreigners ([Deuteronomy 27:19](#)). God wanted the Israelites to represent his justice (see [10:17-19](#)). He wanted them to always remember that they had been slaves. He wanted them to remember that they were defenseless in Egypt (see [10:19](#); [24:18-22](#)). As those who received God's constant love and faithfulness, how could they ignore the rights and needs of the weakest among them?

Every society has structures that separate the powerful from the weak and the important from the less important people. This was true for Old Testament Israel, even with its special role as "a holy nation" ([Exodus 19:6](#)). Judges and officials were responsible for protecting the law. They might favor those with money, high status, or influence, especially if they offered bribes ([Deuteronomy 16:19](#)). Yet, no one can bribe God and he treats all people fairly ([10:17](#)). To God, the rich and poor, powerful and weak, honored and desperate are all the same.

The prophets of Israel knew the importance of fairness and justice. They often urged these principles in both community and national life ([Isaiah 1:17](#); [10:1-4](#); [59:14-19](#); [Ezekiel 22:23-29](#); [Amos 2:6-8](#); [Habakkuk 1:4](#)). The New Testament also commands for fair treatment of the poor and those without advantages. It mentions that God is not pleased when others ignore them ([Matthew 23:23](#); [2 Corinthians 9:6-10](#); [James 2:1-7](#)).

Justice that does not follow God's standard is not true justice. Those who are unjust will encounter full punishment from the Judge of all the earth (see [Deuteronomy 25:13-16](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 23:3](#); [Leviticus 19:15](#); [Deuteronomy 10:17-19](#); [16:19](#); [24:12-22](#); [25:13-16](#); [27:19](#); [Psalm 82:1-5](#); [Proverbs 11:1](#); [Isaiah 1:17](#); [10:1-4](#); [11:3-4](#); [59:14-19](#); [Jeremiah 22:13-17](#); [Ezekiel 22:23-29](#); [45:9-10](#); [Amos 2:6-8](#); [8:5-6](#); [Habakkuk 1:4](#); [Matthew 23:23](#); [Luke 18:6-8](#); [James 2:1-7](#)

True Success

God wants his people to fully commit to him ([Deuteronomy 6:4-6](#); compare [Matthew 22:37](#)). True success comes from seeking God and acknowledging him as the ruler, avoiding all false gods ([Matthew 6:33](#); [1 John 5:21](#)). For the people of Israel, success depended on their obedience to God's covenant (see [Leviticus 26:1-46](#); [Deuteronomy 28:1-68](#)). Israel's spiritual condition and its leaders greatly affected whether they would keep God's favor and remain in the promised land.

The author of 1-2 Kings starts each ruler's story with a spiritual evaluation. This often compares each king's devotion to God with King David's example (see [1 Kings 11:38](#); [14:8](#); [15:3-5](#), [11](#)). These books show that the future of Israel and Judah depends on their kings' spiritual leadership. God's people could only succeed in Canaan if they worshipped God faithfully (see [Deuteronomy 12:4-7](#)). The text often criticizes worship of false gods in local places (see, for example, [3:2-4](#); [11:7](#)).

Starting with King Jeroboam I, the kings of Israel (the northern kingdom) consistently practiced false religion and Scripture criticizes them for it ([1 Kings 12:31-32](#); [13:33-34](#); [15:25-26](#), [33-34](#); [16:11-13](#), [25-26](#)). Among these kings, King Ahab was the most evil ([16:30-33](#); [21:25-26](#)). His son Ahaziah followed his example and God condemned him for his worship of false gods ([22:51-53](#)).

The kings of the northern kingdom led their people toward certain exile ([2 Kings 17:21-23](#)). Despite God's repeated attempts to gain their attention, they did not listen ([2 Kings 17:13-15](#), [23](#)). So God gave them the consequences for continuous spiritual unfaithfulness (see [1 Kings 13:33-34](#)).

Some kings of Judah (the southern kingdom) receive praise, but Scripture criticizes many of them. Rehoboam allowed worship of false gods to spread in Judah ([1 Kings 14:22-24](#)). Abijam continued his father's sins ([15:3](#)). Scripture even criticizes the good kings Asa and Jehoshaphat for allowing popular local worship sites to remain (see

[15:14](#); [22:43](#)). Failing to give God his rightful place led to disastrous results.

The kings and people of the northern kingdom were stupid for doing what they wanted. Yet, the Lord will bless and give true happiness to those who respect and live by his commands ([Psalms 33:12](#); [119:1-2](#); [144:15](#)). True success comes from recognizing and trusting God as the ruler of one's life ([Matthew 6:33](#)). As shown by Jesus and his early followers, success does not always mean having material wealth. Joy and peace come from living by God's will and trusting in him (see [Philippians 3:8-14](#); [1 Peter 4:12-19](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 6:1-8](#); [12:4-7](#); [Joshua 1:7-8](#); [1 Samuel 18:14](#); [1 Kings 11:38](#); [12:26-33](#); [13:1-3](#); [33-34](#); [14:8-11](#); [2 Kings 17:13-23](#); [Psalms 33:12](#); [119:1-2](#); [144:15](#); [Matthew 6:33](#); [Luke 10:25-28](#); [1 John 5:21](#)

Trusting God in Isaiah

The prophet Isaiah knew that humans can be unreliable ([Isaiah 2:22](#)). When in trouble, the people of Judah often asked other nations like Egypt or Assyria for help. Yet, Isaiah explained that Judah's success and safety depended on trusting God (see [Isaiah 8:9-17](#)). The Assyrian army made fun of King Hezekiah for trusting God, but this trust led to a great victory for God's people ([Isaiah 36:1-37:37](#)).

Those who trust in the Lord feel deep respect for him and do not fear ([29:23](#); [35:4](#)). This is because they know the Lord is with them ([51:12](#)). They praise him because they trust him ([12:1-2](#); [25:9](#)). They show their trust by obeying him ([26:8](#)).

The faithful people of God may experience the effects of his judgment on his enemies as they wait for the Lord's salvation. Yet, they gain new strength each day ([40:31](#)). They consider themselves citizens of God's city, Zion (see [26:1-3](#)). Those who trust in the Lord have true and lasting inner peace ([26:3](#); [12](#); [32:17-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Isaiah 2:22](#); [7:4-9](#); [8:16-20](#); [12:1-2](#); [26:2-3](#); [12](#); [32:17-18](#); [35:4](#); [40:9-11](#); [28-31](#); [51:12](#)

Trusting God in the Psalms

The Lord's love inspires people to trust him ([Psalms 13:5](#); [17:7](#); [21:7](#); [32:10](#); [36:7](#); [52:8](#); [143:8](#)). His name and reputation also build trust ([9:10](#); [20:7](#); [33:21](#)). Godly people avoid worshiping false gods and anything that makes their complete trust in the Lord weak ([31:6](#); [14](#); [44:6](#); [49:6-13](#); [52:7](#)). Trusting the Lord is wise. It rejects what is stupid and evil and follows the spiritual way of the Lord ([31:19](#); [37:3](#); [5](#); [115:11](#)).

For godly people, every challenge in life is a chance to grow in trust ([Psalms 9:9](#); [25:2](#); [46:1](#); [55:23](#); [57:1](#); [59:16](#); [62:8](#); [78:7](#)). Godly people do not fear life's situations ([56:3-4](#); [11](#); [112:7](#)). Instead they become more confident during them ([112:7](#); [125:1](#)).

The Lord saves, cares for, and rewards those who trust in him (see [Psalms 7:1](#); [16:1](#); [25:20](#); [26:1](#); [31:1-2](#); [4](#); [19](#); [34:22](#); [37:39-40](#); [86:2](#)). God blesses them as they hope for God's redemption ([2:12](#); [22:4-5](#); [34:8](#); [40:4](#); [84:12](#); [37:7](#); [34](#); [38:15](#); [40:1](#); [119:166](#); [130:5-6](#)). Faith in the Lord brings joy and reasons to praise him ([5:11](#); [18:30-36](#); [28:7](#); [40:3](#); [56:4](#); [64:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 7:1](#); [9:9](#); [11:1](#); [18:30-36](#); [22:4-5](#); [8-9](#); [25:1-3](#); [20](#); [26:1](#); [28:7](#); [31:1-6](#); [34:8-10](#); [37:3-9](#); [40:1-4](#); [46:1](#); [56:3-4](#); [11](#); [62:1-12](#); [64:10](#); [78:7](#); [84:12](#); [86:2](#); [112:7](#); [115:9-11](#); [119:42](#); [125:1](#); [130:5-6](#); [141:8](#); [Proverbs 3:5](#); [22:19](#); [Isaiah 26:4](#); [40:31](#); [Jeremiah 17:7](#); [Hebrews 10:35](#)

Trusting in Human Strength

God often showed his power to his people throughout their history. He made an elderly couple, who could not have children, the ancestors of a great nation. He saved this nation from the powerful ruler of Egypt. He performed many miracles to help them survive in the wilderness.

He also won victories over their enemies many times during the conquest, the time of the judges, and the period of kings. Yet, throughout their history, the people of Israel often did not trust the Lord. They chose to rely on human strength instead.

Once, Asa, King of Judah, asked the king of Aram for help. Aram was a long-time enemy of God's people. Asa gave him treasures from the temple and palace so he would attack Baasha, King of Israel ([2](#)

[Chronicles 16:1-6](#)). The prophet Hanani criticized Asa, warning that Aram would remain an enemy to Judah. Past battles showed that Asa only needed God as support ([16:8](#)).

Asa's dependence on the king of Aram showed a deeper spiritual issue. Asa forgot that "the eyes of the LORD roam to and fro over all the earth" ([2 Chronicles 16:9](#); see also [Zechariah 4:10](#)). When Hanani showed Asa his mistakes, Asa quickly put the prophet in prison. The angry king also unfairly harmed the people ([2 Chronicles 16:10](#)).

Asa shows how people often rely on their own resources and get angry when corrected (see [Proverbs 11:7](#); [Isaiah 31:1](#); [Jeremiah 17:5-6](#)). Even those who have seen the Lord's power can act this way. This was true for the Israelites rescued from slavery in Egypt. It is better to trust the Lord and accept his guidance (compare [Psalms 33:18](#); [37:7](#); [Isaiah 50:10](#); [Jeremiah 17:7-8](#); [Acts 13:43](#)).

Life teaches us to trust God. We might start by doing good and right ([2 Chronicles 14:1-6](#)). But our spiritual impact is not complete until our last action (see [Romans 2:6-11](#); [1 Corinthians 4:1-5](#)). We must not let personal ambitions make weak our faithfulness to God's kingdom.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 13:4](#); [2 Kings 6:15-18](#); [2 Chronicles 16:1-10](#); [32:7-8](#); [Psalms 20:6-8](#); [37:3-7](#); [60:11-12](#); [Proverbs 11:7-8](#); [18:10-12](#); [Ecclesiastes 3:14](#); [Isaiah 31:1-5](#); [Jeremiah 17:5-8](#); [Matthew 10:26-31](#); [Romans 2:6-11](#); [1 Corinthians 4:1-5](#); [Revelation 2:8-11](#)

Understanding Job

The story of Job presents a tension between good and bad aspects of his character. The beginning of the book clearly approves of Job ([Job 1:1, 8; 2:3](#)). But later, God questions Job directly: "Who is this who obscures My counsel by words without knowledge?" ([38:2](#)). "Would you really annul My justice? Would you condemn Me to justify yourself?" ([40:8](#)).

Some interpreters think Job talks too much and confuses God's work with Satan's. Some modern interpreters blame Job for his suffering, agreeing with his friends. Others argue like Eliphaz and Elihu ([5:17-27](#); [33:15-33](#); [36:7-17](#)). They say that Job's suffering is God's loving discipline. Even God's faithful encounter such discipline ([Hebrews 12:6-](#)

[12](#); see [Proverbs 3:11-12](#)). But this idea contradicts the book's opening statement.

Job suffered because God wanted to show Satan that Job was honest and faithful. God always had a positive view of Job's life ([Job 1:1, 8; 2:3; 42:7](#)). This idea continues in the New Testament, where Job is an example of patience we should follow ([James 5:11](#)).

Job's reactions are normal. He does not remain firm. His trials affected him. He also does not boldly defy his troubles as if they cannot affect him. He reacts like any human would.

Job becomes angry, protests, complains, and goes back and forth between confidence and despair. But he never gives up hope. He does not curse God or falsely confess guilt, trying to influence God to remove his suffering. Although Job cannot understand his situation, he knows his answer will come from God ([Job 19:25-27](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Job 1:1, 8; 2:3; 5:17-18; 19:25-27; 33:15-28; 36:8-15; 38:2; 40:8; 42:7](#); [Proverbs 3:11](#); [Hebrews 12:7, 10](#); [James 5:11](#)

Violation of the Sacred

Violation of the sacred is the act of disrespecting, damaging, or misusing something that is considered holy or set apart for God. Ever since the early days in the garden of Eden, humans have tried to claim God's holy space as their own ([Genesis 2:15-17; 3:1-6](#)).

The Bible shows God's anger and quick punishment when people fail to respect his holy commands. God called Nadab and Abihu to lead Israel in proper worship. When they ignored God's specific instructions about priestly duties, they died for their sin ([Leviticus 10:1-20](#)). Jesus showed God's righteous anger when he entered the temple with a whip. He chased out the merchants and money changers who were polluting the holy space for profit ([John 2:13-16](#)).

No one could violate God's holy presence, including in the temple in Jerusalem. The temple represented God's presence in the world, so all its ceremonies had to show its holy status. Only those anointed for the task could enter to make offerings.

One serious mistake was when King Uzziah "entered the temple of the LORD to burn incense on

the altar of incense" ([2 Chronicles 26:16](#)). Unlike kings from other ancient Near Eastern cultures, Israel's kings could not enter the holy space. God anointed them only for government duties. The king of Israel was not a priest nor could he represent God in holy matters. He was not a god, unlike in other cultures.

He was a servant of God chosen from his people for "carefully observing" the covenant in the community ([Deuteronomy 17:18-20](#)). When King Uzziah tried to act in a priestly role that did not belong to him, he violated the holy place set apart for God's presence. This violation was a serious matter related to the function of the temple.

King David shows humility compared to Uzziah's pride ([1 Samuel 21:1-9](#)). When his men were hungry, David knew there was bread at the tabernacle. Instead of taking it, he asked the priest, who gave them the holy bread with his blessing.

In contrast, Uzziah entered the temple and showed no respect for this holy space ([26:16](#)). He thought that, as king, he could enter God's temple. Yet, he did not have that right. God punished him with a skin disease and separation from daily life. This punishment matched the pride of his actions.

The temptation to act like Uzziah, who showed no respect for holy things, is always present. Any action that fails to honor God, shows no respect for his holy space. Human history is about God restoring the heavens and earth to be his home.

In the new covenant through Jesus Christ, God's holy space is not just a temple in Jerusalem or any building. He sets apart the lives of those who trust him ([1 Corinthians 6:19-20](#)). Through his grace, God makes the people of the new covenant his temple on earth ([1 Peter 2:4-5](#)). They become the place where his holiness enters creation. History will be complete when all of heaven and earth become God's temple ([Isaiah 65:17-18](#); [Revelation 21:1-2](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:15-17; 3:1-6; Exodus 19:12-13; 31:14-15; Leviticus 10:1-20; 24:16-17; Numbers 1:51; 15:32-36; 2 Chronicles 26:16-21; 1 Corinthians 6:19-20](#)

Visions

Visions are similar to other experiences of God's revelation, like dreams ([Genesis 37:5-10; 40:5-](#)

[19](#)). Classic examples include the prophet Ezekiel's vision of the valley of dry bones and the prophet Isaiah's vision of God's throne ([Ezekiel 37:1-14; Isaiah 6](#)). Old Testament prophets often received messages from the Lord through visions. The visions in the Bible often showed powerful and memorable pictures that helped people understand God's message. In these visions, God showed special pictures or scenes that had deeper meanings about real things happening on earth. God or an angel would then explain to the person what these pictures meant.

Visions are important in the book of Acts and often occur during prayer ([Acts 9:10-12; 16:9-10; 22:17-21; 23:11](#); see [Luke 1:8-20](#)). In one instance, an angel visited Cornelius, a Roman officer ([Acts 10:1-6, 30-32](#)). The angel told him to send for the apostle Peter. The next day, as Peter prayed, he had a vision ([10:9-16](#); see [11:5-10](#)). It was connected to his meeting with Cornelius.

In Acts 9, the visions of the apostle Paul and Ananias also show God's role in their lives ([9:3-6, 10-16](#)). These visions are not by accident but part of God's plan to save the world.

Visions provide divine guidance and show Christian workers how to fulfill the Great Commission.

Paul experienced several visions:

- during his conversion on the Damascus road ([Acts 9:3-6; 22:6-10; 26:12-19](#))
- before his missionary journey to Europe ([16:9](#))
- in Corinth ([18:9-11](#))
- in the temple ([22:17-21](#))
- in Jerusalem before his trip to Rome ([23:11](#))

Through visions, God actively guides the church's activities and expands its mission (see the study notes on Acts 10:3, 9-16; 22:17-22; 23:11; see also [Galatians 1:8-9](#) and study note there).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 37:5-10; 40:1-41:36; Isaiah 6:1-13; Jeremiah 14:14; Ezekiel 37:1-14; Daniel 8:1-27; 9:21; Hosea 12:10; Obadiah 1:1; Habakkuk 2:3; Luke 1:8-20; Acts 9:3-6, 10-16; 10:3-6, 9-16, 30-32; 11:5-9; 16:9-10; 18:9-11; 22:6-10, 17-21;](#)

[23:11](#); [26:14-19](#); [2 Corinthians 12:1-10](#); [Revelation 1:9-22:7](#)

Vows to God

A vow to God means something like saying, "If God does 'this', then I will give 'this' to God or his holy place."

Examples include:

- Jacob gave a tenth of his earnings ([Genesis 28:20-22](#)).
- The Israelites promised to give God the Canaanite war spoils ([Numbers 21:2](#)).
- Hannah committed to giving her son as a lifelong servant to the Lord ([1 Samuel 1:11](#)).
- Absalom offered sacrifices to God at Hebron ([2 Samuel 15:8](#)).

The sacrificial laws often mention rules for vows. Israelites made vows based on God answering their requests. They would then fulfill their vows to God, often by giving offerings (for example, [Leviticus 7:16](#); [22:23](#); [Deuteronomy 12:11](#)).

Yet, people could take advantage of vows. The law itself warns against this ([Deuteronomy 23:21-23](#)). So do the wisdom teachings (for example, [Proverbs 7:10-14](#); [20:25](#)). Also, the books of the prophets (see, for example, [Jeremiah 44:25](#)).

King Saul often made foolish vows ([1 Samuel 14:24-28](#)). He did not keep the vows he made ([19:6](#)). People might not fulfill or repay careless vows. This could cause God to punish them. It is better not to make a vow than to break one ([Ecclesiastes 5:3-5](#)). Jesus commands us to live with such honesty and integrity that we do not need to make vows ([Matthew 5:33-37](#); compare [James 5:12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 28:20-22](#); [Numbers 21:2-3](#); [30:1-16](#); [Deuteronomy 23:18-23](#); [Judges 11:30-40](#); [1 Samuel 1:11](#), [24-28](#); [14:24-45](#); [Psalm 76:11](#); [Proverbs 20:25](#); [Ecclesiastes 5:3-5](#); [Malachi 1:14](#); [Matthew 5:33-37](#); [Acts 18:18](#); [21:23-24](#); [James 5:12](#)

Wealth and Poverty in the Wisdom Literature

The sayings in Scripture about wealth and poverty, especially in the wisdom literature, show a broad truth. God blesses wise people with wealth, which makes life's challenges easier to handle ([Proverbs 3:9-10](#), [15-16](#); [10:22](#); [10:15](#)). Foolish behavior, especially laziness, often leads to poverty (see [10:4](#)).

The book of Proverbs acknowledges that some evil people who are foolish are wealthy, but it reminds us that this wealth will not last long ([Proverbs 11:18](#); [13:11](#)). Poverty can sometimes result from injustice rather than foolishness ([13:23](#)). Wealth can come from injustice and dishonesty ([16:8](#)). Those with wealth need to use it wisely, including being generous to those in need ([28:27](#); [29:7](#), [14](#)).

Wealth has limited benefits. Sometimes, it creates problems instead of solving them ([Proverbs 11:4](#); [13:8](#)). Wisdom can help in ways that wealth cannot, making wisdom more important than money ([15:16-17](#); [16:8](#), [16](#)).

God often blesses people who live to please him by providing what they need. When this happens, these people can then help others by sharing what they have received. This giving to others is itself another blessing from God. Yet, circumstances are not always fair. Sometimes, wealth does not go to those who deserve it (see [Ecclesiastes 9:11](#)). It does not always bring happiness (see [Ecclesiastes 2:17-23](#); [5:10-17](#)). In fact, money can harm faith ([1 Timothy 6:10](#); [James 2:1-13](#)). When choosing between living to please God and money, wise people will choose living to please God.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 6:10-13](#); [8:10-11](#); [1 Samuel 2:7](#); [Psalm 37:16](#); [Proverbs 3:9-10](#), [15-16](#); [10:15](#), [22](#); [11:4](#), [18](#), [28](#); [13:8](#), [11](#); [14:24](#); [15:6](#), [16-17](#); [16:8](#), [16](#); [23:4-5](#); [28:27](#); [29:7](#), [14](#); [Ecclesiastes 5:10-17](#); [1 Timothy 6:10](#)

What Is Good

[Micah 6:8](#), a famous and often memorized verse, answers questions from people who became confused and had lost their moral and spiritual direction.

The people of Israel wanted to know how to please the Lord. In a society full of lies and oppression, they forgot what the Lord considers good. God gave

them a clear answer. God does not want people to worship him by just following rules and ceremonies without meaning ([Micah 6:6-7](#)).

Instead, he wants them to do what is right in their relationship with him and with each other. When motivated by love, their actions should show justice, mercy, and humility. God's people should not oppress others but act justly, righteously, and honestly toward one another.

[Micah 6:8](#) summarizes what God had already told Israel. Humility, faith, and obedience please God.

God shared this message:

- with Abraham ([Genesis 15:6](#); [17:1, 9](#)),
- with Moses at Sinai ([Exodus 20-23](#)),
- through his prophets (for example, [Deuteronomy 6:1-8](#); [Hosea 6:6](#)), and
- through Israel's wise men ([Proverbs 1:7](#)).

It pleases God when people live humbly in faith, like:

- Moses ([Numbers 12:3](#)),
- Habakkuk ([Habakkuk 3:17-19](#)),
- Daniel ([Daniel 9:1-19](#)), and
- Ezra ([Ezra 9:5-15](#)).

True spirituality and devotion result in:

- doing good,
- seeking justice,
- helping the oppressed,
- defending orphans, and
- supporting widows (see [Exodus 22:21-24](#); [23:2-12](#); [Deuteronomy 15:4-11](#); [24:12-15](#); [Nehemiah 5:1-13](#); [Jeremiah 22:16](#); [Daniel 4:27](#); [Amos 5:7-24](#); [James 1:27](#)).

These actions reflect God's own character ([Psalm 146:9](#); [Matthew 11:5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 33:19](#); [34:6-7](#); [Deuteronomy 8:3](#); [16:19-20](#); [1 Kings 3:11](#); [Ezra 7:25](#); [Nehemiah 9:31](#); [Isaiah 2:9](#); [5:15](#); [30:18](#); [38:15](#); [Daniel 9:18](#); [Hosea 6:6](#); [Amos 5:12, 15](#); [Micah 6:8](#); [Malachi 2:17](#); [3:15](#)

Wisdom

Wisdom helps us know how to speak and act in various situations. It allows us to avoid problems and manage them when they happen. Wisdom is more than just intelligence. Proverbs mentions that even animals like ants, rock badgers, locusts, and lizards are wise ([Proverbs 30:24-28](#)). They are not wise because of great intelligence but because they know how to live skillfully.

The foundation of wisdom is God. No wisdom exists without "the fear of the LORD" ([Proverbs 1:7](#)). Wisdom is connected to righteousness and avoids evil.

According to Proverbs, people gain wisdom by:

- Observing and experiencing life ([6:6-8](#))
- Learning from traditional teachings ([22:17-21](#))
- Understanding mistakes ([12:1](#))
- Most importantly, through revelation from God (see [1:7](#))

In [1 Corinthians 1-2](#), the apostle Paul compares the world's "wisdom," which he calls "foolishness," with the wisdom of Jesus Christ. Paul also says about Jesus, "in whom are hidden all the treasures of wisdom and knowledge" ([Colossians 2:3](#)). God's wisdom shows in Christians' lives through their goodness, humility, purity, and peace ([James 3:13-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 1:13-18](#); [4:5-8](#); [1 Kings 3:1-28](#); [Job 12:12](#); [28:20-28](#); [Psalms 90:12](#); [119:98](#); [Proverbs 1:7](#); [2:1-22](#); [30:24-28](#); [Ecclesiastes 2:12-16](#); [7:4-19](#); [Isaiah 11:1-2](#); [Jeremiah 9:23-24](#); [10:12](#); [Hosea 14:9](#); [Luke 7:35](#); [1 Corinthians 3:18-20](#); [James 1:5](#); [3:13-17](#); [Revelation 7:12](#)

Wisdom Psalms

Some people call certain psalms "wisdom psalms" because they emphasize the importance of wisdom. They guide readers on handling life's questions, issues, and doubts (see [Psalms 1](#); [14](#); [25](#); [34](#); [37](#); [39](#); [49](#); [73](#); [78](#); [90](#); [91](#); [111](#); [112](#); [127](#); [128](#); [131](#); [133](#); [139](#)). Many other psalms include wisdom

teachings (see [18](#); [27](#); [31](#); [32](#); [40](#); [62](#); [92](#); [94](#); [107](#); [144](#); [146](#)).

In the ancient Near East, wisdom involved:

- maintaining order
- pleasing the gods and others
- observing life, society, and nature

In Israel, wisdom focused on these areas but emphasized "the fear of the LORD." God is the center of life, and fearing him leads to wisdom ([111:10](#)). "Fear of the LORD" means fully submitting to and trusting in him ([115:11](#); see also [40:3](#); [112:7](#)). This results in a pure life ([19:9](#)). [Psalm 34](#) links the fear of the Lord with a life of plenty.

A life of wisdom means living in a way that pleases God. [Psalm 1](#) invites everyone to find joy in God, his teachings, and the way of life that comes from his guidance for wise people. The lives of godly people show inner harmony, growth, and beauty. They reflect God's righteousness, justice, love, faithfulness, compassion, and grace. They live to please God in both their hearts and their actions.

Wisdom expands a person's perspective on life. A wise person wants to see life from God's perspective. This search involves living with submission and trust under the sovereign king who keeps creation in order and harmony. Seeking God promotes an orderly and peaceful life and encourages obedience ([19:7](#); [25:12](#); [51:6](#); [112:1](#); [119:98-100](#)).

The wise imitate God, and their lives are joyful even during difficulties. They praise the Lord in all life situations (see [22:23](#), [25](#)). They experience life with confidence because the Lord is with them ([23:4](#); [27:1](#), [3](#); [33:18](#); [91:1-16](#)).

The life of the fool, or the evil person, is opposite of the life of the wise. These people see themselves as powerful and always boast about their achievements. They do not accept limits. They brag, oppress, steal, and try to steal others' happiness. They do not fear the Lord ([36:1](#); [55:19](#)). The poets of Israel often warned people to avoid the life of a "fool," or God's judgment might come to them ([2:10-11](#); [94:8-10](#)).

Jesus Christ entered the world as God in the flesh (he is fully God and fully human at the same time). He possesses all the qualities of wisdom. Through him, we can live a life of wisdom ([Colossians 2:2-3](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Psalms 1](#); [14](#); [25](#); [34](#); [37](#); [39](#); [49](#); [73](#); [78](#); [90](#); [91](#); [111](#); [112](#); [127](#); [128](#); [131](#); [133](#); [139](#)

Women's Roles in the New Testament Church

The apostle Paul's words in 1 Timothy about women's roles in the church were intended to correct what was happening in Ephesus. But Bible scholars debate how this passage applies to other situations. There are three main interpretations:

162. Universal Interpretation. [Galatians 3:28](#) ("There is neither... male and female") does not remove gender differences and roles created by God. Even if [Galatians 3:28](#) shows the ideal of equality in God's eternal kingdom, gender roles should follow the guidelines in [1 Timothy 2:11-15](#) as long as this world exists. For comparison, [Matthew 22:30](#) talks about marriage in the new creation, which is different from the current structure described in [Genesis 2:23-24](#). It applies to our current life in a special and limited way (see [1 Timothy 4:3-5](#); [Matthew 19:11-12](#); [1 Corinthians 7:29-35](#)). The new creation's structure is not yet fully realized until the future age and is not the ideal for now.

According to this view, Christian women everywhere must understand their role in God's created order. They should not teach or have authority over men in the church (see also [1 Corinthians 11:2-16](#); [14:34-35](#)).

163. Polemical Interpretation. Paul addressed a specific issue caused by false teachings in the Ephesian church (see [1 Timothy 1:18-20](#); [4:1-5](#); compare [2 Timothy 3:6-9](#)). Evidence shows this teaching was disrupting family relationships (see [1 Timothy 4:3](#); [Titus 1:11](#)). Some Ephesian women, influenced by local heresy, might have misused [Genesis 1-3](#) in their teachings. They could have claimed that females will dominate in the final resurrection. Some Ephesians believed the resurrection had already happened ([2 Timothy 2:18](#)). They emphasized Adam was to blame for the first sin.

Paul corrected their misunderstandings by referring to the biblical text. But he did not intend to make a universal statement about women's roles in the church. His goal was to silence the false teachers in Ephesus, including the women involved. [First Timothy 2:11-15](#) involves a rebuke with loss of privilege specifically for those false teachers.

164. Cultural Interpretation. Paul's argument was not necessarily intended for a local issue in Ephesus. It assumes a strongly patriarchal society (where men have most of the power and authority). This argument focuses on how women should behave in public (knowing their place and honoring men) and interpreting [Genesis 2:7, 22](#). According to this view, Christians should respect cultural norms as much as possible in their mission to spread the good news about Jesus ([1 Corinthians 9:19-23](#)).

Also, most women in that society had limited education. Unlike many societies today, women in Paul's time usually received poor education. Because of their culture's male-dominated structure, women would not normally have qualified as teachers and leaders.

[First Timothy 2:11-15](#) reflects the idea that properly qualified people should lead and teach. Yet, there are examples in Paul's writings and in the early church of women participating in various ministry roles (for example, [Acts 18:26](#); [Romans](#)

[16:1-7](#); [1 Corinthians 11:5](#)). This raises questions about whether Paul's statements on women in the church apply to all times and places.

Christians continue to discuss these complex issues. Many Christians today hold a view called complementarianism (the belief that men and women have different but complementary roles and responsibilities in marriage, family life, and church leadership). Many others hold an egalitarian view (the belief that men and women should have equal roles and responsibilities in the church). All Christians agree that men and women are equal as beloved children of God (see [Galatians 3:26-28](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 2:23-24](#); [Acts 18:26](#); [Romans 16:1-7](#); [1 Corinthians 11:2-16](#); [1 Corinthians 14:34-35](#); [Galatians 3:28](#); [1 Timothy 2:11-15](#)

Work and Patronage

When Paul visited the city of Thessalonica for the first time, he taught the new believers to earn their own money through work instead of relying on other people to support them.

Some Thessalonians refused to work. Paul addressed these lazy Christians in his first letter, but they did not change ([1 Thessalonians 4:11-12](#); [5:14](#)). Why did they refuse to work? They might have expected the Lord to return soon, so they stopped working. Yet, Paul's teachings about the Lord's return never oppose his basic instruction on the importance of work ([2 Thessalonians 3:6, 10](#)).

These lazy Christians might have been clients of influential patrons. Patronage was a key part of the Roman economy. Wealthy patrons often helped many clients by providing food, money, or public representation in court. Having many clients increased a patron's honor. Yet, being a client came with social duties that Paul wanted the Thessalonian Christians to avoid. This was especially important since their patrons were likely non-Christians.

Paul set an example for the Thessalonians. While he was with them, he financially supported himself ([1 Thessalonians 2:9](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:7-9](#)). Paul followed Jesus' teaching that, "the worker is worthy of his provisions" (see [Matthew 10:10](#); [1 Corinthians 9:13-16](#)). But he did not accept support from the Thessalonians (although he did

accept offerings from the Philippians, [Philippians 4:15-16](#)). Paul wanted the Thessalonians to know he did not come to them using "words of flattery" to get money ([1 Thessalonians 2:5, 9](#)). He wanted them to learn from his example how they should live.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 10:10](#); [1 Corinthians 9:13-16](#); [Philippians 4:15-16](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:5, 9](#); [4:11-12](#); [5:14](#); [2 Thessalonians 3:6-10](#)

Worship in Jerusalem

The Old Testament prophets understood that true worship requires knowing God and his expectations. God decided that the temple in Jerusalem would be the main place for his people's worship. The Lord's voice came from Zion and Jerusalem ([Amos 1:2](#)). It was not acceptable for the Israelites to create a central worship site anywhere other than the temple in Jerusalem.

After the Israelite kingdom split into two parts, Jeroboam, who was king of the northern kingdom, set up new places for worship. He tried to stop his people from traveling to Jerusalem to worship God. Over time, various worship sites appeared in both the northern and southern kingdoms. Yet, no matter how many sacrifices were made or how elaborate the ceremonies were, these were not the places God had chosen for worship ([5:4-5](#)).

In the New Testament, worship is not limited to a specific place. Christians can worship wherever they gather (see [Matthew 18:20](#)). Yet, worship must follow God's guidance "in spirit and in truth" ([John 4:23-24](#)). Both the Old and New Testaments stress the importance of genuine worship.

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 12:5](#); [1 Kings 11:36](#); [2 Chronicles 6:6](#); [Nehemiah 1:9](#); [11:1](#); [Isaiah 2:3](#); [52:1](#); [56:7](#); [Joel 3:17](#); [Amos 5:4-5](#); [Zechariah 8:20-22](#); [Matthew 4:5](#); [Luke 19:46](#); [John 2:16](#); [4:21-24](#); [Hebrews 12:18-29](#); [Revelation 21:2, 10](#); [22:19](#)

Zion

Zion is the Hebrew name for the mountain in Jerusalem where the temple was located ([2 Samuel 5:7](#); see also [2 Chronicles 3:1](#)). Over time, people began using the name Zion to refer to all of

Jerusalem. Zion can refer to the real city of Jerusalem, which the Babylonians destroyed in 586 BC (see [102:13](#); [126:1](#); [137:1](#)). Rome destroyed it again in AD 70.

Zion also means more than just a physical place. It represents God's kingdom that exists everywhere ([Psalm 74:2](#); [76:2](#); [84:7](#); [135:21](#); see [Isaiah 26](#)). In this spiritual city where God lives, people trust God and do what is right and good. God does not accept evil behavior, worship of false gods, or unfair treatment of others in his city.

The prophets and poets of Israel wrote that God's city is larger than the physical city of Jerusalem. People from Judah, Israel, and all nations can become citizens of this spiritual city (see [Psalm 87:5-6](#); [Hebrews 12:22-24](#)). Zion is on a high mountain at the center of God's kingdom on earth ([Psalm 48:2](#); [99:2](#); [132:13](#)). God's throne is there ([9:11](#)). Because of this, God's people direct their prayers and praise toward Zion ([53:6](#); [65:1](#); [147:12](#); [149:2](#)). They also look to Zion for God's salvation ([14:7](#); [20:2](#); [50:2](#); [53:6](#)). God chose David's family line to rule over Zion and establish his kingdom everywhere ([2:6](#); [110:2](#)).

Zion represents God's protection and blessings ([Psalms 46:4-11](#); [48:1-14](#); [51:18](#); [128:5](#); [134:3](#)). Anyone who trusts in the Lord is secure "like Mount Zion" ([Psalm 125:1](#)). Those who reject the Lord also reject Zion's security and have no future ([129:5-8](#)).

The New Testament describes Mount Zion as a heavenly Jerusalem, the spiritual home for people from all nations spiritually "born again" through faith in Jesus Christ ([Hebrews 12:22-24](#); see also [Galatians 4:24-26](#); [Revelation 3:12](#); [21:2-4](#)). Abraham looked forward in faith to "the city with foundations" ([Hebrews 11:10](#)). Here all people of faith in God are citizens ([Hebrews 12:22-24](#)). The Lord has no geographic limits ([1 Kings 8:27](#)). So, the true Zion where he lives is in the inner beings of all who worship him.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 5:7](#); [1 Kings 8:1](#); [Psalms 14:7](#); [48:1-14](#); [50:2](#); [51:18](#); [68:16](#); [78:68](#); [87:2, 5](#); [125:1](#); [128:5](#); [132:13](#); [133:3](#); [135:21](#); [147:12](#); [Isaiah 1:27](#); [2:3](#); [3:16-17](#); [26](#); [4:3-5](#); [8:18](#); [10:12](#); [24](#); [32](#); [16:1](#); [24:23](#); [29:8](#); [30:19](#); [31:4, 9](#); [33:20](#); [37:22](#); [32](#); [40:9](#); [41:27](#); [52:1-2](#); [60:14](#); [62:1](#); [64:10](#); [Jeremiah 26:18](#); [51:35](#); [Lamentations 2:13](#); [Joel 2:32](#); [3:16-17](#); [Amos 1:2](#); [Obadiah 1:21](#); [Micah 3:12](#); [4:2](#)

[Zephaniah 3:14, 16; Zechariah 1:14, 17; 2:7; 8:2-3; 9:9; Hebrews 12:22; Revelation 14:1](#)